Some students are chosen.
Others are summoned.



BONE YEAR

Ashwell Academy Book One

ASHLEY R. O'DONOVAN

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Bone Year

By Ashley R. O’Donovan

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For Nanny, Grandpa, and Hank.
I started this book with all three of you. I finished it with none of you. Every page is yours.

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CONTENT WARNING

Before you begin: Bone Year is an adult romantasy that contains mature themes including graphic medical scenes, violence, blood, death, grief, parental loss, panic attacks, trauma, bullying, intimidation, morally gray characters, and sexually explicit scenes. Please read with care.

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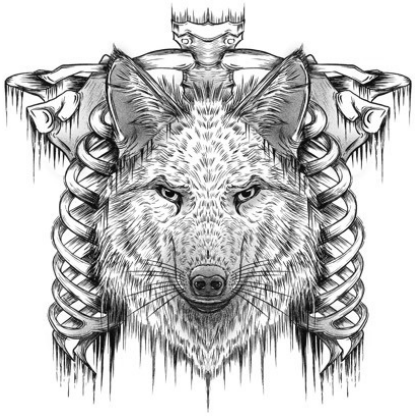
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Chapter One

"The Cycle has never broken. It only waits. And when it returns, it will demand a healer capable of choosing which lives deserve to be saved."

— Excerpt from The Ashwell Academy Founding Chronicle



The first time I watched someone die, I didn't scream. I listened.

I didn't know it then, but that moment would change everything.

It's strange what the mind chooses to remember. A breath, a final exhale, the creaking of bones. I should be past it by now, but sometimes the memory rises without warning, dragging me back.

Suddenly, I bolt upright in bed to the sound of pounding below me.

It's not a memory this time. The knocking is real, sharp enough to rattle the floorboards, and it is far too early for the clinic to be open.

I hop out of bed and quickly pull on a sweater and pants, shoving my feet into boots. As I descend the stairs, I decide not to bother taming my long red hair and twist it into a ponytail instead.

I live with my mother and younger sister in the rooms above the village clinic, the one my father started before I was born. He was the best healer in all of Ironfen, often drawing people from other villages in the Woodlands, many traveled far and wide to see him. Once we even had a family from the

Shorelands make the trek. It took them an entire month by horse to reach us.

My father died last year, and nothing has felt quite right since.

I jog across the clinic and unlock the front door, pulling it open to find Jace standing there. He holds a freshly baked sweet bun from his parents' bakery, offering it to me. A smile spreads across his face as he brazenly looks me up and down.

I grab it, take a bite, and wave him inside.

"You don't have to finish it all at once, Maelis," he says.

"But it tastes like it was made by an angel," I say through a mouthful of warm, sugary bread.

He laughs, shaking his head. He has the straight nose and full lower lip of someone who was clearly built to be looked at, and lately I've been catching myself doing it. I always tease him like that, because the thing about Jace is that he is an angel. An actual one.

His parents are angels too, the only magical bloodline living permanently in our village. We get the occasional fae passing through, and the crazy woman who runs the tavern at the edge of town swears has hosted vampires before, but I've never seen one myself. They may rule over all of Valen, but they like to keep to the Shadowlands.

Most magical bloodlines avoid human villages altogether. We don't have much to offer them, and they probably find us unbearably boring.

Jace moved here about twelve years ago. We were kids then. His father had fallen gravely ill, and after seeing countless healers, they eventually found their way to our clinic. My father was finally able to heal him, and they've stayed ever since.

They opened a bakery and settled into the slow rhythm of our village, as if they had been searching for a place like Ironfen all along. My mother welcomed them with open arms. She had been an outsider before she settled in Ironfen, though she doesn't like to talk about it.

"Are you doing hours with Briana today?" I ask as Jace drops onto one of the cots, already tearing into his pastry.

Briana is my little sister, though calling her little no longer feels right. She's seventeen now, six years younger than me.

After my father passed, my mother and sister took on most of the clinic hours. Before that, I was his protégé. From the moment I could walk, I found my way into the clinic, trailing after him, watching, learning, helping

wherever I could. Our family was never wealthy enough for us to attend one of the larger schools, but we had a tutor, along with lessons from our parents at home.

Every day after my studies, I worked in the clinic. Healing always came naturally to me, but since my father's death, I haven't been able to treat a single patient.

I freeze the moment someone needs me. The memories crash into me all at once. My hands shake, my chest tightens, and panic steals the air from my lungs. Jace used to be my right hand in the clinic. Now, he helps my sister and mother instead, filling the space I left behind.

"No, I'm off today," he says, "but I thought you could use a run to clear your head."

I brush the crumbs from my hands onto my pants, already knowing he won't let it go.

After he witnessed my first panic attack, when we were trying to help a man that had been impaled by a fallen branch after slipping from his roof, Jace started dragging me outside whenever he could. Running. Hiking. Long walks through the forest. He swore it would help, that I would find my way back to the clinic in time.

But here we are, almost a year later, and I'm still broken.

I think the runs are just an excuse now, a way for him to stay close. I've always had the feeling Jace wants more than friendship, but I've never let it cross that line. Not because he isn't attractive. At six feet tall with short silvery-blond hair and wings that catch the light like brushed silver, he is painfully so.

I don't want to ruin what we have, and I know he won't be here forever.

He's too talented to stay in a place like this.

I don't want to be the one left hurting when he leaves.

"Sounds great, but let's walk for the first thirty minutes or so until my food settles," I say.

He nods, already on his feet and heading for the door.

"Maelis, where are you going?" Briana asks as she descends the stairs into the clinic, her blonde hair still a mess of waves as she prepares to start her morning checklist before opening for patients.

"A run. I'll see you tonight," I say.

I'm halfway out the door when she calls, "Tonight, but—"

I don’t turn back. I don’t feel like explaining myself. After our run, I already know where I’m going.

My father’s office.

It’s next door to the clinic, untouched by everyone but me since his death. My mother can’t bring herself to go inside. Some days, she can barely look at me at all after the incident. It’s fine. I don’t want to look at her either after that night.

I need something to fill my time. Something to keep my hands busy and my thoughts quiet. Going through my father’s things has become my way of doing that. His books. His journals. His patient records. Each page feels like a thread still tying him to this world, tying him to me.

It’s how I keep him close, how I hold on a little longer.

And it’s the only place I know where no one will bother me.

“Come on, Mae, cheer up. Look how beautiful it is this morning. The sun’s shining. The air is fresh. You’re alive,” Jace says, teasing as he nudges me while we walk.

I glance up at him and let my lips quirk on one side. A half smile is all I can manage. I’ve been in such a rut lately, and I know I need to pull myself out of it. I don’t know how yet.

“So, have you heard anything from Ashwell?” I ask, changing the subject. A small, selfish part of me hopes he hasn’t.

Ashwell Academy of Medicine and Alchemy is the most elite school for healers. I had never even heard of it before Jace, which makes sense considering they don’t accept humans. They train magical bloodlines to become Veilguards, and getting in is nearly impossible.

Jace talks about it like it’s more a myth than a school. No one knows where it’s located. Some don’t even believe it exists. The way he describes it, it sounds more like a secret society than an academy. Still, it’s his dream to get in.

He’s applied every year for the last three years and never hears a word.

I asked him once how he applies if no one knows where the school is. He explained it’s magic. You send your application with a spell, and it finds its way on its own. I asked what happens if it finds its way into the school’s toilet instead, but he didn’t appreciate the question. I appreciated it enough for both of us.

“I haven’t heard anything,” he says, shoulders slumping.

Feeling guilty, I think maybe I shouldn’t have brought it up.

“It’s been one hundred and sixteen years since the last cycle. Maybe they stopped training Veilguards. If the cycles are over, it wouldn’t be needed anymore,” I say, kicking a loose rock off the cobblestone road.

“That sounds like a very human thing to say.” Jace says without looking over at me. “As long as there are people walking the earth, the cycles will continue. Balance is a necessity.”

The cycle comes every hundred years like clockwork, according to history. A constant written into records older than Valen itself. Still, it’s hard for most humans to truly grasp what that means. Our lives are too short, blinks in the grand scheme of things compared to other bloodlines.

Most of us will never witness a cycle firsthand, and any humans who did are long gone now, their stories reduced to ink on aging pages and fading warnings no one takes seriously anymore.

“Ashwell would be lucky to have you. They don’t know what they’re doing if they think you’re not a good fit. Maybe they want to see more clinic hours with the magic-blessed bloodlines like you instead of humans,” I say, tucking a stray copper strand behind my ear.

Veilguards are the most elite battlefield healers in the world, trained to heal both humans and magical races. According to the history books, they’re what keep the world from tipping over the edge each cycle. Without them, we wouldn’t stand a chance against the twisted creatures that emerge from the fissures when the balance begins to falter.

“I don’t think that’s it,” Jace says, “but I don’t know enough to say what their criteria is or how anyone is chosen. My parents say the school itself is like a living entity. It has its own magical core that chooses its students.”

It sounds unsettling, but maybe that’s the human in me talking.

“Ashwell, you magical asshole, you don’t know what you’re missing!” I shout into the trees as we reach the outskirts of the village, the forest enveloping us.

Jace’s head snaps toward me, blue eyes wide with shock before he breaks into laughter.

“You’re completely nuts,” he says, “and it’s why I love you.”

I stick out my tongue to avoid dwelling on the feelings swelling in my chest. It must mean the warm-up is over. We both start jogging down the path stretched out ahead.

We run until we reach the river then follow the water for a few miles. By the time we finally slow to a stop, I’m thoroughly sweaty and panting,

my lungs burning with each breath. I'm exhausted enough that my mind has gone blissfully quiet.

All I can focus on is the fire in my lungs and the ache in my legs.

I walk over to the rapids and brace myself against a smooth rock, bending down to scoop a handful of ice-cold water into my mouth. Jace splashes his face before straightening with a satisfied breath.

We move a few steps away from the river and collapse onto our backs beneath a broad tree, staring up through the leaves as they sway in the breeze overhead. I let my eyes close, letting the steady rhythm of my heartbeat slow while we rest, knowing we'll have to make the same run back soon.

"If you get into Ashwell, I don't know what I'll do around here without you. These runs won't be the same," I say, staring up at the wisps of sunlight streaming through the branches overhead.

"You'd never make it this far without me," he says. "You'd stop halfway and call it a victory."

I snort. "I would stop halfway and call it self-care."

"Lying in the dirt gasping for air is not self-care."

"Bold of you to assume I'd be gasping," I say, reaching over to jab him.

He laughs, "You despise exercise."

"I tolerate it. There's a difference."

"Come here."

He lifts his arm and tugs me closer, and I settle against him, my head resting on his chest. His heartbeat is steady beneath my ear, grounding in a way nothing else seems to be lately.

"I won't get in," he says, "so you don't have to worry about it. If I were meant to be a Veilguard, they would've accepted me three years ago when I first applied."

Gods, it's moments like this that test me, standing on that thin, dangerous line between what we are and what we could be. One shift, one kiss, one choice away from everything changing.

"Maybe they're slow," I murmur.

"Or maybe they're smart enough to see I don't belong there," he says, his hand tracing slowly along my back.

I pull back enough to look at him. "That's not true."

"But either way, we need to get you back to treating patients. You have the talent. One day, you'll be even better than your father was. You're only

twenty-three and are already as good as he ever was. Talent like yours shouldn’t be wasted.”

His fingers hook gently under my chin, tipping my face up until I meet his gaze. “Maelis Rose, you’re destined for greatness. This is just a small bump in the road.” He taps my nose then leans back against the ground as if he hasn’t unraveled me.

I stare up at the canopy above us, my mind drifting.

I don’t feel destined for anything right now. Maybe I used to. But my father’s death… That night changed everything.

A loud crack echoes through the trees, sharp enough to be heard over the rapids. We both sit up at the same time, scanning the forest.

In nearly a year of running out here, we’ve never seen anyone. The occasional squirrel or rabbit, but never someone from the village.

There’s a man standing in the brush ahead of us.

Jace is on his feet instantly, offering me a hand and pulling me up beside him. The man stands at an odd angle, one shoulder slumped lower than the other, his head tilted sharply to the side.

Something about him prickles my skin.

“Do you think he’s hurt?” I ask.

At the sound of my voice, the man turns.

His head jerks first, snapping toward us, followed by his arm twitching as if his body can’t quite agree on how to move. He sways, unsteady, then stills.

“There’s blood on his shirt,” Jace says quietly.

We start toward him anyway, old instinct and training drilled into us since childhood, taking over.

“Hey,” Jace calls out as we near the edge of the clearing, “do you need help?”

The man’s head whips fully toward us, and now we’re close enough to see his face.

I suck in a sharp breath.

Something is very wrong.

His mouth hangs open at an unnatural angle, froth bubbling along his lips. The skin on one side of his face looks raw, slick, as if it’s been stripped away or burned clean off. His eyes are wide but unfocused, darting around.

“What’s wrong with him?” I whisper.

My pulse pounds in my ears. Gods, maybe he was burned or fell or is delirious.

I draw in a breath to speak, and the man explodes into motion.

One second he’s swaying in the brush, the next he’s sprinting straight at us, feet stomping into the earth. His movements are erratic, his limbs pumping hard like his body is being driven by something else entirely.

“Run!”

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Chapter Two

"Not every wound bleeds. Some take the mind first and the body after."

— Field Notes on the Cycle, Veilguard Archives



"Run," Jace yells again.

The man lets out a guttural sound that isn't quite a scream and isn't quite human.

And he's closing the distance quickly.

I turn and start running, my boots barely touching the ground, but then I realize Jace isn't with me.

I whirl around.

He stands with his arms out in front of him, a dagger clenched in one hand.

"We can help you," he says, but the man doesn't slow.

My eyes widen. I slap a hand over my mouth to smother the scream building in my throat as the man barrels straight at him. At the last second, Jace's wings burst outward in a flash of silver and light, lifting him clean off the ground and over the man's head.

My relief fizzles when the man turns and starts coming straight for me.

I freeze.

Jace drops from the air, slamming down onto the man's shoulders and driving him to the ground. The impact knocks the breath from my lungs

even though it isn’t me taking the hit. The man thrashes beneath him, limbs jerking violently, a low growl reverberating through the air. He thrashes around like an animal caught in a trap.

He twists, shoving Jace off, and springs back to his feet in one fluid, unnatural motion. He lunges again, teeth snapping as if he’s trying to tear into flesh instead of fight.

This sick person is fast, but Jace is faster.

He ducks to the side and plunges his dagger into the man’s chest. I expect him to cry out, to grab the wound, to falter, but he does none of it.

Instead, his hands clamp around Jace’s arm, his jaw snapping wildly, teeth clicking inches from skin like he’s trying to bite through bone.

I grab the nearest branch and swing it as hard as I can, the crack of wood against his skull making my stomach turn. It doesn’t slow him.

Jace kicks him backward, sending him crashing to the ground, and then he’s on him again. The dagger rises and falls over and over. The man’s movements grow weaker until finally his body goes still.

Jace stumbles back, chest heaving. I rush to his side, my heart pounding so hard it hurts as we stare down at the body.

“Is he a vampire?” I whisper.

Jace shakes his head slowly. “No, vampires look like you and me. They don’t look like this even when they’ve been starved.”

I want to ask how he knows what a starved vampire looks like, but it’s not the right time.

“Maybe he was bitten by an animal or poisoned,” I say, my voice strained. “Maybe it drove him mad.”

Jace’s jaw ticks as he looks back down at the man.

“Yeah,” he says quietly, “let’s hope that’s all this is.”

We debate taking him back to the clinic to study him, to see if we can figure out what was wrong, but we both know it’s not a good idea. My mother and sister are there. What if whatever he had is contagious.

The run back is quiet. Even when we reach the village, we don’t say a word. The adrenaline fades, leaving an uncomfortable feeling of unease. We weave through the carriages lining the road, the familiar sights doing nothing to settle my nerves.

When we reach Jace’s house, I slow to a stop. “You don’t have to walk all the way back with me. It’s your day off.”

He shakes his head. “No, I want to grab a few supplies from the clinic, then I’m going back to check the body more closely.”

“I can go with you, if you want.” The offer feels hollow the moment it leaves my mouth.

He studies me for a moment. “You don’t want to do that. It’s okay. I’ll be fine.”

He’s right. I don’t want to go back out there. Not today. Maybe never. “I’ll see if I can find anything like this in my father’s notes.”

I’m planning to spend the rest of the afternoon going through his things anyway.

Jace nods, and when we reach the clinic, I don’t follow him in. Instead, I enter the next door over. My father’s office.

The room smells faintly of dried herbs and ink.

I move deeper into the room and light the lantern on his desk. The flame flares then steadies, amber light filling the space with a warm glow. Bookshelves line the walls, crowded with ledgers, bundles of notes tied with twine, heavy tomes, and jars filled with crushed leaves and powders, each labeled in his careful hand.

Everything is exactly as he left it.

I take a seat and run my fingers along the edge of the desk, over the nicks and scratches I remember making as a child while he worked late into the night. I used to sit on the floor beneath this table, pretending to read while listening to the scratch of his pen and the steady rhythm of his breathing. I used to think that sound meant safety.

Nothing has ever really scared me, aside from death.

Even as a little girl, far too young to understand what death really meant, I thought about it constantly. Awake at night, I’d wonder what happens after a heart stops, terrified that one morning I would wake and find my parents gone or my sister Briana cold and still beside me.

I don’t know if something happened to me when I was very young, some old trauma sealed behind a door my mind refuses to open. I only know that death and what comes after has haunted me far longer than it should.

Maybe that’s why I started working in the clinic with my father before I even understood what healing meant. As soon as I was old enough to carry a bowl of water or cut strips of linen, I was in the thick of it. Some villagers used to say healing was in my blood. I used to believe it too.

Working in the clinic was my way of trying to understand the thing that kept me awake at night. I told myself that if I feared something, the only way to conquer it was to study it, learning its patterns and its rules. If I could learn how to prevent death, how to anticipate it, how to accept it, maybe the fear would loosen its grip on me.

Maybe if I stood close enough to death, it would stop looking back at me.

I thought knowledge would ease the fear. Instead, all it did was sharpen the edge of the thing I dread most.

Even thinking about it now takes my breath away, the fear coursing through me at the thought of nothing. Time is the only enemy that can't be conquered. We live this life, and then that's it. Forever. For as long as the mind can stretch.

My breaths turn shallow as that familiar panic rises. It's not fair that I was born human. We are not only the weakest race, but our lifespans are cruelly short. I would have given anything to be an angel, fae, or even a shifter. They live far beyond what any human can hope for.

I shake off the thought and reach for the nearest ledger and flip to the page I marked the last time I was here. I have only worked my way through about half of my father's things, and I know it will take time before I finish. A part of me doesn't want to. I draw out the process on purpose, clinging to the illusion that as long as there are pages left unread, he isn't truly gone.

I skim patient names, treatments, and observations. I flip past them until the handwriting tightens, the margins crowded with notes written too fast to be tidy.

One cramped note in the corner catches my eye. "Injuries that do not match known beasts. Wounds that resist healing, as if the body itself is being told to fail."

I chew on my bottom lip as I turn the page. The ink grows darker, pressed hard into the paper.

"The injuries are patterned. Not random. This is not a normal attack. It feels like preparation."

I flip another page.

"If the cycle is delayed, then something else will respond. It always does."

My gaze catches on a single word, underlined twice, and my breath stutters.

Ashwell.

“If the cycle is late, Ashwell will act.”

The final lines are shorter, the ink smudged.

“I pray it is not in my lifetime, or hers.”

How did my father know about Ashwell Academy? He never spoke of it, not even when I told him about Jace applying. And yet, buried in his notes, the name appears.

I read into the early hours of the night, turning brittle pages until my eyes burn. I don’t find anything else about Ashwell or what happened in the woods today.

I stretch my arms over my head and yawn, my body aching from the long day. My thoughts drift to Jace. I hope he made it back home safely. I debate going to check on him when a faint blue glow flickers in the middle of the room.

I shove my chair back and stand. Goosebumps ripple along my arms as I step around the desk toward the light, my pulse thudding in my ears. The orb hovers at eye level, no bigger than a coin at first, then it grows.

The light flares.

I throw my hands up to shield my eyes as brightness floods the room. When it vanishes suddenly, I lower my arms, blinking rapidly.

A tall man stands where the light had been.

I gasp and stumble backward until the backs of my legs hit the desk. He’s tall and broad, wearing a black cloak.

“Holy fuck. What are you?” I ask. This person is not human.

“Maelis Rose,” he says.

He knows my name. How does he know my name?

I nod numbly as he reaches up and pulls back his hood, revealing pointed ears and gray hair framing a slender face.

He’s fae.

He reaches into his cloak and produces a rolled piece of parchment, the paper bound with a seal of deep-blue wax. He holds it out to me, stoic and yet observant.

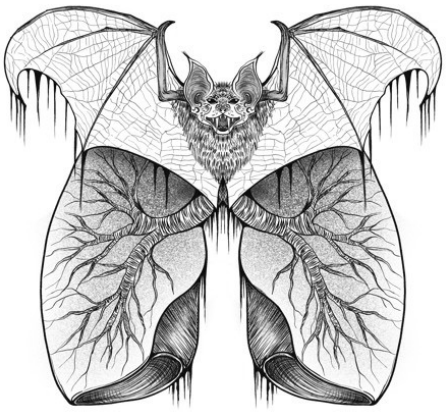
“Ashwell Academy of Medicine and Alchemy has accepted your application.”

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Chapter Three

"I thought Ashwell would teach me how to save lives.
It taught me how to survive them."

— Unattributed Student Journal, Confiscated



I stare at him then at the parchment, my mind lagging. Slowly, I take it from his hand.

"That's not possible," I say. "I didn't apply."

The wax seal breaks with a soft crack beneath my fingers as I unroll the parchment, my heart thrumming in my chest as fast as a hummingbird.

I read the neatly written script first.

Maelis Rose,

You have been accepted to Ashwell Academy of Medicine and Alchemy.

Your presence is expected immediately.

Further instruction will be provided upon arrival.

My breath catches as I reach the final line. Expected immediately.

Then my eyes drop to the bottom of the page.

Something has been scribbled there, darker and uneven, as if written in haste.

"Blood remembers what history forgets. Your father knows you are ready."

My mouth goes dry as I swallow.

My father.

Did he send in my application before he died? Is he tied to this somehow? He must be. It says it right here. My pulse thunders as questions spiral faster than I can hold onto them.

“Who wrote this?” I ask.

The moment I say it, the parchment flares hot in my hands. Silver flames race across the page, swallowing ink and paper alike. I yelp, jerking back as the scroll disintegrates into nothing but drifting ash.

“I see you accept,” he says.

My gaze snaps back to him, to eyes so pale they nearly blend into the gray of his hair. In the dim room, they look almost white. “I did no such thing.” I shake my head and try to process what the hell is happening.

“I’m sorry, Miss Rose,” he says calmly, “but the invitation only burns silver when the student has decided. Whether verbalized or not, you have chosen to accept.”

My eyes drop to my hands where the parchment had been, my fingers curling instinctively as if it might still be there. Did I decide? I don’t know. I think I did. Some part of me was already reaching for it the moment I saw my father was mentioned. Whatever connection exists, whatever truth is buried in Ashwell, I need to know it. Who wrote that? I need answers.

Fuck.

I did accept, and whatever magic binds Ashwell knew it.

“I don’t even know where Ashwell is,” I say, shifting my weight anxiously. “I don’t know how to get there. How long do I have?”

“We leave now,” he replies.

My throat closes, panic spiking sharp and fast. I would step back if I could, but the desk is still pressed into the backs of my legs, leaving nowhere to go. “I need to pack. I need to tell my sister and my mother.” I swallow hard. I need to tell Jace. Gods, I wish he were here right now. He would know what to do. He always does.

The fae watches me impassively, as if none of that changes anything.

“Everything you need will be waiting for you when you arrive, and your family will be notified,” he says, placid.

It all sounds absolutely mad. For one wild heartbeat, I consider sprinting past him, racing into the clinic, locking the door, and bolting upstairs like I’m still a child who can hide from consequences. But he appeared out of an orb of light. A locked door won’t save me from that.

Relax, Maelis.

I don’t need to tell them goodbye. My mother would probably welcome the space, and Briana will be better off without me having another panic attack in the clinic.

They’ve managed this long. They’ll keep managing. Maybe this is exactly what I need, something to shock my senses, to drag me out of the fog I’ve been living in. It could force me to start really living again, the way Jace is always telling me to do.

“Very well,” I say, crossing my arms to steady myself. “What do you need me to do?”

He steps close enough that the air around him feels different, heavier somehow, and every muscle in my body tenses. “This may feel unusual for a moment, but you’ll be fine,” he says, looming over me. “I can’t say I’ve ever done this to a human before.”

My eyes widen, a dozen protests crowding my tongue, but none of them make it out. His hand settles on my shoulder, anchoring me in place. Light erupts around us, bright enough to burn away the room, the desk, the walls of everything I know.

The world folds in on itself.

Then everything goes dark.

The first thing I feel is cold seeping through muscle and bone, spreading beneath my flesh in a thousand prickling trails like tiny insects skittering through my veins. It lingers for a moment before slowly retreating, replaced by a faint warmth against my face.

My feet touch solid ground.

Soft light flickers as I blink, my vision swimming as if the world is struggling to reassemble itself around me. The pressure on my shoulder disappears, and I realize the man has stepped away.

I lift my head to see a wooden door directly in front of me. The number 303 is fixed to the center, the digits formed from what appear to be tiny bones fitted together.

An anxious feeling starts to fester inside me.

We’re in a narrow stone hallway lit by torch filled sconces mounted along both walls, their flames casting a low, flickering glow. The stone is dark, nearly black, and lined with paintings framed in tarnished metal. Most of them blur together at first glance. Shapes. Figures. Landscapes swallowed by shadow.

Except for the one beside my door.

A massive white wolf stares out from the canvas, its fur rendered in painstaking detail, its pale eyes unnervingly bright. I take a step back, certain I saw those eyes shift.

I tell myself it's exhaustion, shock, my imagination running wild.

Still, the unease doesn't fade.

If this is room 303, then we're on the third floor, at least one would think. I glance down the corridor in both directions, counting seven doors spaced evenly along the hall, all identical, all closed.

"This is your room. Don't come out. Someone will find you come morning with further instructions," he says.

I turn toward him. "That's it? Where is everyone else?"

His mouth settles into a thin, emotionless line. He pats my shoulder before abruptly turning away. A few quiet footsteps later, he rounds the corner at the far end of the hall and is gone.

I lower my gaze to the doorknob.

It too is made of bone. After a moment's hesitation, I curl my fingers around it and turn. The door opens without a sound. I step inside and pull it shut behind me.

Thankfully there is a lock on the inside that I turn into place.

I lean back against the wall, pressing my palms flat to the cold stone as I draw in a slow, steadying breath.

Whatever Ashwell is, I'm in it now.

The room is beyond strange. I don't know what I expected, but this isn't it.

Golden light spills from a chandelier and pools on the floor. The ceiling vaults high above, painted in dark blues and muted gold, the geometrical shape pulling my eyes upward whether I want them there or not.

A four-poster bed dominates the right side of the room, dark wood wrapped in teal fabric. The bedding is layered in deep green and pale blue, tucked so tight it looks like no one has ever pulled it back. Maybe no one has.

The floor hums beneath my boots, a mosaic of inlaid stone and tile forming interlocking circles that compel me to step farther into the room. A narrow beige throw runs the length of the bed.

Two tall arched windows line the far wall. Frost creeps inward across the glass. Beyond them, nothing. No landscape, no lights. Darkness swallows everything, a sliver of moon too weak to fight it.

A heavy wooden desk is between the windows, bare except for an unlit candle and a stack of parchment. The chair is pushed in tight. A wardrobe is opposite the bed, its doors carved with vines that twist upward. Everything is beautiful.

I cross the room and open the wardrobe. Inside hangs a single black cloak, identical to the one the fae wore only this one has a thin purple border lining it. I pull it free, and the weight surprises me. My gaze catches on the markings stitched across the back. Three symbols arranged vertically, each contained within an intricate circular border that looks burned into the cloth rather than sewn.

The top circle depicts a ribcage with the head of a wolf suspended inside it staring straight at me. The middle holds a heart, dark and anatomically precise, a serpent coiled around it. The bottom symbol shows a bat with its wings spread wide and a pair of lungs below it. Interesting and slightly unsettling. I slide the cloak back onto its hanger and push it farther into the wardrobe.

There is a folded sweater bearing the same wolf and ribcage sigil in a purple amethyst color, along with a simple black shirt, a skirt, and a pair of black pants. Everything is dark. I open the drawers beneath and find a mixture of unfamiliar clothing and, to my surprise, some of my own. Magic. I spot a familiar pair of soft navy pajamas and grab them.

On the far side of the bed, another door leads into a small bathroom. Stone basin, toilet, and a tub tucked beneath an arched alcove with a narrow showerhead mounted above it. Modest but immaculate. I release a slow breath. Having my own bathroom feels like an unexpected mercy.

I change quickly, tugging on the silky pants and matching top then unwrap the toothbrush beside the sink and brush my teeth. When I finally look up, my reflection catches me off guard. Bloodshot eyes rimmed with exhaustion. Copper hair loose and frizzed, falling out of my ponytail. I look like someone who barely survived the day.

What will the other students think when they see me tomorrow? Will I be the only human here? Does Ashwell truly not accept humans at all, and if so, why am I standing in this room like I belong? Maybe Jace was wrong.

I drag my hands down my face. I should wash properly, search for soap, lotion, anything that might make me feel marginally more like myself. The thought alone exhausts me.

Instead, I turn off the lights and crawl into bed. The mattress sinks beneath me, softer and more luxurious than anything I've ever slept on, the pillow cool against my cheek. I lie there staring up at the canopy, mind still circling the same unanswered questions. I hope Jace made it home okay after going back to see that man's body. I'd give anything to see his face when he finds out where I ended up. He's hardly going to believe it.

I hardly believe it yet myself.

Gods, I hope my mother and sister aren't panicking right now. I hope someone actually told them where I am, instead of leaving them to imagine the worst. I'm assuming someone had to talk to them if they got my clothes. I hope tomorrow brings better answers than the ones that fae gave me tonight, because I feel like I have no idea what I've got myself into.

I toss and turn beneath the covers, the bed far too soft for how restless I feel. My mind refuses to settle, thoughts looping endlessly, replaying the silver flame, the parchment, my father. Exhaustion eventually drags me under. At least the room is quiet and safe.

I'm suddenly jolted awake at the sound of the door flying open.

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Chapter Four

“Eidolon animals become part of the owner, bonded to them and tied to their very life source, forming as a manifested reflection of the student’s inner essence.”

— First Year Handbook, Mirror Ceremony Procedure



“Rise and shine, little boner.”

The voice is cheerful. Far too cheerful.

My door slams shut. I could have sworn I locked it last night. I blink, still half trapped between sleep and waking, as I take in the unfamiliar girl standing a few feet away.

“Little what?” I ask, certain I must have misheard.

She grins. A girl not much older than me with long black hair and dark, amused eyes tucks a strand behind her ear as she wanders farther into the room like she belongs here. She stops at my wardrobe, pulls it open, and immediately starts rifling through my things.

“I’m just messing with you. It’s your bone year, so the name is fitting.”

“Sorry,” I say, dragging the blankets higher around me, “who the fuck are you, and why are you in my room?”

“Elizabeth. I’m in my blood year,” she says, still flipping through clothes. “Before you say anything, I had a whole year of being a little boner too, so I know what it’s like.” She turns and drops onto the end of my bed with an armful of garments.

“Stop saying that,” I mutter. “It’s kind of disgusting.”

She laughs, enjoying herself far too much.

Something shifts beside me.

A dark shape drops from one of the bed pillars and lands on the mattress with a soft rush of wings. I shriek and scramble backward, nearly tumbling off the bed as a small bat settles inches from my leg, folding its wings neatly against its body while its glossy black eyes fix on me.

Holy hell, has that thing been in my room all night?

"Relax," Elizabeth says, reaching over and scratching the creature gently between the ears. "That's Fern. She's my eidolon."

The bat chirps, and I stare at it then back at her. "What the hell is an eidolon? Don't those things carry diseases?"

She giggles, and the bat vanishes in a quick burst of sparkling mist, as if it was never there at all, and my mouth falls open.

"What are you?" I ask, the first of many questions that come to mind.

"I'm a shifter," she says easily, as if she's telling me the weather. "Not the kind that can turn into anything. Those are rare. I shift into a panther."

My eyes widen.

She rolls her shoulders, preening. "Don't look so nervous. Get in the shower. I'll fill you in on things while you get ready."

I reluctantly head into the bathroom, remembering a second too late that the shower doesn't have a curtain. Elizabeth follows me in, drags the small stool from my bedroom across the floor, and sets it on the far side of the room. She plops down with her legs crossed beneath her, deliberately turning her back to me.

"Go on," she says. "I'm not watching you. You're not my type anyway. Don't get me wrong. You're hot for sure, but I've tried it with girls, and it's not for me."

Heat creeps into my face as I quickly pull my hair out of its loose tie and slip out of my pajamas. A moment later, warm water cascades over me, and I can't stop the small sigh that escapes.

The heat feels glorious.

"I'll take you to get your class schedule and your books. Then I'll give you a tour of the school grounds and a rundown of everything you'll need to know," she says as I work shampoo into my hair, the warm water sliding down my back.

"Okay," I mumble, tipping my head beneath the stream.

"This afternoon, you'll have orientation, and tonight will be the Mirror Ceremony. Probably some after-parties to celebrate too."

I’ve never been to a party before, not a real one at least. I’ve been to family gatherings back home. Quiet dinners. The occasional village festival where everyone knows everyone else. But a party at a school filled with magical bloodlines is kind of intimidating.

I shut off the water and reach for the nearest towel, squeezing the excess moisture from my long hair as steam curls around me, fogging the mirror.

“Put these on and come out when you’re ready. We have a lot to cover. Oh and use this. You’ll want dry hair today,” she says brightly, holding out a folded bundle of clothes and pointing to a button on the wall.

I wish I woke up with even a fraction of her energy. She sounds like she’s already had several cups of coffee. Maybe it’s a shifter thing, or maybe everyone here is like that. I imagine Ashwell Academy attracts that kind of person, highly motivated and competitive.

I nod, and she steps out, pulling the door closed behind her and finally giving me a moment of privacy. I brush my hair and then eye the labeled button on the wall for the dryer. I push it, and a mixture of heat and wind shoots out from the ceiling above me, drying my hair in a matter of seconds. I’ve never seen anything like it. I glance in the mirror, and my copper hair looks pristine. Long shiny waves fall down the center of my back. I don’t even bother with a ponytail today, merely pushing it behind my shoulders.

I pull on the black fleece-lined leggings and the black lace shirt, noticing a small circular symbol stitched into the sleeve in deep amethyst. Bones curve around a wolf like on the cloak.

When I step back into the bedroom, socks and boots are next. Elizabeth hands me a black coat, heavy and warm.

“The school is always heated, but when we walk between buildings like today, you’ll need this,” she says. “Have you looked outside yet?”

I hurry to the window. I couldn’t see anything last night beyond darkness and frost, but now the view steals my breath.

It’s stunning.

Snow stretches as far as I can see, blanketing the world in soft white. Mountains rise in the distance, their jagged peaks covered in ice, while dark trees are frozen beneath layers of frost. We’re high. We’re higher than I realized. Beyond the slopes, I catch sight of vast, glassy fields of ice, like a massive frozen lake extending toward the horizon. I can only assume we are somewhere in the Frostlands, the northernmost reach in all of Valen. It’s

nearly impossible to travel here and even harder to survive the year-round freezing temperatures and volatile storms.

“Yeah, this building has some of the best views,” Elizabeth says. “You’re on the far edge of the school grounds, so nothing blocks the scenery.”

I turn back to her, only then noticing the symbol on her sleeve. It’s the same circular design, but hers is crimson instead of amethyst, a heart at its center with a serpent coiled around it.

“Wait,” I say. “Before we go, can you tell me what these symbols mean and why I’m dressed like this?”

“You really don’t know anything, do you?” she says, settling onto the foot of my bed.

“No, I don’t, so please explain. Maybe that’s why they told you to come see me,” I reply, leaning back against the cold glass of the window.

“Every first year is assigned a mentor on their first day,” she says. “Someone to show them around, make sure they get settled, and answer questions. I’ll check in on you periodically throughout the year too.”

I fold my arms across my chest. “I see. So I’m not special then.”

She smiles, clearly amused. “Not in that way at least, but you are the only human who has ever been accepted to Ashwell, and everyone is already buzzing about it.”

I’m not sure that’s a good thing.

Elizabeth hops to her feet and crosses the room, yanking the wardrobe open. She pulls out the black cloak and carries it back to the bed, spreading it carefully across the blankets in front of me.

“Year one is bone year. This is its symbol. You’ll see these symbols all throughout the school,” she says, her fingers trailing over the ribcage and wolf. “All three symbols stacked on top of each other form the symbol of Ashwell Academy. Year two is blood year. That’s the year I’m starting.” She taps the serpent coiled around the heart. “And the final here, year three, is breath year.” Her finger drifts to the bat with lungs beneath it.

“But what does it mean?” I ask. “What actually happens in bone year?”

She crosses back to the wardrobe and hangs my cloak neatly in place before answering. “Every year has a set curriculum. Bone year focuses on structure, survival, and physical reality. You’ll learn all the basics. Professor Cane likes to say, ‘Before you can save a life, you must understand what holds it together.’” She snickers after performing a stodgy imitation.

“And we’re supposed to dress according to our year every day?” I ask.

“Weekends you can wear whatever you want, but during classes they’ll expect you in your year’s attire. During labs, you’ll have a locker to change into proper training clothes or a lab coat to protect your uniform.”

I nod, committing it to memory.

“Come on,” she says, already moving for the door. “We can talk while we walk. Plus you’ll learn more at the orientation this afternoon, well maybe. The headmaster can be intense.”

We both shrug into our coats and step out into the hallway. It’s still quiet up here, and I hurry to keep pace beside her as we descend a wide staircase that spirals down through the center of the tower. I tilt my head back, counting at least three more levels rising above us.

“There are six floors total, and each one has five to ten rooms depending on size. This tower is ladies’ housing for all the first years.” She gestures vaguely upward then glances behind us toward a pair of large double doors at the base of the stairs. “The men in your year live right through that courtyard.”

We reach the bottom, and she smirks over her shoulder. “We are all adults, of course, so there are no rules about having men in your room. Housing is just organized this way. But keep in mind the walls aren’t that thick.”

She winks then pushes through the massive double doors on the opposite side of the entrance hall, leaving me to trail after her with my heart thudding a little harder than before.

The thought hasn’t really crossed my mind until now that I am going to be taking classes with a whole lot of men and women my age, and none of them will be human.

I’m not terrible at talking to people after working in the clinic and speaking to patients day after day, but most of my patients were human. Most of them were elderly. The only boy my age I have ever truly spent time with is Jace.

Our village never had many children. Since we were educated at home, tutored mostly by my parents, my world was always very small. Jace, Briana, and the eccentric husband and wife who live in the tavern down the street from our house are my people.

That leaves Jace as my one real friend.

The idea of navigating a school full of magical bloodlines around my age, of learning how to exist among them, makes my stomach twist.

It's a good thing I don't mind being alone, because I have a feeling I am about to be very alone indeed.

Once outside, I'm taken back for a moment by the courtyard. It is a winter wonderland of snow and ice, but alive with motion. Students cluster in loose groups, talking and laughing, boots crunching against frost, arms full of heavy-looking books. Breath fogs the air. The contrast is jarring after the warm, hushed stillness of the dormitories, and I simply stand there, overwhelmed.

"How many people attend Ashwell?" I ask, as Elizabeth tugs my arm to get me moving again, my gaze drifting as I take it all in.

A girl with pale-pink hair and startling blue eyes catches sight of me as we pass, and her steps slow. Her stare lingers, curiosity flickering across her face.

I swallow.

"Ashwell accepts a hundred students a year when taking new students. Sometimes there are….gaps," she says.

I find myself wishing I knew more about the other bloodlines so I could tell them apart. I know angels have wings. Fae have pointed ears. Beyond that, everything blurs together into unfamiliar possibilities.

"A hundred students a year seems like a lot," I say, but I don't know how many gap years there are. "I didn't realize there were so many Veilguards."

We follow a narrow path lined with trees, their branches bare and sheathed in ice. From the frozen limbs hang delicate blue trumpet-shaped flowers, translucent and glowing faintly, as if grown from frost rather than soil.

"There aren't that many Veilguards," she says. "Bone year starts with roughly a hundred students. Blood year usually begins with fifty to sixty. Breath year has around thirty, and not all of them graduate."

I snap my head toward her. "What the hell happens to all the other students?"

She glances at me, and for the first time since barging into my room, her expression isn't playful or amused. It's almost pitying.

"Let's hope you don't find out."

That's reassuring.

Of course being the only human here is going to put a target on my back. And most of them are going to expect me to fail. But I am not going to make it easy for them.

We reach the end of the path between the two dormitories, and the campus opens up in front of us.

Ashwell is enormous, a sprawling complex of dark stone towers, interlocking buildings, and high walls stretches across the mountainside. The structures rise at different heights, some only a few stories tall, others climbing so high their upper spires disappear into drifting clouds. Narrow bridges span the gaps between towers. Arched walkways cut through lower levels. Staircases cling to outer walls, winding upward in tight spirals.

The stone is almost black, mottled with deep browns and charcoal tones, dusted with snow that clings to ledges and window frames. Hundreds of tall, narrow windows line the buildings, many glowing with dim amber light. Others remain dark, creating an uneven pattern that makes the school feel awake in some places and asleep in others.

At the heart of the grounds stands a massive central structure wider and taller than the rest with a broad stairway leading up to enormous iron doors. Beyond it, more buildings branch outward in layered tiers, forming a rough semicircle around an open courtyard of packed snow and stone.

Elizabeth keeps leading us down different paths, and I barely manage to process anything she says. My attention keeps snagging on the scenery, the buildings, and the steady flow of students moving between them. We pass directly by the largest structure near the center of the grounds, and carved above its doors are three words, “Bone. Blood. Breath.”

A wolf stands etched beside “Bone.” A snake weaves through the letters of “Blood.” A bat clings to the curve of the H in “Breath.”

What is it with this place and animals?

We continue toward the front of the campus, where a gigantic iron gate looms in the distance, closed and blocking the main road. Near it is a much smaller building compared to everything else around it, though people constantly move in and out.

“This is where we’ll pick up your class schedule,” Elizabeth says.

I follow her inside and fall into line behind two girls.

“So what other bloodlines go here?” I ask quietly as we wait for the girl in front of us to finish checking in. “Are there a lot of other shifters like you?”

“Oh, Ashwell accepts all bloodlines other than humans.” She glances at me, lips twitching. “Well, until now.”

I lift a hand in a small circular motion. “Like…”

“There are shifters, fae, vampires, angels, demons.” She ticks them off on her fingers. “Oh, and mages ,though they’re rare. I only know of five here at the school.”

“Five?” I echo.

“Other than the headmaster,” she adds casually.

That makes me blink. I had not even considered the headmaster.

“Who’s the headmaster?” I ask.

“Headmaster Valerius Ashmoor,” she says. “He’s a blood mage. Those are extremely rare, practically extinct and extremely powerful. He’s the only one I know of in Valen.”

Sounds powerful and intimidating. “And what’s he like?”

She thinks about it for a second. “Intense.”

Before I can ask anything else, the girl in front of us steps away from the desk. An older woman with pointed ears and thin spectacles looks up at me, offering a polite smile.

“Name, dear?”

I clear my throat. “Maelis Rose.”

Her hand pauses before she opens a large drawer beside her. She flips through several folders before pulling one free. Her brows knit together as she scans the page then looks at me. Then back at the paper. Then at me again.

She hesitates then slides the sheet across the counter.

“Thank you,” Elizabeth says quickly, plucking the schedule before I can even reach for it.

I realize I’m still staring at the woman, caught on the way her smile has faded into something strained.

“Come on,” Elizabeth says, tugging me toward the door. “Let’s see what you’ve got.”

I let her pull me back outside as she glances over the parchment. “Architecture of Flesh. Fracture and Form. Mortal Limitations. And Triage of the Damned.”

My stomach tightens. None of those sound like topics I know anything about.

“That’s…a lot,” I mutter.

She snorts. “Welcome to bone year. That’s not even all of them. You’ll have six classes and two labs, not to mention ward hours, but you won’t have them all every day.” Her eyes light up. “Look on the bright side. You’ve got Professor Nestor for Architecture of Flesh and one of your labs.”

She finally hands the schedule over, beaming like she has delivered good news. I glance down at the parchment, catching glimpses of days, times, and unfamiliar professor names before my brain threatens to short-circuit. I fold the paper and shove it into my pocket.

“Who’s Professor Nestor?” I ask. “And are you being sarcastic, or is that actually a good thing? I honestly can’t tell with you.”

She laughs, “I didn’t have him last year, but he’s supposed to be kind of a mad genius. Everyone says he’s brilliant but unpredictable.”

That does absolutely nothing to calm me. At least with other students I’ll be able to hide in the back and never have to interact directly with any of the faculty or staff. They’ll probably never know I’m here.

A deep male voice from behind startles me out of my thoughts.

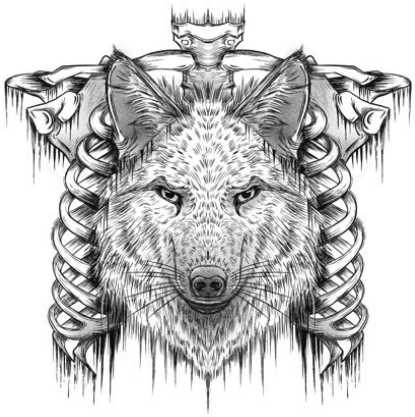
“Maelis Rose, you’ve been summoned to the headmaster’s office.”

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Chapter Five

"Among documented bloodlines, blood mages exhibit the highest recorded capacity for current density and manipulation."

— Bloodline Physiology, Volume II



I turn to see who spoke and fight the instinct to gasp.

He's tall and wide with dark-brown hair that sticks up in sharp, uneven spikes, but it's his eyes that steal my attention. Red. Not a soft or warm red, but a deep crimson, split down the center by vertical slits instead of rounded pupils.

Predatory.

"Why?" Elizabeth asks beside me before I can say or do anything other than stare.

"You really think he told me?" the male replies flatly. "He said to find you since you were assigned as her mentor." His gaze shifts to me. "You are Maelis Rose, right?"

I nod.

"This is Felix," she says, crossing her arms and narrowing her eyes at him. "He's a brown-nosing demon who plays assistant to the headmaster."

Felix sighs.

"Go ahead," she adds, already turning away. "I'll head to the library and pick up your books for you. Head back to your room after." She waves

dismissively in his direction and stalks off before I can protest. I glance between her retreating back and the demon beside me.

“After you then,” I say.

Felix turns and starts walking. I fall into step beside him.

“So,” I say, sneaking a sideways glance at him, “you’re a demon?”

“Last I checked,” he says under his breath.

The tone makes it very clear the conversation is over, and I guess I’m perfectly fine with that. I have more important things to worry about at the moment.

Maybe the headmaster will know something about what was written at the bottom of my invitation to Ashwell. Maybe he will be able to tell me if my father was the one who applied for me in the first place. We cross yet another stretch of stone walkway covered in ice. Gods, I am certainly going to stay fit here with how far apart everything is. I won’t be jogging with Jace anymore, but it seems I will be getting my exercise simply trying to navigate the layout of this school’s campus.

We finally stop in front of a tall, narrow stone tower riddled with arched windows that stretch skyward, disappearing into the drifting gray above. Once inside, warmth rushes over me, so I tug off my jacket and drape it over my arm before I start sweating. The contrast from the bitter cold outside makes my skin prickle as I follow Felix up several flights of stairs, the steady echo of our footsteps bouncing off the stone walls.

Felix stops at a single door tucked along a quiet landing and lifts a finger, pointing.”Knock. He’ll see you when he’s ready.”

Then he turns and descends the stairs, leaving me alone in the corridor.

A flicker of panic stirs. Why do I suddenly feel like I’m in trouble?

I lift my hand, hesitating inches from the door, when it creaks open on its own.

A spike of tension slides down my spine.

I have no idea if he opened it with magic or if the door simply sensed my presence, but either possibility is unsettling. Blood mage, whatever the fuck that means. I clear my throat louder than necessary and peer inside.

He sits at a massive desk near the far side of the room, head bowed, attention fixed on something in front of him, as though I am not standing here at all.

I step inside and quietly close the door behind me then glance around as I move toward the chair positioned in front of his desk. The walls are lined

from floor to ceiling with shelves overflowing with books, not arranged neatly for show but stacked in layered rows. Between the shelves are glass bottles filled with softly glowing liquids, trays of metal instruments shaped for purposes I cannot begin to guess, and strange trinkets that hum faintly with restrained energy. The space feels less like an office and more like a private laboratory fused with a personal library.

Every instinct in me wants to drift closer, to study the shelves, to touch something, to understand any of it. Instead, I lower myself into the chair, folding my hands in my lap and forcing my spine straight.

“Maelis Rose,” he says, still not looking up.

I swear I have heard my full name more in the past twenty-four hours than in my entire life.

“Yes,” I answer.

“You didn’t apply to Ashwell,” he says, dark reddish-brown hair slipping loose over his forehead as he flips a page in the book he’s reading.

“I know.” I’m not sure what he’s getting at or how he even knows that. Shit, maybe the fae who came to collect me told him what I said. He can’t send me away now. I haven’t found anything out yet, and things are just starting to get interesting.

“Yet, you’re here.”

Silence stretches between us until he snaps the book shut. The sharp sound makes me flinch. I look from the closed cover to him as his head finally lifts, dark eyes meeting mine. Brown so deep they border on black, heavy-lidded and assessing. The kind of gaze that feels less like being looked at and more like being weighed.

“You’re aware Ashwell doesn’t accept humans,” he continues.

My jaw tightens. “So I’ve been told.”

“And yet you arrived without reluctance.”

His gaze drags over me slowly, from my face to my boots and back again, clinical and unhurried, like he’s taking inventory.

“You have to know you’re unremarkable.”

I want to say the same about him, but it would be a lie.

He is broad-shouldered and solid, built like someone who has never needed to rely on speed. His features are sharp without being delicate. A dark, neatly kept beard frames his jaw, threaded faintly with silver even though he doesn’t look truly old, though I don’t know how blood mages age. There is nothing flashy about him. No ornamentation. No excess.

And yet the room feels oriented around his presence. Power radiates from him in a quiet, oppressive way that has me on edge, I've never felt anything like it.

I shift in my seat. "Then why am I sitting in your office?"

He rises, steps around the desk, and stops directly in front of me, tall enough that I have to tilt my chin up. He leans back against the edge of his desk, folding his arms loosely.

"Because something about you doesn't align with what you claim to be."

My brows lift. "A human."

He flicks an invisible piece of lint from the sleeve of his black coat. The fabric is simple, tailored, and immaculate.

"You were raised by a human healer."

"My father—"

"Was a competent man," he cuts in.

My ire rises at the back-handed compliment. "He was the best healer in Ironfen, even beyond that."

Ashmoor studies my reaction.

"Admiration is a weakness," he says. "Attachment even more so."

"You didn't bring me here just to insult my family."

"No," he says, "I brought you here because whatever you are won't survive without toughening up. You will attend every assigned class. You will not request special treatment. You will not expect leniency."

I swallow.

"You will work harder than your peers because you won't be as good as them," he continues. "You will fail faster, you will bleed sooner, and you will adapt, or you will be gone."

His eyes narrow, and my anxiety rises.

"If you were ordinary," Ashmoor adds, "you'd already be dead."

She signed the divorce papers. Now he wants to talk.

Sometimes the best part is watching him earn a second chance. Find your next read at Lokepub.

I don’t know what that means and don’t know if I should be pissed or terrified.

“Why do you care?” I ask.

Something flickers across his face. “Because wasted potential offends me.” He turns away, returning to his chair. “You may leave.”

I push to my feet. I want to ask how I’m here or who applied for me, if it was my father. The questions feel urgent, but none of them escape.

I turn toward the door.

“Maelis Rose.”

I stop without looking back.

“Do not attempt to become a healer like your father. Become better.”

His voice follows me into the corridor as I step out and pull the door shut, drawing in a long, steadying breath.

Once I’m down the stairs and back outside, I tug my jacket on and start speed walking toward the dormitories, keeping my eyes fixed on the ground. I don’t want to see anyone else and don’t want anyone looking at me.

What about me screams human anyway? How can they all supposedly tell? Maybe they can’t. Maybe I let the headmaster work his way under my skin and now am spiraling for no reason. I try to steady my breathing as I weave through courtyards and cut across several narrow paths, barely paying attention to where I’m going.

It isn’t until the space around me grows too quiet that I realize I’ve wandered somewhere more unfamiliar than the grounds I covered with Elizabeth.

The path opens into what looks like a garden, though it feels wrong to call it that. Snow blankets nearly everything, broken only by narrow stone walkways and clusters of dark, skeletal trees. Most of the branches are dead and brittle, stripped bare by winter, except for the occasional light-blue trumpet flower drooping from frozen stems, their soft glow standing out unnervingly against all the gray. There are no voices here. No movement, as if this part of the grounds has been forgotten.

I slow without meaning to.

Statues line the garden, spaced between the trees and bare hedges along the path, but they are nothing like the ornamental fountains or gentle angels you’d expect to see in a village square. These are grotesque. A winged man bends over a body, stone fingers buried deep inside a cracked-open chest,

ribs splayed outward, a heart exposed. The detail is horrifyingly precise, every feather, every tendon, every groove of bone carved so realistically I don’t want to look away.

I turn quickly, my boot sliding on a patch of ice, and I stumble hard, landing on the stone with a sharp gasp as pain shoots through my tailbone.

When I look up, my blood turns to ice.

A massive black wolf stands inches from my face.

Its lips curl back in a low snarl, long teeth bared, glowing eyes locked onto mine with terrifying focus. My heart slams so violently it feels like it might break free from my ribs. I don’t know if it’s a shifter, something like Elizabeth’s bat, or some kind of wild animal that broke in here.

I slowly lift my hands, palms open, afraid to stand or move at all.

“Sorry,” I whisper.

I squeeze my eyes shut, bracing for teeth.

Nothing happens.

When I dare to look again, the wolf is trotting away, circling the legs of a man leaning against a stone pillar several yards away. He’s watching me, honey gold eyes stark against warm golden skin. His dark hair falls to his shoulders, half tied into a loose bun, dusted with snowflakes as if he’s been standing here longer than I’d like to think about.

The wolf presses against his side.

My legs feel unsteady as I push myself upright, brushing snow and ice from my clothes without lifting my gaze.

When I finally look up again, they’re gone, leaving an empty garden and a cold, crawling sense that I was never alone at all.



I eventually found my way back to my room. Elizabeth isn’t here, but a neat stack of books is on my desk beside a folded map of the school. I shrug off my coat and cross the room, pulling my schedule from my pocket and smoothing it out across the worn wood.

A small handwritten note is on top of the stack.

“Orientation is at 3 p.m. in the Grand Hall. Don’t be late.”

I read it twice before setting it aside then pick up the map and scan the layout. The Grand Hall isn't far, two buildings over connected by an enclosed walkway one story up.

That's something at least.

I glance at the small clock mounted above my desk, and it's already ten past two. I don't know where the day went, only that everything here feels like a blur layered on top of another blur. Too many faces. Too many corridors and pathways. Too many things I don't understand yet.

I don't want to wrestle with the heavy coat again if I can use the enclosed walkway, so I pull off my shirt and slip into one of the button-up long-sleeve sweaters instead. The fabric is soft, warm enough. It'll do.

In the bathroom, I run the brush through my hair then pause when I catch my reflection.

No pointed ears. No unusual pupils. No glowing eyes. No wings.

But not all bloodlines have such conspicuous characteristics. The headmaster looked human enough, and so did half the people I passed in the courtyard, even though I knew they weren't.

What about me makes people look twice? What gives me away as human?

I tilt my head slightly, studying my face the way I've done a thousand times before, but it feels different now, like I'm searching for something that's never been there. My skin is pale, dusted faintly pink across my cheeks. My nose is straight and covered in freckles that fan out beneath my eyes. Lips full enough that my mother used to tease me about them when I was younger, always saying I'd grow into them one day.

Maybe I did.

My eyes are dark brown, almost espresso colored when the sun hits just right. I've always wished they were green or blue like everyone else in my family, something brighter and softer, but my father used to say they gave me character, whatever that means.

My hair has always been the one thing people notice.

It's a deep-coppery red, not bright like fire but rich, warm, the kind that catches light and holds onto it. It falls down my back, thick enough that it takes effort to tame but mercifully not the wild, unmanageable curls my mother battles every morning. I drag the brush through it again, watching it spill over my shoulders, familiar and strangely foreign at the same time.

I glance down, taking in the rest of myself.

I’ve never been delicate. I’m not thin, not willowy, but I am fit, built from years of hauling supplies, standing on my feet all day in the clinic, helping lift patients when no one else was around. Curves where I should have them. Strength where it counts. A body that’s always felt practical rather than ornamental.

Today, it feels like something else.

I’m being measured against a scale I don’t understand.

I lean closer to the mirror, searching for something hidden beneath skin and bone, some invisible mark that explains why I’m here and why everyone seems to know I don’t belong.

The reflection offers nothing back.

Just me, unremarkable Maelis.

But in the back of my mind, the question still gnaws at me. What the headmaster said is replaying on a loop. *“If you were ordinary, you'd already be dead.”*

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Chapter Six

"Ashwell does not simply house current. It generates, circulates, and adapts it, exhibiting behavior consistent with autonomous cognition and unclear intent."

— Professor Nestor's private notes



"Looks like we're neighbors. You headed to orientation?"

The pink-haired girl I noticed in the courtyard this morning stands outside her door as I shut mine. I nod and start toward the end of the hall.

"I'm Lux," she says, quickening her pace to walk beside me.

"Maelis." I manage a small, automatic smile, though my thoughts are still stuck on everything the headmaster said and the way this entire day keeps sliding sideways. If anything, it only hardens my resolve. I'm determined now more than ever to prove I belong here. I don't like being underestimated or dismissed because I'm human and a woman. And I really don't like being spoken to like I'm already doomed to fail, and that's exactly how he made me feel in his office. I still don't even know why he summoned me there. Apparently to get a look at the human girl.

"I know," Lux says easily. "News has traveled fast that there's a human at Ashwell, but I think it's great. Humans are always overlooked."

I glance over at her, surprised.

She isn’t smirking or teasing. There’s no edge in her tone, and I think she’s being sincere.

For a split-second, I don’t know what to say.

I’d always imagined fae as aloof, superior, convinced they are better than everyone else by default. Maybe that’s unfair. Maybe it’s an assumption I’ve carried without realizing it.

“Come on,” Lux says, already turning down the corridor. “It’s easy to get lost up here, but I know the way. My father’s a professor, so I’ve been wandering these halls longer than I care to admit.”

That earns a sideways glance from me. “And this is still your first year?”

She nods. “Ashwell doesn’t care about age. It cares about readiness. Some people arrive at twenty. Some don’t arrive until their late thirties, I’m twenty six so I guess I’m the middle of the pack. Most of the youngest students are in their early twenties though.” Her mouth curves faintly. “Almost everyone has some kind of medical background already. Healers, field medics, battlefield attendants. If they don’t, then they were exceptional somewhere else. Top of their class, unusual aptitude, or they did something that caught the academy’s attention.”

That makes my skin prickle.

We cross one of the enclosed upper walkways, the stone arches framing drifting snow and jagged mountain silhouettes beyond the windows. The glass is rimmed with frost, spiderwebbed with thin cracks that catch the light. Below us, I can glimpse lower courtyards and students moving all about in the distance.

“Everyone talks about this place like it chooses people,” I say as we walk. “When you say the academy, do you mean the headmaster?”

Lux slows then turns her head toward me, studying me. “No. I mean Ashwell.”

I frown. “The building?”

“This place is alive,” she says quietly. “The walls, the floors, the towers. They’re threaded with current from the core.”

“Current,” I repeat. My brow lifts.

She reaches out and gently tugs my sleeve, stopping us near one of the arched windows. “Yes, magic and current are basically the same thing. People use them interchangeably, but professors always say current.”

“Why?”

“Because magic makes it sound…mystical, like a trick.” Her mouth quirks. “Current sounds more honest.”

I tilt my head. “How?”

She blows out a breath. “Do you know the three types of current?”

I shake my head.

“Okay,” she says, leaning against the window, her blue eyes focused on mine. “First is bloodline current. Think instinct. It’s tied to species and expressed naturally. I’m fae, so I have fae abilities. Demons have theirs. Vampires, angels, shifters, mages etcetera. Every bloodline has its own way of interacting with the current.”

That tracks. I picture Elizabeth’s bat dissolving into mist, Jace’s wings, the demon’s slit pupils. “So it’s something you’re born able to do.”

“Exactly.”

“And the second type?”

“Structured current. Learned magic includes alchemy, runes, sigils, and spoken spells. It’s built, not instinctive.”

“So Ashwell teaches medicine and structured magic on top of whatever someone already has.”

Lux nods. “That’s the idea.”

We start walking again, the sounds of voices echoing in the distance.

“And the third?” I ask.

“Core-driven current.”

The way she says it is different, quieter like it’s something to fear.

“What does that mean?”

“It means the magic doesn’t come from the world,” she says. “It comes from the caster, from the soul itself.”

I try to wrap my head around that. “How is that different from bloodline magic?”

She presses her lips together, thinking. “Okay, imagine current is a massive underground river running beneath everything. Bloodline users open channels to that river and let it flow through them. Core-driven casters are the spring, the source. They generate it.”

A chill moves through me that has nothing to do with the temperature. “That sounds dangerous.”

“It is,” she says then shrugs. “But it’s also powerful.”

She snickers, “We’ll get the official version in class. Professors explain it better than I ever could.”

“No, I appreciate you telling me,” I say. “I grew up in a tiny village. Most of what I know about magic comes from stories and rumors.”

Her expression softens. “Yeah, you’re starting on hard mode.”

We reach the top of a wide staircase carved directly into the stone wall. As we descend, Lux rests her hand briefly on the banister, fingers trailing along the surface.

“Anyway,” she says, “the reason I brought all of that up is because Ashwell has core-driven current.”

I stop again.

“The school?”

She nods. “Not enchanted or layered with spells. The heart of Ashwell is a living core. It repairs itself, regulates temperature, maintains wards, moves structures and adjusts lighting, sometimes even redirects hallways.”

It sounds unfathomable.

“And the headmaster controls all that?”

Lux shakes her head. “No, Ashwell does. The school selects its students, not the headmaster or the professors.”

Now I’m painfully aware of every wall we pass, every arch, every shadowed corner, like something is looking back at me as we pass.

“When you say it like that,” I murmur, “it’s a little creepy.”

Lux lets out a quiet laugh. “Most people cope by not thinking about it.”

“That’s worse.”

Her smile tilts. “You’ll fit right in.”

We reach a massive set of double doors as they begin to swing inward on silent hinges.

“One more thing,” I say, “is Ashwell the only place that has core-driven current?”

She sucks her teeth. “The only place, but not the only beings.”

I glance at her.

“Blood mages,” she adds under her breath, “are the only other known source.”

My mouth goes dry. “That’s why they’re such a big deal?”

Billionaires who fall first. Alphas who have to earn her trust.

Search **Lokepub** on Google when you feel like a romance with a little more tension.

“That’s why they’re terrifying and nearly extinct.”

The doors finish opening.

Warmth, candlelight, and low murmurs spill out as the Grand Hall unfolds in front of us.

The ceiling disappears into shadow, supported by massive timber beams darkened with age. Circular tables ring the perimeter of the room, arranged in deliberate arcs, leaving the center open. A long strip of dark-red carpet runs through the middle, leading toward a low stage at the far end.

Behind it rise three towering arched windows, stretching from floor to ceiling, each one revealing a sweeping view of Frostlands beyond.

Above each window, a symbol is carved into the stone and faintly illuminated.

A wolf framed by a ribcage, glowing amethyst.

A heart bound by a serpent, glowing crimson.

A bat with wings spread wide above a pair of lungs, glowing pale blue.

Those symbols really are all over this school.

Lux leans closer, her voice dropping. “This is where people find out whether they’re built for this…or whether Ashwell made a mistake.”

Great.

The room is already more than half full, tables crowded with unfamiliar faces, the air threaded with overlapping voices and restless movement. Students continue to pour in behind us, boots scraping against stone, cloaks brushing past shoulders, laughter flaring in uneven bursts.

“Come on,” Lux murmurs, fingers closing around mine.

She tugs me forward before I can argue, charting a course through clusters of bodies, offering quick smiles and murmured apologies as we pass. We end up at a table near the front along the outer edge of the room, sliding into two empty seats beside a blonde girl with her hair braided loosely over one shoulder. A thin silver ring pierces the center of her bottom lip, and she keeps nudging it back and forth with her tongue as she watches the crowd like she’s already bored.

“This is Ellavee,” Lux says, motioning to the blonde. “She grew up in Whitehaven. It’s one of the few villages in the Frostlands.”

Ellavee’s eyes shift to me, impassively assessing like she’s filing me away in her memory.

“Hi.” Her mouth twitches.

“Do your parents teach here too?” I ask, glancing between them. “Is that how you know each other?”

Lux shakes her head. “Nope. When my dad isn’t buried in work, we stay in Whitehaven. Been running into each other since we were little.”

“Unfortunately,” Ellavee adds.

Lux bumps her shoulder. “She loves me.”

Ellavee doesn’t deny it.

I blurt out, “So…what are you? I mean, what bloodline?”

Ellavee arches a brow.

“Straight to the personal questions,” she says. “Bold.”

Heat creeps up my neck. “Sorry. You don’t have to answer.”

“I’m a demon.”

My eyes widen before I can stop myself. “You don’t have the vertical pupils like the guy I met earlier.”

Someone a few seats down snorts.

Lovely.

Ellavee leans forward, resting her forearms on the table. “You mean like this?”

She blinks, and her pupils stretch, narrowing into sharp vertical slits, then she blinks again to bring them back to normal. “We can control it,” she says, settling back. “I only use the scary version when I want something.”

Lux grins. “Which is always.”

Ellavee shrugs.

I swallow, nodding like this is all perfectly normal.

Ellavee tilts her head, studying me now with more interest than before. “You’re the human.”

“Yeah,” I say.

“Huh,” she murmurs like I’m a mildly interesting puzzle. Then she looks toward the front. “Orientation’s about to start.”

The moment Headmaster Ashmoor steps onto the stage, an unseen pressure settles across the hall, thinning conversation until voices taper into nothing. Gazes fix on the tall figure at the front of the room, his posture

rigid, his hands clasped behind his back, his dark eyes moving slowly across the first year students as if committing each face to memory.

“Welcome to Ashwell Academy of Medicine and Alchemy,” he announces, his voice carrying. “You sit here because something about you suggested potential.”

His eyes drift across my table, and I become painfully aware of my own breathing. A faint ripple of unease passes through the hall.

“Ashwell exists for one purpose,” he continues, “to produce Veilguards. They are not menders. They are not assistants. They are not sent to ease suffering. They are stabilizers of catastrophe. When fissures open, reality destabilizes. Current surges. Bodies fail in ways conventional healing cannot address. Veilguards enter these environments not to fight but to prevent collapse. They decide who survives and whether entire regions fall into chaos or remain standing.”

His eyes narrow slightly.

“The cycle will come again. It always does. It has been more than a century since the last, and we are far overdue. But even in the absence of an active cycle, fissures form. Twisted creatures and crawlers cross through. Plagues emerge. Corruption spreads. Veilguards are deployed constantly as an ongoing necessity.”

I swallow, unable to look away from him.

“You have been selected for a three-year program. Bone year is your foundation, and it is where most of you will fail. You study anatomy across all known bloodlines. You learn how their bodies work. You learn to stabilize catastrophic injuries and cut out corruption. You learn to realign shattered bones, set compound fractures, reduce dislocations, and reconstruct structural damage under pressure. You learn to control hemorrhaging through physical intervention and basic current, and you learn when current will make the situation worse rather than better.

“You are not taught in silence. You are not taught in safety. You are taught in noise, in blood, in smoke, and in chaos. You are taught while people scream. You will be injured. You will make mistakes. You will watch patients die while your hands are still inside their bodies. Ashwell does not simulate danger. It exposes you to it. You will be deployed to controlled fissure zones before this year ends. Some of those zones will become uncontrolled while you are inside them.”

A nervous murmur ripples through the crowd.

“Some of you will die during training. Some of you will withdraw because you cannot endure the psychological toll. Some of you will fail academically and be dismissed. Veilguards are the most elite healers in Valen not because they possess superior compassion but because they endure what others cannot. While you are not trained as front-line combatants, you will receive combat instruction. You will learn how to defend yourselves long enough to reach your patients.

“Many of you arrive with training. Some of you arrive with experience. That grants you nothing here. Ashwell does not care who you were before you crossed its gates.”

So in his office earlier he wasn’t merely being an asshole to me. It seems this is his personality in general. Intense is an understatement.

“By the end of this year, you either possess a functional understanding of living anatomy across bloodlines or you are not here. If you remain, you proceed to blood year. If you remain after that, breath year. Graduation is not guaranteed.

“I trust your mentors for the day have provided your class schedules and books. Classes begin at first light tomorrow. The Mirror Ceremony has been pushed until tomorrow night. Not all of you will make it even that far.”

His eyes shift, finding mine. My throat tightens, but I don’t look away. His eyes narrow briefly, seemingly looking through me.

“You’re dismissed.”

He steps down from the stage and disappears through a side door, leaving the room suspended in stunned silence.

I realize I’ve been holding my breath.

“Welcome to Ashwell,” Ellavee mutters, a humorless huff slipping from her as she pushes back from the table and stands.

Chairs scrape across the floor all around us as the room begins to empty, conversation returning in low, unsettled murmurs. Lux rises beside me, and I follow them both automatically, drifting a step behind as they start talking about something I don’t quite catch. Their voices blur together, distant and muffled, my mind still tangled in everything the headmaster said, in everything he implied.

I barely register where my feet are taking me, then something pale catches the corner of my eye, a flash of silvery white.

I turn.

A tall young man stands a few rows away, light-colored wings folded neatly behind his back, feathers catching the glow of the sconces along the walls. My gaze locks instinctively, tracing the familiar line of his shoulders, the curve of his jaw.

And then his eyes meet mine.

Blue. Impossible, unmistakable blue.

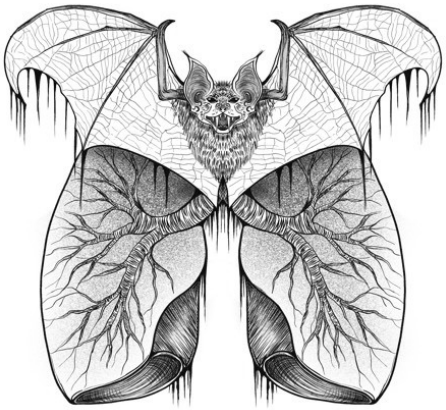
Jace.

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Chapter Seven

"The crawlers and twisted creatures who emerge from the fissures exhibit violent instinct, distorted anatomy, and nonviable organ systems. Specimen recovery is secondary. Allied survival is absolute."

— Triage of the Damned, Professor Bale Field Doctrine



Jace.

The name forms in my head before my lips can shape it, and my chest constricts so sharply it almost hurts.

He stares at me like he's seeing a ghost.

My eyes burn, but I blink hard, refusing to let the tears spill as Jace is suddenly here, arms wrapping around me, lifting me clean off the ground in a fierce, familiar hug. His warmth and sweet scent anchor me in a way nothing else here has managed to. He always smells so sweet, no matter how long he's away from his parents' bakery. I swear he still smells like cinnamon and sugar.

"Maelis, it's really you." He sets me back on my feet but doesn't let go, hands sliding up to cup my face as his gaze drags over me. "How are you here? How is this possible?"

I shake my head, a breathless huff slipping out. "I have no idea, honestly."

Movement in my peripheral pulls my attention, and I realize Lux and Ellavee have stopped a few steps away, openly watching us. Heat creeps into my cheeks.

“This is Lux,” I say quickly, gesturing between them. “And Ellavee. They’re bone years too.”

Jace gives them a distracted nod, eyes already drifting back to me like he’s afraid I might vanish if he looks away for too long.

“Come back to my dorm,” I add, clutching his sleeve. “We need to talk.”

We go back to my room, and I tell him everything.

“I can’t believe the headmaster said those things to you,” Jace says, lying beside me on the bed. “But more than that, I still can’t believe we’re both at Ashwell Academy.”

“I know,” I murmur. “Gods, I’m so thankful you’re here.”

I squeeze him tighter, my head resting on his chest, arm draped over his torso.

“Hey,” he says gently, “it looks like you already made friends.”

I scoff, “Lux seems nice enough. Ellavee…we barely had time to say two words to each other.”

He chuckles under his breath.

“I hope my mom and sister aren’t worried about me,” I add. “I didn’t get to say goodbye or pack. I didn’t get to explain anything.”

“That part’s strange, being taken so suddenly like that. Maybe they handled things differently because you’re human. My parents would have been pissed if I didn’t get to tell them where I was going and say goodbye.”

His hand trails slowly up and down my back, steady and warm, and I could fall asleep like this.

But I haven’t eaten much of anything today, and I promised Lux I’d go with her to the descent tonight. It’s some kind of party down in one of the basements, put on by blood and breath years to welcome the new students before classes start tomorrow.

I don’t much feel like going to a party in some creepy basement the night before I have to wake up early and take what will probably be some of the most demanding classes anyone has ever taken.

But I also don’t want to start my time here by not making friends.

It’s already going to be hard enough for me to fit in, given the obvious, so I’ll at least make an appearance and hopefully meet a few more people.

It’s too much to think about, and I want to clear my mind, eyes fluttering closed.

Shit.

I jolt upright at the knock, the movement nearly tangling me in the blankets as Jace stirs beside me with a groan. For a second, I’m disoriented, heart thudding, then memory rushes back all at once. The orientation. Lux. The descent.

I glance at the dark window.

My eyes snap to the clock on the wall.

Half past nine.

“Oh no,” I mutter, scrambling out of bed and nearly tripping over my own feet as I cross the room and yank open the door.

Lux stands in the hallway, perfectly awake and infuriatingly put together, her gaze sweeping over me. I’m still wearing the sweater and pants I pulled on earlier, hair slightly mussed, face bare except for lip balm.

“Are you planning on going like that?” she asks.

She’s wearing a long, flowing blue dress that brushes her ankles, paired with a light-pink corset that matches her hair almost exactly. Soft, delicate, and somehow still dangerous in that effortless fae way.

“I didn’t realize it was that kind of party,” I say, glancing back at Jace, who’s sitting up on my bed and rubbing his face.

“I’ll be right back,” Lux says, already turning on her heels.

I leave the door open and hurry toward the bathroom. I can’t believe we fell asleep.

“I’m gonna go change,” Jace says behind me. “I’ll meet you guys there.”

I hear his footsteps fade down the hall as I step inside and start pulling open drawers, expecting to find nothing useful, but I see some of my things from home are here.

I smooth on my shiny lip balm and darken my lashes then turn as Lux reappears in the doorway.

“Here,” she says, thrusting a garment into my hands. “Put this on.”

I change quickly, slipping into a short black dress with long sleeves made of sheer lace that hugs my arms and dips low enough at the neckline to make me feel painfully aware of my own body. It’s like nothing I would find back home.

When I look in the mirror, I barely recognize myself.

“You look great,” she says, beaming.

“Thank you,” I reply, meaning it. “So do you.”

I slip on my black loafers then edge toward the doorway and peer into the hall, half expecting to see other students.

“Is Ellavee coming with us?”

Lux shrugs, looping her arm through mine as we step out. “She hit it off with some guy and might show up later, but she was heading to his dorm first.”

Hope that guy knows he’s about to hop into bed with a demon.

We trek clear across the campus, Lux guiding us through enclosed passageways, heated corridors, and narrow connecting halls that feel like veins running through the mountain. Eventually, we’re forced outside, the cold slamming into us the second we step through an exterior door.

Neither of us brought jackets.

We break into a jog, shoes crunching over snow as we race for the next building, breath puffing white in the air. By the time Lux shoves open the heavy doors ahead of us, my fingers are numb, and my cheeks burn.

The warmth almost feels painful against my frozen skin.

“This should be it,” Lux says, lowering her voice as she leads us past the main entry and toward the back of what seems to be a medical building.

We slip through another door and into a narrow stairwell spiraling downward, the light dimmer here, the air cooler and strangely still. The deeper we go, the quieter everything becomes, the distant hum of the campus fading.

“What’s this clinical hall used for anyway?” I ask, peering around, trying to reconcile this eerie silence with the idea of a party happening somewhere below us.

Lux glances over her shoulder. “The ten floors above us are patient wards. Surgical amphitheaters too.”

I snap my head toward her. “Ashwell has real patients? Like an actual clinic?”

She nods, smirking at me as if this is common knowledge. “Anyone who can’t afford treatment or can’t be cured anywhere else eventually finds their way here. People get desperate enough to let students practice on them in exchange for a chance at living. If they’re lucky, a Veilguard might take their case.”

We reach the bottom of the stairs and step into a long, narrow corridor that stretches through the basement, lit by widely spaced sconces casting weak pools of amber light across the low ceiling.

We turn the corner and catch sight of two men slipping through a large metal door at the end of the corridor. The moment it opens, a swell of voices pours into the hall, carrying with it a wave of warmth and purple hues. Lux and I exchange quick grins before breaking into a light jog. I was beginning to think the party wasn't real.

We spill through the doorway and straight into heat, noise, and motion.

The basement cavern opens wide, its ceiling vaulted high above us and ribbed with exposed beams. Clusters of flickering orbs drift near the ceiling, casting the space in shades of purple and soft shadows that slide over stone and skin alike.

"Those are fae lights," Lux says, nudging my shoulder.

I glance up again, watching the floating glow sway gently overhead as we weave deeper into the crowd. Purple must be intentional to celebrate bone year students' arrival.

I spot a long wooden table buried beneath trays of bread, sliced meat, fruit, and hunks of cheese and remember with a wince that I slept straight through dinner. I snag a couple pieces of cheese as we pass, barely slowing, and shove them into my mouth, chewing fast while trying not to look feral.

A brunette man on my left laughs. "Rough first day?"

"You have no idea," I mumble around a mouthful.

"Want to tell me about it?"

I turn toward him. He has dark-golden eyes and a stubbled jaw, the kind of face that looks better the longer you stare at it. There's something about him that pulls at my attention, though I can't quite place why.

"If I start listing everything, are you offering sympathy…or a distraction?"

One corner of his mouth lifts, his gaze flicking briefly to my lips before meeting mine again. "Definitely a distraction," he says. "Sympathy costs extra."

I laugh through my nose. "Bold strategy, considering you don't even know my name."

His eyes drift over my face then drops lower as he checks me out. "Mystery keeps things interesting."

I roll my eyes, but Lux has disappeared into the crowd, and I decide to play along.

"What are you drinking?" I ask, nodding toward his glass.

He runs his tongue over his bottom lip before smirking. "Oh, you don't want this, Red. But I think I can find something you'll like."

This guy must think he's real cute, already handing out pet names.

I let him lead me toward the drink cart anyway. He grabs one of the premixed bottles, pours into a narrow glass, and passes it to me. The liquid looks clear, though it's hard to tell under the purple glow drifting through the cavern.

He steers me toward one of the tall standing tables tucked into a back corner where the noise dulls.

I lift the glass, take a sip, and immediately regret my life choices. I cough, bringing the glass away from my mouth. Whatever it is burns straight down.

He grins like he was waiting for that.

"Strong," I manage, setting the glass on the table between us.

"Builds character," he says, taking an easy swallow of his own.

I squint at him. "So…what year are you?"

"Blood."

Of course he is.

"You have any advice for surviving my bone year?" I ask mostly out of obligation, my attention drifting across the room. It catches on the man from the courtyard earlier, the one with the massive black wolf. He's posted in a shadowed corner, shoulder to the wall, drink loose in his hand. Those honey-gold eyes don't blink as they lock onto mine.

I hold the stare a second too long.

"Oh, Red," the guy beside me says, leaning in, "I'll give you all the tips you want…from my room tonight." His mouth curves as his hand drops lower, gripping his crotch. "Got a pretty good one waiting for you here."

Disgusting. Any interest I might've had dies instantly.

"I'll pass," I say, stepping away from the table.

He catches my waist, fingers digging in enough to make it clear he's not giving up. "Don't be rude. We were having a conversation."

I look up then look down at his hand.

"Don't touch me," I say evenly. "I don't have anything else to say to you, or your tiny tip."

I peel his hand off, glance at him once for emphasis, then turn and walk away.

“You don’t want to make an enemy out of me, Red,” he calls.

I don’t look back. Guess I made my first enemy.

So far, Ashwell has a headmaster who seems determined to break me and a blood year with a sense of entitlement and boundary issues. Fun.

I head back to the food table, grab a few more pieces of cheese, and shove them into my mouth. As I scan the room, a flash of light pink catches my eye.

I make a beeline for Lux.

“It’s supposed to be some kind of test,” a girl with black wings and violet eyes says from across the table, “an early way to see who’s going to cut it and who’s going to choke. The upperclassmen spend the party sizing everyone up and taking bets.”

“I heard the professors are even in on it,” another girl adds, this one with short dark hair and a scar across her chin. Her eyes slide to Lux. “Didn’t your father tell you anything? He had to have given you a little advantage.”

“What are you talking about?” I cut in.

“These two think tonight’s some kind of test for first years,” Lux says lightly, though her grip on her glass tightens.

If so, I’m glad I only had one sip of that awful drink earlier.

“What kind of test? Not all the bone years even came tonight.” I scan the crowd, counting quickly. “Maybe half of them.”

The girl with violet eyes shrugs, her wings shifting subtly against her back. “That makes it easier.”

“Come on,” Lux says, looping her arm through mine and steering us away from the table. “If they’re right, I probably shouldn’t indulge any more than I already have.” She sets her glass on a stone ledge as we stop near the wall.

My attention drifts again to the corner of the room. The guy with the man bun and honey-gold eyes still leans against the wall, scrutinizing the crowd. His eyes lift to mine, catching me looking.

“Hey,” I say quietly, nodding in his direction, “do you know who that is?”

Lux glances over my shoulder and snorts. “That’s Draven Alucard. He’s hot, he’s a vampire, and he’s a complete dick. Don’t waste your time.”

I look back at him, curiosity prickling. “How do you know him?”

Her smile turns sharp. “You like him.”

“No,” I say quickly, clearing my throat, “ I saw him in the courtyard earlier. He had a massive wolf with him that nearly took my head off.”

Lux’s expression shifts. “Yeah, I heard his father is high up at one of the other academies, Vanguard War Academy in the Shadowlands.”

I blink. “There are other academies?”

“Well, not like Ashwell,” she says. “This is the only healing academy, the only core-driven current one too. The others specialize in other things.”

“Like what?”

She leans back against the wall, fingers adjusting the laces of her corset. “War, hunting, law, exploration, things like that, but Ashwell’s considered superior.”

The fae lights overhead flicker, shifting abruptly from violet to stark white. The sudden brightness kills off any last conversations. The asshole blood year guy from earlier climbs onto a chair near the center or the cavern, drawing every eye in the room.

“For those of you who don’t know me,” he says, voice carrying easily over the sudden hush, “I’m Malric. I’ll be your official orchestrator of this year’s initiation.”

A ripple of low murmurs spreads through the crowd. Malric basks in the attention. His gaze sweeps the room slowly until it lands on me. A wicked smile curls across his face, and my throat tightens.

“Bone years,” he declares, “your assessment starts now.”

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Chapter Eight

"Keys forged within Ashwell do not open doors by design. They respond to necessity, danger, and intent when no other passage exists."

— Restricted Artifacts Registry



"I can't believe my father never told me about this," Lux mutters beside me, folding her arms across her chest. "After all these years, he had to know."

Across the room, clusters of blood and breath years lean together, voices low as they talk amongst each other. Whatever this is, they've been waiting for it.

Malric clears his throat and steps forward, drawing attention back to himself. "My fellow upper classmates are going to start breaking you into teams of four."

Lux and I instinctively edge closer, shoulders brushing, neither of us saying it out loud but both hoping the same thing. I scan the room and catch sight of Jace near the far wall, his wings half folded, his attention fixed on Malric. I consider slipping away to reach him then think better of it.

A sharp tap lands on my shoulder.

"You," a woman says, already turning away, "follow me."

I offer Lux a helpless look before stepping away and into the stream of moving bodies. We're lined up quickly and pushed around until I find

myself standing in a group of four. My stomach drops when I realize who's beside me, Draven and the violet-eyed girl from earlier. Our fourth teammate I haven't seen until now, a short and stocky guy with black glasses and slicked-back hair.

Malric announces, "The doors you passed in the hallway outside lead to the morgue's examination rooms. Each team has been assigned a body. Tonight, every one of you will perform an autopsy."

I swallow, forcing my breathing to stay even as my thoughts spiral. *Fuck.* I wish desperately that Jace were standing at my side instead.

"We know not all of you have previous medical experience," he continues, pacing slowly along the edge of the room, "which is why we've so generously provided a step-by-step instruction manual and checklist to guide you through the autopsy."

A scoff comes from a few bodies over. "What's the point?" a man calls out. "What's in it for us? Not everybody's even here, and you can't stop me from leaving."

Malric's smile sharpens, pleased by the question. "The winning team receives a prize. And trust me when I say it's something you'll want."

My eyes roll. Whatever he's promising sounds like bait, nothing more than hazing dressed up as opportunity.

"Bone years who didn't bother showing up tonight," Malric adds, "will be regretting that decision by morning."

Sure, if there even is a prize.

"How will the winning team be chosen?" a girl asks from somewhere behind me.

"All teams will be timed," he replies, "but speed alone won't decide the outcome. There is a grading criterion. Several factors will be considered, including how well you work as a team, whether you correctly identify the cause of death, your overall time, and which anomalies you accurately document."

A seedy smile spreads across his face. "Off to your exam rooms," he says, waving a dismissive hand, "boners."

We file out of the room in clusters of four, and our supervisor leads us down a narrow corridor to one of the exam rooms. The body is already laid out on the table when we step inside.

"Time starts now."

The woman assigned to supervise us reaches over and taps the timing device, and red numbers begin counting upward.

We all burst into action at once. Putting on gloves, gowns, and masks.

“Nyra, get the scale. Miles, uncover the body. Maelis, read the chart and take notes,” Draven says, calm and commanding, as though he has done this many times before.

I can see he thinks he is going to be team leader already. The way he stands, shoulders back, chin lifted slightly, radiates authority he hasn’t earned yet.

Fine, I will play along. For now.

“What the fuck?”

Nyra’s voice snaps through the room as she wheels the scale closer to the gurney with a harsh metallic scrape. I glance up from the instruction pages I’m holding as Miles pulls the sheet the rest of the way off the body.

What the fuck is right.

I have no idea what bloodline the body is. There are no obvious tells, no wings, no elongated canines, no animal body parts. It is humanoid enough but at the same time all wrong. The proportions are slightly off, the limbs too long, the joints bent at angles that suggest they once moved in ways joints should not.

I take a step closer to study it and have an uncomfortable realization.

It looks like the thing Jace and I ran into in the forest back home. The crazed man who attacked us and tried to take a bite out of Jace. A shiver spreads up my spine at the memory, the wild, unseeing eyes, the guttural sounds, and the creepy twitching motions he made when he moved.

I cannot believe I forgot to ask Jace if he went back to study the body that night.

Draven pulls a second stainless steel table alongside the gurney, already lined with neatly arranged instruments, scalpels of varying sizes, forceps, rib shears, and a bone saw wrapped in oiled cloth. Everything gleams under the harsh lights.

“It’s a crawler,” he says, lowering his head to catalogue the instruments.

“I’ve never seen one in person before.” Miles lifts one of the man’s hands, examining the bloody, shredded arm. His fingers are steady, but I notice the slight widening of his eyes above his face mask even through his fogged glasses.

“Neither have I,” Nyra says as she takes in the body. “I wonder if every team has a crawler.”

It clearly was a man at some point, but his body is covered in injuries, deep cuts, ragged claw marks, patches of skin torn away entirely to reveal the gray-pink tissue beneath. His eyes are open and abnormally red, as though every blood vessel burst at once and seeped into the whites and irises. He stares blankly at the ceiling.

What did he see in his final moments? Was any part of him still human enough to be afraid?

Nyra snatches the chart and instruction pages out of my hands, causing me to drop the ink pen. It clatters against the floor and rolls toward the drain in the center of the room.

“Here.” She shoves a scalpel into my palm, the metal cold even through my gloves. “You can start weighing the organs. I don’t want to touch that thing. Who knows if it’s contagious?”

I turn the scalpel over in my hand.

“Afraid you might catch something, Nyra?” Draven doesn’t look up from the instrument tray, but I can hear the smirk in his voice. “Cowardice, perhaps? I hear that spreads quickly.”

Nyra’s eyes narrow. “Excuse me?”

“You’re excused.” He finally glances up, honey eyes sharp. “But Maelis is not your assistant.”

Is he...defending me? So it is acceptable for him to order all of us around, but when Nyra does it, he has something to say about it. Interesting.

Draven’s gaze slides to mine, and whatever gratitude I might have felt evaporates instantly. There’s no warmth there, no camaraderie, only calculation.

“Don’t look so surprised, Freckles.” His eyebrow twitches, and I am certain there is a sarcastic smile hiding behind that mask. “I prefer my teammates competent. You can thank me later.”

“I’d rather swallow the scalpel,” I mutter.

“Kinky.” He turns back to the body. “But save the dramatics for after we win. First incision, who’s making it?”

“The human should make it.” Miles stands back next to Nyra, folding his arms across his chest. “She needs to prove she belongs here.”

“I have a name,” I mutter. I want to kick him, but instead I swallow the rage and take his place next to the body.

“Standard Y-incision.” Draven stands across from me on the other side of the gurney. “Acromion to acromion, meeting at the xiphoid process.”

I know he means cut from shoulder to shoulder and down the front of the sternum so we can open him up. I know the anatomy and have done this before.

I take a long inhale, forcing my lungs to expand. I can do this. I have assisted my father on autopsies before in the clinic back home. I have held tools like this one and made cuts like this one.

My father.

I bring the scalpel over the body and hover the blade close to the skin.

This is anatomy. Structure. Skin, fascia, muscle. I have studied this.

My eyes trail up to the man’s face.

His skin is pale and bloodied with pieces of flesh peeling back like he scratched at his own face in a frenzy. His lips are parted, frozen during a scream or gasp. And then I don’t see the crawler anymore.

I see my father.

I see his lifeless body lying there, cold and pale and so terribly still. I see the way his chest did not rise. The way his eyes stared at nothing. The way my mother screamed.

My hand starts to shake. My vision tunnels, everything around me collapsing into darkness until all I can see is my trembling fingers and the gray skin of the crawler beneath them. The scalpel hovers, quivering.

I cannot press in. I cannot make the cut.

My breathing turns erratic, short, sharp gasps that do nothing to fill my lungs. And then I hear her voice, distant and damning, rising from somewhere deep in my memory. “You did this, Maelis. Look at him. This is your fault.”

The scalpel slips from my fingers and clatters against the steel table. I stumble back, swaying, losing my bearings. A hand grips my shoulder, steadying me, and for a moment I think someone is helping.

“I knew the human would choke.”

Miles’s voice echoes in my ear, far too loud for how close his mouth is to my head. His breath is warm and smug against my skin. I want to elbow him in his round gut, spin around, and drive my fist into his throat. But I can’t focus. I need out of this room. I need air. I need to run.

“Disappointing, Freckles.” Draven tsks, shaking his head slowly. “Maybe the rumors are true.”

Something inside me snaps.

“Don’t call me Freckles. I don’t need a pet name. I’m not a gods-damned dog.” I step forward, snatching the scalpel off the table and shoving it into his hand hard enough that he has to catch it or let it fall. “I may be human, but I don’t need to prove shit to you. All you’ve been doing is a lot of fucking talking. Why don’t you show us all how it’s done?”

I’m breathing hard, seeing red, my pulse pounding so loud I can barely hear myself think.

Draven tilts his head, studying me like I am something he has found under a rock. Then his eyes crinkle at the corners, the only indication of the smile I know is lurking beneath his mask.

“Some mouth you have on you, Freckles.”

Heat rises to my cheeks, my anger spiking, but I force myself to shake it off. I will not give him the satisfaction. I turn away, snatching the instruction pages back from Nyra and bending to pick up the ink pen from the floor.

“Get cutting,” I say without looking at him. “I don’t want to lose this thing because the vampire choked.”

He chuckles but doesn’t waste any time. I hear the blade press into flesh, the faint pop as it breaks through the first layer of skin.

I keep my eyes on the instructions. I don’t want to see what he’s doing or the body on that table.

I don’t want to see my father lying there.

I try to focus on the task at hand and push all intruding thoughts out of my mind. I skim the instructions every team was handed before we started even as my pulse still thrums with residual panic.

“Here.” I hand the list to Nyra, her violet eyes narrow on me. “When you weigh an organ, write it down in grams.”

She takes it reluctantly and grabs another pen from the counter where the woman supervising us sits in silence. I almost forgot she was there.

“Heart’s out first,” Draven says.

I hear the wet, sucking sound as Miles takes it from him and drops it onto the scale with a squishy thud. So Draven is cutting, Miles is handling the organs, Nyra is tracking the weights, and I am making sure we stay on task. We all have roles now. Hopefully that is good for our team.

I remember Malric said one of the things we are judged on is how well we work together.

My outburst, the scalpel I shoved into Draven's hand, the cursing. Maybe all of it was uncalled for. I need to rein it in and put on a better face if we have any chance at winning this thing.

"If anyone sees anything unusual, call it out so I can take note of it," I say, clearing my throat and trying to sound authoritative. "Remember, we need to come up with a cause of death and list any anomalies we come across."

"Stab wound." Draven doesn't look up as he works. "Fifth intercostal space on the left side. Looks like it penetrated the apex of the pericardium."

I glance up to see him extract the liver and hand it to Miles as though he has done this a thousand times. I want to ask him what he did before coming to Ashwell, but not in the heat of the moment. I'd probably get some sarcastic answer anyway.

"Even if that is the cause of death, we still need to weigh everything and document anomalies according to the instructions," Nyra says from the counter, jotting down the liver's weight before Miles reaches for a viscera bag.

I ask the question I have been holding back. "What exactly is a crawler? They look almost human."

I don't want to show how ignorant I am, but if I am going to be useful, I need to know what I'm dealing with.

"Some are human. This one most likely was, based on his size and bone structure." Miles turns the liver over in his gloved hands, examining it before bagging it.

"Twisted creatures used to be the only monsters slithering their way out of fissures," Nyra says, adjusting her mask. "That was true until a couple of years ago when word started to spread about something new that resembled a person but crawled more than it walked and behaved like a crazed beast."

I glance sideways at her. She said she had never seen one before, but clearly she has heard plenty.

"The origin of crawlers isn't known yet, as far as anyone can tell." Draven's hands pause over the body, and his honey eyes lift to meet mine. "I can only assume that's partly why they're having all of us dissect one before our first class even begins."

I look back at the body, at the ruined face and the blood red eyes.

"You mean this isn't some hazing competition put on by bone and breath years to mess with us?" I say, glancing at the blood year supervisor

in the corner. She has already explained that she is not allowed to help us or even speak to us until we finish and she hits the timer, but I wish she would explain something right now.

“I didn’t say that.” Draven picks up the bone saw, and the metallic whine of it fills the room as he begins cutting into the skull. “I’m sure this is a game to the other years with a prize for the winning team. But for the professors, this isn’t about seeing who chokes and who can cut it. I think it goes deeper than that, especially for the headmaster.”

An uneasy feeling skitters across my skin at the mention of the headmaster.

“What is that supposed to mean? You think they condone this?”

Draven finishes the cut, sets down the saw, and carefully lifts the top of the skull away. The brain is inside, pale and glistening.

“It means these crawlers are starting to show up more and more,” he says, and I don’t like the sound of this. “They’re crazed. Uncontrolled. They spread and infect others through bites and scratches, turning any bloodline into a crazed monster just like them.” He removes the brain with both hands, cradling it gently. “We know they come out of the fissures, but we don’t know why or how.”

I lean forward, studying the brain’s color and grooves, the folds that once held thoughts, memories, a life.

“I would bet the headmaster and professors have all of us do this to get fresh eyes on these things,” Draven continues, handing the brain to Miles. “Maybe one of us will notice something that hasn’t been called out before. The crawlers may not look as terrifying as the twisted creatures, but they’re far more dangerous. The twisted creatures can kill us, sure, but they can’t turn us into them.”

Nyra whimpers, fidgeting with her posture like she’s tired of standing. “My parents told me that if the next cycle releases crawlers instead of twisted creatures, they fear none of us will have a chance.”

She shivers then writes down the weight of the brain on her sheet. The pen trembles slightly in her grip.

“What a messed up time to be at Ashwell,” Miles muses, shaking his head.

“More like what a messed up time to be alive,” I say more to myself than anyone, “if the next cycle does start soon.”

“Your parents are right to worry.” Draven strips off one glove to adjust his mask, and I catch a glimpse of his large hand, a thin scar running across his knuckles. “Crawlers wouldn’t simply kill our people and our fighters. They would turn them, and the numbers would grow too quickly to stop it.”

I swallow hard, my throat suddenly dry.

I am definitely going to have nightmares about this tonight.

But worse than the nightmares is the cold realization settling into my bones. I am suddenly worried for Ironfen, for my village, my sister, my mother. If that was a crawler Jace and I saw in the forest, then where did it come from? Is there a fissure we didn’t know about in the woods?

After this, I need to find Jace.

And I need a way to contact my family.

I need to warn them.

I zone out for the second half of the autopsy, too busy worrying about my family and kicking myself for not insisting I speak to them before leaving.

Everything’s been weighed and catalogued and the viscera bags all put back into the body. “We have our presumed cause of death and all the measurements, but we didn’t note any anomalies,” I say, looking over our paperwork.

“There are too many to name. The body is clearly fucked up. This thing has a number of unusual injuries that didn’t heal properly, but organ wise I don’t think we know enough to call anything an anomaly,” Miles says, his eyebrows scrunching as he pulls his gloves off and his mask down, taking in a deep breath like he’s been dying to do that since we started. His glasses finally clear up with the mask off.

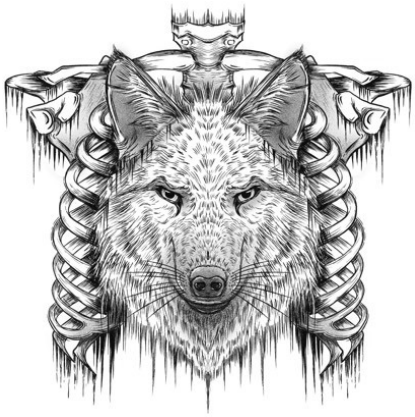
I read over the sheet again at all the notes I took and the weights Nyra wrote down as Draven dissected the body. “Wait.” I say, before we call time. “I need to see the heart.”

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Chapter Nine

"She doesn't freeze because she's weak. She freezes because she remembers. If she's ever going to be herself again, she'll have to face the memory."

— Jace's private notes



"Get the heart out," I tell Draven since Miles has already stripped off his gloves and Nyra refuses to touch anything.

"I told you the muscle was torn near the apex. He has a stab wound." Draven pulls open the viscera bag nestled in the body cavity, sounding impatient.

"The average adult heart weighs 250 to 350 grams," I say, not backing down. "Given this crawler is male, he should be on the higher end of that range. And since you said he was stabbed, I would expect that number to be even higher due to bleeding and inflammation."

I wave my hands, gesturing for him to hurry up and pull it out for us to see.

"Your point?" Miles asks, folding his arms.

Draven lifts the heart from the bag, cradling it in his gloved hands and holding it out for me to examine. It looks wilted and shrunken.

"My point," I say, "is that Nyra wrote down that this heart weighs 108 grams. That's a fucking anomaly if I've ever seen one."

Miles lets out a low whistle. “Oh shit. The human may not be useless after all.”

Nyra scoffs, but there is something else beneath it, surprise or reluctant respect. “How do you know all of that?”

I don’t bother answering her. These people are not my friends, and they don’t need to know about my past.

“You’re right,” Draven says, turning the heart over in his hands, studying it with new interest. “It does look small and thick. The walls are denser than they should be.”

I file that detail away and quickly fill out the rest of our sheet: cause of death, listed anomalies, organ weights, observations. My pen moves fast, my handwriting messier than I would like but legible enough. Draven places the heart back in the bag and draws the sheet over the body once more, covering the crawler’s ruined face.

“Time,” he calls out.

Our supervisor reaches over and taps the timing device beside her. The red numbers freeze, ceasing their relentless climb upward. She takes the chart and all the paperwork from my hands. Then she writes our final time at the bottom of the sheet. Ninety-seven minutes and twenty-three seconds.

I didn’t completely fail my team, but I’m marked now as the human girl who froze, the one whose hand shook when the scalpel was placed in it, who couldn’t bring herself to cut into the body.

They don’t know why, and I don’t want them to.



It’s safe to say we lost this competition. By the time we hurry back into the room where the party was held, it is already full of students. Only two teams finish after us, so we’re not last, but closer to it than I would like.

“That thing was vile.” Lux shudders beside me, rubbing her hands over her arms as we wait to see who won. Her team finished first, so the odds are in her favor. “My father says we will dissect all sorts of twisted creatures in Architecture of Flesh. Something to look forward to apparently.” She wrinkles her nose. “It’s my first class tomorrow, so I guess I’ll be skipping breakfast.”

“I’m pretty sure that’s my first class too, with Professor Nestor,” I say.

“Thank the gods.” She exhales dramatically. “At least we can help each other get through it.”

I’m glad I will know at least one person in my first class tomorrow, but unlike Lux, the idea of learning more about what twisted creatures exist out there doesn’t repulse me. It excites me. Dissecting one sounds even more interesting. I want to understand what they are and how they work. I don’t know much about any of the fissure-born creatures. I assume my parents never taught us out of fear of scaring us. Or maybe they never believed it was something we would need to know.

I know they at least hoped that.

“It seems we have our winning team.”

Malric’s voice echoes across the room, and everyone falls silent. I straighten, my attention snapping to the front.

“Before I announce it, let me tell you all what the prize is.” He waggles his eyebrows and holds up four necklaces, the chains glinting in the low light. I squint to see what dangles from each one.

“Each member of the winning team will receive an Ashwell key. This is no ordinary skeleton key. It doesn’t open every door, but it can open any door, or shall I say any lock.”

A murmur ripples through the crowd. I frown, suddenly confused.

“What does that mean?” someone calls out.

Malric smiles in a way that has me on edge. “These four keys are as old as Ashwell Academy itself. They were forged in the very core of this school.” He begins to pace slowly at the far end of the room. “The key will open something different for each of you. Always keep it with you, and it will open something when you need it most. The core current of the school will know. It will decide what that is when the time comes.”

Lux and I exchange a curious look, one of her eyebrows raised.

I can see why this is a coveted prize. The possibilities are endless. I can’t think of any reason I would need a key right now, but that’s the point. You don’t know what lock you need opened until you are standing in front of it I guess.

“As for the winning team,” Malric continues, gesturing to his fellow blood and breath classmates behind him, “we have all reviewed your notes and discussed each team at length. Time and teamwork did come into play, but ultimately only one team positively identified the crawler’s anomaly.”

My heart leaps into my throat.

I know I was right about that heart, but there could have been many more anomalies. Things we didn't catch and didn't know enough to look for.

"Draven, Miles, Maelis, and Nyra, come collect your Ashwell keys."

I think I'm in shock. My feet don't move until Lux shoves me forward with a breathless laugh, and I stumble after my teammates toward the front of the room.

Malric gives me another wicked smile as he places the key in my palm. Then he winks at me.

Gross.

I look down at the key, ignoring the crawl of discomfort his attention leaves on my skin. It is threaded through a long silver chain, and the head of it is an oblong circle bisected by a single vertical line. The metal is cold, heavier than it looks, and hums faintly against my palm. Or maybe I'm imagining that.

I slip the chain over my neck and tuck the key beneath my dress as the crowd begins to disperse. It's late, and most people are either heading out to get some sleep before classes or drifting toward the drink cart for more alcohol and bad decisions.

I don't look for Lux. She'll be fine on her own.

Instead, I slip out of the building and weave through the thinning crowd, scanning faces and silhouettes until I spot him. Jace's height and silvery white wings make him stand out even in the dark among the crowd of students.

"Jace, wait."

He turns at the sound of my voice, his wings folded against his back as I catch up to him. The moonlight highlights the planes of his face, and I notice he looks as drained as I feel. There's a tension in his shoulders that wasn't there earlier.

"There you are," he says, relieved. "I was looking for you. I thought maybe you got ahead of me outside." He falls into step beside me, a grin tugging at the corner of his mouth. "I can't believe your team won. Are you excited?"

I glance around at the other students still milling about, their voices carrying through the cold night air as they make their way back to the dorms. "Can we go somewhere quieter to talk?"

He nods, placing a hand on the small of my back and guiding me away from the others.

We walk until the noise fades behind us, following an icy stone path that winds between buildings until we reach a low wall overlooking the grounds outside the bone year male dormitories. The cold has seeped through my dress and settled into my bones.

“Do you want to come to my room? Aren’t you freezing?” His breath leaves puffs of condensation in the frigid air.

“No, I’m okay for a few minutes,” I say, hugging myself tighter. My long-sleeve dress does little to keep me warm, but I don’t want to be in his room right now. This conversation can’t turn into something else.

“Here, this way.” He leads me through a back door on the ground floor of the dormitory and into a small room stuffed with linens and miscellaneous things you might find in a bedroom. Stacked furniture and piles of spare blankets that smell of dust and cedar.

“This is the supply room,” he says, and I raise an eyebrow.

“What?” he chuckles, holding his hands up. “I was exploring earlier. Don’t give me that look.”

He walks around a few stacked desks to a tall table and pats the surface for me to sit. I have to jump up to get on it, but once I’m settled he grabs one of the folded blankets and drapes it over my shoulders. The wool is scratchy but warm. He moves to stand in front of me, close enough that I have to tilt my head back to meet his eyes.

“What do you want to talk about?” he asks, his voice soft in the dim, cluttered space.

“Your team had a crawler too?”

“Yeah.” He scrubs a hand through his silvery blond hair. “I’ve never cut into something like that before. The way the body looked reminded me of the thing in the forest that attacked us.”

“I know.” I tug the blanket tighter around my shoulders. “That’s all I could think about while we were in there.” I chew on my bottom lip, the worry I’ve been pushing down all night finally clawing its way to the surface. “I need to find a way to tell Briana and mother about the crawler. What if there’s a fissure near Ironfen? The whole village could be in danger.”

Jace shifts his weight, moving closer. “Listen, don’t worry about your family.”

“How can I not worry?”

“Because I already told my parents before we left. I told them everything about the guy that attacked us. I don’t know for sure if it was a crawler or some sick, crazed man, but they know. And by now they’ll know that you’re at Ashwell.” His hand finds my cheek, tilting my face up until I’m looking at him. “They’ll look out for your mom and sister. They’ll be okay.”

I want to believe him. I want to let go of the knot in my chest and trust that everything will be fine, but I’ve learned the hard way that hope is a dangerous thing to hold too tightly.

“There’s something else you should know,” he says with some reluctance, making my stomach drop. “About the body.”

I swallow. “What about it?”

“I went back to examine it.” His thumb traces a slow line across my cheekbone. “But when I got there, it was gone.”

My eyes widen. “Are you sure you went to the right spot? Maybe you were confused.”

He shakes his head. “No, there was blood on the ground and drag marks leading into the forest. I followed them for a bit, but then I lost the trail.”

“That thing could still be alive.” I sit up straighter, my heart pounding. “It could have attacked someone else by now.”

“I don’t think it’s alive. There was a lot of blood, Mae. And the drag marks...” He shrugs. “I bet an animal took it up into a tree and ate it.”

I don’t know what animal would do that. A panther maybe, but those are rarely sighted near Ironfen. The explanation feels thin, like he’s saying it more to comfort me than because he believes it.

“Maelis.”

His hand is still on my cheek, his fingers tracing up and down in a slow, soothing pattern. I meet his blue eyes and find something there that makes my breath catch. Something that has nothing to do with crawlers or fissures or the danger waiting back home.

“I don’t want you to stress about this,” he murmurs. “My parents are with your family. That thing is dead. And we have enough to worry about here with classes starting.” He tucks a strand of red hair behind my ear, his fingertips brushing the curve of my jaw. “It’s going to be okay. We’re together.”

I don’t say anything. I’m not sure I can.

“Mae.” His voice drops to something barely above a whisper. “I would never let anything happen to you or your family. You know that, right?”

I nod, not trusting my voice.

His gaze lingers on my face, tracing over my features like he’s thinking something he doesn’t want to voice. Then his eyes fall to my mouth. He’s closer than he was a moment ago. I don’t remember him moving, but I can feel the warmth of him through the blanket, can smell pine and something faintly sweet on his skin like cinnamon.

For a moment, I think about letting him close the distance, falling into something easy and familiar that doesn’t require me to think about dead bodies and shrunken hearts and my father’s warnings scrawled in fading ink.

But I can’t when my head is so full of everything else.

I clear my throat and slide off the table, the blanket slipping from my shoulders. “It’s late. I need to get some sleep if I’m going to make it through our first day of classes tomorrow.”

I brush past him toward the door, my skin still tingling where his fingers touched my cheek. When I pull it open, I glance back.

He’s watching me with a soft smile, something patient and understanding in his expression. Like he knows and has been waiting all these years for me to finally see it.

“Goodnight,” I tell him.

He doesn’t say anything else as I slip out into the cold and make my way back to my room.

The hallways are quiet, most students already behind closed doors. My footsteps echo against the hard floors, and I find myself reaching up to touch the key beneath my collar. The metal is warm now, heated by my skin, and I wrap my fingers around it as I walk.

I need to find out how my father applied for me and what his connection is to this school. Why didn’t he tell me? How did he know I’d get in? Why am I the first human to ever be accepted to Ashwell, and what was that speech from the headmaster about?

Gods, I was too stunned to even think clearly in his office. The way he looked at me, the way he spoke like he knew things about my life that I don’t even know. How does he know anything about my father? My father was a village healer. He spent his life treating farmers and merchants and

children with fevers. He wasn’t connected to magical academies hidden in the Frostlands.

Or was he?

I keep seeing the writing at the bottom of the acceptance letter scrawled in handwriting that didn’t match the rest. I keep playing them over in my mind. “Blood remembers what history forgets. Your father knows you are ready.”

What blood? Ready for what?

And if my father knew I was ready, why didn’t he prepare me? Why did he leave me with nothing but cryptic journal entries and questions I can’t answer?

I tighten my grip on the key until the edges bite into my palm.

He’s dead. He can’t explain himself. He can’t tell me what any of this means.

But someone at this school knows, and I’m going to find them.

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Chapter Ten

"We called them omens. Then we called them myths. By the time we called them heralds, it was already too late."

— A History of the Fissures, Vol. II



The body on the table sits up.

I'm whispering something to Lux about how I didn't sleep well last night when the sheet slides off and the creature beneath it jerks upright with a rattling gasp.

The classroom is long and narrow, built like a chapel dedicated to something darker than any god. Rows of old wooden benches line either side of a central aisle, long tables in front of each one. The vaulted ceiling rises high above us, all dark timber beams and stone arches that swallow the weak light from the iron sconces along the walls. The air smells of dust and old wood and something metallic beneath it that clings to the back of my throat. At the front of the room, where an altar might stand in a place of worship, there is only the table. And the thing that was supposed to be dead now perched on top of it.

It's massive, far larger than the crawler we dissected last night. What was once in the deer family has become something nightmarish. Its body is skeletal and towering even while seated, patches of rotting hide failing to cover exposed bone.

But it’s the antlers that are terrifying.

They branch upward and outward like a chandelier made of bone, twisting into dozens of sharp points that almost reach the ceiling. Its chest is partially carved open, ribs splayed wide, and I can see inside. There are organs in there, a heart and lungs and other glistening things I can’t name, but they aren’t where they should be. They’re suspended, floating in the hollow cavity of its body, held in place by faintly glowing strands that pulse with soft light. Like puppet strings made of electricity or current.

Someone screams. The sound bounces off the stone walls and multiplies, filling the narrow room with chaos. Chairs scrape back against the worn floor. Someone near the front falls trying to scramble away, their boots slipping on the uneven flagstones.

Draven Alucard catches my eye from where he sits a few rows ahead on the opposite bench, leaning back with his arms crossed like everyone in the room is being dramatic and he’s amused.

A sound comes from the creature’s throat, or maybe from its chest cavity. A low vibration that I feel before I hear rolls through the room like a wave. It rattles the old sconces on the walls and hums through the wooden bench beneath me, up through my bones.

My stomach lurches. My vision swims. The flickering light from the sconces seems to dim and pulse in time with that horrible frequency. Beside me, Lux doubles over, her pink hair flying forward as her hand clamps over her mouth, and I grip the edge of my desk to stay upright. The old wood bites into my palms. The panic is instant and irrational, flooding my veins with the overwhelming urge to run, to flee, to get as far from this thing as possible.

Professor Nestor stands at the head of the table, watching the mayhem with an expression of pure amusement. His hair is wild and gray, sticking up at odd angles like he’s just rolled out of bed or been electrocuted. His spectacles are crooked on his nose, and his white coat is stained with things I don’t want to identify.

The creature swings its head toward him, empty eye sockets searching, skeletal legs scrabbling against the table. Its hooves scrape against the metal with a sound that makes my teeth ache.

Around me, roughly twenty students are in various states of panic. Across the aisle, an angel with rich brown skin and massive gray wings pressed tight against her back grips her desk so hard I can see the tendons

straining in her hands. I recognize her from orientation. She was near the front during the headmaster's speech, standing tall and composed but she doesn't look so composed now. Her dark eyes are wide, fixed on the creature like she's calculating whether she can make it to the door before it moves again.

"Sit down," Nestor says calmly, and the room starts to quiet as everyone tries to regain control of themselves. "It can't hurt you. I've severed its motor control tendons." He shakes his head at the class, disappointed. "It merely doesn't know it's dead yet."

A few rows ahead, a man with pale white skin and striking green eyes hasn't moved at all. He sits rigid, his jaw clenched tight, watching the creature with an intensity that makes me wonder if he's a shifter. There's something predatory in his stillness, like prey holding its breath while a hunter passes.

"What the fuck?" someone mutters from the bench behind me. I don't turn to look.

Nestor pulls a long silver instrument from his coat, something between a needle and a blade, and drives it through the monster's skull in one smooth motion. There's a sound like cracking ice, and then the thing collapses back onto the table. Its antlers clatter against the metal. For a smaller gentleman, Professor Nestor packs some strength.

The low vibration cuts off abruptly, and the nausea recedes along with the unease that surged through me moments ago. I release my grip on the desk and realize my knuckles have gone white. Beside me, Lux slowly straightens, her face tinged green. Across the way, the angel with the silver-streaked braids exhales shakily and loosens her death grip on the wood too.

"Lesson one." Nestor wipes the instrument on his sleeve and tucks it back into his coat. "The twisted creatures do not obey the rules of death as we understand them. If you retain only one thing from my class, let it be that. It could save your life one day."

He scans the room, cataloging each of our faces. What does he see? Terror, probably. Revulsion, maybe. A few students still look like they might pass out. The pale shifter with the green eyes has finally blinked, some of the tension leaving his shoulders now that the thing is truly dead. A girl near the front, small with delicate pointed ears and hair the color of autumn leaves, has tears streaming silently down her freckled cheeks.

What does he see when he looks at me?

His light-blue eyes stop on my face, and an unnerving giggle escapes his throat before he moves closer to the table. Something about that laugh makes my skin prickle.

“Welcome, bone year students, to Architecture of Flesh.” He spreads his arms wide in greeting. “It’s going to be a fun year.”

He slaps his hand down on the metal table loud enough that I flinch. The girl with the autumn hair flinches too. The angel across the aisle doesn’t move, but I see her wings twitch out of the corner of my eye.

“This here is a hollowstag. You may have seen its distant relatives before, prancing through the forest like cute little deer that flee from predators.” He tilts his head as he examines the cadaver with something like affection. “This guy here is a little more scary than his relatives.”

He reaches into the creature’s open chest and plucks one of the glowing strands like he’s playing a stringed instrument. A faint hum fills the room, and my breakfast roils in my stomach again. I swallow hard, willing myself not to be sick.

“Should’ve skipped breakfast,” the angel mutters. I want to tell her I was thinking the same thing.

“The organs of a hollowstag are suspended by strands of pure current. We don’t know how this happens. We don’t know why.” He plucks another strand, producing a different tone, almost musical. “What we do know is that this current allows the creature to emit a low-frequency vibration that induces panic and vomiting in any living being within range.” He smiles, and it’s not a reassuring expression. “As you’ve experienced firsthand.”

“Why would it need to do that?” someone asks from behind me.

I look back to see a guy with long brown hair and high cheekbones. He looks genuinely curious rather than horrified, which is more than I can say for most of the class. His skin has a faint bronze undertone, and there’s something almost feline about the way he holds himself. Another shifter maybe. I wish I knew how to tell for sure. Maybe I’ll learn that in my next class.

“Excellent question.” Nestor points at the student without looking. “Hollowstags are not predators. They don’t hunt us. They don’t feed on flesh. So why evolve such a terrifying defense mechanism?”

He waits for an answer, but no one speaks. Twenty students and not even one willing to guess.

“Because they are heralds,” he says with relish, drawing it out like it tastes good on his tongue. “Hollowstags appear before mass fissure events. Always and without fail. They emerge from the deep forests and the mountain passes. Days, sometimes hours before a fissure tears open and spills its horrors into our world.”

He leans forward, bracing his hands on the table, his eyes glittering with something between madness and fascination. In this light with that expression, he looks less like a professor and more like something that crawled out of a fissure himself.

“They’re warnings, living, screaming, panic-inducing warnings. And for centuries, we ignored them.” He straightens, clasping his hands behind his back. “We won’t be making that mistake again.”

His gaze sweeps across the room one more time, lingering on faces seemingly at random. The green-eyed shifter. The crying fae girl. The angel with the silver braids. Draven, who still looks bored. And then me. When his eyes pass over me again, I feel the weight of it like a physical thing.

He claps his hands together. “Who wants to touch it?”

I throw my hand up along with a dozen other people, and Lux grabs it, pulling it back down beside me.

“Yuck.” She scrunches her nose. “Why do you want to touch that thing?”

I laugh, “What are you doing here if things like this gross you out?”

“I want to heal people, not dissect crawlers and twisted creatures.” She shudders. “Those are the exact things I want to stay away from.”

I slide off the bench and stretch my legs. “Come on, you don’t have to touch it. Let’s get a closer look. Besides, it’s not a twisted creature. He said it’s a herald. They only have a bad reputation because they look scary.”

She sighs but gets up with me.

Most of the class has formed a line down one of the aisles, only a few people going up at a time to speak with the professor and peer inside the creature’s open cavity. The air near the front smells worse, thick with something organic and faintly sweet, like decay masked by preserving chemicals.

“The Mirror Ceremony is supposed to be after dinner tonight,” the angel with silver threaded through her braids says to the guy standing next to her. “I hope it doesn’t get pushed back again.”

“Yes, I can’t wait to meet my eidolon,” Lux chimes in, and they both turn to look at us.

“Er, sorry to interrupt.” She tucks a strand of pink hair behind her ear. “I’m Lux. This is Maelis.”

I give them a quick wave. I’ve never been big on shaking hands or hugs. I’m not big on any physical touch really.

Unless it’s Jace.

“Zuri.” The angel inclines her head, her gray wings shifting slightly behind her. “Pleasure to meet you both.”

I can’t help focusing on the guy next to her. He’s hot, and I don’t mean in the rugged, sexy way. He’s pretty and pampered looking with tan skin and a neatly shaved face, a strong jaw, and short brown hair styled like he cares about his appearance. No less hot for it though.

“I’m Killian,” he says, smiling, and then his pupils change, narrowing to vertical slits that cut through his emerald-green eyes like cracks in glass.

I swallow.

He’s a demon, gorgeous, and seems like trouble.

“You’re the human, right?” He looks me up and down with open curiosity, like I’m a fascinating specimen he’s never encountered before.

I make an exasperated sound. “Yes, I am.” I’m already tired of that question, and it’s only my first day of classes. “Anyway, can one of you explain to me what an eidolon is?”

Their heads snap toward me.

“You don’t know what an eidolon is?” Lux says it like I’ve admitted I don’t know how to breathe.

I want to roll my eyes, because she knows I don’t know much about anything when it comes to this school. Everything here is new and strange, and no one bothered to give me a handbook.

“You’ve seen some students with animals around campus, right?” Zuri asks, and I nod.

Elizabeth had the bat perched on my bed when we first met. And Draven was with that gigantic black wolf when I first saw him across the creepy garden with statues, though I haven’t seen it since.

“Are they pets?” I ask. “Do we get to pick a pet to keep us company or something?”

Zuri’s eyes widen like I’ve said something blasphemous. “No, eidolons are not pets. They are externalized soul fragments.”

I wait for her to continue because I have no idea what that means, but it's Lux who speaks up.

"Ashwell's core takes a piece of your essence and shapes it into symbolic form." She says it like she's reciting something she's known her whole life. "They can appear when emotionally triggered or whenever you want them to. They assist you instinctively. It's like a pet but far more intimate. It's bonded to you, tied to your soul, your essence, for life."

I'm not sure my mind is grasping it yet. How will the core current in this school extract a piece of my essence and merge it with a creature? What does that even feel like?

Zuri must see the confused look in my eyes. "You can think of your eidolon as a pet if that makes it easier to understand, but it's a pet that can appear and disappear at will. It will be able to understand you and know you in a way no one else can because you'll be connected on a deeper level."

"The type of eidolon you get is supposed to represent your strengths too," Killian adds. "The school already knows what you'll excel at, and they give you an eidolon accordingly."

Those slit pupils catch the low light as he turns his head. "But you don't have current. You've probably never used current in your life, and an eidolon has never been given to a human before, so...maybe you'll be the first bone year death tonight."

I refrain from jabbing him with my elbow. Barely.

"Real reassuring," I grit out. "I can't wait."

He smiles, showing off his perfect teeth. "Don't worry, little human." He leans in slightly, close enough that I catch the faint scent of something smoky. "I'm sure it will only hurt a lot."

"Killian," Zuri warns, but she's laughing too.

"What?" He straightens, all false innocence. "I'm being supportive."

"You're being an ass," Lux mutters, and I decide I like her even more.

"I guess we'll find out tonight if humans can even have eidolons," Zuri says, not unkindly.

Killian opens his mouth, probably to deliver another charming comment about my impending death, but we've reached the front of the line, and Nestor waves us forward impatiently.

"Come, come. Don't be shy. Get your hands in there."

We gather around the hollowstag's open chest, and one by one we reach inside. The strings of current hum beneath my fingertips, warm and alive despite the creature being very much dead. It's strange and unsettling but also fascinating in a way.

While we examine the creature up close, Nestor explains that for the first part of the year we'll be covering all of the twisted creatures associated with fissures.

"Even though you aren't training to be Vanguards, the elite war soldiers who fight on the front lines, you will be deployed to fissure sites eventually. You will be put in dangerous situations."

He nudges my hand, encouraging me to touch an antler.

"And you need to know what you're up against so you can protect yourselves properly. Without you, no one is getting saved. Dead healers don't heal. Remember that."

Lux fidgets next to me, not wanting to touch the creature, and Nestor gives her an incredulous look. "Alright, that's enough touching for today. Back to your seats. I have reading assignments for you and I expect them to be done by our next class."

We file back to our benches, and I find myself replaying everything he said. I found his class kind of exciting, minus starting it off thinking I might vomit up my breakfast. I have his class twice a week, and the reading assignments will probably be interesting.

I'm eager to learn more about what he knows about fissures and the twisted creatures. There's something about the way he talks about them, equal parts reverence and warning, that makes me want to understand. I need to read up on the last cycles too. I don't even fully understand what we might be up against.

Lux nudges me as we gather our things. "You okay? You got quiet all of a sudden."

"I'm thinking," I say, tucking the reading assignment and syllabus into my bag for later.

"About the dead healer comment?" She wrinkles her nose. "Yeah, that one's going to stick with me too. So what class do you have now?"

We spill out into the corridor with the rest of the students.

"Fracture and Form with Professor Cane and then a lunch break." I pull the map from my bag and squint at the tiny labels. "After lunch, I have

Triage of the Damned with Professor Bale. Then I’m done for the day...until the Mirror Ceremony tonight.”

“Bale?” Lux perks up. “That’s my dad’s class. I have him after lunch too.”

“Nice, so since it’s your dad, he’ll go easy on us right,” I say, laughing as I fold the map back up.

“Yeah, about that.” She gives me a wiry smile, and I frown. “You’re better off claiming you don’t know me. He’s not going to go easy on me because I’m his daughter. If anything, he’ll be harder.” She fiddles with the strap of her bag that crosses her chest. “Something about not wanting to show favoritism and needing to toughen me up.”

“I’m sure it won’t be that bad. At least we can suffer together,” I say, buttoning up my black sweater and pulling my coat tighter around me before I reach the doors to the outside.

“Anyway, I have Endurance of Pain with Professor Clementine right now.” She sighs dramatically. “I’ve heard she makes students cry on the first day on purpose.”

“Sounds fun.”

“Oh, it’ll be a blast.” She gives me a mock salute. “If I don’t see you at lunch, assume the worst.”

She says the last part over her shoulder as she heads down the corridor, her pink hair bouncing with each step. I round the corner and push through the doors leading to the courtyard.

The freezing air hits my chest. I shove my hands into my pockets to keep warm while I try to get my bearings. Everything looks the same. Stone and ice and spires all covered in a perpetual winter haze. Somewhere across this frozen campus is Professor Cane’s classroom, and I have about five minutes to find it.

“Wrong direction.”

The voice comes from behind me, and I recognize it before I turn to see Draven standing a few feet away. All his hair is pulled up into a bun today, and he’s breathing into his hands. Even doing something so mundane, he looks dangerous. The beard makes him look older, wilder, less like a student and more like something that wandered out of the frozen woods. Snowflakes speckle the dark wool of his coat, and I realize I’m studying him for too long and look away.

“I wasn’t—” I start.

“You were heading toward the stables.” He tilts his head toward the opposite end of campus. “Cane’s class is that way.”

I narrow my eyes at him. “How do you know what class I’m going to? Were you eavesdropping on our conversation, or are you my stalker now?”

He doesn’t rise to the bait but watches me with that infuriatingly blank expression.

I brush past him in the direction he suggested. I want to pull the map out again, but he starts to walk with me, ignoring my former statement entirely.

So stalker it is then.

We walk in silence. He doesn’t try to fill it with conversation or even seem to care at all whether I’m there. I don’t know why, but it infuriates me.

And at the same time, it’s a relief. I’m tired of people asking about being human, tired of the stares and the whispers. I’m comfortable in silence. I’m usually too caught up in my own head anyway.

“Two classes together,” I say finally.

“I noticed.”

“You don’t talk much, do you?”

“I talk when there’s something worth saying.”

I huff out a breath that clouds white in the frozen air. “And right now there isn’t?”

He glances at me then, a flicker of those molten honey eyes before he looks ahead again. “You froze yesterday.”

“What?”

“During the autopsy, you had the scalpel in your hand and couldn’t make the cut,” he says. “Your hand trembled.”

My jaw tightens. “I don’t remember asking for your opinion.”

“It wasn’t an opinion. It was an observation. Everyone has something that breaks them. Yours showed up early.”

I want to snap back at him and tell him he doesn’t know anything about me, but something in his tone stops me. He’s not mocking me. He’s not judging. He’s saying it like a fact, like something he’s seen before, like something he’s lived.

“And what breaks you?” I ask.

He doesn’t even acknowledge the question until we reach the far east side of the campus.

“Everyone has walls, Freckles.” He glances sideways at me, and I hold his stare. “Some of us build them higher than others.”

Before I can respond, he looks away and pulls open the heavy door.

“After you,” he says, and I step past him into the warmth of the main hall.

We enter the classroom, and I immediately spot Jace.

The room is shaped like an amphitheater, a dozen rows of curved wooden benches rising in tiers around a central pit. Short walls separate each row, their flat tops serving as desks. Jace is seated seven rows up in the middle of the room, and his face lights up when he sees me. That familiar warmth spreads through my chest at the sight of him, comfortable and steady.

Then his gaze shifts to Draven behind me, and something in his expression changes. Not jealousy exactly. Something more…watchful.

Jace stands as I approach, touching my arm with an easy familiarity that suddenly feels very public. “Mae, I saved you a seat.”

“Thanks.” I slide onto the bench next to him, hyper aware of Draven moving past us to find his own seat somewhere behind me. I don’t turn to look, but I can feel exactly where he is, like a cold spot in a warm room.

“You look tired,” Jace says quietly, leaning closer. His wing brushes against my shoulder, a whisper of warmth. “Did you get any sleep last night?”

“Not really.” I pull out my notebook, trying to focus on something other than the prickling sensation at the back of my neck. “Kept thinking about everything.”

“Me too.” His voice drops lower, meant only for me. “I meant what I said last night about looking out for you. I know things are complicated right now, but I’m here for whatever you need.”

His hand finds mine under the desk, and he gives it a quick squeeze.

“I know,” I tell him, squeezing back before letting go. “Thank you.”

He smiles and turns to face the front of the room as other students filter in.

I try to focus on the professor’s desk at the front, on the strange instruments across its surface, on the diagrams covering the walls, but my attention keeps slipping.

I glance back once.

Draven is three rows behind me, slouched on his bench with his arms crossed. He’s not looking at the front of the room. He’s not looking at his notebook or the other students settling into their seats.

He’s looking at me.

Our eyes meet for a single, charged second. His expression gives nothing away. No smirk. Just that steady, unblinking gaze, like he’s trying to figure out what I’m made of.

I turn back around, my heart beating a little faster.

Whatever Draven Alucard is hiding behind those walls, I get the feeling it’s darker than anything I’ve seen at Ashwell so far.

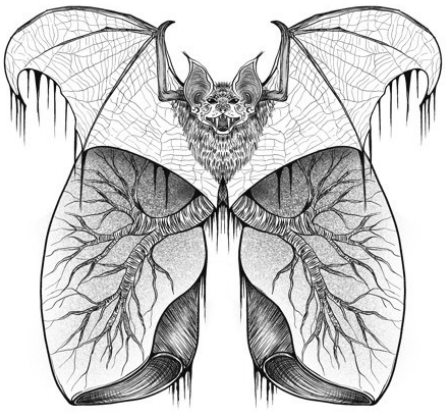
And the stupid, reckless part of me wants to break them down.

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Chapter Eleven

"The Upper Veil did not create angels to be kind. It created them to endure. Kindness, if it comes at all, is a choice they make despite themselves."

— Professor Cane, Fracture and Form



Professor Cane breezes into the room like she's late to a garden party rather than a lecture, her curly brown hair piled loosely on top of her head and held in place by what appears to be a paintbrush. Silver rings adorn nearly every finger, and her flowing emerald-green dress looks more suited for a summer festival than a classroom in the frozen north.

She's fae. I can tell by the pointed ears peeking through her curls and the way she moves, fluid and unhurried, like time is something that happens to other people. Her face is heart shaped and lovely with laugh lines around her eyes and a mouth that suggest she smiles often. If I had to guess, I'd put her somewhere in her fifties, though with fae that could mean anything.

"Hello, my darlings," she says, dropping an armful of books and scrolls onto her desk with a dramatic thud. "Welcome to Fracture and Form. I'm Professor Cane, and I'll be the one putting you back together when the other professors inevitably break you."

A few students laugh nervously.

"Every week we will be covering a different bloodline. You can't heal what you don't know, and I'm going to make sure you know everything

there is about each bloodline, including humans.” She perches on the edge of her desk, crossing her legs and letting one embroidered slipper dangle from her foot. “This week we’re starting with angels. Gorgeous creatures. Terrible patients. Very particular about their wings. We’ll get into all of that, but first I need a volunteer.”

Her eyes scan the room, bright and mischievous.

“An angel volunteer specifically. Don’t be shy. I promise I won’t bite.” She chews her lip. “Well, not in class anyway.”

More nervous laughter. I feel Jace tense beside me.

“You there.” Cane points directly at him, a slow smile spreading across her face. “The handsome one with the silver wings. Perfect. Come down here, darling.”

Jace resigns himself to the inevitable and stands. I watch him descend the tiered rows toward the front of the room, his wings folded tight against his back like he’s trying to make himself smaller, but he’s too tall, too broad, too obviously an angel to blend in anywhere.

“Don’t look so nervous,” Cane says as he reaches her. “I’m not going to hurt you. I’m simply going to use you.”

She gestures for him to turn around and face the class.

“Name?”

“Jace.” His voice is steady, but I can see the tension in his shoulders.

“Lovely. Now then, Jace. Extend your left wing for me. All the way, darling, don’t be modest.”

His wing unfurls slowly, stretching out to its full span, and I realize I’ve never seen him do this before. Not fully. The feathers are pale silver, almost white, layered over each other like armor made of moonlight. The wing itself is enormous, easily six feet from his shoulder to the tip.

“Beautiful,” Cane murmurs and shifts closer, running her fingers along the upper edge where feathers meet flesh. Jace flinches slightly but doesn’t pull away, and I have to put a hand over my mouth to keep from giggling.

“Pay attention, darlings.” Her voice shifts, still warm but with an edge of authority beneath it. “This is not decoration. This is not for flight, not primarily. An angel’s wing is a weapon, a shield, and a warning system all in one.”

She traces a line down the wing’s leading edge. “Thirty-seven bones in each wing. More than your entire arm and hand combined. Every single one of them can fracture under the right conditions.”

Her fingers stop at a joint halfway down. “Here. The medial humerus is where angels break most often. In battle, they instinctively shield with their wings.” She looks up at Jace’s face. “It’s a reflex, but it means this joint takes the worst of it.”

I’m barely breathing. Jace is standing completely still, his jaw tight, his eyes fixed on some point at the back of the room. I wonder if he’s embarrassed. Either way, he looks beautiful, and I think Professor Cane is enjoying this.

“You can feel it, can’t you?” Cane asks him softly, pressing gently on the joint. “The vulnerability there. Angels always know where they’ll break. It’s instinct.”

“Yes,” Jace says quietly, “I can feel it.”

She holds his gaze then pats his wing affectionately. “Good boy, you can sit down.”

He folds his wing back and returns to his seat beside me. I want to say something, but the look on his face tells me to leave it alone. I have to chew on the inside of my cheek to keep from laughing.

Cane turns back to the class, all business again.

“No bloodline can generate current,” she says, pacing slowly in front of her desk. “We all draw from what exists around us. Well, almost all, but blood mages are a topic for another day, and most of you aren’t ready for that conversation yet.”

A few students shift uncomfortably. Cane waves like she’s brushing the thought away, and my mind immediately goes to the headmaster.

“Angels evolved in the Upper Veil, where current is thin. They learned to survive on almost nothing. They have to regulate, contain, and stretch every drop of current until it’s nearly gone.”

She holds up a finger. “This makes them extraordinarily efficient, the best stabilizers on a battlefield. They can hold a wound closed, halt a magical surge, even slow fissure expansion when no one else can. It also means they have no reserves. When an angel burns out, they burn out completely, fast and hard and often permanently.”

Her gaze sweeps across the room, pausing briefly on the few angels at the front then moving on.

“An angel who pushes too far doesn’t just get tired, darlings. They fracture, and I don’t mean their bones.” She says, then lets out a soft,

breathy laugh that’s slightly unnerving before continuing. “Now let’s do an in-class assignment labeling angel wing bones.”



The great hall is warmer than anywhere else I’ve been on campus. Massive fireplaces anchor each end of the room, their flames crackling and popping, casting flickering light across the long wooden tables. Frost creeps along the edges of the tall windows, but where Jace and I sit on a bench near the glass, I can feel the heat from the nearest hearth seeping into my bones.

I tear off a piece of crusty bread and dip it into my bowl of beef stew. The meat is tender, the broth rich and peppered, exactly what I need after a morning of hollowstags and angel anatomy.

Jace sits beside me, close enough that his wing occasionally brushes my shoulder. He’s been quiet since Cane’s class, and I’ve been trying to find the right way to ask about it.

“Can I ask you something?” I say finally, keeping my eyes on my stew.

“Always.”

“In Cane’s class, she said angels aren’t emotional creatures, that you have to learn it like a language.” I glance at him. “Is that true?”

Jace turns a chunk of bread over in his hands. “For most angels, yes, emotion doesn’t come naturally. It’s something we observe in others and slowly learn to replicate. Some angels never bother. They go their whole lives feeling nothing beyond duty and instinct.”

“That sounds lonely.”

“It’s not lonely if you don’t know what you’re missing.” He looks at me then, his blue eyes shining. “But once you learn to feel something, you can’t unlearn it, but you can block it out. Turn it off.”

I hold his gaze. “And did you have to learn?”

His jaw works like he’s chewing on the words before he says them. “I used to think I was broken. I felt things other angels didn’t. Worry. Attachment. Fear of losing people.” He shakes his head. “My family thought it was a flaw, something to be trained out of me.”

“But it wasn’t.”

“No.” He turns to face me fully, and there’s something raw in his expression. “And when it comes to you, Mae, I don’t have to try to feel anything. It’s always been there, since we were kids. I’ve always felt at ease when I’m close to you.”

My chest tightens. I don’t know what to say to that or what I’m allowed to feel in return.

Before I can respond, a dramatic groan cuts through the moment.

“Move over. I’m dying.”

Lux drops onto the bench across from us, her pink hair disheveled and her face flushed from the cold. She slumps forward, pressing her forehead against the table and I move my tray to make room.

“Clementine?” I ask.

“She made three people cry. Three in the first hour.” Lux lifts her head enough to glare at me. “And now I have my dad’s class. This day is a nightmare.”

“At least you survived,” I offer.

“Barely.” She sits up, stealing a piece of bread from my plate. “I need sustenance. And therapy.”

Another figure slides onto the bench beside Lux. Blonde hair, a glint of metal at her lip, and an expression that says she knows exactly what kind of entrance she’s making.

Ellavee.

“So you never made an appearance at the party last night.” Lux says, before taking a drink of water.

“I had somewhere to be,” Ellavee says, completely unbothered. She picks up a spoon and examines it.

“Somewhere being a boy’s room,” Lux adds.

“A gentleman’s room,” Ellavee corrects, taking a bite of her stew. “There’s a difference.”

“How was that, by the way?” Lux asks, raising an eyebrow.

Ellavee smirks, evidently full of stories. “I don’t kiss and tell.”

“Since when?”

“Since now.” She shrugs and starts to play with her lip ring. “New year, new me.”

I laugh through my nose, and Ellavee’s sharp eyes flick to me, but then her lips quirk up on one side.

Movement across the hall catches my attention. I look up without meaning to, and there he is.

Draven.

He’s not sitting with the other bone year students. He’s at a table near the far fireplace, surrounded by older students, blood and breath years by the look of their red and blue emblems on their black clothes.

Malric sits beside him, leaning in to say something. Draven stares ahead with that placid expression.

“They always stick together,” Lux says, following my gaze. “The vampires, I mean. They’re the only bloodline that thinks they’re better than everyone else, so they tend to keep to themselves.”

“It’s a superiority thing,” Ellavee adds, twirling her spoon. “Old blood, old power, old grudges. They don’t mix with the rest of us unless they have to, or unless they want to fuck you, then suddenly they’re very interested in interspecies relations.”

Lux snorts. Jace shifts beside me, and I hope he’s not thinking about how Draven and I walked into class together today.

I force myself to look away from Draven’s table, but not before I catch him looking back.



“This isn’t exactly what I expected my afternoon to look like,” I say to Lux, Ellavee, and Jace, who flank either side of me.

We changed into our training attire, leather pants and long-sleeve black tops, and are now having class outside in the freezing cold.

It’s a giant stone courtyard covered in some kind of enchanted ceiling that keeps the snow out but lets the gray sky show through. There are bleachers on either side, but we all stand in a clustered line, shifting our weight, breath visible in the air.

“I probably should have mentioned my dad is a hundred and fifty years old and used to be a Vanguard before teaching,” Lux says quietly.

Jace and I both lean forward to look at her.

“What the hell, Lux?” I breathe.

“Wait.” Jace’s brow furrows. “Your father lived through the last cycle?”

Lux nods. “He fought in it, and that’s why he’s always saying Veilguards need to be trained to be tougher, not just healers.”

She makes a frown that shows all of her bottom teeth. I smile at the expression but look back to the empty courtyard as we wait for Professor Bale to show up.

“You could have warned us,” I grumble. “I would have stretched more or faked an illness.”

“Where’s the fun in that?” She bumps her shoulder against mine.

Jace leans closer to me, his hand brushing my lower back. “I’ll be right here.” He tugs me closer to him. “Someone has to drag you to the infirmary.”

“My angel,” I tease then slap his chest.

“Always.” He winks.

Ellavee makes a gagging sound. “If you two are going to be disgusting, can you do it downwind? Some of us have sensitive stomachs.”

“We’re not—” I hold up my hands. “It’s not like that. We’re just friends. We grew up together.”

“Sure.” Ellavee picks at her nails. “Friends, that’s what they all say right before they start making out in supply closets.”

“There will be no supply closet making out.”

“Don’t knock it until you’ve tried it.” She examines her cuticles. “Carry on then.”

Jace catches my eye, and there’s something in his expression, a flicker of hurt or hope. I look away before I have to figure out which one.

Professor Bale.

Lux’s dad. A fae who was a fighter. A Vanguard over one hundred years old.

Wow.

I glance around and quickly realize this isn’t like my other classes.

There’s a mix of students here, mostly bone years but also blood years scattered through the crowd. I see their red emblems, the heart and serpent symbols against black leather. This is the first class I’ve had where the years are combined. I thought the headmaster said all years were kept separate. Or did I assume that?

This is the most students I’ve seen in one place since orientation. There must be at least sixty people here.

I spot Draven and Malric standing together in the back. It makes sense now why they hang out. Different years but they must have known each other before, both vampires and all. Zuri and Killian are here too.

“Why is this such a large class?” I ask Lux under my breath.

“Triage of the Damned is mandatory for all students, and my dad’s the only one who teaches it.” She keeps her voice low. “He mixes upperclassmen into his first year classes so they can help when he needs it, and I think they like to keep their skills sharp.”

“Wonderful. So we get to be the practice dummies for blood years.”

“Basically.” Her grin doesn’t reach her eyes. “Welcome to my childhood.”

One second we’re all staring into an empty courtyard, and the next a man is standing before us. Pointed ears. Same startling blue eyes as his daughter.

“He likes to make an entrance,” Lux groans.

He’s tall and broad in the shoulders but lean everywhere else, like anything unnecessary got carved away a long time ago. He doesn’t look a hundred and fifty years old, but there are signs of age, gray hairs around the temples.

He doesn’t greet us. His face isn’t cruel exactly but hard in a way that suggests warmth left him a long time ago.

“You’re here because you think you want to save lives.” His voice carries across the courtyard and echoes off the magical ceiling. “But saving lives isn’t pretty or noble, and most of you aren’t ready for what it takes.”

He sounds like a military man already.

“My class won’t teach you to heal. The other professors, the softer ones, they handle that. This class teaches you to survive long enough to do the healing. To protect yourself and your patients. To stay alive when everything around you wants you dead.”

He gestures to the small group leaning against the bleachers. “The blood years will run drills, lead groups, help keep you in line. Listen to them like you listen to me.”

Lux elbows me gently. “Told you.”

“This year, we’ll cover basic defensive maneuvers, how to block and evade, create distance, as well as how to triage. The goal is to be able to assess a scene and make decisions in seconds.”

“Your father is a real charmer,” Ellavee drawls, and I snort.

“Gets it from my mother,” Lux fires back. “She’s worse.”

“Halfway through the year, I’ll take you to active fissure sites. You’ll see exactly what we’re training for and how you perform in the field.”

His eyes sweep across us. I think Lux stops breathing when her father’s gaze drifts to her. “Some of you will rise. Some won’t. Today, I’ll split you into groups, each led by myself or a blood year. Rotate through stations without complaints or embarrassing yourselves.”



The next two hours are complete hell.

We run laps first, and by the fifth lap my thighs are screaming. Jace keeps pace beside me even though I know he could run circles around the whole class without breaking a sweat.

“You’re doing great,” he offers.

“I’m dying.”

“Gracefully though.”

I laugh even though it hurts. “Shut up.”

He grins, and I hate that it makes me feel better. I hate that I notice the way his hair falls across his forehead when he runs, damp with sweat despite the cold. I hate that I’m noticing anything at all when I can barely breathe.

I don’t even know what the fuck I’m doing here. I used to want to be a healer, and now I don’t know if I’m even capable of overcoming my shit and using a scalpel ever again.

I run until my mind is mush and I forget what I’m even stressed about.

Then we do stances and basic positioning. How to stand so you don’t get knocked down. Hands up to protect your center.

Malric is the blood year assigned to my group. He walks around correcting posture, kicking feet into wider stances without warning. He tells me I’m not protecting my core properly, and I’m pretty sure he does it just to put his hands on me. He touches my stomach and back, fixing my stance, and leans close to my ear. “Like this, Red.”

I want to vomit my lunch from the running and from him touching me, but I keep it together.

Lux catches my eye from across the group and makes a face like she's plotting his murder. I give a slight shake of my head, because he's not worth it.

We all got split up, but luckily Lux and I are in the same group of eight at the farthest end of the yard. We're partnered for evasion drills. She throws slow strikes, and I practice dodging and blocking.

My arms ache from holding them up, and every time I drop my guard, she flicks my forehead.

"Stop that." Flick. "Stop dropping your hands."

I glare at her, gasping for air. "I'm sorry, but I didn't grow up with a crazy Vanguard dad running me through drills. I'm dying over here. I wanted to be a healer, not a fucking combat fighter."

"And I wanted a normal dad who makes pancakes on Sundays and doesn't know eighteen ways to kill someone with a dinner fork." She shrugs. "We don't always get what we want."

I laugh, "Eighteen?"

"Minimum." Her expression softens. "I know he's intense, but he means well. He doesn't want any of us to get hurt out there, and he's paranoid about when the next cycle could come."

I nod as Bale bellows for everyone to gather.

"Time for a demonstration." He stands at the center of the courtyard. "Bone years need to see what a real attack looks like, not training pace but real speed and intent."

Oh this is going to be lovely.

"I need a bone year volunteer."

No one raises a hand, but Lux shifts to stand behind me, drawing her father's attention to us.

Great.

"You." He points at me. "What's your name?"

I swallow and look side to side, hoping someone else will speak up. "Maelis."

"Maelis, front and center."

Lux pats my back from behind. When I glance over my shoulder, she's cringing and mouths, "Sorry."

"I'm going to kill you later," I hiss.

"Fair."

I step forward. Sixty pairs of eyes on me.

Holy fuck.

“I need a blood year to run the attack.” Bale scans the crowd, and I pray it won’t be Malric. “Malric.”

My heart sinks.

Malric grins, pushes off from where he’s sitting on the bleachers, and rolls his shoulders like he’s been waiting for this all day. There’s something in his eyes that makes unease start to fester inside me.

He’s going to enjoy putting me down.

“I’ll do it.”

The voice comes from behind Malric, and Draven steps forward. He’s only a bone year. Why does he think he can volunteer?

Bale must know him or know his father. If his father really is high up at the Vanguard Academy, then I can only assume Draven knows a bit about fighting. But why is he volunteering? Is he saving me from Malric? They seem to be friends.

Malric’s grin falters. His jaw tightens, but he doesn’t argue and steps back.

Bale considers them both for a moment. “Alucard, you’re up.”

He calls him by his last name. There’s definitely history there. If Lux knew who Draven is, then it makes sense Bale does too, but why is he letting him do this instead of Malric?

I realize everyone is still staring at me, and I straighten quickly as Draven approaches, his usual stoic expression in place. His eyes scan me once from head to toe.

He leans in close enough that only I can hear. “Remember what I said about hesitation?”

He pulls back before I can respond.

“Defensive stance,” Bale orders. “Block what you can. Evade what you can’t. Don’t die.”

Hilarious.

I raise my hands and try to remember everything from the last couple hours. Feet apart. Weight centered. Guard up.

Draven bursts into motion. One second he’s standing there, and the next his hand is past my guard and shoving my shoulder hard. I stumble back and catch myself.

He’s already reset. Expression blank.

I raise my hands again. I want to shout this isn't fair and that he's a fucking vampire, but I don't want to play the weak human card.

He comes faster this time. I block one strike and miss the next. His palm hits my sternum, and I'm on my back before I understand what happened. Stone cold through my shirt. Air gone from my lungs.

Someone laughs. Sounds like Killian, that asshole.

I get up, my hands shaking, and ready myself.

Draven watches me with those honey eyes. He doesn't taunt me or smile. Then he charges again. I try to evade and almost manage it. His leg sweeps mine, and I'm down, hip hitting stone, pain instantly blooming up my side.

I push myself up slower this time, palms scraped and ribs aching, something warm trickling down my arm. Blood. I don't look at it.

"Stay down, Freckles," he says under his breath.

I get up anyway. Fuck him for trying to make me look weak in front of everyone. It's not enough that I froze in front of my group during the autopsy, but now he wants everyone to see how weak I am out here too.

His eyes narrow, and he delivers three more strikes. Faster. Harder. I block one, and it sends pain shooting up my forearm. The second catches me across the jaw, snapping my head to the side, and I taste blood.

The last one hits my ribs, which were already hurting.

I go down hard and lie there staring at the gray sky through the enchanted ceiling. Everything hurts in a way that feels permanent.

"Enough," Bale says, sounding irritated. "That's what real conflict looks like. The rest of you, take note."

Draven walks away. I don't watch him go, but I hear what he says to Malric as he passes, loud enough for the people around them to hear. Loud enough for me.

"She's not cut out for this. Give her a week. She'll be gone."

It feels like a sucker punch considering how much I want this, and I have to reign in the tears.

Bale dismisses the class. I don't move and don't cry, keeping it together even though I feel humiliated.

Lux is beside me in an instant, helping me sit up. "You okay? Maelis, talk to me."

"I'm fine." I'm not. Everything hurts. My jaw. My ribs. My fucking pride. But I say it anyway.

Jace appears on my other side. He's looking at Draven's back as he walks away, and there's something in his expression I've never seen before. Something dangerous.

"Jace." I grab his arm.

He looks down at the blood on my lip and the way I'm cradling my ribs. His jaw tightens so hard I can see the muscle twitch.

"He didn't have to go that hard."

"I'm fine," I insist. "Don't."

He wants to go after Draven, but he stays and keeps his hand steady on my back as I find my balance.

"Can you walk?" Lux hovers at my elbow.

"I think so."

"I'm going to trip him in the hallway later," she announces.

"I'll assist," Ellavee chimes in on my other side. "I know some demons who owe me favors. We could make it look like a training accident."

I laugh, and it hurts. "I appreciate the loyalty."

"I told you," Lux says as we start toward the changing rooms. "Those vampires are assholes. Every single one of them thinks they're better than everyone else. And Draven Alucard?" She shakes her head. "He's the biggest dick of all."

I keep replaying it in my head as we walk. The way Draven looked at me with nothing in his face. The way he whispered about hesitation before we started like he was setting me up to fail. The way he announced to everyone that I wouldn't last a week.

I didn't think we were friends, but after we talked on our way to class earlier, I thought maybe he wasn't so bad. I thought there was something underneath the cold exterior.

Now I know I was wrong.

He wanted to hurt me. He wanted everyone to see me fail.

And the worst part is some small, ridiculous part of me still doesn't understand why.

"I'll talk to my father tonight," Lux says as we walk. Her voice has an edge to it. "That was bullshit. He shouldn't have let it go that far."

I shake my head. "Don't."

"Mae—"

"I mean it. I'm already a target for being human. I don't need people saying I ran to a professor the second things got hard." I run my hands

through my hair, tucking wild strands behind my ears. “I can handle it.”

“No one could hate you, Mae. You’re not a target,” Jace says as he peels off toward the men’s changing room. I want to roll my eyes. Clearly he hasn’t been paying attention.

The door swings shut behind him, and Ellavee snorts. “He’s sweet, wrong but sweet.” She tilts her head, examining me. “Here’s the thing. The other bloodlines might hate you because you’re different, and they think it’s unfair that someone weak and fragile got into Ashwell when so many of their kind didn’t. But the guys don’t hate you.”

Lux makes a strangled sound. “Ellavee.”

“What? I’m being honest.” She shrugs. “Half the males in our year would trip over themselves to get your attention, some of the chicks too. The ones who hate you are jealous. The rest just want to sleep with you.”

My face goes hot. “That’s not—”

“Oh please, you’re either naive or in denial. You’re human. You’re new. You’re pretty. To these bloodlines that barely interact with humans, you’re exotic like forbidden fruit.” She smirks. “You don’t have to be strong for them to want you. You just have to be interesting.”

“I’m really not.”

“Your angel thinks otherwise.” She glances toward the door Jace disappeared through. “That boy looks at you like you hung the moon and he’s grateful to be standing in the light. He’d walk through fire if you asked him to and probably wouldn’t even ask why.”

I don’t want to think about the way Jace looks at me, not when everything else is already too much.

Lux loops her arm through mine as we push into the changing room. “Ignore her. She’s trying to get a reaction.”

“I’m trying to prepare her,” Ellavee corrects. “This place is going to eat her alive if she doesn’t figure out how things work.”

“Thanks for the vote of confidence,” I mutter.

“Anytime.” She winks. “That’s what friends are for.”

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Chapter Twelve

"Those who enter the mirror whole do not always emerge that way."

— Unsigned note found in a former student's room



I pull on my black sweater and try to tame my mess of red waves in the mirror, but it's pointless. They do what they want.

After dinner, I told everyone I'd meet them at the Mirror Ceremony. I didn't feel like going back to Ellavee's room with her and Lux. I don't care to hear about Ellavee's latest conquest or be probed about my relationship with Jace.

Because there's nothing to tell. At least that's what I keep saying.

I never wanted to cross that line with him before. I was afraid it would ruin our friendship, and I was protecting myself because I knew one day he'd leave our small village and go on to do bigger things. He was always meant for more than Ironfen. I wasn't going to be the girl who held him back or who got left behind.

But now we're both here at Ashwell. Both at the start of something new.

I don't know how I feel anymore.

It was clear he wanted to kiss me last night. I was so close to letting it happen. Gods, a part of me wanted it so bad I could taste it. I could use the distraction, something good to hold onto when everything else feels crazy right now.

But that’s the problem. It would be a distraction, and Jace deserves more than that.

I love him. I’ve always loved him, and I’m attracted to him. I just don’t know if it’s the right kind of love. The kind that builds something or the kind that ruins everything.

I huff out a breath and shove the thoughts aside. Not tonight.

I grab the map off my desk and squint at the tiny labels, trying to figure out where I’m supposed to be going for the Mirror Ceremony. The location isn’t marked with a name, only a symbol, a circle made of bones beneath the headmaster’s tower.

That’s not ominous at all.

Good thing I threw my cloak over my clothes tonight, because I have to walk most of the way outside, and it’s a full-on snowy blizzard. I pull my hood up over my head and hold the cloak tight around me. The cold bites through anyway.

I’ve been to the headmaster’s tower before, but I find myself once again unsure if I’m going the right way. Everything looks different in the dark. The buildings blur together, all the same stone and frost-covered arches. I thought there would be more students around since all years are required to be there tonight, but the paths are empty. It’s me and the snow and the howling wind.

I quicken my pace and take a shortcut through a small alley between the blood year dormitories.

A prickle runs along my skin, like the feeling of being watched. I glance back.

Nothing. Just darkness and whirls of snow. I pull my hands from my cloak and breathe into them for warmth. I need to keep walking, I must be close.

Something drops down right in front of me.

I cry out and stumble back. A large figure. Giant black wings spread wide for a second before it all vanishes.

He steps toward me, and I hold my breath and take another step back. My spine hits the cold stone wall.

Then he pushes his hood back, and I see his face.

Draven.

So vampires have wings too. His were even larger than Jace’s, if that’s possible. And now they’re gone. They must be manifested with current.

I shake off the thought and stare daggers at him.

“What the fuck, Draven?”

“You should really watch where you walk at night.”

“And you should really stop stalking me.” I cross my arms despite the cold. “People will talk.”

“Let them.”

“What, you want them to think you’re obsessed with me?” My ribs ache from earlier, but I ignore it. “Because this is twice now you’ve gone out of your way to find me alone.”

His eyebrows furrow. “Don’t flatter yourself.”

“Hard not to when you keep showing up.” I push off the wall and take a step closer, tired of being the one backing away. “What is it about me that bothers you so much? That I’m human? That I’m still here? Or that you can’t figure me out?”

He watches me with those amber eyes. Snow catches in his dark hair and melts against his jaw.

“I think I make you nervous,” I say. “I think that’s why you want me gone.”

“You don’t make me anything.”

“Prove it. Leave me alone.”

He leans in close enough that I can feel the cold radiating off him. I catch his scent for the first time. He smells like winter. Cold air and whiskey and something I shouldn’t want to lean into.

I hate that some part of me files it away.

“No.”

A shape emerges from the darkness behind him. Massive black fur and gleaming eyes.

His wolf.

I tense but don’t look away from Draven. I won’t give him that.

“Your dog is showing.”

“He’s not a dog.”

“Could’ve fooled me.”

The wolf growls low in its throat. Draven doesn’t call it off or even glance at it.

“You should be afraid,” he says quietly.

“Of what? You? Your oversized pet?” I force my voice steady even though my heart is slamming against my bruised ribs. “I’ve had much

scarier things happen to me. You're going to have to try harder."

"This isn't a joke, Maelis." His shoulders square. "Being a Veilguard requires great sacrifice. You don't even know what sacrifice is in your small human life. You don't belong here, and you're going to get someone killed if you don't die first."

He presses his hand against the wall above my head, peering down at me. I really need to start carrying a weapon around this place.

"You don't know me." I stare right back up at him even though my pulse is racing. "I know what sacrifice is, but I don't need to explain any of that to you. Get out of my way, Draven. I'm going to be late."

I don't want to argue with him. I'm tired of these threats.

"Humans don't get eidolons. You're useless here." His amber eyes start to bleed red at the edges. So that's what a vampire looks like when they're really angry. Good, let him be angry. "You froze during the autopsy. You froze on the field today. And you're going to freeze again when it matters, when it's someone's life on the line." His eyes bore into mine. "Maybe the mirror will save us all from your incompetence tonight and you won't make it back out."

He pushes off the wall and starts to walk away.

I stand there for a moment, catching my breath. Hands shaking at my sides.

"Fuck you, Draven," I yell it at his back, wishing I had something clever to say that could hurt him. "I'm going to the ceremony."

He doesn't turn around.

"Your death wish."

And then he's gone, swallowed by the dark blizzard beyond the alleyway.

I stand there, his voice echoing in my head.

But he doesn't get to decide how my story ends.

I kick the pile of snow in front of me, my face heating despite the cold. I don't know why he's got it up his ass to come after me. Our team won the stupid keys. I may have frozen when it was my turn to cut, but I helped our team win. I don't know what I did to make him hate me this much, but he's not going to scare me into leaving.

He thinks I'm soft because I'm human. He doesn't understand that soft things learn to survive in ways hard things never have to.

I don't scare easily, and I don't fucking quit.



“Hey, I was starting to worry about you,” Jace says, hurrying toward me.

He opens his cloak and pulls me into him, his arm and wing folding around me like my own personal cocoon of warmth and safety. I sink into it without thinking.

“You didn’t have to wait up here for me.” I peek up at him, and he shakes his head.

“Lux and Ellavee are nice, but they’re a lot to be around for long periods of time,” he groans. “Especially without you.”

I giggle, glad he can still make me laugh after the day I’ve had.

I stay bundled up next to Jace as he leads us along with a handful of other students down a long, winding stairwell. We started in the headmaster’s tower, but now we are deep beneath it, winding down until the air thins and the walls change from normal interior stone to something colder and rougher, a cave carved out of the earth centuries ago.

“This isn’t creepy at all,” I whisper.

“There’s so much current down here.” He leans down near my ear. “I wish you could feel it.”

I want to ask him to describe it, but we reach the bottom, and the words die in my throat.

The entire space opens into a massive cavern, not a claustrophobic underground chamber but something gigantic and ancient. The ceiling disappears into darkness overhead, so high I can’t see where it ends. There are no seats down here, just a giant room with walls lined in torches, all of them alive with fire. All except three across from us in the distance. Those burn different colors. Amethyst. Crimson. Icy blue.

Bone. Blood. Breath.

Below the colored torches must be the mirror everyone’s been talking about. It’s covered with a black drape, and as large as I expected it to be.

“I see Lux’s pink hair. Come on.” Jace pulls me through the crowd of students and faculty.

Everyone really is here tonight.

I spot Draven as we pass by. His gaze locks on mine then flicks up to Jace. Something hard passes through his expression before he looks away. I

don’t think Jace notices him at all.

Gods, it’s not fair that all the vampires are so hot, especially that fucking jerk.

We reach Lux and Ellavee, and Jace unwraps me but keeps his arm around my shoulder. I don’t fight it and don’t care what Ellavee thinks. He’s warm, and it feels good to be like this with him.

The room is quiet. I can hear the faint drip of water somewhere in the distance. The air smells of damp earth and something else I can’t place. Maybe current has a scent.

Everyone waits.

I don’t know if I should be excited or anxious right now. I’m assuming since I’m human I won’t get an eidolon. It’s a mirror. How scary can this thing be after all?

“Welcome to our annual Mirror Ceremony.” Ashmoor’s voice echoes through the cavern, and I glance up at him through the people around me.

I see Professor Nestor fiddling with the drape over the mirror. I realized I have no idea what bloodline he is. Definitely not fae. No pointed ears. And I can’t imagine him being a vampire, plus most of the vampires seem to have some shade of golden eyes. I could see him being a shifter and shifting into something funny like a scruffy fox or coyote.

“The ceremony is simple. You will approach the mirror and know what to do. Ashwell will decide your fate. The eidolon you are given will be telling of your future and your strengths.”

This is what they were talking about in class earlier. The school decides. The school knows. *The school is fucking creepy.*

“There are three possible eidolons, and Professor Nestor will go into further detail for you.” The headmaster steps aside.

He doesn’t seem as scary tonight as he did at orientation. That’s a relief.

“I’m sure all of you know the symbols for each year by now.” Nestor’s reedy voice carries across the cavern. “Bone year has the wolf and ribcage. Blood year has the serpent and heart. Breath year has the bat and pair of lungs.”

He clears his throat and tries to project louder. It echoes off the stone walls, bouncing back at us from the darkness above.

“One of these creatures will become your eidolon after tonight. The wolf represents endurance. The serpent, control. And the bat, understanding.”

As he speaks, I start to notice that animals are everywhere.

Upperclassmen around me are letting their eidolons out, pulling them from somewhere deep inside themselves, from their current or their soul or whatever.

A man standing next to me has a yellow serpent coiled around his arm, its scaled head resting on his shoulder, tongue flicking lazily at the air. I spot Elizabeth near the front, her bat circling her head in slow loops. A massive gray wolf sits at the feet of a woman with sharp cheekbones and sharper eyes.

I've never seen this many eidolons in one place. I haven't been around many upperclassmen, and maybe they wait until after this ceremony to let them be seen, some kind of rite of passage.

But if that's true, how does Draven already have a wolf? He's only a bone year like me.

I file the question away for later.

"Your eidolon will become one with you." Nestor's voice pulls my attention back. "It will know you inside and out. And you will know it, for it is partly an extension of yourself. It will assist you when needed. It can help you and protect you."

He pushes his glasses higher on his nose.

"Your eidolon is not a pet but a permanent part of you. The closest relationship you will ever have with another living thing. Your love for your eidolon will know no bounds, and the same in return." His pale eyes scan the crowd. "The eidolon revealed for you tonight will not only speak of the creature. It will speak of you. What's inside of you. What you're made of."

Jace holds me a little tighter. I lean into him without thinking.

"Wolf-marked healers are built to withstand what breaks others." Nestor shifts his weight, rocking slightly as he speaks. "They are not always elegant. They are not always gentle. They keep people alive long enough for miracles to happen. Endurance is their gift."

I glance around the room. White and gray wolves are scattered throughout the crowd.

"Serpent-marked healers are decisive and precise." Nestor starts to pace in front of the covered mirror. "They excel where others freeze. Control is their gift."

The serpents on the man's shoulder near me turns its head, and its red glowing eyes look right at me.

“Bat-marked healers are defined not by what they touch but by what they notice.” He tilts his head to the side. “Bats are drawn to anomalies, things medicine does not yet understand. They often save lives before a blade is ever needed. Understanding is their gift.”

Jace will get something powerful. He wants this, deserves it, has the current to call something forward. But me? I might step in front of that mirror and find nothing at all but glass and silence and proof that I don’t belong here.

Nestor steps away from the headmaster and moves toward the covered mirror again. His fingers brush the black drape, ready to pull it off.

“One by one, you will be called upon,” Ashmoor says. “You will approach the mirror and wait for your signal. When the mirror is finished with you, you will go stand with the upperclassmen on the other side of the room. Once all students have completed the ceremony, you will be dismissed.”

I swallow. A knot of unease forms in my chest. It tightens with every breath.

Jace must sense it. His hand slides to my arm, rubbing slow and steady, up and down, like he’s trying to soothe something he can’t see.

I don’t think he can protect me from what’s coming. Maybe Draven was right and I shouldn’t have shown up tonight.

“Jace Seravin,” Professor Bale says, reading off a piece of parchment as Nestor pulls the drape off the mirror.

I can’t see it clearly from where I stand, and it appears to be made of bones. It’s a tall, rectangular thing, large enough for someone as tall as Jace to stand in front of and still tower over him. The border is thick and ridged, twisted together like something grown rather than built. I think I see an entire ribcage protruding from the bottom of one side. The whole frame is bones, human and creature alike woven together. I spot a pair of antlers curving out near the top. A skull I don’t recognize jutting from the corner.

Holy fuck, what am I getting myself into?

“Good luck,” I say as Jace releases me.

I squeeze his hand before he goes. He squeezes back then turns and walks toward the mirror.

Professor Bale nods, and Jace steps to stand in front of it. Why did he have to get called first? Now I have to sit here through all one hundred first

years alone. The headmaster made it clear that once you had your eidolon you went to the other side of the room.

Jace won't be able to tell me what it's like. If it hurts. What happens inside.

Okay. Relax, Maelis.

I think I'm starting to spiral. I take a deep breath and force myself to stare ahead as Jace stops in front of the mirror. The liquid surface ripples even though nothing has touched it.

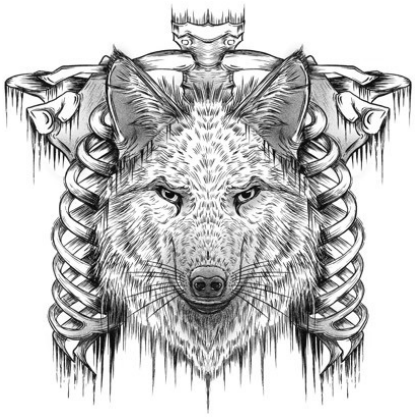
It knows he's there.

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Chapter Thirteen

"No one knows who made the mirror. The prevailing theory is that no one did. It formed at the site of the first cycle, where Veilguard and creature died together in such numbers that their bones became one. That site is now the core of Ashwell. The school was built because of the mirror, not the other way around."

— Unsigned Entry, Ashwell Archives



Jace places his hand on the mirror.

His arm pushes right through like it's made of water. Liquid silver ripples around his wrist, swallowing him to the elbow, and several bone years gasp. I hold my breath.

His hand is only in there for a few seconds. His face stays calm and focused. I don't see any visible signs of pain.

When he pulls it back out, there's a little brown furry bat nestled in his palm. It blinks up at him with wide, dark eyes then crawls up his arm to perch on his shoulder.

That's it?

That was easier than I thought it would be.

He crosses the room to where the other years are gathered. His eyes find mine through the crowd, and he gives me a soft smile. A nod. He's trying to

tell me it’s going to be okay. I want to believe him. But the next girl that gets called doesn’t simply touch the mirror. She steps forward, and the liquid surface parts for her like a curtain. She walks straight through and disappears.

“What is happening?” I whisper.

Lux stares straight ahead, her jaw tight. She’s getting nervous too. I can see it in the way her fingers twist together.

“The school decides what it wants from you before you get your eidolon.” Ellavee leans in from Lux’s other side. “It’s different for everyone.”

We wait.

The cavern is silent except for the faint drip of water somewhere in the dark. I count the seconds. Ten. Twenty. Thirty.

The mirror ripples, and the girl stumbles back out, gasping, a serpent clutched tight in her trembling hands.

Everyone lets out a breath. A few nervous laughs scatter through the crowd.

The professors don’t look worried. They’ve been watching this for years.

I shouldn’t be worried either but I can’t help it.

The ceremony picks up speed after that. Names called one after another. Some people step fully into the mirror and vanish for seconds or minutes. Some press their palm to the surface and pull back their eidolon like reaching into a bag. I want to know what they feel when they touch it or what happens to the ones who enter the mirror, but I’m not able to talk to anyone on the other side of the room.

Lux gets called. She walks up with her chin high, but I can see her hands shaking at her sides. She stops in front of the mirror and waits.

The liquid surface reaches out to her. A silvery translucent hand emerges from the glass and presses against her chest, right over her heart. Lux’s eyes go wide. Her breath catches.

A solid white wolf steps out of the mirror. It sits at her feet and looks up at her like it’s been waiting for her all along.

A huge smile breaks across her face. She looks back at me and gapes before crossing to the other side with her wolf padding beside her.

Ellavee goes next and gets a serpent. The thing coils around her wrist like a bracelet, and she smirks like she expected nothing less.

I watch the eidolons emerge one by one. All the wolves are white or gray, thick-furred and watchful. All except Draven's, which is solid black and noticeably larger than the rest.

The serpents come in every shade. Yellow, green, brown, and black. Some small enough to curl in your palm. Others thick as my arm, long enough to loop around your body twice.

The bats are shades of black and brown, leathery wings folded against soft fur. When I first saw Elizabeth's, I thought it was creepy, but the more I watch them emerge, the more I realize they're sort of cute. Big dark eyes. Tiny clawed feet.

None of this eases my anxiety.

"Nyra Fenwick."

I watch the girl from my autopsy team walk toward the mirror. Violet eyes and black wings. The one who shoved the scalpel in my hand because she didn't want to touch the crawler.

There's only a handful of us left now, and I don't know how I haven't let my anxiety get the better of me yet.

The headmaster probably put my name last on purpose to torture me. Or maybe he won't call me at all. Maybe humans don't get to participate. Maybe I'll stand here until everyone leaves, and then someone will escort me back to my room and tell me it was all a mistake.

Nyra steps into the mirror. The liquid swallows her whole, and the waiting begins. Silence presses against my ears. I count the seconds again.

This is taking too long.

Nestor shifts his weight. Bale's jaw ticks, and they exchange a grim look. A full minute passes.

The mirror starts to vibrate.

I take a step back. My eyes stay locked on the rippling surface. Something is wrong.

Nyra Fenwick falls out of the mirror, hitting the stone floor with a crack that echoes through the cavern like a bone snapping.

She doesn't move.

Whispers break out. Someone gasps. Someone else makes a sound like a sob.

Professor Nestor rushes forward and drops to his knees beside her. His hands move over her chest, her throat, her face.

Then he stops, looks up at the headmaster, and shakes his head.

Two professors I don’t recognize step forward. A woman and a man wearing belts filled with medical supplies. They lift Nyra’s body between them and carry her toward a door I hadn’t noticed before guarded by Felix, the demon assistant of the headmaster. He pulls the door open as they approach with her body.

She’s limp, pale, empty-handed. No eidolon.

She’s dead.

The door closes behind them, and the cavern goes silent. The headmaster doesn’t address it. Nestor doesn’t explain. They stand there, waiting for the ceremony to continue like a girl didn’t just die in front of us.

I knew they said bone years would die, but I thought it was a scare tactic, something to keep us working hard and staying sharp.

I didn’t think it would happen like this or that I would see it.

“Maelis Rose.”

Professor Bale’s voice startles me.

I can’t move. My feet are frozen to the stone. My lungs won’t fill.

She just died. She walked into that mirror and died, a fucking angel, and whatever happened inside that mirror killed her. And now they want me, the human, the one everyone says doesn’t belong here, to go stand in front of that same fucking thing.

No way. There is no fucking way.

I turn away from the mirror. My eyes find the stairs. The way out. I could run. I could leave right now, and no one would stop me. No one would blame me.

Then I see Draven.

He’s standing at the bottom of the stairwell, his black wolf sitting beside him like a shadow with teeth. His arms are crossed, and his face gives nothing away.

But his eyes are locked on mine.

I remember what he said in the alley. That I don’t belong here. That I’ll freeze when it matters. That I won’t make it out. He’s waiting for me to prove him right.

Something shifts in my chest. Something hot and stubborn and angry.

Fuck no. Draven Alucard, you absolute asshole. You don’t get to be right about me.

I will not show fear. I will not run. This mirror can’t give me any more pain than I’ve already endured in this life. It can’t show me anything worse

than what I’ve already done.

I turn back to the front and walk toward the mirror.

My legs shake, and my heart pounds in my chest. It feels like time slows to a crawl, and it takes me entirely too long to reach the thing.

The liquid surface ripples as I approach like it senses me coming. I want to recoil but force one foot in front of the other. I don’t look for Jace. I can’t look at anyone else or I might lose my nerve. I finally reach it, and I’m not ready to look into the surface, too afraid of what I’ll see. I let my eyes trail the frame.

Hundreds and hundreds of bones are fused together. Ribcages arch along the sides, curving inward like hands reaching to pull you closer. Femurs and tibias stack on top of each other, bleached white and yellow with age. Skulls are embedded in the corners. Some human. Some twisted creatures. Their hollow eye sockets stare at nothing and everything all at once.

I see vertebrae twisted into spirals. A full set of antlers crowns the top, jagged and reaching toward the darkness above. At the base, a pile of smaller bones. Delicate ones. The kind that come from children’s hands.

The death mirror, that’s what this should be called.

I close my eyes, exhale, raise my chin, and look into the mirror.

My reflection stares back at me, only something’s wrong.

I take a step closer. The copper hair. The freckles. The same lips. All of it’s the same except for the eyes.

Those are not my brown eyes.

They’re amber. Bright and molten like honey held up to firelight, and there’s red bleeding into the edges of the irises, creeping in like ink dropped in water.

I blink a few times, but my reflection doesn’t change.

My body fades, but the eyes remain, glowing at the center of the mirror and pulling me in.

Everything around me darkens and disappears all at once. I don’t recall moving, but suddenly I’m no longer in the cavern at all.

I’m swallowed by complete darkness. Complete silence. Not even the dripping water can be heard anymore, but I feel something.

A presence surrounds me, pressing in from every direction. Not touching but there. There’s no floor beneath my feet, and yet I’m standing.

No walls and yet I feel enclosed. No light and yet somehow I can see my own hands when I lift them in front of my face.

And beneath me, beneath everything, I feel a pulse.

A heartbeat.

Slow and deep and rhythmic. Like the earth itself is breathing. Like I'm standing inside something alive.

The core of Ashwell. The heart of the school. Is it possible I'm inside it?

Then the voice comes.

It doesn't come from anywhere. It comes from everywhere. Inside my head. Inside my chest. Echoing in the darkness all around me.

"Maelissss Rosssse."

Not a question. It already knows.

"Yes."

"You have come to receive your eidolon, to be judged worthy of the bond."

"Yes."

"Then we will see what you are made of."

The darkness presses closer, and a coldness spreads across my skin as a tingle creeps up my spine.

"What do you fear mossst?"

"Death."

"No." The voice wraps around me. "You do not fear death. You fear what comesss after. Or rather what doesn't."

I'm speechless.

"You fear the void, the end, the eternal nothing. It keepsss you awake at night. It sssitsss on your chest and stealsss your breath. You cannot prove there is something more. And that uncertainty is the thing that truly hauntsss you."

I can't breathe. I can't move. I can't find my voice.

She signed the divorce papers. Now he wants to talk.

Sometimes the best part is watching him earn a second chance. Find your next read at Lokepub.

“You became a healer to fight thisss and have control over the one thing no one can control.”

My chest starts to heave, but I fight it, burying it where I bury everything else.

“You fear the end so profoundly. You want to become an elite healer. A Veilguard who savesss livesss. Sssomeone who stands between the living and the dying.”

The darkness shifts, and an icy chill settles over me as the temperature plummets.

“And yet you have taken a life.”

The tears come before I can stop them. Hot and sharp, spilling down my cheeks. I want to scream no, but it would be a lie.

“Yes.” My voice cracks. I wipe my eyes and look down to see my hands covered in blood. Panic spikes inside me like a jolt to my heart.

“I know this blood.”

I blink. “What?”

“Your father’s blood. It has walked these hallsss.”

My father…was here? He went to Ashwell?

It explains so much. The journals and the acceptance letter. The way he knew things he shouldn’t have known.

“He never told me,” I whisper.

“There is much you have not been told. In time, you will learn.”

Before I can ask what that means, the darkness begins to recede. Light bleeds in at the edges. I feel the ground solidify beneath my feet.

“You have been judged, Maelissss Rosssse. You have been found worthy.” The voice fades. The light grows brighter. “Your eidolon awaits.”

And then I’m through. Standing on the other side of the mirror, gasping for air, shaking from head to toe and flooded with the warmth from the cavern. The chamber is silent. Two hundred students watching. Faculty along the walls like statues.

I look down.

A small shape appears at my feet. Gray fur. Round black eyes. A ringed tail curled around tiny paws.

A raccoon.

Someone in the crowd laughs. Whispers spread like fire catching dry leaves.

“Even the mirror knows she’ll be picking through scraps to survive here,” someone says loudly enough for everyone to hear, and my cheeks burn.

“A bottom feeder for a bottom feeder,” someone else adds. More laughter follows.

I stare at the creature. She stares back.

I don’t know whether to laugh or cry.

The raccoon tilts her head like she’s asking me the same question.

I crouch down slowly and hold out my hand. She sniffs it once then presses her small head against my palm.

Something clicks into place, a warmth I didn’t expect. A connection I can’t explain. Like a thread pulled taut between us, invisible but unbreakable. Suddenly I don’t care about the laughter or the whispers. I don’t care what anyone else thinks.

She’s mine, and I’m hers.

I scoop her up and hold her against my chest, wrapping my cloak around us both. Her tiny hands grip my sweater. Her heartbeat thrums against me, finding the rhythm of mine. I run my fingers along her soft fur, and she leans into the touch.

Her eyes meet mine again. Dark and knowing and full of something that feels like trust.

“Poppy.” The name comes to me instantly. “You will be my Poppy.”

I feel her pleasure at the name. A flutter of warmth in my chest that isn’t mine. This must be what the others feel when they talk about current. I can feel her emotions and thoughts, like an extension of myself I never knew was missing.

I don’t know how to describe it because I never knew such a thing was possible.

“Okay,” I murmur.

I turn and walk back through the crowd. A sudden urgency to protect her rises in my chest. The feeling spreads through me, and she vanishes, only she’s not gone. She’s a part of me now, like Lux tried to explain before. I couldn’t comprehend it then. Now I understand how she can appear and disappear at will but always be here.

I don’t look at the students snickering, Draven or Malric or anyone.

But I feel Headmaster Ashmoor’s eyes on me as I pass him. Heavy and watchful as I take my place on the other side of the room.

Lux and Jace are there in an instant. Jace wraps his arm around me, and I sink into his warmth without thinking. He looks down at me, and I can see it in his face. All the questions he wants to ask. All the things he wants to say.

But we have to wait. There's still a handful of students left to finish the ceremony, and we're supposed to remain silent.

I survived the mirror. I got my eidolon.

I have Poppy.

I never imagined wanting something like this, never knew there was a hole in me until she filled it. But she's mine now, woven into every part of me, and I love her in a way I don't have words for yet. I would destroy anything that tried to hurt her. And I know deep in my bones she would do the same for me.

The headmaster waits until the final student takes their place. Then he steps forward, hands clasped behind his back.

"Tonight you have all faced the mirror. Some of you found it easier than expected. Some of you did not."

His eyes flick toward the door where they carried Nyra's body.

"Not everyone survives the judgment. This is not cruelty. It is truth. Ashwell does not coddle. It reveals. Those of you standing here have been deemed worthy of continuing. Do not waste that. Return to your rooms. Tomorrow we begin again."

He exchanges a few hushed words with Professor Nestor as they cover the mirror with a drape and then departs.

A hand clasps my shoulder.

"Maelis, I was having a panic attack when you were in the mirror for so long. What happened?" Lux exclaims, moving to my free side.

"How long was I in there?" I ask, looking from Jace to her as we start walking slowly among the crowd toward the stairwell.

"Longer than anyone else. At least ten minutes." Lux shakes her head like she still can't believe it.

Holy hell.

They all must have thought I died in that thing. No wonder everyone looked like they were in shock when I came out. It wasn't only the sight of Poppy. It was probably the fact that I was alive at all and made it out.

"Miss Rose, may I have a word?"

Professor Nestor appears out of nowhere, sneaking up behind us. I stop and look over my shoulder seeing his eidolon for the first time. A little gray bat the same color as his hair is perched on his arm.

“Sure,” I say hesitantly, turning to Lux and giving her a reassuring look. “We’ll talk tomorrow.”

I know she wants to keep talking, and I want to know all about her eidolon, but it will have to wait. She nods, sulking a bit, and squeezes my arm before stepping away.

I reach up and let Jace pull me into a hug. His wings fold around us enough to give us a moment of privacy, and I whisper against his chest, “Can we talk tonight? Will you wait for me in my room?”

He holds me a second longer than necessary, his hand warm on my back. “Yeah, I need to stop at my dorm first, and then I’ll come over.”

I pull away and turn to Professor Nestor, who guides me off to the side of the room as the last of the students and staff filters out and up the stairwell. The cavern feels bigger now that it’s emptying. Colder too.

“What happened when you were in the mirror?” He watches me with those unsettling pale eyes, his hair sticking out in all directions. “What did it say to you?”

How does he know it said anything to me? Maybe it normally speaks to everyone.

I say carefully, “It recognized me and said my father went here. I never knew that.” I remember the weight of the darkness, the voice inside my head. “It recognized my blood.”

I think about the blood that was on my hands in there, but it wasn’t real. It was gone the moment I emerged. I want to shiver thinking about the cold pressing against me from all sides.

“I don’t recall another Rose attending Ashwell, but perhaps it was before my time.” He rubs at his chin, curious. “You can write home and ask him about it, can’t you?”

He doesn’t know about my father. I mean, why would he? But then why did the headmaster know?

“My father’s dead,” I tell him flatly.

He presses his lips together and pushes his spectacles back up his nose. “I’m sorry. Perhaps check the library then. It should have all the previous years’ students on record.”

That’s actually a good idea. I never got to see the library on my first day here. Elizabeth retrieved my books for me when the headmaster summoned me. Maybe it’s time I pay it a visit.

“Was there something else?” I ask him.

He fidgets, pulling off his glasses and cleaning them on his coat. “Yes, could I see your eidolon?”

I think about it for a moment. I’m not worried he’ll hurt her, but I don’t know how to make her appear again. But as soon as I think it, as soon as I will it, she’s there. Standing on her back legs beside me, her tiny hands gripping my leg.

“An anomaly. A wildcard.” Nestor’s eyes light up behind his spectacles. “I do love anomalies.”

He bends down and reaches out to pet Poppy. She leans into his touch, and I take that as a good sign. I get the feeling Professor Nestor is a kind man beneath all his eccentricities.

“Professor, can I ask what bloodline you are?”

He rises to his feet. “I’m an earth mage.”

That explains why he’s so connected to the animals and twisted creatures. It makes sense now, the way he talks about them with such reverence.

“You know, I heard the others and their ignorant remarks.” He looks at me sympathetically. “Don’t listen to them when it comes to her.” He turns his head toward Poppy. “Raccoons are misunderstood creatures. They are clever, resourceful, and highly adaptable. Yes, they are known to be curious and mischievous but are no less intelligent for it. The other eidolons all have their strengths, but you are studying to be a healer, to perform surgeries, and you now have something none of the rest of the students here do, an extra pair of hands.”

I look down at Poppy and pick her up, cradling her against my chest. She does have hands. Five little fingers on each one. I never thought about it that way.

“She is special,” I tell him, running my fingers through her soft fur. He doesn’t say anything else, so I clear my throat. “I guess I’ll see you in class then.”

I start to step away.

“One more thing, Miss Rose.”

I stop and turn back to him. He’s watching me curiously.

“An eidolon has never been given to a human before. I do believe anything is possible. There are firsts for everything.” He presses his lips together like he’s weighing whether to say the next part. “But you are the first human to attend Ashwell. And if what the mirror said is truth, which it doesn’t lie, and your father did come here...then he was anything but human.”

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Chapter Fourteen

"The dead leave more behind than bones. They leave questions that haunt the living."

— Professor Renn, Mortal Limitations



The campus is quieter now. Most students have already made it back to their dormitories, eager to bond with their new eidolons and process what they witnessed tonight. I walk alone, Poppy tucked inside my cloak. She snuggles into my side, gripping my sweater with her small hands. I imagine she doesn't get cold like I do given all her fur, but I keep her tucked inside anyway.

I'm almost to my building when I hear a muffled sound coming from a narrow alcove tucked between two pillars.

I squint into the night, the snow coming down in flurries and sticking to my eyelashes. I quiet my steps and move closer until I see two figures pressed against the wall, tangled together in the shadows.

I shake my head, holding back a giggle. From what Elizabeth and Ellavee insinuated, people hook up at Ashwell all the time. I guess there's not a lot to do when you're in the middle of nowhere, plus it's a pleasure you can seek out when everything around you is so emotionally draining.

I start to walk back toward my dormitory's front door when I hear a whimper and sounds of a struggle.

"Stop. Please, let me go." I hear the sob underneath it. The fear.

Without another thought, I run toward the alcove and shove the larger figure from behind with everything I have. “Get away from her!”

The guy stumbles forward, caught off guard, and the girl slips free. I only catch a glimpse of her face, wide eyes and a streak of lavender in her dark hair. Then she’s gone, running into the darkness without looking back.

Not much of a thank-you.

I’m alone now as Malric turns around. His eyes glow red in the dark, bright and menacing. He looks at me the way a cat looks at a mouse it’s already caught.

I move to take a step back, turn, and run, but he grabs my arm and yanks me toward him.

“Well, well.” He rolls his shoulders, unhurried. “The little human playing hero.”

I stand up straighter, lifting my chin. “She said stop.” I bury the fear somewhere deep where he can’t hear it. “That means stop.”

“Does it?”

He steps closer. I step back until my spine hits cold stone.

Shit.

“You shouldn’t have done that, Red.” His wings unfurl behind him, dark gray and leathery like a bat’s. They curve around us, blocking the moonlight, caging me in shadow. “Unless you are ready to take her place.”

“Get off me.”

His hand comes up and tugs my hood down. Fingers run through my hair. They trail down my neck, and I want to scream, but it won’t do any good. No one would hear me with the storm howling around us.

“I’ve been curious about you,” he murmurs, pulling me tight against him. His breath is hot against my throat and reeks of liquor. “What human blood tastes like. If it’s as sweet as they say.”

His tongue drags across my neck.

Poppy shifts up my side, pokes her head out of the cloak, and sinks her teeth into Malric’s hand.

He wails and jerks back, shaking his arm. “What the fuck?”

I bring my knee up hard between his legs.

He doubles over with a grunt, and I shove past him, running. My boots pound against the snow-covered stone, and I don’t look back.

I reach my building, duck inside, and take the stairs two at a time. Once I hit my floor, I press my back against the wall to catch my breath.

My whole body is shaking.

Poppy crawls up to my shoulder and presses her face against my cheek. I can feel her worry. Her anger. Her fierce little heart beating in time with mine.

“Good girl, Poppy,” I whisper.

I slide down the wall until I’m sitting on the floor, knees pulled to my chest. I need a weapon. A real one, something sharp that will make the next person who fucks with me think twice.

I run my hands down my face and force myself to breathe. After a few minutes, I get to my feet. Poppy stands beside me, studying me with her round, knowing eyes.

I don’t want Jace to see me upset. The last thing I need is him going after Malric and getting hurt or causing more trouble for me. Malric reeked of liquor. Maybe he won’t even remember this tomorrow if I’m lucky.

Poppy sits back on her haunches, her plump little belly and fluffy face tilted up at me.

“Okay, not a word,” I tell her.

I know she doesn’t speak and isn’t going to tell Jace anything, but maybe eidolons can communicate somehow. I have no idea how any of this works yet.

She rubs her face with her tiny hands, and I take that as a good sign.

I walk to my door, and Poppy waddles alongside me.

“Mae.”

Jace is in front of me as soon as I step inside. He’s changed into sweats and a loose shirt like he’s planning on sleeping over.

“What’s wrong? What happened?” He cups my cheek, searching my eyes.

I shake him off and move farther into the room. “Nothing’s wrong. I’m fine.”

I can practically feel his stare on my back, heavy with questions I don’t want to answer. I need to change the subject before he presses more.

“Where’s your bat? Is it a he or a she? What’s its name?” I ask, pulling the wardrobe open and grabbing some shorts and a button-up sleep top.

“His name is Flick, and he retreats when I don’t need him.” He crosses his arms. “He’s not a pet you bring out to play with.”

I scrunch my nose at him before pushing into the bathroom to change.

He sounds like a grouch. Poppy is adorable, and I'm going to let her do whatever she wants.

I come out of the bathroom in my comfy clothes and find Poppy in a pile of pillows on the floor next to the bed, munching on some crackers I had stashed from earlier. Her tiny hands hold the cracker as she shovels them into her mouth, and it's ridiculously cute. Tiny crumbs keep falling down onto her belly, and she grabs them and eats them too.

"You don't have to feed them, you know. They don't need food to survive." Jace watches her with one eyebrow raised.

"She clearly enjoys it." I shrug. "I'll let her eat the whole box."

I plop down on the bed and sit cross-legged, grabbing a pillow to hold in my lap. Jace comes and sits across from me, kicking off his shoes. His wings settle behind him, tucked close but relaxed.

"Before anything else," he says, reaching forward to tuck my hair behind my ear so he can see my face, "tell me what happened in the mirror."

I pull the pillow tighter against my chest. I knew this was coming.

"It was dark," I start, staring at the threads in the pillowcase. "Nothing existed except me and this…presence, this voice."

"What did it say?"

"It asked me things about what I fear. About who I am. It said it recognized my blood and that my father had been to Ashwell." I look up at him. "I didn't know that. He never told me. It seems impossible, right?"

Jace's brow furrows. "Your father went here? But he was human. I would have been able to tell if he wasn't, unless he found some way to hide it. It does seem impossible."

"I thought so." I pick at the edge of the pillow. "But after the ceremony, Professor Nestor pulled me aside and said something that's been stuck in my head ever since."

"What?"

"He said in light of that my father must've been anything but human."

Jace thinks it over and shakes his head. "Mae, that's... Do you have any idea what that means? What could he have been?"

"I don't know anything anymore," I stammer. "I thought I knew who I was. I thought I knew who he was, and now everything feels like a lie."

Jace drifts close enough that his knee brushes mine.

“Hey, whatever your father was or wasn’t, it doesn’t change who you are. You’re still Maelis. You’re still the girl who used to beat me at races through the village and patch me up when I scraped my knees trying to keep up.”

I snicker, “Yeah, until your legs grew, and now I can’t keep up. I always let you win a few too.”

“Liar.” He grins. “You’re the most competitive person I know.”

The tension in my chest loosens a little. He knows exactly when to make me laugh.

“Can I ask you something?” I say.

“Anything.”

“What was it like for you when you touched the mirror?”

He scratches his head, thinking. “I put my hand in, and it was like… warmth, and then Flick was there. I felt him before I saw him, this presence that was suddenly part of me. It didn’t ask me questions or show me anything.”

We sit in comfortable silence for a moment. Poppy finishes her crackers and curls into a ball in her pillow nest, eyes closing.

“Mae.” Jace grows serious. “I’ve wanted to say something for a while now.” He reaches out and takes the pillow from my hands, setting it aside. “I keep waiting for the right moment, but there never is one, so I’m just going to say it.”

My heart starts beating faster. “Jace—”

“I know you’ve been holding back. I know you’re scared of ruining what we have.” He takes my hands in his. “But I need you to know that you could never lose me no matter what happens. I’ve been yours since we were kids , Mae. That’s not going to change. I’m not asking you to love me back. I just need you to know you are loved.”

I stare at our hands. His are so much bigger than mine, warm and steady and familiar. *Loved.*

“I’m scared,” I admit, not looking up to meet his gaze, “of letting myself have this and then losing it.”

“I know.” He squeezes my hands. “You don’t have to figure it out tonight. I’ll wait. I’ve been waiting.”

I look up at him. He’s close enough that I can see the silver flecks in his blue eyes. I can feel his breath.

“Jace.”

“Yeah?”

“Stop talking.”

I close the distance between us.

The kiss is soft at first, like we’re both afraid to break something fragile. His hand comes up to cup my jaw, his thumb brushing my cheek, and I feel something open inside my chest, something I’ve been holding shut for years.

This is my Jace. The boy who used to sneak me honey cakes from his mother’s kitchen. The boy who held my hand at my father’s burial and didn’t let go until I was ready. The boy who has always been there, patient and steady, waiting for me to see what was right in front of me.

I kiss him back, and it feels like the most natural thing I’ve ever done.

Then it deepens enough that I feel it everywhere. His tongue presses in, and I part my lips, tasting him as he pulls me into his lap. One hand wraps around my lower back, and I close my legs around him. My arms go around his neck, and his tongue explores my mouth.

When we finally pull apart, he rests his forehead against mine. We’re both breathing harder than we should be.

“That was...” he starts.

“Yeah,” I laugh softly, “it was.”

He pulls back enough to look at me. There’s wonder in his expression, like he can’t believe this is real.

“I’ve wanted to do that for a very long time,” he says.

“How long?”

“Since we were fourteen and you fell in the river trying to catch a fish with your bare hands and came up laughing with mud in your hair.”

I groan. “That’s such an embarrassing memory.”

“It’s my favorite memory.”

I shove his shoulder, but I’m smiling. He catches my hand and presses a kiss to my knuckles.

“Stay with me tonight?” I ask.

“I wasn’t planning on going anywhere.”

We shift until we’re lying down, his arm around me, my head on his chest. Poppy snores softly from her pillow pile. The storm howls outside, but here it’s warm and quiet and safe.

Jace holds me for a while, the covers pulled up tight around us. I start to fall asleep until he says, “Mae, when you were in the mirror... something

happened.”

My eyes open wide. “What do you mean?”

I tip my head back to look at him.

“The mirror started to glow, and the bones in the frame were vibrating. They were pulsing. It didn’t change like that for anyone else. And Headmaster Ashmoor stepped forward like he was going to pull you out or something. But then he stopped himself.” Jace’s eyes meet mine. “And he smiled.”

A chill creeps over me. “He smiled?”

“It was like whatever was happening to you was exactly what he wanted.” His hand finds mine under the covers where it rests on his chest. “I thought maybe he wanted it to hurt you, to take the human out of his school. But then you were out and okay.”

I nestle my head back into his shoulder. I wouldn’t be surprised if that’s what the headmaster wanted after the way he acted with me in his office. *Unremarkable Maelis*. What is that guy’s deal?

Jace lets out a sigh, and I ask, “How does Draven have an eidolon already? He’s a bone year like us.”

He tenses slightly. “I don’t know. I’ve wondered the same thing.”

“His wolf is different too, larger and black.”

“I noticed.” His arm tightens around me. “There are rumors about the Alucard family. Stay away from Draven. Something about him isn’t right, and after the way he attacked you in class today—”

“What rumors?” I press curiosity getting the better of me. “What do people say about the Alucard family?”

“Not all vampires are born, you know.”

I blink. “No, I didn’t know that. I thought all the bloodlines were born what they are.”

“Not vampires.” His fingers trace slow circles on my back. “In fact, most of them are turned, usually at a young age by their family.”

I sit up a bit to look at him. “So if two vampires have a baby, it’s not a vampire?”

“No, having a vampire baby is rare. It happens, but most are turned. That’s how the bloodline keeps thriving.”

“And what’s the rumor about the Alucards?”

I rest my head back down, and Jace starts to run his fingers across my lower back now where my skin peeks through below my shirt.

“They’re an old bloodline. His ancestors may even be the original bloodline. Draven was born a vampire, and born vampires are far more powerful than turned ones.”

I think about him in the alleyway earlier. The things he said to me about how I don’t belong here. The red bleeding into his amber eyes. His giant black wings when he first dropped down in front of me.

“The point is, he’s powerful and comes from an old powerful bloodline with many connections.” Jace’s hand stills on my back. “You don’t want to get on his bad side. You don’t want him to take an interest in you. Stay away from him, okay?”

I should tell him the truth that staying away from Draven feels impossible. That he keeps finding me in the dark corners of this school. That some twisted curious part of me doesn’t want to stay away at all.

“I will,” I say.

Jace presses a kiss to the top of my head and pulls me closer. His breathing evens out within minutes as he fades into sleep.

But I don’t fall asleep for a long time.

I lie there in the dark, thinking about amber eyes bleeding red and a voice in the mirror that knew my blood, a headmaster who smiled while I was trapped inside.

And there’s a boy made of shadows and secrets who told me I would never survive this place.

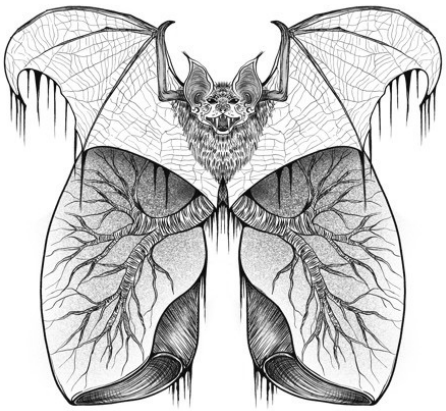
Maybe he’s right, but I’m going to prove him wrong anyway.

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Chapter Fifteen

"Your blood lead will teach you more than any book. Listen to them. They have already made the mistakes you have not yet had the chance to make."

— Patient Ward Orientation Handbook



It's been four weeks since the mirror ceremony, and I think I'm finally falling into a routine here.

Jace and I have gotten comfortable spending at least a couple nights a week together, sometimes at my place and sometimes at his. We haven't done more than kiss and sleep in the same bed, but it's nice. The way things have always been between us but with the added bonus of falling asleep in his arms.

I can't imagine my life without Poppy now. We've become so close I feel incomplete when she's tucked away. The only downside is her and Flick don't get along, which is odd since they're basically an extension of us. Poppy is constantly trying to catch him. Jace swears she even tried to take a bite out of him once, but I don't believe my sweet Pops would do that.

As for Draven, he's kept his distance, other than challenging me every chance he gets in class, which is incredibly annoying but only makes me more determined to excel. Every time he tries to make me look weak, I push harder. I refuse to give him the satisfaction of breaking me.

I’ve gotten comfortable with the curriculum and haven’t had to cut anything yet, so my hands have been okay. The scalpels stay in the drawer for now, except for the one I’ve started carrying for protection.

But today is the first day of clinical hours in the patient wards. After four weeks, we are apparently deemed fit enough to practice on actual patients with a blood lead or Veilguard watching our every move, surely.

I try not to think about what happens if I freeze again. If my hands shake. If I prove everyone right about the human who doesn’t belong here.

“I hope we get assigned the same group,” Lux says as we head up to the second floor of the patient wards building to check in.

“Me too.” I glance over at her. We all signed up at the same time, hoping that would make the odds of us getting clinical hours together higher.

“Do you know how this works?” Ellavee asks from ahead of us.

“Sort of. My dad explained it briefly.” Lux pulls her pink hair back into a ponytail as we ascend the steps. “We get assigned a blood lead who’s responsible for us during our shifts. They decide what we do, what we watch, what we’re allowed to touch. Basically, we’re their shadows until they decide we’re competent enough to be trusted.”

“So we’re at their mercy,” Jace says from behind me as we reach the second floor.

“Completely.” She grins, but there’s a nervousness underneath it, and I think we’re all a little anxious about the unknown.

We gather in the waiting area, basically an empty room with chairs and a couple of desks. Draven shows up, and I take a step closer to Jace without even looking in his direction. He probably planned this on purpose, signing up when we did to be a dick during clinic too.

Killian and Zuri are already here, sitting in the corner talking quietly amongst themselves.

The double doors into the patient wards swing open, and out comes a woman dressed in all black with a wide medical belt around her waist stuffed with supplies. The red heart and serpent symbol marks her clothes. Blood year.

“I’m Senna. I’ll be helping oversee bone year clinical rotations.” Her voice carries across the room, confident and sharp, until her pale yellow eyes land on me. She almost chokes. “You are here to learn. I don’t want anyone trying to prove themselves early on and killing a patient.”

I don’t understand what her problem is until she turns her head. A lavender streak of hair runs down one side, standing out starkly against long black waves. This is the girl from the alcove, the one Malric had pinned against the wall. The one who ran without looking back.

Her face visibly pales when our eyes meet, but she forces herself to continue.

“If any of you disobey an order from your blood lead, you will be removed from the wards. If you endanger a patient through carelessness or arrogance, you will be removed as well.” Her gaze drifts away from me, landing anywhere else. “People die in these beds. I don’t say this to frighten you into compliance. It’s simply the truth.”

Lux glances over at me, narrowing her eyes. She noticed how off that was too.

“You will be separated into two groups of four. Your blood lead will be responsible for you every time you step foot in the patient wards. You will report to them at the start of every shift and defer to their judgment in all things.”

She pulls a folded parchment from her pocket and reads off the first group. “Luxanna, Killian, Jace, and Zuri. You’ll be with me.”

“Damn it, I wanted us to be together,” Lux pouts.

“Sorry, I’m still stuck on the fact your name is Luxanna! I’m supposed to be your best friend here and had no idea.” I blink at her, waiting for an explanation.

She laughs, swatting at my arm, “No one calls me that. I’ll see you later.”

She follows after Killian and Zuri while Jace comes over to me. He pushes the hair back from my face and kisses my forehead, lingering there for a moment.

“You’ve got this,” he whispers.

All I can focus on is Draven standing behind him, watching me with those honey eyes. Something about the way he watches me makes it hard to breathe.

“I know.” I give Jace a sweet smile as he pulls away. He leaves with the others. They disappear through the double doors, and I’m stuck waiting here with Draven. Of course he would end up on my team.

Fuck me.

“Making eyes at the vampire, are we?” Ellavee murmurs quietly, winking as she walks up to wait beside me.

“No,” I say quickly. It sounds guilty even to my own ears.

“It’s okay. I wouldn’t blame you.” She tilts her head, studying Draven across the room. “He’s fucking hot.”

I don’t trust myself to respond.

The door bursts open and another guy rushes in, out of breath, glasses fogging from the cold. It’s Miles from our autopsy team.

Great. I have two assholes and a demon menace in my group.

“Boners.”

I cringe at the voice and turn to see Malric strolling through the double doors, letting them swing shut behind him. His grin spreads slow and wicked as he takes us in, eyes dragging over me and Ellavee before landing on Draven.

Make that three assholes.

“Looks like I’ll be your blood lead this year.” He walks over and pats Draven on the shoulder like they’re old friends, because they are. “This is going to be fun.”

Malric leads us through the double doors and deeper into the second-floor patient wards. The smell of herbs and antiseptic is impossible to ignore. I wish I had a mask to help filter the scent. It reminds me of my father’s clinic, and I quickly bury the memory before it can take root.

“Welcome to the wards. Consider this your orientation.” Malric spreads his arms wide like he’s showing off a fucking palace. “Your home away from home for the foreseeable future.”

The corridor stretches far ahead of us with hallways branching off in different directions. Doors line either side of the space, some open, some closed. Sconces cover the walls, their steady pale-blue flames casting everything in cold light. Menders and ward hands pass by us, some pushing carts of supplies, others walking with purpose toward patient rooms.

“Ten floors,” Malric continues, walking backward so he can watch our faces. His eyes linger on me. “Ground floor is intake. If you’re lucky, that’s where you’ll spend most of your time handling scraped knees and bruised egos, nothing that’ll make you lose your lunch. Anyone getting hurt in the nearby village or on the academy grounds will find themselves there first.”

He stops at a large board mounted on the wall, a directory of sorts, each floor listed with a symbol beside it. “Second floor is minor injuries and

recovery. Third is illness and disease. Fourth is serious trauma. Fifth floor handles fissure injuries. Sixth is crawler cases."

Ellavee shifts beside me. "Crawler cases, as in people who've been bitten?"

"As in people who might turn." Malric's smile doesn't waver. "Don't worry, you won't be going up there anytime soon, unless I want to traumatize you early."

She makes a huffing sound next to me like she's not impressed. I smirk.

"Seven is long-term care. The ones who aren't getting better but aren't dying fast enough to move up." Malric shrugs. "Eight is surgical suites. You'll observe from the galleries but won't touch anything unless asked. You haven't proven capable enough for that yet."

He looks over the board like he lost his place for a second. "Right. Nine is critical care, the ones barely hanging on. And ten is restricted. Don't go there. Pretend it doesn't exist."

"What's on the tenth floor?" I ask before I can stop myself.

Malric's pale-yellow eyes snap to mine. Something flickers there. Amusement maybe.

"Curiosity killed the cat, Red." He takes a step closer, rubbing his stubbled jaw as he leans toward me. "And in this place, curiosity kills a lot more than cats."

I feel Draven shift behind me. I turn away from Malric and cross my arms, putting distance between us.

"Anyway, pay attention to the rules, because I'm only saying this once."

He starts walking again, and we follow like reluctant ducklings. I can't believe this guy is going to be bossing me around for hours every week.

He stops in front of an alcove set into the wall. Inside is a large stone platform surrounded by low iron railings. Faint blue light pulses up the walls, humming softly.

"This is the current lift powered by the academy itself. It's how you move between floors when the stairs are too slow or you're transporting a patient." He gestures to a panel on the railing where swirls of light blue glow within the stone. "You place your palm here, focus on the floor you need, and the lift does the rest."

"What if you don't have current?" Ellavee asks. "I mean, what about Maelis?"

I give her a side-eye. I don't need her asking things like this for me.

Malric looks at me, and I feel my cheeks heat.

“Like the mirror, the school will know her intention. She doesn’t have to use current. Ashwell will do that for her,” he says, looking back at Ellavee. “Now at any given time, there are usually one to two blood leads in the building as well as a healer or two, but the healers are usually doing procedures on floor eight. It’s rare a Veilguard is here. If they are, it’s usually for a complicated case. They tend to be needed in other parts of Valen. Fissure sites and hot spots. You know, all the places more likely to get you killed.”

He winks, and I turn away from him.

Ellavee chews on her bottom lip ring, and I find myself wondering how things are going in the other group. I wish I was with Jace and Lux. That would make this so much more enjoyable.

“Every floor will have a mender. They are not students or advanced healers. They’re assistants who handle basic patient care.” Malric continues walking, and we follow. “Lastly, scattered throughout you’ll find ward hands. They fetch supplies, clean exam rooms, change bandages, handle intake paperwork. The grunt work.”

This may be the largest healing ward I’ve ever heard of. My father’s clinic back home had some cots with curtains separating the rooms. This place is massive with so many people running it at once.

“Roughly how many patients are here on any given day?” I ask. The last thing I want to do is talk to Malric, but I need to know.

He glances over his shoulder at me, almost surprised I spoke.

“Depends on the day, anywhere from fifty to a hundred.” He taps his fingers against his thigh as he walks. “More after a fissure event or if something goes wrong during training. Fewer during quiet stretches, but quiet never lasts long around here.”

A hundred patients. Ten floors. Menders, ward hands, blood leads, the occasional healer or Veilguard. And now a handful of bone years who don’t exactly know what they’re doing yet.

No pressure at all.

We reach the other end of the second floor, and there’s another stairwell here. Good to know there’s a stairwell on either side of this place and the current lift in the center.

“Alright, Ellavee, this week you’ll be assigned to floor one, intake and assessment. You can do whatever the mender needs help with.” He jerks his

head toward the stairwell for her to leave, and she heads down without any questions.

“Miles, I want you on floor eight for your entire shift. There are a lot of surgeries scheduled today, and you’ll be helping the ward hand clean and prep the rooms between procedures.” Miles frowns but doesn’t object. He turns away from us to head back to the lift.

“Miles, buddy.” Malric stops him. “I think you have a lot to gain by taking the stairs.”

I almost feel bad for him. Miles is a little pudgy, but gods, Malric is a dick. I’m really beginning to think it’s a vampire thing. Are they all this intolerable? Poor Miles doesn’t say anything, lowers his head, and takes off up the stairs to the eighth floor.

I’m internally cringing, waiting to see what horrible task Malric assigns me, when he hands me and Draven each a piece of parchment. I look down to read it.

“Nella Thorne. Room 503. Cael Brannock. Room 709.”

Floors five and seven, so I have someone with a fissure injury and someone in long-term care.

“What is this?” I ask, looking up at Malric.

“You two are each assigned two patients. It’s your job to take care of them.” He crosses his arms. “Head to the floor they’re on, and check in at the desk with the mender. They’ll get you set up with bracelets and whatever else you need.”

I glance over at Draven, who folds the parchment and slips it into his pocket. He hasn’t said a godsdamn thing this entire time. He nods to Malric and starts walking down the hall. *Stoic asshole.*

“His first patient is on this floor, but since we’re both heading up, let’s take the lift. I’ll help you get settled.” Malric steps closer to me, and I fake a smile.

“Sounds delightful.”

I follow him to the lift, and we both step onto the stone platform. He places his palm on the panel, and a door slides closed, leaving us alone in the tight space. The lift jerks into motion, and I stumble. Malric grabs my arm and presses into me before I can catch myself.

“Careful, Red.” His grip tightens, and he leans closer, his breath hot against my hair. “It’s a shame your little trash-eating pest interrupted us before. I really do want to taste you.”

He sniffs the top of my head, and my stomach turns. I wrench my arm free and step back, pressing myself against the railing. “You’re vile.”

He chuckles, like my disgust entertains him. The doors slide open, and I’ve never been more grateful for anything in my life. It’s safe to say he remembers that night then. I was hoping he was drunk enough to have forgotten, but that was wishful thinking.

“I’ll check in on you later.” He leans against the wall of the lift, making no move to follow me out. “Don’t kill any of your patients today. Or do. Then I’ll get to punish you.”

I shake my head and step into the waiting area of the fifth floor. The doors close behind me, and the lift continues upward, taking him with it.

Thank gods.

I see a man with spiky blond hair and a bunch of charts in his hands standing behind the desk. He’s dressed in the black ward robes with a medical belt of supplies around his waist, so this must be the mender for this floor. I walk toward him and clear my throat.

“Hi, I’m Maelis, a bone year checking in. I’m supposed to take care of Nella in room 503.”

He drops the stack of charts onto the desk and pulls a bracelet off his wrist. “I’m Theo. This is for you to keep track of Nella. You’ll need to pick it up and drop it off with me directly, or with whatever mender is scheduled to this floor. Understand?”

He has amber eyes, a grouchy attitude, and a scar that cuts through his left eyebrow. Must be a vampire. I’m getting pretty damn good at identifying them these days.

“I understand, but I don’t know what the bracelet’s for. No one explained it. I was just told to check in with you.”

He motions for my hand, and I hold it out as he slides the bracelet on. It’s a stretchy, twisted fabric thing with a small metal plate on the top. I hold it closer and read the name etched into the plate. “Nella Thorne.”

“If the bracelet lights up, that means Nella needs something. If it vibrates, it’s an emergency, and you need to respond quickly.” He’s already rifling through a drawer, barely looking at me.

I have several more questions, but he doesn’t look like he wants to chat. “What controls the bracelet? How does it know to vibrate or light up?” It must be nice having current. Our clinic at home certainly could benefit from some magic.

“If the patient needs something, they push the button in their room, then it lights up. If there’s an emergency, the academy is always watching. The current will know and vibrate.” He pulls something from the drawer and turns back to me. “That’s how the headmaster has it set up. You don’t like it, take it up with him.”

He practically throws a wide leather belt at me, stuffed full of supplies.

“I don’t have a problem. I just wanted to know how it worked,” I say, catching the belt before it hits my chest.

He hums, uninterested. “Put that on. Keep it and bring it with you for every shift. Keep it stocked too, and make sure you sanitize anything you use.”

Then he turns and walks off, leaving me fumbling to get the belt on by myself.

I manage to buckle it around my waist and take stock of what’s inside. Folded pieces of clean cloth in varying sizes. Clips for wrapping bandages. A bottle of sanitizing liquid. Forceps. A scalpel that makes my stomach clench. My fingers itch to shove it deeper into the belt where I can’t see it.

And an actual bone saw hanging from a loop at my hip.

What in the hell is happening in this place that I need a bone saw strapped to my waist? I don’t want to find out, but I have a feeling I’m going to.

I adjust the belt, feeling the unfamiliar weight settle against my hips. Everyone else probably got training for this. I got Malric and a grumpy vampire who couldn’t wait to get rid of me.

Nella Thorne, whoever you are, please don’t be a nightmare. I’m fresh out of patience and armed with a bone saw. Room 503, here I come.

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Chapter Sixteen

"Some wounds want to stay open. Some wounds are hungry."

— On Corrupted Tissue, Restricted Archives



I grab the chart hanging outside room 503 and scan it quickly. "Nella Thorne. Fourteen years old. Fissure wound, left wing. Three weeks admitted. No improvement."

She's been stuck here for three weeks, and no one has figured out how to help her.

I push open the door and stop short.

I see her wings first, a dark-gray membrane spread wide across a padded frame that extends the entire width of the room, like an oversized headboard. Delicate bone structures are visible beneath the surface, thin as the skeleton of a leaf held up to light. Vampire wings. I've seen Draven and Malric's, brief flashes of dark leather before they vanished back into wherever they keep them. But I've never seen them like this, forced open and vulnerable.

The girl they belong to reclines against a pile of pillows, her back to me, facing the window. She's watching the gray sky outside or maybe the birds that cut across it. Things that can fly when she can't.

I smell rotting flesh masked by something chemical, the sharp tang of experimental treatments that burn the inside of my nose. This is the smell of

desperation. Of healers trying things they're not sure will work on wounds they don't fully understand.

"I know you're standing there." Her voice is raspy, annoyed. She doesn't turn around. "I can smell you too."

So much for introductions.

"I'm Maelis, bone year." I step further into the room, letting the door close behind me. "I've been assigned to help take care of you."

"Fantastic, another one."

I circle around the bed so I can see her face. She's small for fourteen, thin in a way that makes me wonder if she's been eating. Or maybe that's how vampire girls are built at that age, all sharp angles and limbs they haven't quite grown into. Dark hair falls around her shoulders, tangled like she's stopped caring about brushing it. Her face is sharp, high cheekbones and a stubborn jaw, but there's something soft underneath. Something she's trying very hard to hide.

A small table beside the bed holds a cup of water, a half-eaten roll going stale, and a stuffed animal that looks like it's been loved within an inch of its life. Some kind of fox, missing an eye and patched in three places with mismatched thread. It's tucked against her hip, and I notice her fingers resting on its worn fur. She's probably embarrassed to still have it but hasn't let it go.

A chair in the corner is buried under a pile of books, spines cracked and pages dog-eared. Escapism, I understand that. When everything around you is falling apart, sometimes the only safe place is inside someone else's story.

"Another one?" I grab the chair, dump the books onto the wide window ledge, and drag it around so I can sit facing her.

"Bone year, baby healer, whatever you want to call it." She finally looks at me, amber eyes narrowing. "You're human."

I'm getting used to that reaction by now.

"I am."

"Huh." She studies me with an intensity that feels too old for her face. "They let humans in here now? Things must be getting desperate."

I could take offense. I probably should. But there's something underneath the sharpness in her voice. Something tired and scared that she's working hard to bury. I've seen it in my own mirror on the nights I can't sleep.

“Desperate enough to send me to deal with sarcastic vampire teenagers apparently.” I settle into the chair across from her. “So, Nella, how are you feeling today?”

She blinks at me like she can’t figure out what to do with someone who doesn’t cower or apologize.

“I’ve been stuck in this bed for three weeks with my wings pinned open like some kind of fucking butterfly collection.” She gestures weakly at the frame behind her. “How do you think I feel?”

“That sounds miserable. I’d be losing my mind.”

Surprise flickers across her face, or relief perhaps that someone isn’t feeding her empty reassurances.

“I am losing my mind.” She slumps back against the pillows. “But thanks for acknowledging it.”

Now that I’m facing her, I can see the damage clearly. The right wing looks healthy enough. Dark-charcoal-gray membrane stretched taut across delicate bones, faint vessels visible when the weak light from the window catches it. There’s an iridescent quality to the healthy tissue. It’s beautiful in a strange way.

The left wing is a different story entirely.

A jagged slash nearly two feet long runs from the joint near her shoulder blade down toward the outer edge. The edges are ragged, torn rather than cut clean. This wasn’t a blade. This was something with claws like broken glass.

The membrane around the wound is discolored, the healthy gray giving way to sickly green and mottled black. Dark lines spread outward from the gash, branching and splitting as they creep toward the wing’s edge. Some of them look faded, like they’re receding. Others look fresh and angry, still pushing outward.

The wound itself is a mess of contradictions, partially closed in some places where vampire healing has tried to knit the tissue back together, raw and weeping in others where something keeps tearing it open again. The edges are thin and papery, threatening to split farther with any wrong movement. A dark fluid seeps slowly from the worst sections.

“It’s worse today.” Nella’s watching my face. “I can tell by how you’re not saying anything.”

I force myself to meet her eyes. “I’ve never seen a fissure wound before. I don’t have anything to compare it to.”

“Liar.” But there’s no heat in it. “You’re making the face.”

“Let’s agree on mildly concerned.”

“That’s more than mildly concerned. That’s approaching deeply troubled.” She turns her head back toward the window. “It was better yesterday. The lines were pulling back. I thought maybe...”

Her hopes have been dashed.

I lean forward in the chair. “Tell me what happened. How did you get this?”

She’s quiet, but I wait.

“My brother.” Her fingers find the stuffed fox, grip tightening around its worn fur. “He’s a second year Vanguard trainee at the academy in the Shadowlands. I wanted to watch him practice, see what he could do. I wasn’t supposed to be there but snuck out anyway. There was a breach. A small fissure opened suddenly, barely a crack, but something came through before anyone could react.”

“What kind of something?”

“A riftling about the size of a large cat with six legs and too many joints. Skin like burned leather stretched too tight over bones. No eyes, just smooth dark patches where eyes should be. A mouth that split its face in half, full of needle-like teeth.”

Something twists inside me listening to her describe it.

“It didn’t make any sound.” She’s staring out the window again, but I don’t think she’s seeing the sky anymore. “I didn’t even hear it coming. When I saw it, I panicked and got my wings out, thinking I could fly above it to get away.”

“And?”

“It was faster. It launched at me before my feet left the ground, slashing across my wing, and I went down hard. The Vanguards killed it a few seconds later, but the damage was already done.”

A fourteen-year-old girl, wings barely unfurled, trying to escape something with claws and a mouth full of needle teeth. No wonder she keeps that stuffed fox close.

“The corruption?” I ask quietly.

“Riftlings are full of fissure energy. That energy is in me now. My body keeps trying to heal the wound, but the corruption, rot, necrosis, whatever you call it keeps reopening it. They’re fighting each other, and I’m...”

“Stuck in the middle.”

“Yeah, stuck.”

I look at the wing again. At the necrotic lines that spread and recede and spread again. At the wound that heals and tears and heals and tears. A battle happening inside her body, and she has no control over any of it.

“What treatments have they tried?”

“Everything.” She laughs, but there’s nothing funny about it. “Current flushing is where they channel clean current through my system to try to push the corruption out. Hurts like hell and helps for maybe a day before the lines start spreading again. Bloodletting is great. Nothing a vampire loves more than having her blood drained. Some kind of paste made from burned ashroot and moonpetal has been smeared on the wound. It burns so bad I bite through my lip every time.”

She gestures weakly at the bandages wrapped around the worst parts of her wing.

“And these binding wraps soaked in something that smells sour slow it down but don’t stop it.”

“And if none of that works?”

“They’re talking about cutting the whole wing off before the corruption reaches my core.” She sniffles but doesn’t cry.

Her fingers clutch the stuffed fox.

“I’ve only been flying for four years. I was turned when I was little, but it took me forever to learn to fly. I was starting to love it, and now...”

She swallows hard. Her eyes drift to the window again.

“Do you know what it’s like to dream about flying every night and then wake up and remember you might never do it again?”

I think about my father. About the clinic. About holding a scalpel and watching my hands shake because I know what these hands have done.

“I know what it’s like to dream about something you’ve lost.”

She turns her head to look at me.

“Your brother, does he visit?” I ask.

The softness vanishes. “No.”

“Why not?”

“Because he blames himself, and my parents blame him. Everyone’s so busy being angry and guilty that no one actually comes to see me.” She picks at the fox’s worn ear. “I’ve been here three weeks, and the only people who talk to me are healers who poke at my wing and tell me to stay positive.”

I lean back in the chair, keeping my voice light. “I’m not going to poke at your wing and tell you to stay positive.”

She looks up. “What are you going to do then?”

“Check your bandages, make sure nothing needs changing, and then sit here and talk to you like a normal person instead of a patient.” I shrug. “If you want.”

She stares at me for a long moment. I watch the walls she’s built waver slightly.

“Fine.” The corner of her mouth twitches. “But if you make the pity face, I’m biting you.”

“Fair enough.” I reach for the medical belt at my waist. “Let’s take a closer look at this wing.”

I unwrap the bandages carefully, taking my time. The wound looks exactly as terrible up close as it did from across the room. The black, rotted lines pulse faintly, like they have their own heartbeat. I clean around the edges with the sanitizing liquid from my belt, trying not to notice how Nella flinches every time the cloth touches the raw parts.

“Sorry,” I murmur.

“It’s fine.” She grits her teeth. “I’m used to it.”

No fourteen-year-old should be used to this.

I rewrap the wound with fresh binding cloth from my supplies, making sure it’s snug but not too tight. When I’m done, I sit back and study her. She’s watching me with those sharp amber eyes, waiting for me to make the pity face or say something stupid about staying positive.

“Can I ask you something about being a vampire?”

She blinks, clearly not expecting that. “Uh. Sure.”

“The blood thing.” I feel stupid even asking, but I genuinely don’t know. “How does it work? Do you have to bite humans? Other bloodlines?”

Nella snorts. “Gods no. I mean, some vampires do. The old traditionalists in the shadowlands still hunt, but that’s considered barbaric by most standards now.” She shifts against her pillows, settling in like she’s happy to talk about something other than her wing for once. “Ashwell provides synthetic blood. It’s made in the labs here and tastes like watered-down garbage, but it keeps us alive. Some vampires prefer animal blood if they can get it. Tastes better than synthetic but not as good as the real thing.”

“Have you ever...” I’m not sure how to phrase it.

“Bitten someone?” She raises an eyebrow. “I’m fourteen. My parents would kill me. But I’ve tasted real blood once. My brother let me try some of his when I was first turned, a few drops.” She gets a faraway look. “It was like the difference between a candle and the sun. The synthetic stuff keeps you alive but doesn’t make you feel alive, if that makes sense.”

I file that information away for later.

“What about the Shadowlands?” I lean back in my chair. “I’ve never been anywhere outside my village until I came here. What’s it like?”

Nella’s face lights up for the first time since I walked in.

“It’s beautiful. Dark, obviously, but not in a scary way. The sun never fully rises there, so everything is lit by moonlight and lanterns and these glowing flowers that grow wild everywhere. The cities are built into the mountains, all black stone and silver spires. My family’s estate has a view of Obsidian Falls. It’s this massive waterfall that looks like liquid night pouring off a cliff.” She catches herself, the excitement fading. “I haven’t been home in almost a year. First school, then this.”

“You’ll get back there,” I say before I can stop myself. “When you’re healed, you’ll fly over those falls again.”

She looks at me like she wants to believe it but doesn’t dare.

“You don’t know that.”

“No,” I admit, “but I’m going to do everything I can to make sure it happens.”

I think I finally put a crack in her armor, but before she can respond, I catch movement in my peripheral vision. The door’s open a crack, and someone is standing in the gap, watching us.

“Can I help you?” I call out.

The door swings open, and Draven steps through, his face arranged in that familiar mask of bored indifference.

“Malric sent me to check on the human.” His eyes look from me to Nella and back again. “Make sure you haven’t killed anyone yet.”

“As you can see, everyone’s still breathing.” I cross my arms. “You can report back to your master.”

His jaw tightens at that. “He’s not my master.”

“Could have fooled me.”

We stare at each other for a long moment. Finally he turns, glancing at Nella’s wing with an expression I can’t read.

“Fissure wound,” he says quietly.

“Riftling.” Nella’s voice is smaller now, the bravado fading in the presence of another vampire. An older, powerful one. “Three weeks ago.”

Draven nods once, and then he’s gone, the door clicking shut behind him.

Nella lets out a breath and turns to me with wide eyes.

“Oh. Now I understand why you’re asking so many questions about vampires.”

“What? No.” I shake my head quickly. “That’s not—”

“He’s gorgeous.” She’s grinning wolfishly. “Like, offensively gorgeous. Those eyes? That jaw? Gods. And the man bun.”

“Nella—”

“And the way he was looking at you?” She fans herself dramatically. “You’re so lucky. I would kill to look like you. All that red hair and those curves. Guys like that probably fall all over themselves trying to get your attention.”

My face is burning. “Stop. You’re beautiful, and you’re going to be out of here in no time. I’m going to make sure of it. I’m sure there are plenty of gorgeous vampires in the Shadowlands waiting for you.”

She waves dismissively. “Please, I’m fourteen and stuck in a hospital bed with my wings pinned open like a science experiment. My dating prospects are not exactly thriving.” She tilts her head, studying me. “But you’ve got that brooding vampire eating out of your hand and don’t even see it.”

“I’m not… We’re not…” I take a breath. “I actually despise him, and he hates me. Trust me.”

Nella raises an eyebrow. “Didn’t look like hate to me.”

“Well, it is. We can barely be in the same room without wanting to kill each other.”

“Mhm.” She doesn’t look convinced. “So you’re single then?”

“No, actually.” I lean back in my chair. “I’m kind of dating an angel. I mean nothing has been defined officially…His name is Jace. We grew up together.”

Nella makes a face, scrunching up her nose. “An angel. Huh.”

“What’s that face for?”

“Nothing.” She picks at the stuffed fox’s ear. “Angels are intense. They feel things differently than the rest of us, if they feel things at all. It’s a lot to deal with.”

“Jace isn’t like that. He’s sweet.”

“They’re all sweet at first.” She shrugs. “My mom always says to never trust something that pretty. Too good to be true.”

I think about Jace. His soft smiles. The way he holds me like I might break. The way he looks at me sometimes like I’m the only thing in the world that matters.

“He’s not too good to be true,” I say quietly. “He’s...good.”

Nella studies me for a moment, then nods slowly. “Okay. I believe you.” She pauses. “But that vampire is definitely into you. Just saying.”

I roll my eyes and stand up, gathering my supplies. “I have to go check on my other patient, but if you need anything, press the panel. The bracelet will let me know.”

I hold up my wrist, showing her the metal plate with her name on it.

“I’ll come back before my shift ends. I promise.”

She looks at the bracelet then at me.

“Most people don’t come back,” she says quietly. “They say they will, but they don’t.”

“I’m not most people.”

The corner of her mouth twitches. “No, I’m starting to figure that out.”

I head for the door, pausing with my hand on the handle.

“Nella?”

“Yeah?”

“For the record, you’re going to fly again. I don’t care what the healers say or what the corruption does. We’re going to figure this out.”

She doesn’t say anything. But when I glance back, her eyes are shining.

I slip out into the corridor and close the door behind me. Time to head up to level seven.

The current lift is already waiting when I reach it, doors open. I step inside and reach for the panel then freeze.

Jace is leaning against the back wall, arms crossed, a disarming smile spreading across his face.

“Fancy meeting you here.”

“What are you doing on five?” I step closer, letting the doors slide shut behind me.

“Senna sent me to grab supplies from the surgical stock. Apparently floor eight is running low on sutures.” He pushes off the wall, moving toward me. “But I’ve got a few minutes.”

“A few minutes for what?”

He answers by backing me against the lift wall as the door slides shut, one hand bracing beside my head, the other sliding around my waist.

“I’ve been thinking about you all morning. It’s very distracting.”

“We’re at work,” I whisper, but my hands are already grabbing his shirt.

“So we’ll be quick.”

His mouth finds mine, and I stop thinking about patients and fissure wounds and grumpy vampires. I stop thinking about anything except the heat of him, his taste, the way his wings rustle and press against the lift walls like they’re trying to wrap around us both.

The lift lurches into motion, and I gasp against his lips.

“What floor?” he murmurs.

“Seven.”

“That gives us about thirty seconds.”

“Then stop talking.”

He grins against my mouth and kisses me harder.

When the lift doors open on level seven, I’m flushed and breathless, and my hair is messier than it was before. Jace looks annoyingly composed and perfect.

“Good luck with your patient.” He tucks a strand of hair behind my ear. “I’ll see you later.”

He steps back into the lift, that satisfied smile on his lips. The doors start to close between us.

Someone shouts, “It’s 709! Someone get to 709!”

I spin around. Two menders sprint past me, faces tight with panic.

My blood turns to ice.

709. Cael Brannock.

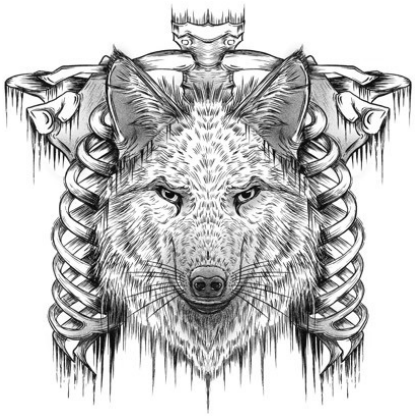
That’s my patient.

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Chapter Seventeen

"The ones who let you in are the ones who will break you when they go."

— Unsigned Healer's Warning



Floor seven smells different than five. Less chemical, more stale. Like air that's been breathed too many times by people who've been here too long. Long-term care.

I follow the sound of shouting.

Room 709 is at the end of the corridor, and I can hear a deep, gravelly voice roaring words I can't quite make out followed by a crash that echoes off the stone walls.

Two menders are huddled outside the door, one of them pressing a cloth to a cut on her forehead. Blood seeps through the fabric. Inside I can see another mender backed against the wall, hands raised, while a figure on the bed hurls what looks like a water pitcher across the room.

"Someone get a blood lead," the injured mender hisses. "He's out of control."

"Malric's on three. He'll take forever to—"

"I'll handle it." They both turn to stare at me. The one with the head wound laughs. "You? You're a bone year. You've been here what, an hour?"

"He's my patient." I hold out my hand. "Give me the bracelet."

She clutches the thin band with Cael's name on it against her chest, but after a moment she huffs and drops it into my palm. I slip it onto my wrist next to Nella's, the metal plate cold against my skin.

"Cael Brannock. Room 709."

Now it's official.

I push past them before they can argue.

The room is a disaster. Medical supplies are scattered across the floor. A tray overturned, instruments everywhere. The curtains have been ripped half off their rod. And in the center of it all, sitting up in bed like a king on a ruined throne, is Cael Brannock.

He's old, not frail old but weathered. Ancient. His skin is leathery and scarred, crisscrossed with marks that look like they came from claws and blades and things I don't want to imagine. His eyes are dark, so dark brown they're almost black, and when they catch the light, I see his pupils are vertical slits like a snake's. Demon. He must have been terrifying once. Now he looks tired and furious and ready to burn the whole world down.

His eyes lock onto me the second I step through the door.

"Another one." His voice is a rasp, raw from shouting. "Another fucking baby healer come to poke and prod and pretend they give a damn."

"Everyone, out."

The mender against the wall looks at me like I've lost my mind.

"You can't—"

"Out. Now."

Something in my tone makes her move. She edges along the wall, keeping as far from Cael as possible, and slips through the door. I hear whispered protests from the corridor, but I'm already pulling the door shut behind her.

Cael watches me with those dark predator eyes, pupils narrowing to thin slits as he assesses me. "Brave little thing, aren't you. Stupid, but brave."

"You're Cael Brannock." I step over a pile of scattered bandages. "I'm Maelis. I've been assigned to take care of you."

He sneers. "Take care of me. That's what they all say. Then they stick needles in my arms and pour potions down my throat and act surprised when I don't magically get better." He gestures at his ruined body. "I've been rotting in this bed for eight months, girl. Look how well it's working."

I crouch down and start picking up the supplies he threw. Bandages. Gauze. A pair of forceps that somehow ended up under the bed.

“What are you doing?”

“Cleaning up.” I set the forceps back on the overturned tray. “Someone has to.”

“I asked them to leave me alone so I could die in peace. Instead they send children to—” He stops and stares at me. “You’re human.”

“So I’ve been told.”

“They let humans in here now?”

“Apparently desperate times.” I right the tray and start organizing supplies onto it. “You going to throw anything else, or are you done?”

He’s quiet for a long moment. I can feel his eyes on my back as I work, assessing, calculating. Trying to figure out what my angle is.

“You’re not afraid of me.”

“Should I be?”

“Everyone else is.”

I turn to face him, a roll of bandages in my hand. “Everyone else didn’t just spend an hour with a fourteen-year-old vampire whose wing is rotting off her body while she tries to pretend she’s not terrified of dying.” I set the bandages on the tray. “After that, one grumpy old demon throwing a tantrum doesn’t really register.”

His vertical pupils widen slightly. For a second, I think he’s going to start throwing things again. Then his mouth twitches. Not quite a smile, but close.

“Grumpy demon.” He shakes his head slowly. “Three hundred and seventeen years old, fought in the last two cycles, killed more twisted creatures than you’ve ever seen. And she calls me a grumpy demon.”

“Would you prefer cranky?”

“I’d prefer dead, but no one seems willing to grant that request.”

I pull the chair from the corner, the one that isn’t buried in debris, and drag it to his bedside, sit down, and look at him properly for the first time.

Up close, the scars are worse. Some of them aren’t fully healed, even after what must be decades. Fissure wounds, I realize, the kind that never really close. His chest rises and falls with effort, each breath a small battle.

“You want to die,” I say quietly.

“I want to stop being a fucking science experiment.” He slumps back against his pillows. “Every day’s a new treatment. A new theory. A new young healer who thinks they’re going to be the one to fix me. I’m tired and have been tired for longer than you’ve been alive.”

The question slips out before I can stop it. “Aren’t you scared?”

“Of what? Death?” He shakes his head. “I’ve been dying for eight months. The scary part is over.”

“No, I mean...what comes after, or what doesn’t.”

His dark eyes sharpen on me. “Ah. You’re one of those.”

“One of what?”

“The ones who lie awake at night wondering if the void is all there is. I used to be like that, when I was young and stupid and thought I had something to lose.”

“What changed?”

“I’ve seen enough bad to have to believe in the good.” He shrugs. “Otherwise what was the point of any of it?”

“So you think the gods are going to welcome you with open arms? A demon?”

He barks out a laugh. “Girl, if the gods don’t want me after everything I’ve done for this world, then they can go fuck themselves. I’ll find my own afterlife.”

I can’t help it. I smile. “I think I like you, Cael Brannock.”

“Don’t get attached.” He says, but there’s warmth underneath the gruffness. “I’m still planning on dying.”

“Not on my shift.”

Before he can argue, Poppy appears crawling around my legs, gray fur ruffled, round black eyes blinking in the light. She climbs up onto the bed and sits back on her haunches, studying Cael with that knowing look she gets.

He freezes.

“What,” he says slowly, “is that.”

“My eidolon. Her name is Poppy.”

“Your eidolon is a raccoon.”

“Yes.”

“A raccoon.”

“She’s very smart.”

Poppy waddles closer to him, sniffing. Her tiny hands reach out and pat his scarred arm once, twice, like she’s checking if he’s real. Then she sits back and tilts her head at him.

Cael stares at her. She stares back.

And then he laughs. “A human with a raccoon eidolon.” He shakes his head, still chuckling. “The world really has gone to shit.”

“She grows on you.”

“I’m sure she does.” He reaches out one gnarled hand, and Poppy sniffs his fingers then allows him to scratch behind her ears. Her eyes close in contentment. “Unexpected little thing, like her owner.”

We sit in silence. The tension from before has drained out of the room, replaced by something quieter, and it feels almost peaceful.

“You asked what I want,” Cael says finally. “I want someone to look at me and see more than a dying body. I want someone to remember that I used to be someone.” He strokes Poppy’s fur absently. “I want to tell my stories before I go. I want to matter to someone, even if it’s just one person for a little while.”

My throat tightens.

“I can do that,” I say quietly. “I can listen.”

He studies me for a long moment. Whatever he sees makes him nod slowly.

“You’re not like the others.”

“So I’ve been told.”

“No.” He shakes his head. “You mean it. I can tell.” He leans back against his pillows, suddenly looking every one of his three hundred and seventeen years. “Come back tomorrow, human girl. Bring that ridiculous creature, and maybe I’ll tell you about the time I watched the earth split open and hell pour through.”

“I’ll be here.”

I stand, gathering my supplies. Poppy doesn’t move from her spot on his bed. She’s curled up against his side now, eyes half-closed.

“She can stay,” Cael says gruffly. “Been a long time since I had company that didn’t want something from me.”

“She’ll find me when she’s ready.” I head for the door then pause with my hand on the handle. “Cael?”

“What?”

“For what it’s worth, you do matter. The fact you’re still fighting after three hundred years, even if it’s fighting for yourself among the people trying to help you, that matters. Just no more hurting staff members please.”

He doesn’t say anything. But when I glance back before closing the door, his hand is resting on Poppy’s soft fur, and some of the hardness has

left his face.



I try to explore the rest of the patient wards before my shift is over and I get a good lay of the land but at some point I take a wrong turn.

The corridor is empty, quieter than the others, no menders rushing past, no patients calling out. I don't recognize this wing. The doors along the walls are all closed, their handles thick with dust.

I should turn back, but then I hear voices.

Hushed and intense. Coming from somewhere ahead.

I press myself against the wall and edge closer, my heart beating loudly in my ears. The voices are coming from a room at the end of the corridor, the door cracked open enough for me to see movement inside.

I peer around the corner.

Headmaster Ashmoor's back is to me, but even without seeing his face, I can tell something's wrong.

And facing him, fists clenched at his sides, jaw tight is Draven.

I catch pieces. Not enough to understand.

"—never agreed to that—"

The headmaster murmurs something and sounds almost amused.

"—can't change the terms—"

Raw and frustrated, Draven grumbles, "That wasn't part of the deal."

The headmaster responds, too quiet to hear. Whatever he says makes Draven flinch. I've never seen anything crack that cold exterior. For one moment, he looks young and scared.

Then the headmaster tips his head, like he's listening to something. He turns toward the door.

I scramble backward. My boot scrapes against the floor, and the sound echoes.

Both heads turn.

Fuck.

I run.

I don't think about where I'm going. I rush down the corridor, around a corner, my lungs heaving, my heart pounding so loud I can barely hear

anything else.

I make it to a stairwell and down one flight before something black and massive appears out of nowhere, blocking my path.

Draven's wolf stands on the landing, huge and dark, green eyes fixed on me. It stares at me with an intelligence that makes my skin crawl.

There are footsteps behind me. I turn, and Draven steps out of the shadows, breathing heavily, but his face has gone cold again.

"What did you hear?" His voice is barely above a whisper.

"Nothing. I was—"

"Don't lie to me." He trudges closer, backing me toward the wall. "What did you hear?"

There's nowhere left to go, the wall is at my back. He keeps coming until his face is inches from mine, one hand braced beside my head.

"We really need to stop meeting like this, Alucard." I force a smirk even though my pulse is racing. "I'm starting to think you enjoy pressing me against walls."

Something flickers in his expression. His eyes drop to my mouth for a fraction of a second before snapping back up.

"Answer me."

"Let go of me first."

"I'm not touching you."

He's right, but he's so close I can feel his heat and smell winter air and whiskey.

"I didn't hear anything. I took a wrong turn and saw you having a lovers' quarrel with the headmaster. It wasn't my business."

"You're lying."

"I'm not. That wasn't part of the deal. That's all I heard. One sentence. It doesn't mean anything to me."

He searches my face, looking for a crack.

Silence stretches between us. Beside me, I can feel the wolf's presence, still watching.

"Forget it." Draven's voice is ice. "Forget you were here. Forget you saw anything."

"Then why are you so scared I heard it?"

His jaw ticks and something dangerous flashes in his eyes.

He leans in close enough that his breath brushes across my cheek. "Knowing too much in this school can be dangerous. Ashmoor's deals and

secrets, you don’t want any part of them, Rose. Trust me.”

“Why should I trust you?”

He pulls back enough to look at me, and the mask slips. Underneath is something tired and angry and desperately lonely.

“You shouldn’t, but I’m the only one warning you. So maybe that counts for something.”

He steps back, and the wolf melts into the shadows like it was never there. Draven turns and walks away, disappearing down the stairwell.

I stay pressed against the cold stone, heart pounding, trying to make sense of what happened. “That wasn’t part of the deal.”

I don’t know what it means. I don’t know what deal he made or why, but I know one thing for certain. Draven Alucard is afraid of something in this school.

And whatever scares a vampire from one of the oldest bloodlines in the Shadowlands should probably terrify me.

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Chapter Eighteen

"Be careful what you search for in the dark. Some things search back."

— Librarian's Note, Unsigned



The dining hall is loud and warm, and I can barely focus on any of it.

I push a piece of roasted meat around my plate, watching the gravy pool in the dip I've made in my mashed potatoes. My herbal tea has gone lukewarm, but I drink it anyway. I'm going to need it if I plan to stay awake in the library tonight.

"And then she had the audacity to tell me I wrapped the bandage wrong!" Lux throws her hands up, nearly knocking over Jace's drink. "I've been wrapping bandages since I was twelve. My father is literally known as the combat professor. I think I know how to wrap a godsdamn bandage."

"Maybe you were wrapping it wrong," Ellavee says, smirking while staring down at her plate.

"I wasn't."

"How do you know?"

"Because I wasn't." Lux stabs a roasted carrot with her fork. "And then Senna made me rewrap the same patient six times while she stood there watching with her arms crossed like I was some first year who'd never seen a wound before."

"You are a first year," Jace points out.

“That’s not the point.” Lux waves her fork at him. “The point is she singled me out. The whole time, Killian was over there wrapping bandages like a drunk toddler, and she didn’t say a word to him. But me? Daughter of Professor Bale? Suddenly I need to prove myself twice as much.”

There it is. The thing Lux doesn’t talk about directly but always circles back to. Her father’s name opens doors, but it also puts a target on her back. Everyone expects her to be perfect because of his name, and she’s exhausted from trying to live up to it while pretending she doesn’t care. I know the feeling. I remember the way I used to feel treating patients in the clinic back home before…

“Senna’s tough on everyone,” Jace says gently. “It’s not personal.”

“It felt personal.” Lux slumps back in her chair. “Whatever, I’ll show her. By the end of the year, she’ll be begging me to wrap her bandages.”

“That’s the spirit,” Ellavee says dryly. “Petty revenge through superior wound care.”

“Damn right.”

I take another sip of tea. Across the hall, I can see Draven sitting with Malric and a few other vampires. He hasn’t looked my way once, but his giant black wolf lies at his feet and hasn’t taken his eyes off me. Those greenish-yellow wolf eyes track my every movement, unblinking. *That wasn’t part of the deal.*

What deal?

“Mae.” Jace’s hand finds my knee under the table. “You okay?”

“Hmm?” I blink, pulling myself back. “Yeah, just tired.”

“You’ve barely touched your food.”

“Not that hungry.”

He doesn’t look convinced but doesn’t push either. His thumb traces a small circle on my knee, and I lean into him slightly, letting his warmth ground me. This is what I need, this boy who has known me since we were children, who doesn’t need me to explain myself, who accepts that sometimes I disappear inside my own head.

“Did you guys hear about the breath year?” Ellavee asks, reaching for the bread basket.

“What breath year?” Lux is still fuming about the bandage incident.

“Cassia Venn was doing onsite work at a fissure in the Shorelands.” Ellavee tears off a piece of bread, casual as anything. “Didn’t make it back.”

The table goes quiet.

“What happened?” Jace asks.

“I don’t know the details.” Ellavee shrugs, but there’s something tight around her eyes. “Crawler attack maybe, or the fissure shifted. Does it matter?”

“How do you always know these things before everyone else?” Lux narrows her eyes at Ellavee. “Seriously, a student dies, and you hear about it before the professors even make an announcement.”

Ellavee smiles, brushing her blonde hair off her shoulder, that knowing smile she gets when she’s keeping secrets. “I pay attention. You should try it sometime.”

“To what? You lurk around corners listening to people?”

“I prefer the term ‘observing.’” Ellavee takes a bite of bread. “You’d be amazed what people say when they think no one important is listening.”

There’s something I’ve noticed before but never pressed on. Ellavee knows too many things. I’ve never asked how or why, and she’s never offered to explain. Maybe it’s from all of her late-night hookups she never gives us details about.

It shouldn’t surprise me that people die here. That’s what everyone keeps saying. But hearing it spoken so plainly about someone who was walking these halls days ago makes me sick.

“I didn’t know her,” Lux says quietly, “but still.”

“Yeah.” Ellavee nods. “Still.”

The noise of the dining hall feels louder now, all those voices and lives continuing on like nothing happened. Because for them, nothing did. Another name, another empty bed.

Across the room, I see a group of older students laughing about something. A couple in the corner feeding each other bites of dessert. Two demons arm wrestling while their friends cheer them on. Life goes on, even when someone’s daughter or sister or friend isn’t coming home.

Jace clears his throat, trying to shift the mood. “A patient came in today with something living inside him. It was a parasite from a fissure site, and you could see it moving under his skin.”

“Stop.” Lux holds up a hand. “If you tell me you got to watch them cut it out, I’m going to scream.”

“Theron was the Veilguard on duty. He opened him up and pulled this thing out.” Jace’s eyes brighten, animated in a way that makes my chest

ache. This is what he loves, and it's exactly why he's here. This is the kind of thing I used to love too. "Size of my fist, all legs and teeth, still squirming when it came out."

Ellavee leans in, bread forgotten. "Was the patient awake?"

"They needed him conscious to avoid the nerves. He was screaming, but Theron kept working. Steady hands, no hesitation, it was great." Jace shakes his head. I recognize that expression. It's the same one he gets when he talks about why he came here. "That's what I want, that kind of calm under pressure."

"That's disgusting." Lux stabs her meat aggressively. "And I'm insanely jealous. I got bandages and bedpan duty, and you got a live parasite extraction. The universe is deeply unfair."

"Did the patient make it?" I ask quietly.

Everyone looks at me.

Jace squeezes my knee. "Yeah, he's going to be fine. Theron got it all out. But another day and it would have reached his heart."

I nod, trying to feel relieved, but all I can think about is Nella. The corruption spreading toward her shoulder. The clock ticking down.

"What about you, Mae?" Lux leans forward, oblivious to where my thoughts have gone. "How was your first day in the wards? Any drama? Any near-death experiences?"

"It was fine. Long."

"That's it? Fine and long?"

"I have a demon patient who throws things and a vampire teenager with a fissure wound from a twisted creature that won't heal." I shrug.

"You got a demon?" Ellavee raises an eyebrow.

"He's three hundred years old and wants to die." I reach over and give Poppy another slice of bread. She's sitting on the bench next to me like a little human, watching everyone talk with those round black eyes. "But Poppy cheered him up. She has that effect on people."

Poppy chirps and shoves the entire piece of bread in her mouth at once. Lux snorts.

"Your eidolon is a menace, and I love her," Lux says.

I say, "She's a perfect angel who can do no wrong."

Poppy chooses that moment to reach across the table and steal a roasted carrot off Ellavee's plate. Sighing, Ellavee slides her entire plate closer to Poppy.

“What about the vampire?” Jace asks. “The teenager?”

Nella’s face flashes in my mind. The wings pinned open, the corruption spreading. The fear she’s trying so hard to hide beneath sarcasm and walls she’s built up so high.

“She’s fourteen.” I stare at my plate. “Her name is Nella. She got slashed by a riftling three weeks ago, and no one can figure out how to stop the corruption. If they can’t fix it, they’re going to have to take her wing, but so far she’s refused to let them amputate.”

I see their grim faces.

“She’s just a kid,” I continue, not sure why I can’t stop talking. “She should be worried about school and boys and whatever vampire teenagers worry about, not whether she’s ever going to fly again or if the corruption is going to reach her heart before anyone figures out how to stop it.”

Jace’s hand tightens on my knee.

“Mae,” he says softly, “you can’t save everyone.”

“I know.” I push my plate away. “But I want to save her.”

The table is quiet. Even Lux doesn’t have a joke to fill the silence.

“I should go.” I push back from the table. “I need to check something in the library.”

“The library?” Lux stares at me. “We finished a long shift in the patient wards, and you want to go to the library?”

“I need to look something up.”

“You’re insane.”

“Probably.”

Jace catches my wrist as I stand. “I can come with you.”

I look down at his warm blue eyes and the worry creasing his forehead. The way he looks at me should be illegal, like I’m precious, like I’m his, when I know deep in my bones that I am neither.

“No, it’s okay.” I lean down and kiss his cheek, letting my lips linger. “I need some quiet time. I’ll see you later.”

He searches my face for a moment. “Don’t stay too late.”

“I won’t.”

It’s a lie, and we both know it.

I grab my bag and head for the door, feeling their eyes on my back. Lux says something, and Ellavee laughs, and the conversation picks up again behind me, filling the space I left.

Poppy hurries beside me, her little paws pattering against the stone floor. I reach down and scoop her up, pulling her against my chest. She's so plump and furry and warm. I want to go back to my room and curl up with her and not think about anything, but I can't.

As I pass through the doorway, I feel that prickle on the back of my neck. I glance over my shoulder without meaning to.

Draven is looking at me.

Those amber eyes catch mine across the crowded hall. His expression gives nothing away, but his wolf's tail twitches once, twice, before going still.

Then he looks away, turning back to Malric like I don't exist.

I keep walking.

The library. The records. The name I've been hoping to find and terrified to find in equal measure. I've been avoiding this for weeks now, making excuses, telling myself I wasn't ready, but I can't keep running from the truth.

My father walked these halls.

Time to find out who he really was.



The library is different at night.

During the day, students crowd the first two floors, hunched over texts and whispering to each other across study tables. But now, an hour until midnight, the space is almost empty. The current-powered lamps have dimmed to a faint glow, and shadows pool between the shelves like dark water.

The entrance opens into an atrium that stretches up and up and up. I count the floors as my eyes climb. Five. Six. Seven. The spiral staircase winds around the edges like a metal spine, and the railings of each level crisscross above me like a web.

A desk curves across the entrance like a barricade. Behind it sits a tall and thin woman. Her silver hair covers the desk in front of her, and her pale eyes fix on me without blinking.

"Name," she whispers.

“Maelis Rose.”

She writes something in the ledger without looking down. Her eyes never leave my face.

“The records you want are on the fifth floor.” Her voice is a whisper that seems to come from everywhere at once. “But the answers you need may be higher.”

I open my mouth to ask what she means but she’s already gone.

I stare at the empty space where she sat for a long moment, my skin prickling with unease. Then I turn toward the spiral staircase and begin to climb. How does she know what I’m looking for?

The higher I go, the quieter it gets. By the third floor, I can’t hear anything but my own breathing. By the fourth, even that sounds too loud. The fifth floor is dark. Only a few lamps are lit, and they flicker like they’re fighting to stay alive.

I find the records section in the back corner. Rows and rows of leather bound ledgers, organized by year. Student enrollments, graduation lists, and death records.

So many death records.

I pull the first ledger from fifty years ago and start to search.

After over an hour of searching student records as far back as my dad’s been alive and not finding anything I feel a little defeated. Charlie Rose never went to Ashwell Academy. And if he did, he went by a different name.

I must be missing something.

Maybe I should write my mom or Briana and see if they know anything. I mean, I doubt my sister knows anything, and I can’t bring myself to write my mother after what happened.

I venture down two floors and find a book on eidolons then head over to the fireplace and get comfy in one of the wide-cushioned chairs, throwing my stack of books on the side table. The fire crackles softly, and Poppy chooses now to appear and lays on her belly in front of it watching me. Or watching my back. Either way, I’m grateful. I glance around and don’t see anyone. The library is eerily quiet, nothing but the occasional pop from the fire and the distant creak of old wood settling, but I’m glad I have Poppy to keep me company.

I crack open the first book. *Eidolons: A Comprehensive Study of Soul-Bonded Companions at Ashwell Academy.*

The title has me thinking of the other academies. Do they get eidolons as well? Are they the same three animals Ashwell has?

The introduction is dry, and I skim past it looking for something more useful.

The bond between a bloodline individual and their eidolon is forged during the Mirror Ceremony. Other academies across Valen have their own bonding rituals, and not all grant eidolons. Ashwell is unique in that its mirror bestows one of three forms: wolf, serpent, or bat.

So Draven got his eidolon somewhere else, probably the Vanguard academy. That explains why his wolf looks nothing like the ones I've seen here. Larger. Darker. Built for war instead of healing.

I flip forward.

For the first year of the bond, an eidolon is considered nascent regardless of its physical size. During this period, both eidolon and partner are still learning to sense each other, the eidolon attuning to its partner's emotions, needs, and physical state, while the partner learns to interpret the eidolon's subtle cues and communicate through impression rather than words.

A nascent eidolon tires quickly when manifested for extended periods. Most new partners find their eidolons retreating inward after only a few hours of physical presence, requiring rest before emerging again. This endurance grows with time and practice. Seasoned Veilguards can maintain manifestation for days without strain.

Distance too is limited during the nascent period. An eidolon cannot travel far from its bonded partner before feeling an uncomfortable pull back toward them. Pushing against this tether causes distress to both parties. The range extends as the bond matures. Experienced partners report their eidolons scouting miles ahead without discomfort.

I glance at Poppy. She's rolled onto her back, paws in the air, completely unbothered by the existential weight of what I'm reading.

"So you're basically a baby," I tell her.

She chirps without opening her eyes.

I flip forward, looking for the section on anomalies. There has to be more information about them.

Anomalies—eidolons that do not conform to the three standard forms—are exceptionally rare. Historical records indicate four confirmed anomalies in the past five centuries.

The significance of an anomaly eidolon is debated among scholars. Some believe anomalies indicate an individual whose path cannot be defined by traditional means, a healer who will forge their own way rather than follow established patterns. Others suggest anomalies are mistakes, imperfections in the mirror's ancient magic.

A minority of scholars propose a third theory, that anomaly eidolons are given to those with unusual destinies, individuals fated to bring about great change.

All of that blows my mind.

"There you are."

I spin around, heart lurching into my throat, but it's Jace. He's standing at the edge of the firelight, hands in his pockets, that familiar sweet smile on his face.

"Gods, you scared me." I close the book and place it in my lap.

"I went by your room, and when I saw you were still gone, I got worried. Figured I'd come check on you." He rounds the chair next to me and drops into it, stretching his legs toward the fire. He scans the stack of books on the side table. "Eidolons and current. You could ask me about current, you know. From somewhere more comfortable. Like in bed. On top of me in bed even."

I snicker. "I know I can ask you. I don't like not knowing anything, and we haven't covered current much in classes yet. I want to be prepared. It's so easy for everyone else—"

"It's not easy for me either. Just because I can feel current doesn't make it come easy." He turns his chair to face me more. "Most bloodlines don't get good at using current until they've practiced a lot, and it always comes at a cost."

"What do you mean when you say you can feel it? Explain it to me. What does it feel like?" I pull my legs underneath me and place my book on the side table so I can get more comfortable.

"You know how you can feel a fire or feel a draft?" He gestures toward the hearth. "Like that, I can feel current, but only if it's strong. All over the academy's campus I can feel it, but out there in Valen, back home in Ironfen, I couldn't feel it unless I was trying to draw from it."

Flick appears and swoops down next to the fire. Poppy sits up, gives him a disgusted look, and then makes a point to move two feet away before plopping back down. I giggle then look back at Jace.

“Why have I never seen you use it much before?”

“I’ve tried a little bit back home, but nothing big. To warm up my coffee or close my bedroom door for me. Current isn’t supposed to be used unless it’s really needed. I only did those things to practice. Current shouldn’t be used much until it’s taught to you, and even then it costs you when you use too much.”

He looks away from me and toward the fire.

“What does it cost?”

“Doing little things like closing a door or getting help stitching up a wound isn’t a big deal, but the more you pull, the more it drains you physically. Healing a major wound, fighting off infection, working to keep someone alive who’s dying...” He shakes his head. “That’s like running for miles without stopping. Your body pays the price.”

“What kind of price?”

“Exhaustion first, the kind that goes bone deep, then tremors. Nosebleeds. Headaches. Collapse. Hallucinations. Your body shuts down, forcing you to stop.”

“And what if you don’t stop? What if you keep pushing?”

He meets my eyes. “You can do permanent damage, like burn out your ability to channel current entirely. Some healers have pushed so hard they’ve damaged their organs, their minds. Some have died.”

The fire crackles, and I lean forward to rest my chin on my hand as I listen.

“That’s why Veilguards are so respected,” I say quietly. “It’s not just a skill. It can also be a sacrifice. How am I supposed to make it as a Veilguard if I can’t use current?” I look over at Poppy as she repositions into a ball.

“Veilguards don’t rely on current. Sure, it’s an added bonus, but they must have skill and knowledge for medicine and surgeries. Current helps, but it doesn’t make the Veilguard what they are, and they don’t always use it.” He touches my chin so I turn to look at him again. “You are the most talented healer I know. You can do this, Mae. You just need to get out of your head.”

It’s not the first time he’s said it to me. I give him a small smile. If only I knew how to get out of my head.

“Have you ever let the very real possibility sink in that maybe you’re not entirely human?”

I have considered it after what Professor Nestor said. And the Mirror Ceremony. But I feel human.

“I tried looking for a record of my father attending here, but there’s nothing. So I don’t know what else to do.” I push my hair out of my face. “Maybe the school was wrong about me. Maybe the mirror made a mistake giving me Poppy.”

Jace shakes his head. “What if you’re human now but the mirror saw your future?”

“Why would that matter?”

“What if…and I know this is crazy, but what if something happens and you’re turned?”

I go still.

I remember my reflection in the mirror. How my eyes were amber with red bleeding into them at first. How it didn’t look like me.

What if I’m destined to become a vampire?

“I can’t even think about something like that happening right now.” I shake my head, pushing the image of those amber eyes away. “Tell me about fissure sites. Why is the current different there?”

I change the subject, but the way my eyes looked in that mirror lingers in the back of my mind.

“Yeah, it’s corrupted.” He notices Flick flying over to him and disappearing beneath his wing. “The current that bleeds through fissures is twisted like the creatures it spits out. If you try to pull from it, it can poison you, getting into your blood. It’s why fissure wounds are so hard to heal.”

I sit up straighter, remembering I need to get some books to help me learn more about ways to help Nella.

“I understand that, but why is it corrupted?”

“It’s only hypothesized. I don’t think anyone knows for certain.” He tilts his head. “You know how we covered the bloodlines with Professor Cane? Where they originated? The angels and demons?”

I think back to her classes. “Yeah, angels originated from the Upper Veil above Valen and demons from the Lower Veil below.”

“Well, what leaks out of the fissures is from far below the Lower Veil.”

I can’t even comprehend what that is or what it must be like down there. What kind of place creates creatures like crawlers and riftlings? What kind of darkness births something so depraved that even its energy poisons everything it touches?

“We’ll cover more about the fissures and current in class soon. They’ll want us to be ready for midterms.” He stretches his arms above his head.

I almost forgot about that. I still have a couple months before I need to stress about midterms.

“Have you heard anything about what the tests will be like? I keep meaning to ask Lux about her dad’s…”

Jace’s face pales.

“What?” I press.

“I know Professor Cane will have a written test. Professor Nestor usually makes everyone dissect something. But Bale...his will take place off campus.”

“What do you mean? Where?”

“You know how he was saying he’s getting us ready to experience what a real fissure is like? I’m pretty sure our midterm will have something to do with that.”

I’m partly excited and terrified to think about leaving campus, possibly seeing a fissure up close for the first time in my life.

“Do you know where or what we’d have to do?”

“There are rumors that apparently we get paired up and sent to an active site. Small fissures, nothing too dangerous. But still...”

“Still what?”

“People have died during midterms before, Mae.” His blue eyes meet mine. “People die trying to become Veilguards all the time. Notice how few blood and breath years there are compared to us.”

I remember Elizabeth telling me we’d lose about half the bone year students by the end of the year.

“Yeah, some students fail. Others drop out.”

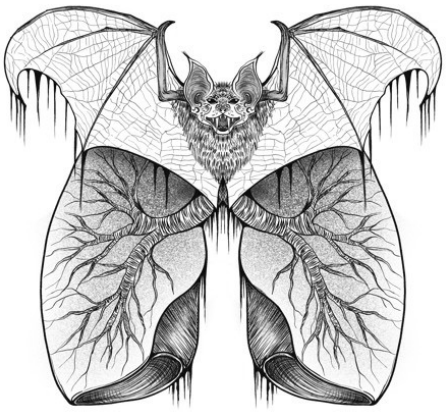
“Yeah.” He holds my gaze. “And some die.”

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Chapter Nineteen

"A wound cannot heal if the one who carries it believes they deserve the pain."

— Professor Nestor, Architecture of Flesh



The library doors groan shut behind me, and the cold hits like a slap. The perpetual winter here in the Frostlands sure is pretty, but the cold…that's getting a little old.

Snow has started falling again while I was buried in books. A fresh white layer of powder coats the ground and the bare branches overhead. The campus is silent, and I'm starting to wish I hadn't told Jace to go back without me an hour ago.

I breathe into my hands to warm them.

My bag is heavy with borrowed books. Notes on corrupted tissue. Case studies of riftling wounds. An old leather-bound journal detailing experimental treatments most healers considered too dangerous to try.

It's not much, but it might save Nella's life.

My breath fogs in front of me as I cross the courtyard. The snow muffles my footsteps.

I'm halfway to the dormitories when I feel that uncomfortable familiar prickle at the back of my neck.

I walk faster, and still the feeling doesn't leave me. It sharpens instead, pressing in at my back like a shadow with weight, a presence that is close

and getting closer.

My hand slides into my satchel. Fingers close around the scalpel handle.

I spin, grab a fistful of fabric, and use my momentum to slam him against the wall. The blade is at his throat before my mind catches up to my body.

Amber eyes stare down at me.

Draven.

Snow clings to his dark hair, half down and falling in pieces around his face. His breath clouds between us. He's not fighting back, just watching me with an eerie expression.

"Bale's class is paying off," he says.

"Why are you following me?"

"Who says I'm following you?"

"You were right behind me in the dark well after midnight."

"It's a path."

"Bullshit."

He narrows his eyes. He's not used to people calling him out on his shit.

"Careful, Rose." He tsks. "You're shaking."

"It's cold."

"It's not the cold."

I press the blade harder against his throat, not enough to cut but enough to make a point.

"Now look who's pinned against a wall," I say.

He leers at me. "I don't hate this view."

"You should. I could slit your throat right now."

"Could you?"

He's testing me, watching to see what I'll do.

"You freeze over dead bodies." His head tilts slightly, eyes never leaving mine. "You really expect me to believe you'd cut a living person?"

"You're not a person. You're a vampire."

"Same thing."

"Is it?"

The snow falls around us, soft and relentless. I'm suddenly aware of how close we are. I can feel the heat radiating off his body. His eyes drop to my mouth for a fraction of a second before snapping back up.

"You've got fire, Freckles." His voice is barely above a whisper. "I'll give you that."

“Don’t call me that.”

“Why not?”

“Because I hate you.”

“You think your hatred wounds me, Rose? I’ve been hated by people who actually matter.”

“Ouch,” I say sarcastically, but it does kind of hurt me in a way I don’t expect.

“You’re still not moving.”

He’s right. I should probably step back, lower the blade and walk away.

“What were you doing with the headmaster?” I ask before I can stop myself.

His expression shutters. That flicker of something human disappearing behind the mask.

“Forget what you heard.”

“I can’t.”

“Try harder.”

“Tell me what deal you made with him.”

“No.”

“Why not?”

“Because it doesn’t concern you.” His jaw tightens. “Because I’m trying to—”

He looks away from me for the first time since I pinned him here.

Trying to what?

I wait for him to continue, but when he speaks again his voice is different, stripped of its usual edge. “Go inside, Rose. It’s late.”

“Is that a threat?”

“It’s a warning.” His eyes meet mine again, something tired behind them. “Not everything that follows you in the dark wants to hurt you, but some things do.”

“And which one are you?”

He reaches up slowly and pushes the blade aside with one finger, like it’s nothing. *Like I’m nothing.*

“Next time,” he says, leaning close enough that I can feel his hair brush against my cheek, “aim for the heart. That’s the only way to kill a vampire.”

He melts into the shadows like he was never there at all.

I stand in the falling snow, scalpel still clutched in my hand, heart pounding.

What was he about to say?

And why do I care?



I’ve been in Rot, Ruin, and Putrefaction for the last three hours listening to Professor Rowan lecture us about different infections, wounds, and ways to combat them in the field.

Actually, I haven’t been listening. I’ve been tuning her out while reading, too focused on one wound that I thought might be getting better.

I’ve made it a point to stop by the patient wards every day for the last two weeks, even when I didn’t have a shift, to check on Nella and let Poppy hang out with Cael while he tells me insane battle stories that are almost too wild to believe.

I’ve gone to the library at least five times in the last two weeks and tried a couple different things on Nella’s wing. The binding wraps soaked in purging solution slowed the spread but didn’t stop it. The extraction method—cutting away the corrupted tissue layer by layer while still trying to salvage the wing—seemed promising until the decay crept back within days, angrier than before.

Venom therapy worked the best.

I convinced Senna and her serpent eidolon, Zee, to help me. She was hesitant at first, worried about getting in trouble for administering an unauthorized treatment, but I begged, and eventually she said yes. I think it’s because she felt she owed me that after I saved her that night from Malric, but neither of us brought it up.

The venom attacked the corruption aggressively. Within hours, the rot started to recede. Nella cried when she saw it, happy tears streaming down her face as she watched the blackness retreat from her wing.

For four days, I let myself believe we’d done it. That I’d saved her.

Then yesterday the decay started spreading again, faster this time.

I’m running out of options, but there’s one thing I haven’t tried. I read about blood mages in an old text buried in the restricted section, healers who could follow corruption into the blood and burn it out from within.

They could cure what no one else could because their blood was current itself.

I've also learned blood mages truly are practically extinct. I thought maybe the others were exaggerating when they said so, but it's in the text. They were hunted to death centuries ago, feared for the power they could wield.

But the headmaster is a blood mage.

Maybe he can help.

It's possible he knows how the blood mages did it. Or knows someone who does. Or has some text, some record, some secret tucked away in that office of his. Or maybe he will be willing to try it himself.

It's a long shot, but Nella is running out of time.

So after classes today, after my shift in the patient wards, I'm going to the headmaster's office.

I have to ask him if he will help.

"We have a three-hour break until we have to report for ward hours. Want to come back to my room for a bit? I'll help you relax." Jace says, rubbing my shoulders as we exit the lecture hall.

I see the headmaster walking by himself across the courtyard.

This might be my chance. Instead of waiting and working up the courage to go to his office later, I can approach him now out in the open.

"Sounds great. Can you take my bag? I'll meet you there in a few minutes."

I hand Jace my satchel, and he nods, a question forming on his lips. Before he can ask it, I'm already moving, cutting across the courtyard and rounding the corner.

"Headmaster Ashmoor."

He turns. His cloak whips around in the breeze, dark fabric snapping like a wing. His eyes land on me. Dark, narrow eyes that look like they've seen centuries pass and found them all disappointing.

His nose scrunches slightly.

I suddenly wish I hadn't come over here.

But then I think of Nella and the necrosis creeping back across her wing. The fear she tries so hard to hide. The way she looked at me yesterday when I told her the venom therapy wasn't working anymore.

I hurry the rest of the way to him.

“Miss Rose.” His voice is smooth, like he has all the time in the world and I’m an inconvenience he’s choosing to tolerate. “To what do I owe this...unexpected approach?”

My mouth goes dry. Up close, he’s taller than I remembered. The bits of red streaking through his dark brown hair catches the light. There’s something unsettling about the way he stands perfectly still, not a single unnecessary movement, like a predator conserving energy.

“I need to ask you something,” I spit out before I lose my nerve. “About a patient.”

He narrows his eyes at me. “You’re a bone year barely a couple months into your training, and you wish to consult with me about a patient?”

“Yes.”

“How...ambitious.”

I can’t tell if that’s a compliment or an insult. Probably both.

“Her name is Nella Thorne. She’s fourteen. She has a fissure wound on her wing from a riftling attack. The necrosis keeps spreading no matter what we try.” I’m talking too fast but can’t stop myself. “I’ve tried binding wraps and surgical extraction and venom therapy. The venom worked for almost a week, but now it’s coming back faster than before, and I don’t know what else to do. It feels like the healers have given up on her, and I’m the only one searching for ways to help this poor girl.”

He watches me without blinking. “And you believe I can help?”

“I read about blood mages.” I chew on the inside of my cheek. “About how they could follow corruption into the blood and burn it out from within. They could heal things no one else could.”

Something shifts in his expression so subtly I almost miss it. A tightening around his eyes, like I hit a nerve.

“Blood mages,” he says, “now there’s a term I haven’t heard a student speak aloud in quite some time, at least not directed at me as a request.”

“I know blood mages are rare,” I say quickly, “and I know you are busy and can’t personally help everyone, but I thought maybe you’d consider—”

“Stop,” he says abruptly, startling me. “Miss Rose, let me be very clear with you. There is a reason I have survived as long as I have. It has nothing to do with saving vampire wings.”

“But you have the ability. You could—”

“I could do many things.” His lip curls slightly. “I could level this courtyard with a thought. I could stop your heart before you took your next

breath. I could do things that would make you weep with terror and beg for death. The question is not what I can do. The question is what I choose to do. And I choose not to waste my blood on a fourteen-year-old girl with a damaged wing."

I gape, shocked.

"Nella is—"

"A patient, one of hundreds who pass through these wards every year. Some live. Some die. Some lose limbs. The corruption hasn't reached her core yet, has it?"

I shake my head, unable to speak.

"Then the solution is simple. Cut off the wing before it does. She won't die and can live a perfectly normal life without it."

"A perfectly normal—" I choke on the words. "She's a vampire. Flying is everything to her. You can't—"

"I can't?" One eyebrow rises. "I'm not the one who can't do anything, Miss Rose. You came to me begging for a miracle. I'm giving you the practical solution. The wing is infected, so remove it. The girl survives. This is not complicated."

"It's not just about surviving. It's about—"

"What? Quality of life?" he laughs, completely devoid of warmth. "How touching. How idealistic. How utterly naive."

My hands are shaking.

"Do you know how many people have stood where you're standing and begged me to use my blood to save someone they loved?" His dark eyes bore into mine. "Hundreds. Thousands perhaps. Students, professors, nobles, peasants, they all have the same look in their eyes. The same desperate hope and pathetic belief that their person is special, that their tragedy deserves my attention."

He leans closer, and his voice drops to barely a whisper. "None of them are special. None of their tragedies matter to me. And neither does yours. I've watched students like you come through these halls for longer than you can comprehend, bright-eyed little healers who think caring is enough. Some patients cannot be saved. Some wounds cannot be healed. The sooner you learn that, the less time you'll waste."

"She's a child." My voice breaks. "She wants to fly again."

"And I want to be left alone." His smile is thin. "We don't always get what we want, Miss Rose. That's the first lesson of being a healer. I suggest

you learn it.”

He starts to turn away.

“Why?” I cry out. “Why won’t you help her? It would cost you nothing. A little blood. A few minutes of your time. You have the power to save her and you just...won’t?”

He looks back over his shoulder.

“You’re right. I have the power.” His voice is soft again, almost gentle. “And I choose not to use it. That is my right. My blood, my choice.”

“That’s cruel.”

“That’s survival.” His dark eyes hold mine, and there’s something ancient in them, cold. It makes me want to scream. “The world is full of dying children. I stopped trying to save all of them a very long time ago. The ones who survive are the ones who learn to save themselves.”

He walks away, and I stand frozen in the courtyard, the winter wind cutting through my cloak as I watch him disappear around the corner.

He could save her but won’t.

The question that haunts me as I walk back to find Jace isn’t how I’m going to tell Nella. It’s what kind of person has the power to save a child and chooses not to? And what made him that way?

I almost brought up his deal with Draven. If only I knew more, I could have used it as leverage to get him to help me. Even then, I don’t know if that would have worked.

I find Jace’s room on the third floor of the men’s dormitory.

“Hey.” He’s sprawled across his bed, boots off, a book open on his chest that he clearly wasn’t reading. His face lights up when he sees me, but the smile falters almost immediately. “What happened?”

“Nothing.” I close the door and lean against it. “Long day.”

He doesn’t believe me. I can see it in the furrow of his brow, the way he sets his book aside and sits up slowly, blue eyes tracking my every movement.

“Mae.”

“I don’t want to talk about it.” I push off the door and cross the homey room with the worn quilt his mother made, the anatomy sketches pinned to the wall with his chicken scratch notes in the margins, the small wooden shelf cluttered with medical texts and a framed drawing of his family’s farm.

I want to crawl inside that warmth and disappear.

My cloak hits the floor. I don’t bother hanging it up. My boots follow, kicked off carelessly, and then I’m climbing onto the bed, climbing onto him, straddling his lap before he can ask any more questions.

“Mae—”

I kiss him.

He goes still for half a second, surprised, and then his hands find my waist, and he’s kissing me back. Tentative at first. Careful. Always so careful with me.

I don’t want careful.

I fist my hands in his shirt and pull him closer, licking into his mouth until he groans low in his throat. The sound vibrates through me, hot in my belly. This is better than the cold dread that’s been lodged in my chest all day.

His hands slide up my back, fingers spread wide, palms warm through the thin fabric of my shirt. I roll my hips against him and feel him harden beneath me. His grip tightens on my waist, fingers digging in enough to make me gasp.

“Mae.” He pulls back, breathing hard, his pupils blown wide. “What’s going on?”

“Nothing.” I kiss along his jaw, feel the scratch of stubble against my lips, find the spot below his ear that always makes him shiver. “I want you.”

“You have me.” His voice is strained. “You always have me. But—”

I push him back against the pillows, and he watches with those blue eyes gone dark as I undo the buttons of his shirt. His chest is lean and firm. I press my mouth to his collarbone, taste salt, and feel his stomach clench when my fingers trail lower.

“Mae.” It comes out rough. I love that I can do that to him.

I reach for the laces of his pants.

His hand catches my wrist.

“Wait.” He’s breathing like he’s run a mile, his chest heaving, but his grip on my wrist is firm. “Stop.”

“What?” I look up at him, something sharp and ugly twisting in my chest. “Why?”

“Because something’s wrong.” He sits up, shifting me off his lap, and the sudden distance between us feels wrong. “You’re upset about something. You won’t tell me what. And I’m not going to—” He runs a

hand through his hair, frustrated. “I’m not going to do this while you’re somewhere else.”

“I’m right here.”

“No, you’re not.” His eyes search my face, and I hate how well he knows me. “You haven’t been here since you walked through that door.”

I want to shove him back down, make him stop talking and let me feel something other than this gnawing emptiness.

Instead I sit there, half undressed, and say nothing.

“I’ve waited years for this, Mae.” His gentle voice doesn’t help. “And I don’t want our first time to be because you’re running from something you won’t even tell me about.”

“I’m not running.”

“Then talk to me.”

I can’t. The words are stuck somewhere behind my ribs, tangled up with the headmaster’s cold smile and Nella’s desperate eyes and the horrible certainty that nothing I do is ever going to be enough.

“I want our first time to be perfect.” He reaches out, tucking a strand of hair behind my ear, his touch achingly gentle. “I want you to be here, really here with me, and not trying to escape something.”

Perfect. He wants perfect.

I don’t even know what that means anymore.

“You’re right.” I force my mouth into something like a smile. “I’m sorry. I don’t know what’s wrong with me today.”

“Don’t apologize.” He pulls me into his arms, my cheek pressed against his bare chest, his heartbeat steady under my ear. “Talk to me. Whatever it is, we’ll figure it out together.”

Like it’s that simple. Like talking about it would change anything.

I close my eyes and breathe him in and try to let his warmth seep into the cold places.

“I’m tired,” I lie. “Can we stay like this for a while?”

“Of course.” He presses a kiss to the top of my head. “Whatever you need, Mae. I’m here.”

Whatever I need.

I needed to disappear. I needed to stop feeling like I’m failing everyone I try to help. I needed him to stop being so godsdamn patient and let me make a terrible decision for once in my life.

But I can’t say that, so I lie there in his arms and let him think this is enough.

He falls asleep eventually, his breathing going slow and even, his arms still wrapped around me like I’m something so precious.

I stare at the ceiling and feel nothing.

No, that’s not true. I feel fucking angry and frustrated at myself for wanting more than he can give. At him for being so good it makes me feel worse. At the headmaster for being right about everything. At Nella for needing a miracle I can’t perform.

At whoever decided that being held by a boy who loves me, safe and warm and wanted, should feel like a cage I need to claw my way out of.



Nella made me promise to bring her a book from the library tomorrow, some romance novel about a vampire falling in love with a human. She said she wanted to see if it was realistic. I told her I’d be the judge of that.

Cael is in a better mood today. He wasn’t throwing anything or yelling at anyone when I walked in. We’re making good progress. Exchanging stories is softening this old demon up after all.

Or maybe it’s Poppy.

“You brought my little friend.” He nods toward Poppy, who’s already scrambling up onto his bed like it’s her own. “Good. Only decent company I get around here.”

“I’m standing right here.”

“I know.” He half smiles at me, and I scoff.

I settle into the chair beside his bed while Poppy curls up against his side and he tucks his blanket around her.

“You look like hell, girl.” Cael studies me with those vertical pupils. “Something eating at you?”

He fishes a muffin from his side table and hands it to Poppy to munch on, something he’d tucked away for her from breakfast.

I consider lying but decide it’s not worth the effort.

“I asked the headmaster for help with one of my patients. A young vampire with a corrupted wing. The one I told you about when we first

met.”

“And?”

“And he said no.”

Cael laughs. A bitter, rasping sound. “Of course he did. Ashmoor doesn’t waste his blood on charity cases. Never has.”

“She’s only fourteen years old and desperately wants to fly again. I feel so bad for her. Her family hasn’t even come to visit her.”

“Doesn’t matter if she’s four or four hundred. That man hasn’t saved anyone he didn’t have a use for in over a century.” He shakes his head. “You want to know something about our beloved headmaster?”

I lean forward. “What?”

Cael starts to pet Poppy but his eyes go distant, seeing something far away. “I saw him once during the last cycle on the battlefield outside Thornwall. You know how many people died at Thornwall?”

I shake my head.

“Twelve thousand in three days.” He clears his throat. “The fissure there wasn’t like the small ones you hear about, the ones that happen between cycles. This one was a wound in the world, a tear in the sky itself, stretching across the ground and up into the clouds, bleeding black that smelled of burning flesh. The cycles are always a little different, but that one...”

I try to imagine it.

“Twisted creatures by the hundreds came through, swarming so thick they blotted out the sun. But the worst were the ones that came after. Creatures with no real shape. Just darkness and hunger. They didn’t walk. They poured out and flowed across the battlefield like living shadows.” He holds up his scarred arm. “And when they touched you, they didn’t just kill you. They pulled you apart and fed upon you while you were still screaming.”

My nose scrunches, and my stomach churns at the thought. It sounds more like a nightmare.

“There were others too, things that wore the faces of people you loved, whispering your name before they tore into you.”

“Gods.”

“Gods had nothing to do with it. Whatever lives on the other side of those fissures is older than the gods. And the twisted creatures aren’t mindless, girl. They’re organized.”

“How did anyone survive?”

“Most didn’t. Vanguards, Veilguards, civilians, everyone was dying for those three days. And then he showed up.”

“The headmaster?”

“He walked right through the carnage like it couldn’t touch him. The creatures that were ripping apart our best fighters didn’t even get close. I’ve fought in more battles than you’ve had hot meals, and I’ve never seen anything like it before or since. It’s like they were afraid of him.”

A chill works its way up my spine.

“What did he do?”

“He walked straight to the fissure, paying no attention to anything around him. He pulled out a small blade and cut himself open, blood pouring down his wrists and pooling at his feet.” He lets out a long breath. “His blood seeped into the fissure, and the creatures started to retreat. The ones closest to the fissure dissolved, and the fissure itself started closing, sealing from the edges inward. The whole thing took only a handful of minutes.”

I hold my breath.

“How… I mean, I can’t even picture it.”

“That’s not the part that haunts me.” Cael looks at me, and there’s something cold in his eyes. “When it was done, he didn’t collapse. Didn’t even look tired. He walked away and stepped right over the wounded like they weren’t there. Men and women screaming for help, reaching for him, and he never even looked down.”

“He didn’t heal anyone?”

“Not a single one. Had enough power to close a fissure the size of a lake but couldn’t spare a drop for the dying at his feet.” Cael’s lip curls. “That’s your headmaster, girl. That’s the man you asked for help.”

All that ability to save people and he chose to walk away.

Who the fuck do we have looking over the academy training elite healers?

“That’s not the only blood mage I saw that day though.” Cael starts petting Poppy again as she coos in her sleep. “There was a young woman probably not much older than you.”

“Another blood mage?”

“One of the last of them, near as I can figure. She wasn’t like Ashmoor and stayed on the battlefield, tending to the dying soldiers. Must have saved more than two hundred.”

“How?”

“I don’t know. I was too far away to see exactly what she did, but I saw her bleed. From her eyes. Her nose. Her ears. Blood running down her face.”

“That’s incredible.”

“When she was done, she collapsed dead, having given everything she had. Every drop. Two hundred soldiers lived because she decided they were worth dying for.”

I think about what it would mean to have that kind of power. That kind of choice.

“If blood mages were heroes like that, why were they hunted?”

Cael sighs, “Because people fear what they can’t control. A blood mage doesn’t need external current and can’t be cut off from their power. They can sense your blood, feel your heartbeat, some say even control you through your own veins. That kind of power makes people nervous. Easier to call them monsters and put them down than figure out how to live alongside them.”

“But the headmaster survived.”

“The headmaster is smart and connected. He made himself too valuable to kill.” Cael’s lips twist. “Also too dangerous. Anyone who tried to hunt him ended up dead. Eventually people stopped trying. With time, most have forgotten.”

I imagine the headmaster, young and terrifying, walking through battlefields, sealing fissures with his blood, letting people die because they weren’t useful to him.

“The cycle is overdue, you know. Should have come again by now. It’s been over a hundred years. The fissures are becoming more frequent. More of them have been opening and closing all the time. The creatures coming through are stronger than they used to be. I’ve heard about the new crawlers too.”

“You think it’s really coming?”

“I think it’s already starting.” His dark eyes hold mine. “And I think a lot of people are going to die when it does, people who don’t have someone willing to bleed for them.”

Poppy shifts in her sleep.

“What about you, girl?” Cael asks. “Your parents must be proud. Daughter at Ashwell, training to be a Veilguard.”

The question catches me off guard. I look down at my hands.

“I don’t know how my mother feels because I haven’t spoken to her. And my father...” I swallow. “He died about a year ago.”

“Ah.” The sound is heavy with understanding. “I’m sorry.”

“He was a healer though, the best I’ve ever known.” My throat tightens, but I push through it. “He’d probably be disappointed in me right now.”

“Why’s that?”

“Because I can’t…” I stop and try again. “Since he died, I can’t... I freeze up when I have to cut. When someone’s bleeding out and I need to act, I...”

I shake my head, unable to finish.

“Your father,” he says slowly, “how did he die?”

My chest constricts. I can’t go there. I can’t see it. I can’t—

“He. No, I—”

My bracelet flares to life, distracting me.

I look down, and it’s not a soft glow. It’s a strong vibration.

There’s an emergency, and it’s Nella.

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Chapter Twenty

"A surgeon who hesitates is not a surgeon. They're a witness to death."

—Headmaster Ashmoor, Ashwell Academy Handbook



I run as fast as I can, and my bracelet won't stop buzzing against my wrist. I have to get to the fifth floor.

The lift will take too long. I shove through the stairwell door and take the steps two at a time. My medical belt bounces against my hip. I almost trip twice.

Fifth floor.

I burst through the door, and the corridor is empty.

No one. Not a single mender or healer or anyone.

Oh my gods.

My bracelet pulses again.

Room 503. The door is already open.

I hear her screaming, this horrible raw sound that doesn't even sound human anymore.

I shove into the room, and my body goes ridged.

Nella ripped her wings off the wall. The frames that were supposed to hold them spread and stable are hanging crooked and empty. She's hunched over on the bed, curled into herself, her hair stuck to her face with sweat, her hands clenching the sheets so hard her knuckles are white.

And her wing.

The decay has exploded across the membrane. Black lines everywhere, branching and spreading, crawling up toward her shoulder and disappearing under her gown. It wasn't like this before. I checked on her two hours ago at the start of my shift, and it wasn't anywhere near this bad.

How is it this bad?

I rush to her side, and my hands are hovering because I don't know where to touch her. I don't want to hurt her more. "Nella, I'm here."

She screams again, and her whole body seizes up. When her eyes find mine, they're wild with pain.

"Save it," she wails. "Please. My wing. Try anything. I don't care if it hurts, just save it. Please."

I don't know what to do.

"Help!" I scream toward the door. "Someone help!"

Nothing. No footsteps. No response.

I run to the doorway and scream down the corridor. "I need help! Room 503! Anyone!"

My voice echoes and dies. Where the fuck is everyone?

I run back to Nella.

She's crying, these broken, sobbing sounds that get stuck in her throat. Her hand finds mine, and she squeezes so hard it hurts.

"It hurts. Maelis, it hurts so bad. Please. Please make it stop."

I have to do something.

"I need to look at it, okay?" I try to sound calm, like my dad used to when patients were scared. "Hold still for me."

She nods and bites her lip so hard it bleeds.

I grab her wing as gently as I can, and she screams. I don't let go. I start peeling back the bandages, and my fingers come away wet with blood and something dark and thick that isn't blood.

The wound underneath is worse than I thought possible.

The corruption has eaten holes through the membrane. I can see bone in places, gray-white poking through dead flesh. The veins are black and bulging, pulsing with something that isn't life. And the lines are still moving, still spreading. I watch them creep another inch toward her spine while I stand here uselessly.

I fumble with my medical belt. My hands are shaking so bad I can barely open it. I have healing tincture. It's not strong enough for this, but

maybe it’ll slow it down and buy time.

I rip the stopper out with my teeth and dump the whole thing on the wound.

It does nothing.

“Please.” Nella’s voice is getting weaker. “I don’t want to die. I wanted to fly again. I was gonna go home and show my brother I was okay.”

I hear footsteps and spin around.

Theo the mender is in the doorway. His face goes white when he sees her wing.

“You have to cut it off.” His voice is urgent. “Now, before it reaches her heart.”

“I need to give her a sedative. Something for the pain. I can’t—”

“There’s no time.” He shoves something into my hands.

The bone saw. Heavy and cold. The teeth are sharp and clean.

Nella sees it and becomes distraught.

She cries harder, “Please no, not my wing. I’ll do anything. Please don’t take it. Maelis, please. Please don’t let them.”

She’s begging me.

Theo says, “She dies if you don’t cut right now.”

I lift the saw.

My hands won’t stop shaking.

I move to the base of her wing where it connects to her back. The corruption hasn’t reached there yet.

I press the blade to her skin.

Nella screams, “Please I don’t want to lose it. I’d rather die. I’d rather die than never fly again.”

Don’t say that. Please don’t say that. I have to cut.

My father’s face appears in front of me.

His body on the bed. The gray of his skin and my shaking hand.

My arm locks up. All I need to do is cut to save her.

“I can’t,” I moan. “I can’t do it.”

“Maelis!” Theo shakes my shoulder. “She’s dying! Cut!”

I lift the saw again and press it to her wing. My hand shakes so badly the blade skips and cuts a thin red line across her skin.

Nella screams.

I can’t.

“Get someone else,” I say. “Get a healer. Find my blood lead. Get anyone. Now.”

“There’s no—”

“NOW!”

He stares at me for one second. I see the disgust in his eyes before he turns and runs.

The saw falls out of my hands. It clangs against the floor.

Nella stops screaming.

I grab her hand. “Nella, stay with me. Help is coming.”

I cup her face with my other hand, and her eyes find mine. The pain is fading out of them. Something else taking over. Something soft and far away.

“It doesn’t hurt anymore.” Her voice is barely there. “That’s bad, isn’t it?”

“No, that means it’s getting better. You’re gonna be okay.”

“You’re a bad liar.” She almost smiles. “It’s okay. I know.”

“Nella—”

“I’m not mad at you.” Her fingers twitch against mine. “I know you tried.”

“I’m gonna save you. Hold on.”

“Tell my brother something for me? Tell him it wasn’t his fault. The riftling, none of it. Tell him I never blamed him.” Her eyes are drifting. Losing focus. “Tell him I love him.”

“You can tell him yourself. You’re going to be fine. Stay with me and keep talking to me.”

“You promised I’d fly again.” She looks at me and there’s no anger in her eyes. “It’s okay. Some promises can’t be kept.”

“Nella—”

Her voice diminishes with each word. “I dreamed about flying one more time over the Obsidian Falls. The water looked like liquid night. It was so beautiful.”

“Nella stay with me, please.”

Her eyes close. “I think I’ll fly there now.”

Her hand goes slack in mine.

I feel the exact second she leaves. One moment she’s here, and the next she’s...gone.

“No.”

I shake her.

“No, Nella, wake up.”

I press my ear to her chest. Nothing.

“NELLA!”

I slam my fists against her sternum the way my dad taught me.

Nothing. I start doing chest compressions. I can’t lose her, not like this.

The corruption stopped spreading. It doesn’t need to anymore. It won.

I hear footsteps behind me. Someone grabs my shoulders and yanks me back.

“She’s gone.” A voice I don’t know. “The necrosis reached her heart.”

Gone.

The healer pushes past me and picks up the bone saw. She presses it to Nella’s wing and starts cutting.

I hear metal on bone and flesh, grinding that I’m going to hear forever.

Nella’s body jerks with each stroke, but she doesn’t feel it. She’s not in there anymore.

I back away until my spine hits the wall.

The healer keeps cutting. It’s protocol to remove the dead tissue.

About to throw up, I turn and walk out.

The corridor is empty. The lamps flicker. Everything feels far away like I’m watching myself from somewhere outside my body.

She’s dead.

I promised her. I looked her in the eyes and told her she’d fly again, and she believed me.

And I let her die.

No, I killed her.

The saw was in my hand. All I had to do was cut, but I couldn’t.

I froze.

She died because I’m broken. Because I killed my father, and something in me died with him.

The tears come. I don’t try to stop them.

I don’t know where I’m walking. I need to be anywhere else, somewhere I can’t hear that sound. Somewhere I can’t see her face.

I round a corner and shove through the door to one of the empty exam rooms.

I slam into something solid.

Hands catch my arms, steadying me.

I look up through the blur of tears.

It’s Malric.

His amber eyes move over my face, taking in my tears and the blood on my hands. Her blood. Something shifts in his expression, but he doesn’t say anything.

He pulls me into him.

His hand cradles the back of my head, and I cry into his chest—ugly, full bodied sobs that wrack through me like something is trying to claw its way out. My whole body is shaking. I can’t stop it. I can’t control any of this.

I would do anything, give anything, be anything to make this crushing weight disappear for one second.

Malric’s hand runs down the back of my head. Slow. Almost gentle.

But he’s here, and I’m breaking and don’t have the strength to care about anything else.

“Patients die, Red.” His hand keeps moving through my hair. “It’s not your fault. It’s what happens here.”

I shake my head against his chest. He doesn’t understand. It is my fault. The saw was in my hand.

“I can make the pain stop,” he whispers.

I should say no. I should push him away and walk out and find Jace and let him hold me instead. That’s what I should do.

But Jace will ask what happened. He will want to talk. He will look at me with those soft blue eyes, and I’ll have to explain that I let a fourteen year old girl die because I’m too broken to do my job.

Malric won’t ask. He doesn’t care about the details. He is offering me a different kind of pain, and right now that’s the only thing I want.

I want to hurt somewhere that isn’t my chest. I want a pain I can locate. A pain with edges, one I can press a hand against and feel start to fade. Anything but this.

“The bite,” I whisper. “Just the bite. Nothing else.”

He goes still. For a half second I see something flicker behind his amber eyes, calculation maybe, disappointment, I don’t know. Then it’s gone, and that lazy smile pulls at the corner of his mouth.

“Whatever you need, Red.”

He doesn’t ask if I’m sure. His hand slides from my hair to my jaw, tilting my face up, and I look anywhere but at him. His mouth comes down

toward mine, and I turn my head before it can land. His lips graze the corner of my jaw instead, and he huffs a quiet laugh against my skin.

“Have it your way.”

His hands find my waist, and he lifts me onto the exam table. The metal is cold through my clothes. He pushes my hair off my shoulder, and his fingers are not gentle.

I close my eyes.

This isn’t about wanting him. I do not want him. I want the part of myself that has been screaming since Nella died to be quiet for one second. Malric is the door I am willing to walk through to find that silence. That is all he is.

His mouth finds the curve of my neck. I feel his tongue first, then the sharp press of fangs.

The bite is a bright flare of pain, sharp and sudden and so intense my vision whites out. Then a strange tugging warmth as he drinks from me. My fingers go numb. My ears fill with a rushing sound, and the grief, the guilt, the image of Nella’s eyes going empty, all of it blurs at the edges. I cannot think. I can only feel my body emptying.

It’s exactly what I came for.

My fingers go cold. He’s taking too much. Some distant part of my brain knows that. But I don’t tell him to stop. I want to keep disappearing.

His mouth pulls away from my neck with a wet sound. The cold air hits the puncture wounds, and I gasp.

When I open my eyes, his lips are stained red. My blood. He’s looking at me differently now.

“You taste—” He frowns. “Huh.”

I don’t know what that means. I don’t care.

Before I can sit up, his hands slide down my hips, gripping. His mouth finds my throat again, and this time he isn’t biting. He’s kissing. His teeth drag along the wet smear of blood at my collarbone, and his hand pushes my shirt off my shoulder.

“Now for the part where you thank me properly, Red.”

The fog clears.

I see what’s happening. I see what I almost let happen. His hand on my hip. His mouth on my throat. The way he is leaning his weight into me to press me back against the table. I shove against his chest, and when he doesn’t move, I shove harder.

“Get off me.”

“Don’t be like that.” His mouth doesn’t leave my neck. “You asked for this.”

“I asked for the bite. That’s all.”

“Red—”

I shove him with everything I have. He stumbles back a step, more from surprise than force, and I drop down off the table on shaking legs. My hand goes up to my throat. It comes away wet.

“I said the bite. Nothing else.”

He wipes his mouth with the back of his hand. The smile is still there, but the edges have gone hard and I notice he managed to untie the front of his pants.

“You don’t get to invite me in and change your mind.”

“I didn’t invite you to anything else.”

He lets out a slow breath, eyes raking down my body once, then up. “Suit yourself. You’re welcome, by the way.”

He starts to turn away, and that’s when I hear it.

The door.

“Mae?”

My blood turns to ice. It’s Jace.

I spin so fast my vision blurs. He’s standing in the doorway, his blue eyes already on me, already on the blood at my neck, the smear of it on my collarbone, my shirt pulled half off my shoulder. Then his gaze flicks to Malric, who is standing too close to me, his lips still stained with my blood, his shirt rumpled where I shoved at it….and is fucking pants are untied.

Jace doesn’t move.

“Jace.” My voice cracks. “Jace, it’s not—”

“Don’t.”

“He just bit me. That’s all. I swear to gods, that’s all—”

Malric makes a low sound that might be a laugh.

“Sure it is, Red.”

Jace’s eyes snap to him.

Malric shrugs. “She was a mess, angel. I helped. Nothing she didn’t ask for.”

“Malric, shut up—”

“You’re disgusting.” It’s the closest I’ve ever heard Jace come to a yell, but it’s quiet. Too quiet. “Both of you.”

“Jace, please.” I take a step toward him. “He’s lying. He only bit me. Nothing else happened. I stopped him.”

“I’m sure that’s what you’d say.”

“Because it’s true.”

He looks at me for one more second. I watch something die in his eyes. The softness, the trust. The way he’s always looked at me like I was something precious.

“You let him touch you, Mae.” His voice is flat. “I don’t need the rest of the details.”

He turns and walks away.

“Jace!” I scramble after him, my legs barely holding me, blood still wet down my neck. “Jace, wait—”

But he’s already gone. His footsteps echo down the corridor, and then there’s nothing.

Silence.

Behind me, Malric whistles low under his breath.

“That went badly.”

I turn on him, fists clenched. “Why did you say that? You know nothing happened.”

“I know.” His smile is slow and pleased. “But you let him think it did, didn’t you? You stood there looking guilty. I just helped him understand what he was already seeing.”

“You’re a monster.”

“And you’re the one who came to a monster looking for relief, Red. Don’t act surprised by what you found.”

He pushes past me and out the door, leaving me alone in the room.

I don’t remember sliding down the wall. I don’t remember the lamp going out. I don’t remember how long I sit there in the dark with my knees pulled to my chest and the puncture wounds in my neck slowly clotting and the sound of Jace’s footsteps replaying in my head.

I didn’t fuck Malric.

It doesn’t matter. Jace doesn’t believe me. And the worst part is, I can’t even blame him, because I did let Malric put his mouth on me. I did let a man I despise drink from my throat because I couldn’t bear my own grief for one more second.

I’m not innocent. I am only less guilty than he thinks.

Poppy finds me.

She squeezes through the crack in the door, chirps once, and scrambles across the cold stone. She climbs into my lap and presses her small body against my chest like she’s trying to hold me together.

I wrap my arms around her and bury my face in her fur.

She is the only thing I haven’t destroyed yet.

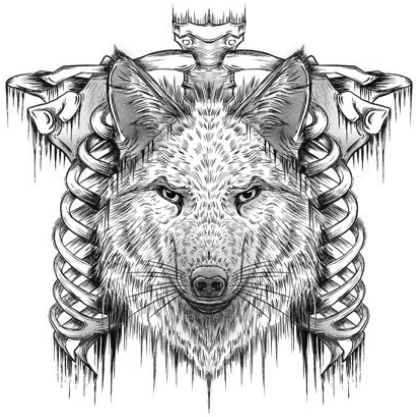
We sit there in the dark. Her heartbeat against mine. Her warmth, the only thing keeping me from disappearing completely.

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Chapter Twenty-One

"The students who survive are not the ones who feel nothing. They are the ones who feel everything and keep walking anyway."

— Veilguard Memoir, Unsigned



I can't go back to my room.

If I go back there, I'll have to think. I'll have to feel. I can't believe I let Malric put his mouth on me. I can't believe how close I came to letting it go further. Jace walked in and saw exactly what Malric wanted him to see, and I don't know if he'll believe me when I tell him I stopped it. It doesn't matter.

My feet carry me down instead of up.

Past the fifth floor. Past the fourth. Down and down and down until I reach the basement level where the descent party happened, where the blood and breath year students keep their bar. It's not official or anything, a forgotten room that someone cleared out years ago, furnished with stolen chairs and a collection of bottles that grows every semester.

It's empty when I get there, because it's the middle of the night and everyone else is asleep or studying or living lives that haven't fallen apart.

I don't bother with a glass. I grab the first bottle I see and drink straight from it. The burn hits my throat and spreads through my chest. It's not nearly enough to take away my pain and disgust with myself.

I drink more.

I sit on the cold stone floor with my back against the wall, and I drink until my hands stop shaking, until the image of Nella's eyes going empty starts to blur. Until I can't feel Malric's hands on my skin anymore. Can't see the look on Jace's face.

The bottle is half empty when I hear footsteps.

I don't look up and don't care.

The footsteps stop.

"Of all the places to find you."

That voice. Cold and sharp and familiar, I hate that I know it without looking.

I lift my head.

Draven stands in the doorway, arms crossed, golden eyes scrutinizing me. The bottle in my hand. My tangled hair. The blood still crusted on my collar.

"Go away." My voice comes out slurred. Good. That means it's working.

"No."

"I said go away, Alucard."

"And I said no." He crosses the room and crouches in front of me, close enough that I can count the flecks of gold in his eyes. "How much have you had?"

"Not enough."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only one you're getting."

He takes the bottle from my hand. Fighting him would require me to care, and I've decided I'm done with caring tonight. His eyes move over my face. Then lower.

He goes completely still.

I forgot to cover the bite.

Draven's eyes are fixed on my throat and his brows furrow.

"Who?" It sounds like he's holding something back by a thread.

"Does it matter?"

His hand shoots out and catches my chin and tilts my head to the side, exposing the wound. His fingers are cold against my jaw. I should shove him off, but I don't have the energy.

He stares at the bite. Two puncture wounds ringed in bruises by now. His thumb drifts along the edge of it, feather-light.

“Who, Rose?”

“Malric.”

His hand drops from my face like I’ve scalded him. He stands abruptly, turns away, and I watch his shoulders lock. His hands are shaking at his sides, trembling with the effort of not driving his fist through the stone.

I must be drunker than I thought, because Draven Alucard does not come undone. Draven does not get emotional for *me*.

“Draven—”

“Did he force you?” He still won’t look at me.

“No.”

“Don’t lie to me.”

“I’m not lying.” My voice cracks straight down the middle. “I asked for it. The bite. Nothing else. I needed to feel anything other than what I was feeling, and he was there. That’s the truth of it.”

When he turns back, his face is carved from stone. But his eyes look like they’re burning.

No, I’m drunk. I’m inventing things.

“Of all the people in this school, you let Malric touch you.”

Cruelty is a language I speak fluently tonight.

“I let him bite me. Right after I let Nella die. What a night.” I want him to hate me. I want everyone to hate me because I hate myself right now.

A muscle ticks in his jaw.

“Did he drink from you?”

“That’s generally what the bite mark implies.”

“How much.”

“I don’t know. A lot. I didn’t time him.”

“Did he do anything else.”

“He tried.”

Draven goes very still.

“I stopped him.”

“Tell me you stopped him.”

“I stopped him, Draven.”

Whatever was rising in him goes back down by a few degrees. He exhales.

“Good. You could have died if he’d taken too much.”

“Would that have been so bad?”

He winces, hurt, then the stone slides back into place.

He crouches in front of me again, and one arm slides under my knees, the other behind my back, and he’s lifting me against his chest like I weigh nothing at all.

“Put me down.”

“No.”

“I can walk.”

“You can barely sit. Try again.”

“I hate you.”

“Noted. Shut up.”

My head falls against his shoulder without my permission, and gods he’s warm. How is he warm? Everything about him reads like frost. His hands in the practice hall are always cold. His voice is always cold. But here with my cheek pressed to the hollow of his throat, he burns like a forge.

I can feel his heart through his shirt. It’s going too fast.

He’s not as calm as he’s pretending to be.

“You’re mad at me,” I mumble.

“Yes.”

“Because I let Malric bite me?”

His arms tighten.

“Because you let a predator put his teeth on your throat when you were in pieces. You could have come to… Because you made a stupid choice, and now I’m the one walking you back to your room at three in the morning. Lucky me.”

“You don’t have to. You don’t owe me anything.”

“I know. That’s the problem.”

I don’t know what that means. I’m too drunk to figure it out, and he doesn’t offer to translate.

The walk is a blur. Stairs. Corridors. The torches in the halls, guttering low. I turn my face into his neck without thinking and breathe him in. Winter air. Crushed pine. Something that might be leather.

“You smell good,” I mumble into his collar.

“Go to sleep, Rose.”

“I’m being carried. That’s not sleeping.”

“It’s close enough. Stop talking.”

“Make me.”

I feel his breath against my hair and realize how gently he’s holding me.

I don’t have a smile in me tonight, but things feel a little less badly than they did before.

“Nella’s dead,” I whisper.

“I know.”

“I killed her.”

“No, the necrosis killed her.”

“I could have—”

“You couldn’t have.” His voice isn’t harsh, but it isn’t gentle either. “I spoke to Theo. I spoke to the healer who came in after. The corruption was at her heart before you made it into the room, Rose. There was no cut you could have made that would have saved her. The alert went out too late.”

“You don’t know that.”

“I do.”

I don’t believe him, but something in my chest loosens by a thread.

We reach my door. He shoulders it open and carries me inside, and for a moment I brace for some mockery, some final barb. *Sleep it off, Rose, and try to do less damage tomorrow.* But he doesn’t say anything like that.

He lays me on the bed and pulls the blanket up over me. His hands linger, and then he steps back.

He crosses the room, pours water from the pitcher, and sets the glass on the bedside table with a soft click.

“Drink it before you sleep. You’ll thank me tomorrow.”

“Why are you being nice to me?”

“I’m not. I’m keeping you from choking on your own vomit.”

“That still counts.”

“It’s the bare minimum for not being a monster. Don’t get sentimental.”

He stands there a moment longer, looking down at me, then reaches into his jacket and pulls something out.

A small leather journal. Worn at the corners. “Nella” is etched into the cover in faded gold.

My breath stops.

“What—”

“They were boxing her things and sending everything to her family.” He sets the journal on the bed beside my hand, not quite touching me. “I didn’t think she’d want them to have this one.”

Nella’s journal. Her fears. Her dreams of flying again. Every small, ugly, honest thing she never said out loud, now here because Draven walked into a dead girl’s room and took it before someone else could.

For me.

I pick it up, and my hands are shaking and the tears come before I can stop them.

“Why?” I gasp. “Why would you do this?”

He doesn’t answer, watching me cry.

“Draven.”

“Get some sleep.”

“Thank you.”

He stops. His hand grips the door frame. I can see the tension in his back, the war he’s fighting with himself.

“Don’t thank me.” He doesn’t turn around. “And don’t mistake this for something it isn’t.”

“What is it then?”

“You lost a patient. That happens here. But what you did after…” He turns enough for me to see his profile. The hard line of his jaw. The muscle jumping in his cheek. His hair, half tied up in a bun. “The drinking. Malric, destroying whatever you had with that boy who actually loved you.”

I flinch at the past tense.

“That’s not grief, Rose. That’s self destruction, and I’ve seen where that road ends.”

“Maybe I don’t care where it ends.”

“You should.” He faces me fully now. His amber eyes are blazing, but his voice stays steady. “Nella is dead. That won’t change. Drowning yourself in alcohol and letting Malric use you won’t bring her back. Won’t fix what you broke.”

“You think I don’t know that?”

“I think you knew it and did it anyway. That’s what worries me. Tomorrow, get up, go to class, and keep moving. The world doesn’t stop turning just because you’re in pain. And neither do you.”

“What if I can’t?”

He looks at me, and something passes between us. Recognition maybe. The kind that only comes from knowing the same kind of darkness.

“You can.” He rubs at his forehead. “I know you’re better than what I saw tonight, so prove it.”

“How do you know what I’m capable of? You don’t even know me.”

“I know enough.” He finally opens the door. “And Rose?”

“What?”

“If Malric touches you again, I’ll kill him.”

He says it like a promise. Then he’s gone.

I lie in the dark, Nella’s journal clutched to my chest, his voice echoing in my mind.

He meant it.

I don’t care if he does kill him.

I have no feelings for Malric other than disgust. I was saving myself for Jace or someone special, for when I knew it was serious. And I almost gave that up to a man I despise because I couldn’t bear the sound of my own grief.

I should have brought the damn bottle of liquor with me, but I wasn’t thinking straight. Not with Draven showing up like that. Why is he always showing up late at night when no one else is around?

I sit up and reach for the journal. My head spins a bit as I blink back tears and wipe my face. Poppy appears and pushes my arm up until she can snuggle underneath it and stare at the journal with me like she wants to read it too.

I open it.

Nella’s handwriting is messy and uneven, like she was always writing in a hurry. I have to blink several more times to focus enough to read. I think it’s a mix of the poor penmanship and the booze.

The first several entries are from when she arrived. Complaints about the food and the menders who treated her like a child. How much she missed her brother. How scared she was but wouldn’t admit it out loud.

I flip forward past the early days until I see my name.

My breath catches.

Maelis came by after her shift today, and I was having a bad night. I couldn’t stop shaking from the pain, and she climbed onto the bed next to me and started reading out loud from that ridiculous romance novel Draven brought me about a vampire and a shifter.

Draven brought her books? I knew she had other books that I didn’t bring her but I never thought Draven visited her too?

I keep reading.

She did voices for all the characters, even the terrible ones, and I laughed so hard I forgot about my wing for a while. But the strange thing was the whole time she was there pressed against my side reading, the pain wasn't that bad. I think it actually dulled, like something warm was spreading from her. I didn't tell her because she would have said I was imagining things, but I don't think so. I've been in this bed for weeks, and nothing has made the pain ease like that. Not the tonics or treatments. Just her. I don't know what that means, but I think there might be something more to Maelis. I wonder if she's hiding it or maybe doesn't realize it at all.

My tears start to fall, and I close the journal, tucking it under my pillow.

I want to tell her she's wrong. That there's nothing special about me. I want to tell her that I didn't ease her pain. I couldn't save her even when it mattered.

But she's not here to argue with me anymore.

She's never going to be here again.

Poppy burrows closer. She's the only thing that feels real right now.

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Chapter Twenty-Two

"Angels were not made to feel the way we do. When the pain becomes too much, they have a choice we don't. They can simply turn it off."

— Professor Clementine, Endurance of Pain



Three days pass, and I'm still breathing.

It seems the dead don't haunt you. They sit beside you, quiet, waiting to see what you do with the time they didn't get.

I do what Draven told me to do, going to class and muddling through the usual routine. I don't look at Jace when I pass him in the corridors, and he doesn't look at me either. We've become experts at being in the same room without ever occupying the same space.

At night, I read Nella's journal a couple pages at a time, because that's all I can handle before the tears come and I have to stop. Poppy curls against my chest, and we fall asleep with the journal tucked under my pillow.

By the time Professor Rowan's class rolls around on the fourth day, I've perfected the art of being numb. I sit in the back row where no one will notice me. I take notes without processing anything. I exist without really being present.

It's easier that way.

“Today, we’re continuing our lecture on wounds you will encounter in the field and how to help them quickly when time matters,” she announces, her eyes sweeping the lecture hall. She’s a thin woman with silver hair pulled back so tight it looks painful. “When you’re deployed to a fissure site and the wounded start piling up, you won’t have the luxury of careful consideration. You’ll have minutes, sometimes seconds. Hesitation will kill more patients than incompetence ever will.”

I grip my pen tighter.

“Let’s start with wound sealing.” She holds up a small pouch filled with black powder. “Ash powder is made from burned ironwood mixed with crusite mineral. When you don’t have time for stitches, you pack the wound with this and touch a spark of current to ignite it.”

She demonstrates on a slab of meat on the table in front of her. The powder catches fire with a hiss, burning fast and hot, leaving the flesh cauterized and sealed.

“It’s brutal,” she continues. “The patient will scream. You have to keep going anyway. Ugly scars are better than death.”

This is what I signed up for. Death is everywhere at Ashwell. In the wards, in the lectures, in the way the professors talk about loss like it’s just another lesson to learn. People die here. Students die here. And if I make it through, if I become a Veilguard, I’ll spend the rest of my life watching people die and trying to stop it.

I wanted to make a difference, to be the person who stood between someone and the end, but no one tells you what it costs. No one tells you that every patient takes a piece of you with them, whether they live or not.

I can’t keep getting attached and caring so much. It’s going to destroy me.

But if I stop caring, what’s the point? What kind of healer saves lives without giving a damn about the people attached to them? Apparently the headmaster.

I don’t know how to find the balance. I don’t know if there is one.

Maybe that’s the real lesson Ashwell is trying to teach me. Not how to heal but how to survive the healing.

“Corrupted wounds are different.” Professor Rowan sets the pouch down. “Ash powder won’t work. The disease fights back, resists the seal, keeps spreading. You have to cut away the dead tissue first, down to clean flesh. If the corruption has reached the bloodstream, ash powder is useless.

Your only options at that point are amputation or letting them die. A bone saw is priceless in the field. Any Veilguard will tell you that."

My chest tightens.

"There are rumors of old techniques that could purify decay from within. Burn it out of the blood itself." She exhales. "But that knowledge died with the older blood mages, so we work with what we have."

A few students laugh nervously. Shouldn't the headmaster have this kind of knowledge?

"Now let's talk about twisted creature bites." She pulls out a jar filled with something I don't want to identify. "Glasswings and goreleeches are the smallest twisted creatures we've identified, and their bites inject a venom that slows healing. You flush the wound with saline and pack it with ash powder."

I remember Professor Nestor describing glasswings in our second week, insectoid predators with translucent wings like fractured crystals. Their bodies refract light and current, making them nearly impossible to target. And when you do manage to kill one, they shatter explosively, sending shards in every direction. Half the injuries from a glasswing encounter aren't from the creature itself but from standing too close when it dies. The tiny shards can penetrate the skin, even the eyes, and be just as bad if not worse than a bite.

Goreleeches are slug-like things that attach to open wounds and feed on blood and current simultaneously. They look like debris, like a clot or a piece of torn fabric, until you realize the wound is draining faster than it should. Professor Nestor said Veilguards are trained to check for them first in triage, because every second one stays attached is more blood and current lost.

"And crawler bites," Professor Rowan continues, "their saliva carries corruption directly. A crawler bite that breaks the skin needs immediate amputation, or the necrosis will spread within hours, and the infection can make the victim themselves start to exhibit crawler tendencies."

Hours between a bite and losing a limb. Hours between a wound and death.

This is what's waiting for us out there, and we're supposed to heal through all of it.

Professor Rowan picks up a bone saw from her table. The same kind I held. The same kind I froze with. "Sometimes amputation is the only way to

save a life. Cut above the corruption, never through it. Tourniquet first, this is where you can use your serpent eidolons. They make excellent tourniquets and can smell the decay even under the flesh. Then you saw, second and cauterize third."

She looks out at us with cold eyes, and I want to know what kind of battles this lady has seen.

"A healer who cannot amputate will watch patients die. It's that simple. If you can't stomach it, if you can't make that cut when it matters, you don't belong in the field. You'll cost lives, including your own."

I don't know if she's saying it intentionally to me or not. I sit there with my hands shaking in my lap, trying not to fall apart in front of everyone.

Class ends, and students file out around me.

I see Jace near the front of the room, gathering his things. He hasn't looked at me once during the entire lecture. Hasn't looked at me in days.

I can't keep pretending we're strangers when a week ago he was telling me he loved me.

I push through the crowd and catch him in the corridor outside. My hand closes around his arm before I can talk myself out of it.

"Jace, please, can we talk?"

He turns and looks through me like I'm not even there.

"There's nothing to talk about."

"There's everything to talk about." I don't let go of his arm. "What happened with Malric—"

"I know what happened." His voice is flat, empty. No anger, no hurt, nothing. "Malric was very detailed."

My stomach drops. Malric told him a bunch of exaggerated lies I'm sure.

"Jace, I was in a bad place. Nella had died, and I wasn't thinking—"

"You weren't thinking about me." There's something amiss with his eyes. The light blue that used to be so warm has gone cold, like ice over a frozen lake. "That's clear."

"It wasn't about you. It wasn't about anyone. I needed—"

"To feel something?" He scoffed. "Did it work?"

I can't answer that.

"I would have been there for you, Maelis," he says. "I would have caught you. All you had to do was fall toward me, not away."

He looked at me like I was precious once. I'm the one who taught him I wasn't. "I know, and I'm sorry—"

He holds up a hand. "I don't want your apology."

"Then what do you want?"

"I want to stop seeing his marks on your neck every time I close my eyes." He's not trying to hurt me. That's what makes it unbearable. "I want to look at you and not feel sick, but I can't have any of that. So I'll settle for nothing. I want nothing from you."

He pulls his arm free of my grip and walks away.

I stand there in the corridor watching him go. That wasn't Jace, the boy who held my hand and made me laugh and told me he loved me while together in his bed.

Over ten years of friendship cannot be over because of one horrible decision I made in a time of despair. Can it?



The rest of my classes are a blur, and I let out a sigh of relief when I finally make it back to my room.

Nella's journal is still under my pillow. I pull it out and flip through the pages, looking for something to make me feel less alone.

I find an entry I haven't read yet.

Draven asked about Maelis today. Tried to be casual about it, like he didn't care. But his eyes gave him away. He wanted to know if she'd said anything about her father. I told him no. He looked relieved and disappointed at the same time. What does her father have to do with anything?

He's asked me not to tell Maelis that he visits, saying he'll get in trouble since I'm not his patient. I don't know if that's the real reason. There's something there he won't say, but I'll keep his secret. It's not my business.

His wolf was here again last night. Draven left hours ago, but the wolf stayed, curled up by the door like he was guarding me. I wasn't scared. I should have been, probably. I think the wolf knows I'm dying. I think he's keeping me company until I do.

My chest aches.

Why was Draven visiting Nella so often? Why did he have his wolf stay with her through the night? He comes off as such a cold-hearted bastard, but maybe there's something softer hidden beneath that icy exterior. Why did he help me the other night? Maybe he feels sorry for the weak little human who can't seem to keep herself together.

I close the journal and walk over to my desk. I should stay up late tonight and get through all my assigned reading. Midterms are coming, and I'm in no state of mind to be ready. At this rate, I'm going to fail out of Ashwell, and honestly I'm starting to think maybe that wouldn't be such a bad thing.

A knock at my door makes me jump.

It swings open before I can respond, and Lux is standing there in a light-pink sweater practically the same color as her hair, paired with fitted black pants. Her arms are crossed. Ellavee is behind her, leaning against the doorframe in black tights, a short skirt, and a deep purple sweater that contrasts her light-blonde hair. Neither of them is wearing their school uniform.

"You're coming out with us tonight."

"I'm not really in the mood for that."

"I don't care." Lux walks over to my wardrobe and starts rifling through it. "You've been a ghost all week. Understandable, but you need to snap out of it." She throws a sage-green sweater at me along with a black knitted beanie. "Put these on. We're going to the village, getting drinks, and having a good time. You're coming."

"Lux—"

"She's not asking." Ellavee pushes off the doorframe and settles onto my bed. Poppy immediately abandons me to climb into her lap. Traitor. "It'll be fun, and it'll get your mind off things."

"Fun." The word feels foreign in my mouth right now.

"Yes, fun, that thing you used to have before you turned into a walking corpse." Lux waves at me impatiently. "Go get dressed."

I want to tell them I'm fine here in my room with Nella's journal and my textbooks and my endless loop of questions and guilt, but they're looking at me like they won't take no for an answer. And maybe I'm tired of being alone with my own thoughts. Getting out of my head for one night would be good for me.

“Fine.” I pull on the sweater and tug my boots on over my thick black leggings. I glance in the mirror and run a quick brush through my hair before pulling on the black knit beanie and grabbing my cloak. “But I’m not promising to have fun.”

Fifteen minutes later, we’re beneath the school, walking through a damp, dark stone tunnel.

“Remind me why we’re taking a creepy tunnel to get to town instead of a carriage?” I ask as Primm brushes past us, her white fur practically glowing in the dim light. Primm is Lux’s eidolon, a beautiful wolf with fur like fresh snow and striking violet eyes. She named her Primm because she thought Primm and Poppy sounded cute together after she met Pops, and I have to admit it does have a nice ring to it. The two of them get along well enough, unlike Poppy and Flick. Poppy couldn’t stand Jace’s bat eidolon. Maybe she knew something I didn’t. Maybe she saw all of this coming before I did.

“I didn’t much feel like getting eaten by a polar bear tonight.” Ellavee smirks.

“Polar bears?”

“Corrupted ones mostly. Small fissures open across the Frostlands from time to time, and twisted things come through.” Lux throws her hand out, and a glowing white orb materializes above us, floating along as we walk and casting soft light across the stone walls. I think it’s the first time I’ve seen her use current. “The normal polar bears are cute but just as vicious as the twisted ones. The village hires wolf shifters to patrol the perimeter around the clock to keep them out.”

“We could walk to the village from the school,” Ellavee adds, pulling off her jacket and throwing it over her arm. It is surprisingly warm down here. “But why risk getting mauled when we have access to a perfectly good tunnel?”

It’s not as claustrophobic as I thought it would be when they mentioned a tunnel beneath the school. The tunnel is wide enough for four people to walk side by side comfortably, and the ceilings are at least twelve feet high, carved from solid stone that glistens with moisture in the orb’s glow.

“Couldn’t you transport us there?” I glance over at Lux. “The fae who brought me to Ashwell did something like that.”

“That’s called current threading, or threading for short.” She tucks a strand of pink hair behind her pointed ear. “Only older, more powerful fae

can do it. I’m not nearly strong enough yet.”

“Why do you think the school has walls that high? Is it for the polar bears?” I ask.

Lux glances over at me. “For the polar bears and other things.”

“And maybe to keep things in too,” Ellavee says quietly.

No one elaborates. I don’t ask them to.



Whitehaven is smaller than I expected. Dare I say even smaller than Ironfen. Maybe a hundred buildings span the village, all stone and timber built to withstand the brutal cold. Smoke plumes from nearly every chimney, fireplaces being a necessity rather than a luxury this far north. The roads are slippery as hell, covered in a thick layer of compacted snow and ice that crunches beneath our boots. Even with the grip of my soles, I nearly slip twice, so the three of us link arms as we make our way past the buildings.

It’s early evening, but only a handful of people move through the streets, bundled in furs and heavy cloaks, their breath fogging in the frigid air.

On the ridge to one side of the village I can see the wolf shifters. Some in wolf form, massive and gray, pacing along the tree line with an alertness that makes me grateful they’re on our team. One side of the village borders a dense forest, dark pines dusted with snow. The other side opens up to endless stretches of flat, snow-covered ground that bleeds into ice-covered water that extends as far as I can see.

“The Frozen Hearth.” Lux points to a building in the distance with smoke billowing from its chimney and laughter spilling out every time someone opens the door. “Best tavern in the Frostlands.” She beams at us like she’s showing off a prized possession.

“I think she means the only tavern in the Frostlands,” Ellavee adds dryly, and I actually laugh. It feels strange in my throat, like a muscle I haven’t used in too long.

“Whatever, first round’s on me.” Lux releases my arm and skips ahead to pull the door open.

The warmth hits me the moment we step inside. A fire crackles in a massive white stone hearth at the center of the room, flames dancing and casting flickering shadows across the worn wooden floor. The smell of spiced wine and roasting meat fills the air, rich and inviting. Bodies are packed together at tables and along the bar, talking and drinking and living their lives like the world isn't constantly teetering on the edge of destruction.

I'd almost forgotten what that feels like. In the months I've been at Ashwell, surrounded by constant reminders of death and the looming threat of the next cycle, I'd forgotten that some people still know how to exist without the weight of it all pressing down on them.

Lux leads us to a table near the back, and she and Ellavee smile and wave at half the people we pass. They're both different here, they seem looser and happier even. Ellavee doesn't seem as guarded, and her smiles look genuine instead of that usual aloof smirk. Lux's shoulders aren't pulled back with the tension of being Professor Bales' daughter. Out here, they're simply two girls who grew up in this village, not students carrying the weight of expectations and bloodlines.

A waiter appears at our table. An older gentleman with shaggy brown hair streaked with gray and a friendly, weathered face. He starts to take our order and then stops.

He's staring at me.

I shift uncomfortably and glance across the table at Ellavee, who shrugs.

"Sorry." He shakes his head like he's clearing cobwebs from it. "You look like the spitting image of someone who used to come in here many years ago."

"Who might that be, Mr. Holloway?" Lux asks, her lips quirking up on one side like she's expecting some kind of scandalous gossip.

He blushes. "Oh no, not like that," he laughs, looking from Lux back to me. "She worked out here for a year or so studying the corrupted polar bears. Her name was Helena."

That catches my attention.

"Do you know what her last name was?" I blurt out.

He closes one eye and cocks his head to the side, thinking. "I believe it was Raven. Yes, that's right. I used to joke that she should be studying the ravens instead of the polar bears." He chuckles at the memory. "Helena Raven."

I can’t breathe.

I look down at my hands, gripping the edge of the table, trying to wrap my mind around what he said while Lux orders drinks for all of us. The noise of the tavern fades to a dull roar in my ears.

“Well, that was strange.” Ellavee’s voice cuts through the fog. “Maelis? You look like you’ve seen a ghost. What’s the big deal?”

I cringe. There’s no other way to say it but to just say it.

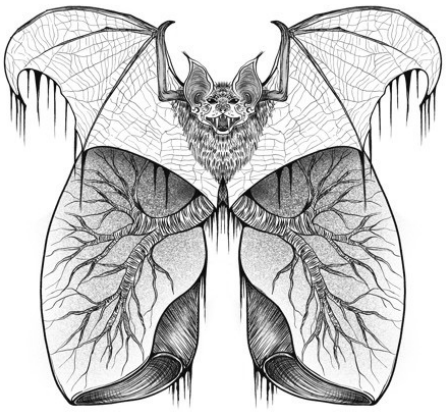
“Helena Raven is my mother.”

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Chapter Twenty-Three

"The lies our parents tell us are the hardest to forgive. They shape who we become before we ever learn the truth."

— Headmaster Ashmoor, Private Notes



"Raven is my mother's maiden name," I add, filling the silence at their awestruck stares.

Their eyes widen.

"I mean, it has to be her, right?" I say, and I'm not sure if I'm asking them or trying to convince myself. "I doubt there are any other Helena Ravens with red hair wandering around the Frostlands studying polar bears."

"This whole time you've been looking for a record of your father at Ashwell," Lux says slowly, the pieces clicking together in her mind. "But maybe it was your mother who went here."

I nod, but my thoughts are spinning too fast to grab onto any single one.

Why would she keep this a secret? Even if she didn't attend Ashwell, she clearly knew about it. She was here in the Frostlands studying corrupted creatures for at least a year. What the hell was she doing that for?

My mother never spoke much about her life before she married my father. I couldn't imagine her traveling across Valen, let alone spending a year in one of the most dangerous and remote places on the continent.

And all I can feel right now is how furious I am. She never told me any of this.

Mr. Holloway returns with three tall glasses of ice-cold ale and three shots of amber whiskey. We down the shots quickly, the burn sliding down my throat, and chase them with the ale. My body heats from the inside out as the alcohol settles into my bloodstream.

“I need to go back to the library,” I say more to myself than to them. I stare off into the distance, trying to piece together what any of this could mean.

“You’re thinking too loud.” Ellavee’s voice pulls me back. “I can hear it from here.”

“Sorry.” I laugh through my nose, but there’s no humor in it.

“Maybe instead of going to the library again you should ask the school,” Lux says. “The school should know everything about you. It would definitely have records of whether your parents attended.”

“How in the hell would I ask the school?” I raise an eyebrow at her.

She grins like she’s been waiting for me to ask. “Why, the mirror of course, silly.”

“You already know the mirror let you inside once.” Ellavee sips her drink, her eyes narrow over the rim. “Find it and go inside again. Ask it questions. Seems a hell of a lot easier than sifting through dusty records in that creepy old library with the creepy old librarian.”

“Do you think the mirror is still down where the ceremony was?” I ask, and they both shrug.

“Honestly, no idea. But there’s only one way to find out.” Lux winks at me, and I can’t help but smile. Now I know exactly what I’m doing when we get back to the school.

By the third round, Lux is venting about her father and how he expects perfection in everything because she carries his name. How she can never fail quietly. It always has to be a public disappointment. She’s wound tight about the upcoming midterms, terrified of letting him down even though she’d never admit that’s what scares her most.

Ellavee doesn’t seem stressed about midterms at all. She’s far more interested in her ongoing mission to seduce Killian, who she has confirmed is only friends with Zuri, nothing more.

“Thank the gods,” she says, swirling her drink. “The last thing we need is another angel pissed off at us.”

“Speaking of angels.” I pick at the edge of my glass. “Do you think Jace will ever speak to me again?”

Our waiter drops off a platter of cubed cheeses, cured meats, and crusty bread for us to pick at. Ellavee doesn’t hesitate.

“Definitely not,” she laughs, popping a cube of cheese into her mouth.

Lux bumps her with her shoulder. “Ellavee.”

“What? She said she wanted the truth.”

“It’s fine.” I snort, reaching for a piece of bread. “I’d rather know where I stand than pretend there’s hope.”

The tavern doors swing open, letting in a gust of cold air and two very familiar figures. Malric and Draven push through the entrance, a woman draped on each of their arms. The girls are polished and pretty, the kind of effortless beauty that makes you want to hate them on principle.

I must make a face because both Ellavee and Lux turn to see who walked in.

“Gods.” Lux shudders visibly. “I still can’t believe you let that bite you.”

“I can.” Ellavee shrugs, tearing off a piece of crusty bread. “He may be a complete bastard, but he’s objectively attractive, in a slimy, ‘I’d rather stab myself’ kind of way.”

“Your standards are terrifying,” Lux mutters.

“My standards are flexible. There’s a difference.”

I watch them settle at the bar, facing our direction, but neither of them seems to have noticed us tucked away at our little table in the back. The tavern is crowded tonight, and I find myself sinking lower in my chair, hoping to stay invisible when I notice Malric has three long red marks down one side of his neck, like something scratched him.

“Do you recognize those girls they’re with?” I ask, trying to sound casual and failing miserably.

“They definitely don’t go to Ashwell.” Lux peeks over her shoulder. “Interesting.”

“It’s not interesting.” I tear my eyes away from them. “I don’t care what he does.”

“Sure you don’t.” Ellavee is smirking at me now, that knowing look I hate. “That’s why you’re gripping your glass hard enough to shatter it.”

I look down. She’s right. I force my fingers to loosen.

“Wait.” Lux’s eyes go wide. “Do you like Malric? I thought you said it was a mistake.”

“We’re not talking about Malric.” Ellavee rolls her eyes. “Keep up, Lux. We’re talking about Draven.”

“Draven?” Lux whips her head toward the bar and then back to me. “Since when is Draven on the table?”

“He’s not on the table,” I snap. “There is no table. I don’t even own a table.”

“And yet you can’t stop staring at him.” Ellavee pops another piece of cheese in her mouth, looking far too pleased with herself. “I recognize the dark-haired girl. She works at the inn down the street. Very friendly, if you catch my meaning.”

“Draven has a type apparently.” Lux grins.

“I said I don’t care.”

“And I said, ‘Sure you don’t.’”

I refuse to look at the bar again or think about Draven’s hands on some other girl. About his mouth on her neck. About whether he’ll bite her the way Malric bit me.

It doesn’t matter. He’s nothing to me, and I’m nothing to him. But what did Lux mean by he has a type, uh it doesn’t matter, clearly she’s just trying to get a rise out of me and it’s working.

“We need more drinks.” I wave at the waiter. “A lot more drinks.”

By the fifth round, two guys had joined our table.

They’re locals, friends of Lux and Ellavee from back when they lived here. One is tall with dark curly hair and an easy smile that crinkles the corners of his eyes. His name is Finn. The other is broader with a neatly trimmed beard and warm brown eyes that seem genuinely kind. Corrin.

Finn has somehow ended up next to me. His thigh is pressed against mine under the table, and his hand keeps finding excuses to touch my arm when he talks. Brushing against my wrist when he reaches for his drink. Squeezing my shoulder when he laughs at something I say.

I let him.

“So you’re at Ashwell.” He leans closer, his breath warm against my ear. “That must be intense.”

“You have no idea.”

“I’ve heard stories. Creatures and fissures and people dying all the time.”

“It’s not all the time.” I finish my drink and set the glass down. “But often enough to keep things interesting.”

His eyes travel over my face. “Still, you must be brave to go there.”

I think about freezing with the saw in my hand, about Nella’s eyes going empty while I stood there useless.

“I’m not brave.”

“I don’t believe that.” He smiles, slow and warm. “You look brave to me.”

It’s such a stupid line, the kind of thing boys say when they want to get you into bed and don’t have anything clever to offer, but the alcohol has made everything fuzzy, and he’s handsome enough. I don’t want to feel the guilt or the grief or the weight of all the questions I can’t answer.

I want to forget, even if it’s for one night.

Across the room, I feel eyes on me.

I don’t have to look to know it’s Draven.

I look anyway.

He’s watching me. The girl on his arm is talking to him, her fingers playing with his hair, but he’s not listening to a word she’s saying. He’s looking at me and Finn. At the way Finn’s hand has settled around my back. At the way I’m leaning into him instead of pulling away.

Finn and Corrin get up to grab another round of shots from the bar, and the moment they’re out of earshot, Ellavee leans in.

“You’ve been eye fucking him for the last twenty minutes. What’s going on there?”

I nearly choke on my drink. “I’m not eye fucking anyone.”

“You absolutely are.” Lux giggles. “I thought your eyes were going to burn holes through that poor girl’s head.”

“I told you both that nothing is going on. I can’t stand either of them.” I set my glass down a little too hard. “I’m disgusted watching that girl lick all over his neck and throw herself at him like that in public. It’s pathetic.”

“Pathetic.” Ellavee’s smirk deepens. “Right, that’s definitely why you look like you want to rip her hair out.”

“I don’t—”

“If it bothers you that much,” she cuts me off, lowering her voice as the guys make their way back with fresh drinks, “then maybe you should do the same. Instead of eye fucking him from across the room, try to get under his skin.” Her eyes glitter. “It might be fun.”

The drinks keep coming, and I stop counting.

Ellavee is leaning into Corrin, laughing at something he said, her usual guard completely dissolved by alcohol. Lux is flushed and giggly, her pink hair falling out of its pins as she gestures wildly telling some story about a prank she and Ellavee pulled when they were younger.

I'm really drunk. Everything feels soft around the edges and nothing seems to matter as much as it did an hour ago.

Finn's hand is on my thigh under the table. His thumb traces circles through the fabric of my leggings. I don't want to stop him.

"You're beautiful, you know that?" he says close to my ear, his breath warm and whiskey sweet. I turn my head and his lips find mine.

The kiss is sloppy and tastes like alcohol. His hand slides higher on my thigh, fingers pressing into my skin, and I let it happen. Let him deepen the kiss, let his other hand come up to cup the back of my neck, let him pull me closer until I'm practically in his lap.

Someone whistles, probably Ellavee.

I don't care about anything right now except the warmth of his mouth and the buzz in my blood and the blessed silence in my head.

His hand moves higher still, fingertips brushing the hem of my sweater, slipping underneath to touch bare skin. I should stop him. We're in public. People are watching.

I kiss him harder instead.

"Maelis."

Lux's voice cuts through the haze. There's something askew with her tone. Something sharp and scared that doesn't match the giggly girl from five minutes ago.

I pull back from Finn, blinking. "What?"

Lux is pale. Standing next to her is a man I don't recognize, middle-aged with a stern face and the dark-navy uniform of someone official. He glances at me briefly then back at Lux before walking away toward the bar, toward Draven and Malric.

"What's going on?" Ellavee straightens up, the playfulness gone from her face.

"That man works for my father." Lux's voice is barely above a whisper. "The school is on lockdown. We have to go back. Now."

"Lockdown?" Ellavee wrinkles her nose. "That seems dramatic. Maybe we should stay the night out here with the guys, wait until morning

when—”

“Ellavee.” Lux grabs her arm. “A student has been found dead, completely drained of blood.”

“What the fuck?” The alcohol fog clears slightly. “Did he tell you who it is?”

“Senna,” Lux whispers.

“Oh shit, your blood lead.” Ellavee’s voice is grim as she stands, pulling on her jacket.

We gather ourselves quickly, the flirtatious warmth of the evening evaporating in an instant. Finn catches my hand as I stand, his brow furrowed with concern.

“Are you going to be okay?”

I look at him, his kind eyes and easy smile and complete ignorance of the world I come from. “I don’t know.” It’s the most honest thing I’ve said to him all night.

He pulls me close and kisses me again, softer this time. When he pulls back, his thumb brushes my cheek.

“I want to see you again.”

I almost laugh. He’s sweet and completely wrong for me in every way that matters.

“That was fun, Finn.” I squeeze his hand once before letting go. “Let’s leave it at that.”

His face falls slightly, but he nods, understanding settling into his features. He knows a dismissal when he hears one and takes it like a champ.

We push through the tavern toward the door. The cold air hits me when we step outside, sharp enough to make my eyes water.

Draven and Malric are already there, waiting in the snow. The girls they were with are nowhere to be seen, probably sent home when the news arrived. The two of them stand like sentinels in the darkness, breath fogging in the frozen air.

Malric spreads his arms wide, that insufferable smirk on his face. “Ladies, looks like you’re lucky we’re here to escort you safely back to your rooms.”

He saunters over to me before I can react and throws his arm around my shoulders, pulling me against his side. His grip is possessive and invasive and makes my skin crawl.

“I can even sleep over if you’re scared.” He leans down, his lips brushing my ear. “Keep the nightmares away. You know how good I am at that.”

I shove him off me so hard he stumbles back a step. “Touch me again and I’ll cut your hand off.”

He laughs like I’ve told a joke. “Feisty. I always liked that about you, but we both know cutting is the last thing you’ll be doing. You don’t cut, Red. We’ve established that. Don’t make threats your hands can’t keep.”

“Malric.” Draven’s voice is ice. “Shut up.”

Something passes between them. Malric’s smile doesn’t waver, but he takes a step back, raising his hands in mock surrender.

“Fine, fine. Trying to lighten the mood.” He turns and starts walking toward the tunnel entrance. “Let’s go, children.”

Lux and Ellavee fall into step ahead of me. Draven lingers, and his eyes find mine in the dark.

He doesn’t say anything. The look on his face says enough. *Stay close. Be careful.*

Or maybe I’m inventing it. Maybe I’m drunk and tired and scared and stitching meaning onto a man who hasn’t given me any. Gods know I’ve done it before.

But a student is dead, emptied like a bottle and left somewhere for someone to find, and I am walking into a black tunnel with two creatures who could do exactly that and make it look like nothing.

I don’t know how many things in this world can drink a body dry. I can name two without thinking.

Lux and Ellavee don’t know what I know. They don’t know about the night outside the dorms. Malric with his hands all over Senna and the way I pushed him off her.

I thought Malric was an asshole. I didn’t think he was a killer.

But Draven called him a predator, and he doesn’t waste words, and Malric has motive. They showed up to the bar after us, which means anything could have happened before. Malric could have drained Senna dry and that’s how he got those scratch marks on his neck before meeting Draven for a night cap.

The thought irks me as we reach the tunnel mouth. Draven’s shoulder brushes mine — accident or not, I can’t tell — and then the dark swallows us.

Lux flicks a fae light into the air. It drifts above us, casting a pale wash across damp stone and the black veins of moss running down the walls. Our breath fogs white. Somewhere ahead, water drips in a slow, uneven rhythm, and I count it without meaning to, the way I count a pulse.

Primm pads ahead, low and silent. Draven's wolf flanks her, scouting, listening for what I can't hear.

The three of us girls may have overindulged a bit, because we're all stumbling along like newborn foals learning to walk. We link arms to try to be more balanced and graceful, but it's not really working. Every few steps, one of us trips, and the other two have to catch her, and we dissolve into muffled giggles that echo off the tunnel. It feels strange to laugh knowing a student has died, but maybe we are starting to get desensitized to death. I think that's what Ashwell Academy wants…the headmaster certainly does.

Malric leads the way, and Draven walks behind us. I can feel his judgmental eyes burning into my back, but I don't care. I'll get drunk if I want and make out with whoever the fuck I feel like. He has no right to stare at me like I'd done something wrong.

I start to relax a bit when we hear other students' voices echoing in the tunnels, assuming everyone was notified to return at once. Malric leads us back a different way then we came, and we pop out one of the staff passages that opens into the main entry hall near the kitchens.

The noise hits first, voices, boots on stone, the low thrum of a castle that has not gone to sleep yet. Torches blaze along the walls in numbers I've never seen at this hour. Professor Cane stands at the base of the wide staircase with a scroll unrolled in her hands and a pen tucked behind one pointed ear, the paintbrush holding her curls up at a precarious angle. She looks unbothered by the chaos.

"Name, darling," she calls, and I realize she's working her way through a small line of students who came from town.

We shuffle forward. Draven and Malric have been three steps behind us since we emerged, quiet in that way that feels less like walking and more like following, and I refuse to turn around and acknowledge either of them. Poppy has tucked herself so deep into my cloak that only one ear is visible, but every now and then she pokes her head out to peek around us.

"Lux, Ellavee, Maelis," Lux rattles off when we reach the front, and Cane's eyes lift. They linger on me a second longer than the others. She doesn't say anything and marks the scroll with a flick of her pen.

“Straight to your rooms, loves. No wandering.”

“Of course, Professor.”

“Luxanna.”

Lux winces. “Professor.”

“Your hair is charming, and you smell like a distillery. Bed.”

“On my way.”

We escape past her. Draven and Malric are giving their names as we pass. I don’t look at them.

We push through the doors onto the frigid courtyard, and Ellavee turns and walks backward a few steps so she can smile at them through the closing gap.

“Thanks so much for the chaperoning,” she calls, sweet as honey. “Couldn’t have made it through a tunnel without two full-grown vampires.”

“Ellavee,” Lux hisses, laughing.

“I’m being polite.”

“You’re being feral.”

“Politely feral.”

We cross the courtyard arm-in-arm again. The snow has thickened. My head is still swimming, but the cold is doing useful work in sobering me up a bit.

“Okay,” Lux says once we are alone, “I’m going to ask, and you’re going to tell me the truth, because you’ve been weird all night and not just drunk-weird. Senna wasn’t even your lead, and every time someone says her name, you look like you got punched in the stomach. Did you have some secret friendship we didn’t know about?”

I walk another few steps.

A marriage on paper. A kiss that felt a little too real.

For nights when you want the feelings to sneak up on you, try Lokepub.

“I didn’t really know her, not the way you’re both looking at me like I did.”

“That’s not why we’re looking at you like that,” Ellavee says.

I swallow. The cold burns the inside of my nose.

“I saw Malric with her once earlier this year outside the dorms, late. He had her pinned against a wall, and she…wasn’t right. I don’t know if he was trying to bite her or sleep with her or both. He was drunk and trying to force himself on her. I pulled him off her, and she took off running.”

Neither of them speaks for a long moment. Our boots crunch through the snow.

“Why didn’t you tell us?” Lux asks.

“Because I didn’t think she’d want anyone to know, and I didn’t even know who she was until we were assigned leads our first day in the patient wards.”

“That’s why she was staring at you. I remember thinking it was odd,” Ellavee says.

“Yes.”

“So you think Malric wanted to get back at her or something?” Lux asks.

“Maybe, I don’t know. The body was drained of blood and Malric showed up tonight with what looked like scratch marks on his neck.” I chew on my bottom lip, not liking the idea of Malric or Draven being killers. I know there are other vampires in this school, but Malric is a known threat. “I’m just saying, what else drains a person?”

“Well,” Lux says slowly, “technically quite a lot of twisted creatures can drain a body. Certain hollowfolk for sure can. There’s a thing in the northern bogs my father talks about that I can never remember the name of—”

“On school grounds?”

“That’s the part, isn’t it?” Lux’s pace slows a little. “If it was a twisted creature, it came from somewhere. And if it came from somewhere on the grounds, it came from somewhere they haven’t told us about.”

Ellavee tilts her head. “Or somewhere they have.”

We walk in silence for a stride.

“Lux,” I say, “what do you mean by that?”

“You’ve never wondered why we’re not allowed on the tenth floor of the patient wards?”

“I’ve wondered every time I’m in that building,” I say.

“What do you think is up there?”

“I have no idea. That’s the problem. I’m a professor’s daughter, and I’ve lived at this school on and off my whole life, and I don’t know what’s on that floor.” She shrugs, and her breath plumes white. “And that’s only one place. You know how many parts of this campus I’ve never been in? Easily half. There are whole wings that don’t appear on any map they’ll give a student.”

“So we don’t know.”

“We don’t know.”

“Great.” Ellavee stops walking. “Well, there’s one way to find out whether it was a vampire.”

Lux and I turn. Ellavee has that look. The one she gets when she’s up to no good.

“No,” Lux says immediately.

“Hear me out.”

“No.”

“We know where the morgue is. We did our first autopsies in the rooms right outside it. It’s past midnight, the academy is in chaos, half the faculty is running around the main hall, and Cane counted us on our way in. That means no one is looking for any of us for the rest of the night.”

“Ellavee,” Lux sighs.

“If it was Malric, she’ll have fang marks and blood under her nails if she scratched him. If it wasn’t him, she’ll have something else. Either way, we’ll know more than we know right now, which is nothing.”

“Ellavee, if we get caught in the morgue—” Lux runs a hand over her face.

“We won’t get caught,” I say, because Ellavee is on to something. The professors aren’t going to tell us any more about what happened. We need to find out for ourselves.

“That’s what people say right before they get caught,” Lux says.

I am swaying slightly on my feet, and the snow is coming down, and the key at my throat is warm against my skin where it’s usually cold. “I want to see her.”

Lux looks at me.

“I want to see her, Lux. I didn’t say anything before. I owe her this much.”

“Mae—”

“If I don’t see her, I’m going to lie in bed and imagine her, and what I imagine will be worse.”

Lux sighs, acquiescing. “Fine, but if we get caught, I’m blaming all of you.”

“Deal.”

“Especially Ellavee.”

“Fair.” Ellavee shrugs.

We take the long way around, staying off the main paths, and by the time we slip into the patient wards building through a side door, I’m sober enough to be afraid and drunk enough to keep moving anyway. The wards are quieter than I’ve ever seen them. A single mender sits at the desk with her chin on her palm, reading. She doesn’t look up as we pass the landing below her.

The autopsy rooms are on the basement level, the same ones where we cut into the crawler on our first day. The corridor looks different at night. The sconces on the walls glow the same pale blue, but something about the silence makes my skin prickle.

“I used to know where the morgue door was in the daytime,” Lux whispers.

“Middle of the corridor,” I say. “Left side. Heavy door.”

“Show-off.”

“I stared at it for too long after my first autopsy.”

We find it. Wide, black iron banded, a lock plate in the center that looks older than the rest of the building. Ellavee tries the handle.

“Locked.”

“Obviously,” Lux breathes.

My hand goes to my throat before I’ve thought about it. The key is warm under my fingers. The oblong bone-pale head, the single vertical line down its center. I pull it out.

“Wait.”

Lux turns. “What?”

“Malric said this key opens something when I need it most. Maybe—”

“Try it.”

I fit the key into the lock. It slides in smoothly, which surprises me. I turn.

Nothing happens.

I turn it the other way. Nothing. I jiggle it, because I am drunk and a little desperate. The key in the lock does absolutely nothing at all.

“Figures,” Ellavee mutters. “Whatever that key opens, it’s apparently more important than a morgue. Great.”

“It’s supposed to know,” I say, a little annoyed. “How does it not know?”

“Maybe it thinks you don’t need this badly enough.”

“I think I need it pretty badly.”

“Tell it that.”

“I’m not talking to a key, Ellavee.”

I pull it out and tuck it back under my sweater. Lux has already moved past me into the small antechamber off the corridor— a desk, a wooden chair, a row of hooks on the wall where spare coats hang, a cabinet.

“Check the desk,” she says. “People who work morgues don’t walk far to get their own keys.”

Ellavee slides the drawers open. I check the cabinet. Lux kneels at a second drawer tucked beneath the desk and makes a small, victorious sound.

“Found them.”

She holds up a ring.

It’s heavy and old and has at least forty keys on it. Brass, iron, one that looks like it was carved from bone. Lux turns the ring in her fingers and frowns.

“This is going to take all night.”

“Can’t you just...know?” Ellavee waves a vague hand. “You’re fae, aren’t you?”

“Yes, Ellavee, let me just know. That’s how being fae works. We simply know things.”

“So figure it out.”

Lux rolls her eyes but closes her hand around the ring and shuts her eyes. I watch her, fascinated. I’ve seen her summon fae light, but I’ve never seen her do anything else with current. Her brows pull together. Her hand flares faintly at the edges, a white shimmer, and then one of the keys on the ring glows for exactly one breath before going out.

Lux opens her eyes and separates the key from the rest of the ring.

“That one.”

“How—”

“Simple echo-charm. It’s a trick fae mothers use to find their children’s lost things. Don’t get excited. I can only do it with objects that want to be found, and keys almost always want to be found. It’s why keys are always in the last place you look but are almost never actually lost.”

“You’re a little bit of a mage, Luxanna.” Ellavee sticks out her tongue teasingly.

“I’m fae, Ellavee, and I swear to the gods if you call me a mage one more time—”

“Shh.”

We cross back to the morgue door. Lux slides the key into the lock. It turns with a soft click. The door opens inward, and the temperature plummets. The cold is not the cold of outside, rather the cold of a room that has been deliberately kept that way.

I notice the clean chemical smell of a place that has been scrubbed.

“Okay,” Lux whispers, “I’ll keep watch and signal you if anyone’s coming.”

“What signal?”

“I’ll tap the door twice.”

“Got it.”

Ellavee and I slip inside.

The morgue is small for a clinic this size. Stone walls, stone floor, a central examination table with a drain beneath it, and a bank of drawers set into the far wall. Twelve of them, each with a small card in a brass holder at the end.

We start reading the cards.

“Vaturi, S.” Ellavee has already found it. Middle row, third from the left.

She pulls the drawer, and it slides out on smooth runners. Senna comes with it.

She’s under a sheet pulled to her collarbones. Her hair has been arranged flat against her scalp, the lavender streak still visible. Her face is… I’m not ready. I thought I was ready.

“Maelis,” Ellavee says.

“Yeah, I’m here.”

I recall months of Professor Rowan’s voice in my head and Professor Cane’s lectures about vampiric physiology. Senna is a blood year, a

vampire, and I am a healer. I am a bone year who is not supposed to be in this room, but I am a healer.

“Pallor’s consistent with exsanguination,” I say quietly. “No signs of livor mortis, consistent with extreme blood loss before death.”

“Her fangs are retracted,” Ellavee murmurs. “That fits too. Vampires retract on death. The body knew it was dying.”

“Good.”

“Not good.”

“You know what I mean.”

“Yeah.”

We work our way down. Neck first, because that’s the obvious place. There’s nothing. Not a mark. Her throat is clean.

“That’s strange,” I say.

“I know.”

“You’d expect the neck.”

I move down her collarbones. Shoulders. Chest under the sheet, which Ellavee lifts only enough for me to look and not enough for me to feel like I’m violating her. Nothing. We check the inside of her elbows, the soft skin there where a careless drinker would go. Clean.

“Wrists,” Ellavee says.

We turn her left hand.

Nothing.

We turn her right.

There are two puncture marks on the underside of her right wrist. They are almost too clean, perfectly spaced, perfectly round, the kind of wound I have seen in a textbook diagram. There is no tearing, no bruising pattern suggesting a struggle. The skin around the punctures is smooth and unmarked.

I stand and look at them for a long moment.

“Maelis.”

“Hold on.”

Ellavee waits.

“Two things,” I say finally. “Those are fang marks. They’re the right spacing, the right depth, and the angle’s consistent with a downward bite. That’s a vampire.”

“Okay.”

“Two. They are too clean.”

“What do you mean?”

“Malric bit me.” I swallow. “It was not like that. It was messy. The marks on my throat look like I was in a fight or something.” I gesture at Senna’s wrist. “This is careful and clean, like it was done with a tool or whoever did this took their time.”

“So?”

“I don’t know what it means. Malric could have been careful. Vampires can be careful. He doesn’t strike me as careful when he drinks, but he could have been.”

“Or it wasn’t him.”

“Or it wasn’t him.”

“Or he wanted us to think it wasn’t him.”

“Or that.”

Two taps on the door.

Both of us freeze.

One pair of footsteps in the corridor fade away.

I look back at the wrist.

“Ellavee, do we tell someone?”

She thinks for a long moment. “No.”

“No?”

“The headmaster’s investigating. Bale, probably. Cane. Whoever else. If we tell a professor we were in here, we’re dead. If we tell a professor someone else’s theory, they’ll ask where we got it. And if whoever did this is paying attention to who’s paying attention to them, we made ourselves into targets.”

“Lux will ask her dad.”

“Lux asking her dad is different. That’s a girl asking her father a question about school safety. Anyone can do that.”

“Right.”

“But we keep an eye on Malric.”

“Oh, I’m keeping an eye on Malric.”

“We both are.”

We slide the drawer closed. I place my hand on the front of it for a second longer than I need to.

“I’m sorry,” I tell her quietly. “I’m going to find out.”

Ellavee waits, and when I turn away from the drawer, she is already moving toward the door.

Lux is in the corridor with her back pressed against the wall and the keyring tucked against her stomach. Her eyes go wide when we come out.

“Well?”

“Vampire,” Ellavee says.

“Shit,” Lux murmurs.

“But the marks are weird. Too clean. Could be him, might not be him.” I say.

“Brilliant. That is so helpful. I love when we find out nothing,” Lux sighs.

“We found out it was most likely a vampire.” Ellavee says.

“Most likely and confirming are different. Sounds like we know exactly what we knew before coming down here.”

We lock the door behind us. Lux drops the ring back in the drawer where she found it. Ellavee closes the cabinet. None of us speaks as we climb the stairs back up and slip out through the side door we came in, and by the time we’re outside again, the snow is coming down in large flakes, fat and slow. The cold has gone past hurting into something else.

“Bed,” Lux says eventually.

“Bed,” Ellavee agrees.

“Bed,” I say.

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Chapter Twenty-Four

"Fear will keep you alive if you let it sharpen you. It will kill you if you let it freeze you."

— Professor Bale, Lecture Notes



It's been several weeks since Senna was found drained, and the story everyone is telling now is that something came through a fissure and killed her.

Headmaster Ashmoor called an assembly the next day and said a minor fissure had opened along the outer grounds that night, too small for the wards to register until it was too late. He said a twisted creature came through and that Senna had the misfortune of being the first one it found. He named the thing, something feline that hunts and drains its prey. He said the breach had been sealed, the wards reinforced, the perimeter patrols doubled. He assured us the academy is safe and everything has returned to normal.

The three of us haven't told anyone what we saw in the morgue. As much as we'd like to believe the headmaster and let it go, especially Lux, we can't. I know we are all still keeping an eye on Malric and watching our backs.

Jace has moved past his indifference and decided to hate me instead. He went from pretending I don't exist to going out of his way to say hurtful things whenever we cross paths. Snide comments about my abilities. Last

week, he told my patient right in front of me that I was incompetent and they should request a different student to be assigned to their case.

The patient actually did.

I try to tell myself I don't deserve this, that what happened between us doesn't give him the right to sabotage my work, to poison people against me before I even have a chance to prove myself.

But deep down, in the darkest corners of my heart, I think maybe I do deserve it.

I broke him. I made him shut off every feeling he had to survive what I did. This cruelty is what's left in the hollow space where his heart used to be. My one action made different people out of both of us, and this is our new normal now.

That's on me. I tried to tell him I didn't sleep with Malric, that all I let happen was the bite, that I shoved him off the moment he tried to push for more. But Malric got to him first, and Malric was thorough. It doesn't matter what I say now. The damage is done, his mind has been poisoned by a monster.

I haven't found the mirror either. Ellavee and Lux have been helping me search for it whenever we have free time, scouring the lower levels of the school, checking every storage room and forgotten corridor we can access, but we've turned up nothing and are starting to run out of ideas.

One location keeps getting brought up, the one place we haven't checked because none of us are brave enough to try. Headmaster Ashmoor's office. Or even scarier, his private residence.

The answers I'm looking for might be there. I know my mother's secrets, my father's lies, the truth about what I am, all of it might be locked away somewhere in those rooms. But breaking into the headmaster's quarters isn't merely risky. It might be suicidal. He could easily make up some story about my death.

So for now, I keep searching, keep hoping the mirror will turn up somewhere less terrifying.

This morning, I wake early, my stomach already twisted with anxiety. Today is our midterm for Professor Bale's class, and I've been dreading it for weeks, but not because I'm unprepared. I've studied harder than I've ever studied for anything in my life. It's because the midterm isn't a written exam.

It's a field assignment at a real fissure site.

And Lux is even more anxious than I am. Her father will be evaluating her performance. The pressure on her shoulders is immense, and I know she's stressed out.

I take a quick shower and get dressed in my leathers, the ones we were issued specifically for combat situations. They're stiff and uncomfortable and make me feel like I'm playing dress-up, like I'm pretending to be someone braver than I am.

Poppy lounges on my bed, watching me with those clever dark eyes. I toss her a blueberry muffin, and she catches it in her tiny hands, chittering happily as she tears into it.

I bite into my own muffin and reach for Nella's journal on my nightstand.

There's only one entry left, the last thing she ever wrote before she died. I've been saving it, rationing the pages because once I read it, there won't be any more. No more of her voice. No more of her thoughts. No more pretending she's still here in some small way.

I need to let her go. I can't keep punishing myself for what happened because it's slowly killing me from the inside out. I need to read that final entry and say goodbye and find a way to move forward.

I shove the rest of my muffin in my mouth and flip to the back of the journal, deciding now is as good a time as any.

The headmaster took me to the tenth floor today. Didn't know there was one. Healers I've never seen strapped me down. He said he needed samples of the corrupted tissue for research.

They gave me something to sleep, but it didn't work right away. I heard sounds before everything went dark. Snarling. Screeching. Clicking like teeth snapping together over and over. Not like any animal, like something else.

When I woke up, I was back in my room. I asked about the sounds, but he smiled and said it was the sedative giving me nightmares.

I wasn't dreaming. Something is up there.

Draven visited tonight, and I finally figured out why he looks so familiar. When I visited my brother at the Vanguard Academy, there was a portrait of Lord Aldric and the royal family.

Draven was standing at his father's right hand.

He's the lost prince, the heir who walked away from the Obsidian Throne. Everyone back home knows the story, but no one here seems to

know who he is.

I don't know why he's here or why he's hiding, but I'm going to tell him what I heard tomorrow.

I hope I have enough tomorrows left.

I read the entry multiple times and am still in shock.

Draven Aldric. Not Alucard. *Aldric.*

He's been using some other last name this whole time.

Holy hell.

He's the heir to the Obsidian Throne. The prince of Valen. It would explain why the other vampires are always parading around him, why Malric listens to him when Malric doesn't listen to anyone. Why he has some hidden agenda with the headmaster and how Lux's father seemed to listen to him too. But Lux doesn't know. There's no way she would have kept that from me.

Fuck, I'm going to be late. I grab my cloak and start walking to class.

What was the headmaster doing with Nella on the tenth floor? Taking samples? I find that hard to believe. If he had anything to do with why the corruption spread so fast, I swear to the gods…

No, I can't think about this right now, because if I don't pass my midterms, I might not make it back to Ashwell at all.



I know something is off the moment I walk into Bale's classroom.

The silver-haired fae stands beside him. The same one who threaded me to Ashwell on my first day. He looks bored, examining his nails like transporting students into danger is just another Tuesday.

"Sit," Bale commands. "We're drawing pairs."

I slide into my seat. Lux is already there, knee bouncing under the desk. She shoots me a look of concern.

"Midterms," Bale continues, pacing the front of the room. "Two nights. Active fissure zones across Valen. You will be paired at random and dropped at a location with a map, basic supplies, and nothing else."

Everyone breaks out into whispers. I notice only bone year students are here today. He must have sent blood years to do something else for their

midterm since they already completed this last year. I almost wish I could be paired with a blood year. That would have been a great advantage. Well, anyone other than Malric.

“Your job is to make it to the marked site, assist any locals, and handle whatever comes through the fissure. Twisted creatures, possibly crawlers.” His eyes sweep the room. “Some of you won’t make it back. That’s not a threat. It’s reality. This is your first taste of what it’s really like out there, and it will be nothing compared to a large fissure or the cycle, gods forbid.”

The silver-haired fae yawns, and I wish I could be that calm right now.

Bale furrows his brows in sympathy. “I know this sounds harsh, but this is what you’re training for. Every single one of you chose to be here. You chose to become Veilguards, and Veilguards don’t get the luxury of safe classrooms and practice cadavers forever.”

He leans against his desk and crosses his arms. “Out there, people are going to be hurt, and they’re going to look at you like you have all the answers. This is your chance to prove you belong here. Not to me. To yourselves.”

Bale reaches into the leather satchel and pulls out a handful of wooden tokens. “When I call your name, you come up, draw a token, and find your partner. No trades. No complaints. You get who you get.”

A million objections lodge themselves in my throat. We aren’t Vanguards. We shouldn’t have to face down twisted creatures with nothing but a map and a bone saw.

This is madness.

And not all of us chose this. I never applied to Ashwell. Sure, I chose to come after the fact, but still—

“You ready for this?” Lux nudges my shoulder, dragging me out of my own head.

“Not even a little. You?”

She gives me a small smile, the kind that doesn’t reach her eyes, as her name echoes through the room. I watch her weave through the desks and pull a token from the satchel.

“Zuri,” she announces, scanning the room.

Zuri rises, chin high and gray wings tucked in like she’s walking into battle. Not the warmest person I’ve met but solid. Dependable. They’ll balance each other well.

Professor Bale continues calling names, the shuffle of bodies and scrape of chairs filling the silence between each one. I let my gaze drift across the room until it lands on Jace. He's sitting on the far side next to Killian of all people. I didn't know they were close.

He catches me looking. I offer a smile.

His expression flattens into something cold and distant, eyes narrowing like I'm a stranger he'd rather forget. Then he looks away.

I deserve that.

But gods I hope we get paired together. Out there, Jace would make me feel safe. And two nights alone might be the only chance I have left to reach him and find my friend buried somewhere beneath all that ice and remind him that I'm still here.

That I'm sorry.

I'm so fucking sorry.

"Maelis Rose."

My heart lurches into my throat because I know that voice, and it doesn't belong to Professor Bale.

Draven stands at the front of the classroom, a token pinched between his fingers. My name. He drew my name.

What are the odds? What are the actual fucking odds?

Two nights in a fissure zone with the vampire who never misses an opportunity to remind me I don't belong here. Who pushes me until I break and then looks at me like he expected nothing less. The last thing I need is him telling me I can't cut it while we're fighting for our lives. On the positive side, now I can question him about being the prince, and if this is a secret he wants to keep, he'll need to give me something in return. I want to know what he and the headmaster are up to.

I rise from my seat, forcing my face into something neutral. I refuse to let him see me rattled. I meet him at the front and follow him to where the other pairs are waiting.

Ellavee ends up partnered with a shifter named Gray. I don't know much about him, but she doesn't seem upset about it, probably because he's tall and attractive, which is usually all she requires of a man before she decides to play with him.

Jace and Killian are together, and I don't like it. Killian has never been nice to me, and he and Jace have apparently decided they have something in common now, their mutual hatred for me. I try not to look at them.

“Emil will be threading most of you to your locations.” Professor Bale goes down the line, handing out envelopes and packs to each pair. “Open the envelope to see where you’re going and head to him when you’re ready.” So the silver-haired fae’s name is Emil.

Draven takes our pack and shoulders it then opens the envelope. I lean closer to see the map. It takes everything I have not to stare at the side of his face while he’s reading.

Draven Aldric, I think and then shove the thought down before it can reach my face. *You don’t know I know.*

Bale walks past us and glances at our map.

“Ah. You’re the only team that doesn’t need Emil’s services.” He gives Draven a short nod. “You can head out when you’re ready. Do try to stay warm.”

Great. We’re the only team staying in the Frostlands. I was hoping we’d be headed somewhere warm, or at least somewhere not covered in snow and ice.

“Let’s go,” Draven says quietly.

I follow him toward the courtyard, the line of other pairs still waiting for Emil stretching out behind us. I glance back once. Ellavee is already talking to Gray while braiding her blonde hair to one side, her black and yellow snake Mr. Wiggles is twisting around her arm while she braids. Leave it to Ellavee to name a scary looking serpent Mr. Wiggles and not give an explanation. Lux catches my eye and waves, and I manage a smile for her that I hope looks like any other goodbye.

It isn’t, and she knows it, and her hand lingers in the air before she drops it.

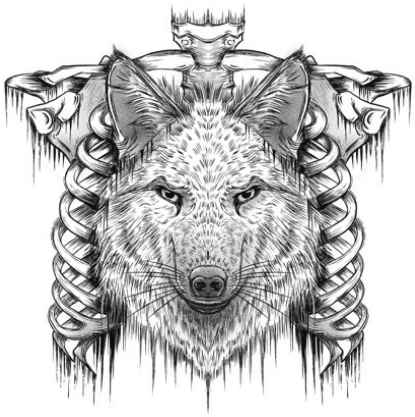
Then I turn and follow the lost prince of Valen out into the snow.

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Chapter Twenty-Five

"You will be paired with whoever the school believes you need. Rarely with whoever you want. Remember, nothing at Ashwell is random."

— Professor Bale, Lecture Notes



I reach for the map, and Draven sidesteps me like he saw it coming from a mile away. "I know how to navigate, you know."

"Do you?" He holds the map out of reach, one eyebrow raised. "Because you've been walking slightly left for the last hour. We'd be circling back to Ashwell by now if I let you lead."

"Maybe I was trying to escape your company."

"And yet here you are, still talking." He hands over the map with a look of exaggerated patience, like he's humoring a child.

I snatch it from him and make a show of studying it, even though my fingers are so cold I can barely feel the parchment. We passed through a small village about an hour ago, mountains to our left, frozen lake to our right. "Looks like a couple more hours if we keep this pace."

"Assuming you can keep this pace."

"Assuming you can keep your mouth shut that long." I fold the map and shove it into my pocket before he can take it back. "They couldn't have spared us a carriage? A horse? Anything? I didn't realize this midterm included a survival test on how not to freeze to death."

He doesn’t say anything, but I swear I see something shift at the corner of his mouth. It’s not a smile, but he’s enjoying this and doesn’t want me to know. Even if our assigned location is in Frostlands, it doesn’t mean we couldn’t have threaded here. I bet the other teams didn’t have to hike this far, and if they do, at least it’s not in the snow.

We’ve been walking for hours, and my legs stopped cooperating somewhere around hour two. Every step through the snow feels like dragging my body through wet sand, and the cold has moved past uncomfortable and into the kind of numbness where you stop shivering and start wondering if that’s a problem.

Draven slows his pace until he’s beside me instead of three steps ahead. It’s a nice change. I’ve been staring at his back for hours, which would be fine if he ever bothered to turn around and acknowledge I exist.

“If fissures open and close all the time, how does the professor know where to send us?” I ask. “What if we arrive and there’s nothing? What if the fissure closed and we walked all this way for no reason?”

He glances at me. A few strands of black hair have fallen from his bun and into his face. He brushes them away from his eyes. “I forget how little humans bother to learn about the world they live in. Must be nice, ignoring everything that doesn’t directly inconvenience you.”

My blood heats despite the cold. I could throw it back at him right now, remind him of the throne he walked away from, the duties he’s pretending don’t exist, but that particular weapon is worth more if I save it for when I really need it.

“Enlighten me then,” I say instead, “since you’re so knowledgeable and I’m so tragically ignorant.”

He’s quiet long enough that I think he’s going to ignore me, which would be predictable and infuriating in equal measure.

“Most fissures open and close unpredictably, but there are fixed fissures scattered across Valen. Permanent tears that never heal. Twisted creatures pour through at random, and someone has to be there to deal with it.”

“Vanguards and Veilguards stationed around the clock?”

“For the villages that can afford it.”

His jaw is tight, his gaze fixed ahead, and something about the way he said it makes me think there’s more than he’s willing to give me.

He lets his wolf out, the massive black creature bounding ahead into the trees without a sound. I watch him disappear into the shadows.

“Must be nice having a built-in scout.”

“Must be nice having an eidolon small enough to hide in your cloak when things get dangerous.”

“Poppy doesn’t hide. She strategically repositions.”

“She stole a muffin from Professor Nestor’s desk last week and then hid in your hood for three hours.”

“That was strategic. She was guarding it.”

“She was eating it.”

“Aggressively, like a predator.”

He makes a sound that might be a laugh, if Draven Alucard were capable of such a thing.

We walk in silence, but it’s different than before, less like he’s tolerating my presence and more like he’s simply sharing space with me. I don’t know what to do with that, so I focus on putting one frozen foot in front of the other and try not to think about how tired my body is.



Holloweir sits in a bowl of snow.

We see it from the ridge before we see anything else, a shallow valley scooped out of the land like someone pressed a thumb into clay, the village tucked into the low point with a frozen lake glinting behind it. I can see a dozen roofs, maybe fewer. The smoke from three chimneys rises thin and gray, suggesting half the village is deserted or freezing.

“That’s it?” I ask.

“That’s it.”

“It looks like somewhere people leave.”

“Most of them did.”

Draven starts down the ridge without waiting for me, and I have to skid and slide to keep up. The snow is deeper on this side of the slope. It reaches my knees at the bottom, my thighs in the drifts, and by the time we reach the first house, my lungs are burning.

The first house is empty. I can tell from the door, which is hanging in the frame like someone left in a hurry. The second has a goat tied to the porch post. She watches us with large yellow eyes and doesn’t blink.

“Friendly,” I mutter.

“Maybe she knows something we don’t.”

“I love when livestock has better information than I do.”

An old woman comes out of the third house before we get there, a broom in one hand and a look on her face that suggests the broom is not for sweeping. She’s wrapped in enough wool to make two of herself.

Her eyes move across us and catch on the Ashwell crest stitched into my cloak. “You the ones they sent.”

“We are,” Draven says.

“You’re late.”

“We walked.”

She makes a scoffing sound. “Seamkeeper’s at the end of the path. He’ll see you in. Don’t eat what he offers you. He’s been rationing amiss again. And don’t go near the lake after dark.”

“What happens after dark?” I ask.

She doesn’t elaborate. “Keep the human one indoors at night,” she adds, eyes on me but speaking to Draven. “Your kind thins out fastest.”

I open my mouth to say something, then Draven’s hand finds the small of my back, steering me forward a half step. How does she automatically know I’m human, and who told her we were coming?

“Thank you,” he says, and we keep walking.

“Witness well,” she calls after us.

I glance at Draven. “What does that mean?”

“It’s what they say here.”

“That’s not an answer.”

“I know.”

The chapel is at the end of the path exactly where she said it would be.

It’s older than anything else in the village by centuries. The stone is a different color, lighter and rougher with signs of age. A squat rectangular building with a bell tower leaning slightly off. Then a second structure is attached to the side of it. Both buildings are tired and lean into each other.

There are no symbols on the chapel. No sun, no star, no angel wings cut into the lintel. The only ornament is the stone itself, and when I look closer, I see what I thought was weathering isn’t weathering at all.

Seams.

Long vertical lines carved into the face of the chapel, from the foundation up past the roofline. Some of them are filled in with a pale-silver

metal, shining dully in the overcast light. Others are left open, dark grooves in the stone, narrower than my finger. The pattern isn’t decorative. It’s a record of something.

“Rose.”

Draven is already at the door. I hadn’t realized I’d stopped walking.

“Alucard,” I huff, rolling my eyes.

He waits for me to catch up before he knocks. The door opens before his knuckles land.

The man on the other side is thin in the way winter makes people thin, not starved exactly but wrung out. His robes are the color of old blood, belted at the waist with a plain rope, and the sleeves are pushed up past his elbows like he’s been working, and I can see a single thin line across his wrist, a scar.

“You walked from Ashwell Academy,” he says by way of greeting.

“We did,” Draven says.

“You must be tired.”

“We are.”

“Good. Tired people listen better.” He steps aside. “Come in before the cold does.”

The chapel is warmer than outside, though not by much. A hearth burns at the far end of what used to be a nave, the pews long since pushed against the walls and stacked into makeshift shelving. The shelves hold books that don’t appear to be religious texts but ledgers. Dozens of them. Hundreds maybe. Dark leather bindings, numbered on the spines in a hand that changes every few volumes as the recorders changed.

Where the altar should be, there’s a table. A long flat slab of dark stone with a few chairs around it, and someone has covered it in maps and candles and a scattering of tools. Forceps, a small scale, and sealed jars of what I hope is ink.

Four candles burn on the table arranged in a precise square. A staircase spirals up the inside of the wall toward what must be the bell tower. A heavier door set into the floor near the hearth leads somewhere down. I look at that door and decide immediately that I don’t want to know what’s under it.

Draven’s wolf pads past us, crosses the nave without ceremony, and drops in front of the hearth like he’s been here a hundred times. Poppy

pokes her head out of my hood, takes one long look at the room, and hurries over to plop down next to the beast. I narrow my eyes at her, traitor.

“Seamkeeper Ostric,” the man says without extending a hand. I don’t take offense to it. I’ve never much liked shaking hands. “The last one at this post for the moment.”

“Maelis Rose,” I say. “This is—”

“Draven Alucard. Ashwell sent us for the midterm assessment.”

“I know what Ashwell sent you for.” Ostric eyes us. “You’ll sleep in the side chamber. There’s only one bed, but I’m sure you’ll make do. The fissure is past the lake. You won’t need a map.”

“Why not?” I ask.

“You’ll probably hear it before you see it.”

“Hear it how?”

“There’s food on the table,” Ostric says, turning away like he didn’t hear me at all. “Bread mostly. Don’t eat the stew. I was distracted when I made it.” He crosses to the shelves and pulls down one of the ledgers without looking at the numbering. “Tomorrow, you’ll walk to the fissure and make your observations. The night after, you’ll do the same. If anything comes through, you handle it. If nothing comes through, document the quiet. Both are data.”

“And if we need you?” Draven asks.

“I’ll be here or above.” He gestures at the spiral staircase. “I watch from the tower most nights. The seam is quieter than it used to be, but if there’s a problem, you’ll hear the bell.”

Ostric proceeds toward a small door at the back of the nave with the ledger under his arm. He turns and looks at me. “Miss Rose.”

“Yes?”

“Your hands.”

I look down. My fingers are red and stiff, and I hadn’t realized they were shaking until he said so, and now that he has, they won’t stop.

“Yes?”

“Keep them warm tonight. The cold doesn’t help.”

He drifts through the small door, and we’re alone in the nave. I walk over to the fire and kneel down next to Poppy, holding my hands out to get warm. They start to burn as my fingers defrost.

“What is this place?” I say quietly.

“Older than the academies. Older than the kingdoms.”

“You’ve been somewhere like this before.”

He glances around. “There are fewer of these than there used to be.”

I wait, but he doesn’t elaborate.

“What is a seamkeeper exactly? He gave me the creeps.” I blow into my hands then rub them together in front of the fire again. He spoke about my hands shaking like he knows I have trouble with them. Or I’m reading too much into it. Either way, this entire place gives me the creeps.

Draven takes off our pack and sits at the table, glancing down at the maps spread across it. “An order. Very old, older than the throne, older than anything that matters politically, which is probably why nothing else wants to remember them. They tend to the tears in the earth. Fissures that don’t heal, the fixed ones, usually have a seamkeeper post nearby. They watch what comes through. They write it down and burn what dies.”

“That’s it?”

“That’s most of it. They also remember things. There’s a lot of history nobody wants in the official ledgers.” He reaches out and straightens one of the four candles a quarter inch, as if he can’t help himself. “They don’t belong to anyone. That’s why they’re barely funded. There are less than a dozen of them left across Valen but there used to be over a hundred.”

“And the mark on his wrist?”

“They make it themselves when they take their vows.” He pushes a stray strand of hair from his face. “A seam, because that’s what their life revolves around.”

I stand and move to sit across from him. “But what’s the point in all of it? They burn bodies and record what they see?”

“Without those records, nobody knows what’s coming until it’s already here.” He meets my eyes. “That’s the point. They’ve been recording data and finding patterns as old as time itself. The Obsidian Throne deemed them useless and stopped funding them, but I don’t think that was a smart choice. How do we change anything without knowing our history?”

He shrugs and takes a bite of bread.

We. Not they. We.

I file it away and take a bit of crusty bread. I’m still chewing on a piece when someone knocks at the door.

Three sharp raps, hard enough that the sound cuts through the nave and makes Draven’s wolf lift his head from the hearth.

Draven is at the door before I've even swallowed, making me think he heard them coming before the knock. Must be nice having vampire hearing.

The man on the other side is wrapped in a coat that isn't warm enough for the weather, and he's gripping a boy by the wrist. The boy is small and silent, and his sleeve is dark with something that isn't melted snow.

"The seamkeeper said—" The man stops when he sees me. His eyes move from my face to the Ashwell crest on my cloak and back again. "He said you were a healer."

I set the bread down. "I'm a student."

"He said you were a healer."

Draven steps aside, and they come in.

The boy is quiet the way children become when they've already cried themselves out. His eyes find mine and stay there, wide and glassy, and I kneel in front of him in an instant.

"What happened?" I reach for the boy's sleeve.

"An axe," the father says. "He was helping me split wood, and it slipped."

"Take a seat on the bench. I need to see it."

He guides his son onto the bench, and I push the boy's coat sleeve back. The wound on his forearm is deep and ragged, but it's bleeding at a pace that means I have time, which means I can do this. It's a clean gash from an axe and not a twisted creature, so no need to cut out any corruption.

"What's his name?" I fold up the sleeve and pin it out of the way.

"Tomas."

"Hi, Tomas." I meet the boy's emerald eyes. "I'm Maelis, and I'm going to clean this up. It's going to hurt a little, but not as much as the axe did. Okay?"

He nods without making a sound.

"Can you tell me something about yourself while I work? Tell me about that goat outside."

"She's mean." His voice is hoarse.

"Yeah, I got that impression."

I reach back for the pack without looking and find Draven already holding it out to me. I pull out the kit Professor Bale gave us and start to work.

My hands shake twice while I'm cleaning the cut. The first time is when I see how deep it goes, and the second is when I pick up the needle. Both

times I stop and breathe and start again. Tomas keeps talking because I asked him to, about the goat and his sister and the dog two houses down that doesn't like her.

"My dad is the best at splitting wood in the whole village." He winces as I thread the needle through skin. "This wasn't his fault."

"I know it wasn't."

"He really is the best at it."

"I believe you." Though in a village with a little over a dozen people, it's not hard to be the best at anything.

His father stands behind us, watching, not interfering. Draven is against the far wall where he was when they came in. Neither of them speaks while I work, and the quiet they're giving me is the kind I didn't know I needed until now. I'm sure it's taking all of Draven's willpower to not chime in and tell me I'm doing something wrong or that he can do it better.

The stitches go in cleaner than I have any right to expect from hands that have been failing me for the last year. Eight of them, small and even, the kind of work I used to do before my father died. I cut the thread and tie the last knot off. Tomas looks down at his arm and then back up at me with disbelief.

"That's it?" He prods gently at the edge of the stitching.

"That's it." I swat his hand away from the wound. "Keep it clean, and don't get it wet for a week. Your father will know what to watch for."

His father nods. "What do we owe you?" He reaches into his coat.

"Nothing."

"Miss —"

"Nothing." I close up the kit. "Go home and feed him something warm."

He hesitates in the doorway with his hand on his son's shoulder, and I can see him working up to saying something.

"The lake was louder today." He looks down at the floor instead of at me. "You'll want to know that. It was louder than it's been in weeks."

Draven crosses his arms over his chest against the wall.

"Louder how?" I stand up, the kit still in my hands.

"Like something's awake in it. I don't know how else to say it. It was louder."

He takes his son's good hand, and they leave. I put the kit back in the pack and look down at my hands. I've been bandaging patients in the wards

for weeks but haven’t done any stitches. I just did stitches, and my hands were steady.

“Rose.”

I don’t look up.

“Rose.”

“I’m fine, Alucard.”

“I didn’t ask if you were fine.”

I look up at him. He’s still against the wall with his arms folded, watching me with an expression I can’t read from across the room.

“You did well.”

“I did basic stitches.” I cross to the table and sit back down in front of my half-eaten slice of bread. “Besides, I wasn’t trying to impress you and am certainly not looking for your approval.” I take another bite of the crusty bread. Draven paces and keeps glancing out the window.

“What do you think he meant about the lake?” I ask.

“From the map, it looks like the fissure runs into the lake. Could be a sign of activity.” Draven’s tracing a finger along one of the maps spread across the stone table. “It’s almost sundown. You should get some rest.”

“And what about you?” I set the chunk of bread down I’ve been pulling pieces off of to try and fill my belly, even though it tastes stale.

“I’m going to check our surroundings and get a look at the fissure.”

I’m stumbling out of my chair. “The seamkeeper said we should wait until tomorrow.”

“I don’t give a damn what he said.” He pulls his cloak off the back of the chair.

“I’m coming with you.” I clip my own cloak back around me and pull our pack on over my shoulders. You never know when we might need it.

“You’re going to bed.” He crosses to me, lifts the pack off my shoulders, then tips his head toward the side chamber door. The one I haven’t looked in yet, the one I’m afraid to see the state of in this place.

“I’m not a godsdamn child, and this is my grade too. If you go, I go.”

“Look around, Freckles. No one is grading us. The grade is making it back alive.”

I cross my arms and don’t move.

He takes in a long slow breath and sets the pack down.

“Fine.”

I practically squeal and skip past him to the door.

“Well, hurry up.” I pull it open and wave an arm toward the cold. He shakes his head once and steps out into the evening air.

The path to the lake runs narrow through the woods, and his wolf leads the way.

We keep a fast pace. The goat lady’s warning was enough to make me not want to be out here after dark, and I think Draven feels the same from the way he steals ahead of me every few steps and then waits, like he’s checking that I’m still behind him.

I squint through the trees. I’ve always hated this time of day, when the sun has just set and it isn’t dark yet but everything has gone soft at the edges.

Then the seam finds me.

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Chapter Twenty-Six

"The seam is loudest to those it knows. Those it's touched."

— Seamkeeper Ostric, personal journal



"Do you hear that?" I slow.

Draven stays with me. "Hear what?"

"That." I stop walking. The humming has moved into my arms and then somewhere deeper than my arms. "You don't hear that?"

He turns to face me fully. "What does it sound like?"

"I don't know. It isn't a sound." I press a hand to my sternum. "It's in my chest."

He doesn't answer.

"Draven."

"I'm taking you back." He puts a hand on my shoulder to turn me around, but I shake my head.

"No, we're almost there. I've never seen a fissure before. I need to see it."

I start walking again, and I hear him curse under his breath behind me.

"It doesn't hurt." I keep moving, pushing a low branch out of my way. "It's a vibration. I can hear it and feel it at the same time. It must be what the man was talking about."

He keeps pace with me as we break out of the trees.

The first thing I notice is that the snow has been pushed back from the edges of the fissure in a perfect, uneven ring, as though the cold itself refuses to touch it. Frost has grown in unusual patterns, fanning outward from the lip of the crack in feathered arcs that shouldn't be possible in still air.

The fissure itself is jagged and dark, at least twenty feet wide and a hundred feet long, crooked through the earth and running down into the frozen lake at the far end where the ice has buckled up around it in pale, heaved plates. A mist drifts above it.

I take a step, and Draven grabs my arm.

"Close enough."

He was right about it running into the lake. The ice breaks along the edge of the fissure in a ragged line, and below that there is nothing but dark jagged rock going down farther than I can see in the fading light. No snow collects inside. No wind churns the mist. No bird calls anywhere in the woods behind us. I hold my hands out in front of me and swear I can feel a hint of warmth rising off the mist, which makes no sense in air this cold.

The humming has stopped.

The night has gone completely silent.

I can feel Poppy's uneasy presence inside my chest, but she doesn't appear.

"There's no one here." I don't take my eyes off the fissure. "No one's watching it? Who protects these people when twisted creatures come through this thing?"

Draven stares at the place where the fissure meets the edge of the lake. "No one. This place is deserted apart from the seamkeeper, and all he does is record what he sees."

"And rings the bell." I glance up at him.

He snorts. "Yes, because that bell is going to save anyone from what comes out of there. He might as well be ringing a dinner bell, because all he's doing is calling the damn things to the village."

I see his point.

"Then why ring it at all? Why do these people stay living here so close to a fixed fissure?"

He shakes his head, still looking off toward the lake.

"The bell is an old warning system. They're too stuck in their ways to do away with it." His voice lowers. "And the people… I imagine it's all

they’ve ever known.”

I have an urge to move closer and look down inside the crack. I look at my feet instead and notice that the snow around my boots has developed the same feathered frost patterns I saw at the edge of the fissure. Small ones spreading out from where I’m standing.

I take a step back. The frost stays where it is.

“Come on.” Draven’s hand finds the small of my back. “It’s getting dark. Let’s head back.”

We make the trek in silence. My chest loosens the farther we get from the fissure, and I hadn’t realized how tight it had been until it wasn’t anymore. I shake the rest of it off once we reach the chapel and step inside into the warmth near the hearth.

Draven kneels to feed the fire, and I open the door to the old bedchamber. It’s a simple room with a single bed that could fit two people. Two people who were entirely comfortable touching each other all night, which we most definitely are not. There’s a window behind the bed with a small crack in the glass and a low whistle of cold air trickling through it.

Great.

“You can take the bed. I’ll take the floor.”

I nearly jump. Draven has come up behind me without a sound, peering into the small space over my shoulder.

“How generous of you.” I step inside and drop our pack onto the foot of the bed. “Are you sure? The stone looks very comfortable.”

“I’ve slept in worse places.”

“Name one.”

He doesn’t answer, and I find it hard to imagine a prince sleeping anywhere uncomfortable, lost or not.

I turn to look at him. He’s leaning against the doorframe with his arms crossed, watching me like he’s already three steps ahead and waiting for me to catch up.

“You’ll freeze down there.”

“I don’t freeze.”

“Right. Vampire. I keep forgetting.”

“You don’t keep forgetting. You keep bringing it up.”

“Because it’s convenient for you and inconvenient for me, and I find that annoying.”

Something shifts at the corner of his mouth. Dare I say the ghost of a smile.

“You can have one of the pillows,” I say, “and one of the blankets.”

“How generous of you.”

“What can I say? I’m a benevolent human.”

“You’re a tired healer with two pillows.”

“And you’re a vampire with neither, so I’d watch the tone.”

He pushes off the doorframe and steps into the room, which feels smaller with him in it. He takes the pillow I hold out to him without touching my hand. Takes the blanket the same way. He’s being careful, and I notice it but don’t know why.

He pulls his hair out of a bun, kicks off his boots, and drops the pillow and blanket beside the bed. He crouches down to arrange them, and for a second I’m looking at the top of his head and the way his hair falls forward when he bends, and I have to remind myself that Draven is a terrible person and that noticing the way his hair falls is the kind of thing that will end badly for me.

I sit down on the edge of the bed and start unlacing my own boots.

“Rose.”

“What?”

“If you kick me in the face getting out of that bed in the morning, I’m leaving you here.”

“I’ll aim carefully,” I chuckle.

I take off my cloak and arrange it against the windowsill, pressing it into the frame to cover the crack as best I can and keep the cold out. Draven turns out the lantern on the bedside table and lies down.

Once he can no longer see me, I slip under the covers and shimmy out of my leather pants. I can’t sleep in anything restrictive. Luckily I wore layers and have my pink pajama shorts underneath. I keep my sweater on though, because even with the blankets it’s not exactly warm in here, and roll onto my side, facing the wall.

The floorboards creak once beneath him as he shifts.

Then nothing.

I’m still shivering even under the covers, weighing whether I should give up and go make a bed by the hearth.

Then the bed dips.

Fuck. I nearly roll off the mattress as a massive black shape lands beside me. “Uh, Draven.”

“He’ll help keep you warm.” Draven’s voice comes from the floor. “I’m never going to sleep with all the noise you’re making.”

“I’m not making noise.”

“You’re shivering loud enough to wake the dead.”

“That’s not a real thing.”

“It is in this room.”

I lift the edge of the blanket, and the wolf crawls under. He settles against my side, enormous and warm and impossibly soft. I lean into him and try not to think too hard about the fact that he’s connected to Draven, that every place he’s warm is warm because of a bond that runs back to the person currently lying on the floor three feet from me.

“Are you still awake?” I whisper.

“You mean, have I fallen asleep in the ten seconds since you stopped talking?”

“Yes, that.”

He sighs, and I laugh through my nose.

“What’s your wolf’s name?”

“Noctis.”

“What does it mean?”

A marriage on paper. A kiss that felt a little too real.

For nights when you want the feelings to sneak up on you, try Lokepub.

“Of night. Of darkness.”

“Fitting.”

I pet the top of Noctis’s head and pull the covers up over both of us.

The room is quiet for a long time.

Noctis’s breathing has slowed against my side. The fire in the nave has burned down enough that the orange glow under the door has gone thin.

“Draven,” I whisper.

“Mm.”

“Can I ask you something?”

“You’re going to anyway.”

I stare up at the ceiling, and the crack in the window whistles faintly behind my cloak. I debate if it’s wise to ask but can’t help myself.

“Do you think Malric killed Senna?”

“This is what you are up thinking about,” he sighs.

“The headmaster said it was a twisted creature that somehow got past the wards and found one girl and drained her and left no other damage.”

“I know what he said.”

“I saw Malric try to bite her once. He tried to assault her outside the dorms late one night after the Mirror Ceremony. I pushed him off her, and Poppy bit his hand.”

“No wonder he hates that raccoon. I would have liked to see that,” he chuckles.

I turn my head toward the edge of the bed. “So do you think he did it?”

The silence that follows is long enough that I start to hear my own pulse in my ears.

“I think Malric is capable of a lot of things,” he says finally, “but I don’t know if he did it or not.”

“If it’s even a possibility, then why hasn’t anyone done anything?”

“Because proving it would require someone with more power than any of us currently has.”

“But you believe he may have done it.”

“I believe Malric has done things that should have cost him his life, and he is still walking around Ashwell because of who his father is and who he knows.”

He still hasn’t really answered the question. He thinks it’s possible he killed her but doesn’t seem to care that his friend is a murderer if that is the case. Draven and Malric showed up at the tavern together that night. That means he was with him right after it happened. Could Draven have been in on it too? Are they both killers? I imagine a vampire prince has probably killed before, but then why would either of them want to be healers?

“Draven.”

“Go to sleep, Rose.”

“Draven.”

“I can’t help her now. Neither can you. Go to sleep.”

I turn over and close my eyes. I hope I’m letting my imagination get the best of me. I don’t want to believe the worst in people, but lately I’m finding it hard not to.



I roll onto my side and reach out to touch Noctis, and my hand presses against a bare chest.

My eyes snap open.

Draven is lying beside me, his eyes already open, that magnificent gold and red swirled together, so bright in the dark of the room. I open my mouth to ask what the fuck he’s doing in my bed, but he presses a finger to my lips before I can speak. I reach up and grab his forearm to tug his hand away, and he moves it behind my back instead, slipping under my sweater and pressing his warm palm to the small of my back, drawing me closer.

“Drav—”

His lips touch mine, and before I know it I’m kissing him back. My tongue tangles with his, and he tastes even better than he smells, fresh snow, sweet whiskey and a hint of smoke. He pushes me onto my back and rolls on top of me, deepening the kiss. It’s hot and rough and all-consuming in the best way. I run a hand along the rough line of his jaw then up into his hair, and he groans into my mouth.

Oh gods, this is naughty and delicious and everything I’ve wanted and didn’t know I needed.

His hand slides under my sweater and finds my breast, pinching my nipple between his thumb and finger until I’m bucking beneath him, my hips rising against his body on instinct. I run a hand down his bare chest, across the muscles of his stomach, lower between us until I’m tugging at the ties of his pants.

He breaks the kiss, and his eyes meet mine again, the red bleeding into the gold until only flecks remain. “I don’t want gentle, Rose. I want every sound you’ve been keeping behind your teeth.”

I suck in a breath, pulling my bottom lip into my mouth as he brushes my hair from my face.

“Look at you, Freckles.” His voice has dropped to something low and dangerous. “Pretty little healer with her hand on my cock.”

Heat flashes through me so fast I forget how to answer.

His mouth finds the two scars on my neck, and his tongue circles the spot where Malric bit me.

“I’m going to bite you here,” he murmurs against my throat. “Right where he did. I want to stop thinking about him every time I see this mark.”

I whimper before I can stop myself.

“I’m going to mark you, Rose.” His fangs graze my skin. “My mark is going to be the only one you carry and I’m going to spend the rest of the night making sure you forget the other one was ever there.”

The anticipation has me melting inside, warmth spreading between my legs. He kicks his pants off, and I feel the swell of his cock between my thighs, pressing against my thin pajama shorts. He kisses me again, and I pull his bottom lip into my mouth and suck until he groans, my hips lifting again, wanting him closer.

He reaches down and pushes my shorts off, and I lift my hips to help him kick them away.

My heart is racing, and I am embarrassingly, achingly wet when his cock starts to push at my entrance.

“Are you ready for me to take you, Rose?”

“Yes. Gods, yes.”

His teeth sink into my neck at the same moment he thrusts inside me, and I cry out at the pain, the sting between my legs and the burn at my throat blurring into one impossible sensation. He drinks from me and starts to move, and the delicious shock of him pushes me past anything I have words for. He pulls out slowly and pushes back in, filling me so full it shouldn’t be possible. I wrap my legs around his waist and my arms around his neck and hold him there, drinking and fucking me in the same rhythm.

When he pulls away from my neck, I see my blood on his lips, dripping down his chin. He pulls his bottom lip into his mouth and licks it clean, his eyes meeting mine, completely red now and glowing in the dark.

“You taste so fucking good.”

He grips the headboard for leverage and thrusts into me again and again. The bite is making me warm and dizzy, and I lift my hips to meet him, staring up into those glowing eyes.

“Are you ready to stop being a weak human, Rose?”

My eyebrows furrow. I don’t know what he means and can barely think straight when he keeps drawing these embarrassing sounds out of me, but I nod anyway. I’m ready for whatever he wants to give me. I want all of it.

“Destiny has been calling.” His voice is rough between thrusts. “It’s time you answered.”

He bites into his own wrist and presses it to my mouth. I fight it for a heartbeat, and then the warm sweetness reaches my tongue, and something in me gives way. He tastes like earth and frost and home in a way that makes no sense. I suck harder, swallowing him down, and he holds his wrist there and rides me in an intoxicating rhythm.

“That’s it,” he says, his breath a tickle at my ear. “Take it.”

His blood hits my belly, and a burning sensation takes hold there, spreading slowly up my torso and into my ears. A round, resonant boom echoes through me, and my eyes widen.

“Draven,” I gasp, “is this supposed to happen?”

He pulls his wrist from my mouth. The sound radiates through me again, so loud it vibrates in my core.

The blankets are torn off me.

I gasp awake, sitting upright.

Draven is standing over me, fully clothed, and a low iron toll is rolling out across the village.

The bell.

Holy fuck, it’s the bell. It’s a warning about the fissure.

“Nice shorts.” Draven’s mouth pulls into a half-smirk as he takes in my tiny pink pajamas.

I scramble out of bed, yanking my leathers up my legs. There’s no time to think about that dream or whether I’ll ever look at Draven the same way again.

“How did you get ready so fast?” I mumble, dropping to lace up my boots.

“I couldn’t sleep.” He’s leaning against the wall like nothing in his life has ever been urgent. “You were making too many sounds for anyone to rest through.”

My face goes hot. *Oh gods, if he only knew.*

“What’s happening?” I ask, because I need to change the subject more than I need air.

Draven pushes off the wall and steps into the nave of the chapel. “Sounds like something has come through the fissure.”

And if the bell’s ringing, that means the seamkeeper saw whatever it is, and it’s heading for the village.

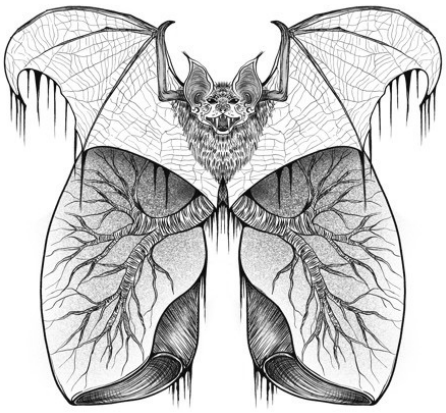
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Chapter Twenty-Seven

"The hands remember what the mind has tried to forget. Sometimes this is mercy. Sometimes it is the worst kind of cruelty."

— Professor Nestor, Lecture Notes



I pull my cloak on and meet Draven across the nave. He's at the window, his palm flat against the cold glass, his head tilted in that way that means he's listening to something I can't hear yet. It's early, so early there's barely any light. Neither of us bothers going upstairs to talk to the seamkeeper. We both know he's good for nothing but observing.

Noctis paces behind us. I reach for the backpack and throw it over my shoulder.

"Shit," Draven says, it under his breath, his eyes locked on something through the snow.

I hurry to the window beside him.

"What is it?"

"That kid's father is out there with an axe. There's a couple of other men with him."

I squint into the gray. The square is mostly empty. Most of the houses are dark, shutters closed tight, the bell tolling slow above us. But near the second-closest cottage, I can make out three shapes against the snow, moving in a loose ring, weapons drawn. The man in the middle is

recognizable even at this distance by the breadth of his shoulders. Tomas's father.

"They must be trained to defend the village."

"These people would be better off barricading their front doors and waiting for the twisted creatures to pass." Draven stalks to the second window, his eyes scanning the rooftops. "Out there, they're just getting picked off."

That must be why the village is so deserted. These people don't have any real help. One of the other men has a dagger out. The third has a bow drawn and is sweeping it slowly across the dark sky. They keep looking up. Something is up there that I can't see.

The bell tolls again, and I wince.

The man with the bow lifts the weapon higher, and then something whips against the dark above the rooftops, a shape too big to be a bird and too fast to be anything that should be in the sky.

It folds, collapsing in on itself in midair and becoming a sharper shape, dropping toward the men in the square so fast that my breath stops in my chest.

"Oh fuck!"

I'm running before I've given it much thought.

I'm out the door and into the cold. Snow swirls thick across the square. My boots sink into the powder up to the shin. The dark thing is dropping out of the sky toward Tomas's father, and there's nothing I can do but run.

It strikes him before I'm halfway across the square.

I see it for one second, wings spread wide, longer than a man is tall, the membrane between them stretched so thin I can see the gray of the sky through it. A body that shouldn't be that long. A tail whipping in a long boneless curl that ends in something hooked. And the head is upside down.

Holy hell. The fucking head is upside down. The beak is opening at me from below, and inside the beak is a tongue, long and ribbed.

Then it's on him.

The strike knocks Tomas's father onto his stomach in the snow. The creature lifts off in the same motion and disappears back into the snowfall above the rooftops, wings beating with the sound of the wind.

The other two men shout. The bowman wheels around firing into the sky, and the arrow goes nowhere. The man with the dagger drops into a crouch over Tomas's father, his eyes everywhere at once.

“Godsdamnit, Rose.”

Draven passes me before I’ve registered him, blade out, his other hand raised toward the sky in a gesture I don’t understand.

Noctis bolts past me on my left. He skids to a stop near the men, snarls once at the sky, and then hurls himself into the tree line beyond the cottage.

I’m at Tomas’s father in three more strides. I drop to my knees in the snow beside him.

It’s so bad.

His coat is ripped from shoulder blade to hip in three long parallel tears. The blood is steaming in the snow around him in pulses, which means his heart is still pumping, and the cuts are deep enough that I can see something pale underneath. Bone, maybe rib, I can’t tell yet and don’t have time. He’s wheezing, face down, one cheek pressed into the snow, and there is a noxious smell coming off the wound.

The spineback’s spines were in the wound. I remember learning about this creature in Professor Nestor’s class. Translucent wings, covered in barbed spines, and they hunt in pairs.

Fuck.

I can see the barbed spines that broke off in the parted muscle, three or four shards each the length of my finger, and around each shard the skin has started to do something I do not have a word for. A faint blue-black ring is spreading outward from each piece of bone…corruption.

I reach for his shoulder to move him.

“Don’t,” he gasps into the snow, and the sound of his own voice makes him cry out from the pain.

“I know. I’m sorry. I have to look. Can you hear me? Stay with me. Where’s Tomas?”

“I told him to stay inside with his mother.” His voice is gravel. “Heard the bell. Came out to…to draw it off the houses.”

“You did well.” I’m reaching into my pack already. My hands have started to shake but are still moving.

Above us, somewhere I cannot see, something shrieks.

The bell tolls again, and Draven drops to his knees next to me.

“Rose, package the wound. We need to move.”

I shake my head. That’s not what our training is. Packaging is for clean cuts.

“There are barbed spines in the wound.” My voice is low so the men don’t hear. “Corruption is already visible.”

Draven goes still. He takes one slow breath, nods once, and takes the pack from me. He shoves one of his daggers into my hand.

“Cover my back.”

I nod, in disbelief he’s trusting me with watching his back. I’m even more thankful he didn’t tell me to cut the corruption out myself, because we both know how that would have gone. I whirl around and search the snow and the rooftops for the spineback.

“Do you know how many there are?” I shout over the wind at the two men.

The bearded one with the bow shifts his weapon. “I’ve only seen two.”

His eyes are tracking the sky. Then they snap past me, and I watch them go wide.

He isn’t looking at the sky anymore.

I flip around.

A twisted polar bear is coming toward us across the snow.

Easily over a thousand pounds, it pauses ten yards out and lifts its snout into the air, taking long deep inhales, like it’s trying to figure out what kind of meal we’ll make. Its ears are too long. Something black is oozing from the corners of its eyes and running down its face in slow streaks, staining the matted white fur in long dark tears.

The eyes themselves are bright red, and it’s looking at us like it wants to find out what’s underneath our skin.

“Draven.” I reach behind me without taking my eyes off the bear, my hand finding his shoulder.

I don’t know if this is one of those times when you keep eye contact or one of those times when you don’t. We haven’t covered twisted polar bears in class. If they’re anything like normal polar bears, this one definitely wants to know what’s inside us and probably wants us for breakfast on top of it.

“Kind of busy, Rose.”

I grab the top of his half up bun and yank his head sideways so he’s looking at the bear.

“Oh.”

Behind us, the two men break and run for the nearest cottage.

I don’t know whether to call them cowards or smart. They left their friend face down in the snow.

The bear lowers its head. Its red eyes lock onto mine. It charges.

I have no time to react. I plant my feet in the snow and bring the dagger up in front of me, and Draven gets to his feet beside me. His wings burst out of his back in a flash of darkness so fast I feel the air pull around us.

He sweeps his other arm forward.

Shadows pour out of his palm.

I can’t look at the bear anymore. I’m staring at him, awestruck, as hundreds of small dark shapes peel out of his hand into the air around him. Hundreds of bats. Shadow stretched into wings and body and teeth. They condense in a wave above his head and pour past my shoulder in one long, shrieking cloud.

I whip around.

The bear is already trying to flee.

It’s halfway turned, plowing back toward the tree line, hundreds of small shadow shapes digging into its back and shoulders and face. Black tears run down its fur. Black wings cling to its head and rip at its eyes. It bellows and crashes through the snow into the trees.

A black streak shoots past me at ground level.

Noctis hits the bear’s flank in a leap, his jaws frothing, and locks down on something with his teeth.

The bear is swallowed by darkness as it disappears deeper into the forest. Wolf and shadows and bear and snow, gone.

“Maelis.”

I turn at the sound of my name. Draven glares at me.

“Cover me, or he’s going to die.”

I nod.

He drops back to his knees beside Tomas’s father. He’s already pulled the spines out of the wound. Long dark slivers lie in a pile in the snow next to him, four of them, five. He’s cutting away corrupted tissue with quick, efficient strokes like he’s done this before. He has a small pouch open in his other hand, and he’s pressing powder into the open cuts, one after another, sealing the bleeding without stitches, because there isn’t time for stitches.

Tomas’s father has gone limp under his hands, passed out I think from the pain, I hope.

I turn my back on them and face the storm.

I can still see the dark shape moving in the trees. The shadow bats are dispersing now, returning to nothing the way they came from nothing. Noctis's tail flicks once where I can see it through the gaps in the trunks and then goes still.

The bear is not coming back.

Then I hear a shriek.

It comes out of the snow above the rooftops, and I look up. The spineback is already in its dive.

It folds in on itself in midair and drops at us like a thrown stone, wings collapsing in toward its body, tail whipping behind it, the upside-down beak opening as it falls.

The dagger in my hand is too small for this, but there's no time for anything else.

I plant my feet over Tomas's father, bring the blade up, and scream.

The spineback adjusts at the last second. It veers. Its claws miss me by inches, and I feel the wind off its wing in my hair. My dagger snags on something as it passes overhead. The blade skips off bone, catches, then tears through membrane.

The spineback hits the snow ten feet from us with a sound like a falling tree.

It shrieks again and flails. One of its wings is half open and won't fold.

Draven is on his feet in one motion, his blade out.

"Stay with him."

He charges.

The spineback is already trying to take off again, flapping its undamaged wing and shrieking, the damaged wing dragging in the snow. Draven crosses the distance, and the spineback turns its head toward him, the upside-down beak opening, the long ribbed tongue lashing out, and Draven sidesteps it cleanly and brings his blade up under its upside down head.

The blade goes in, all the way to the hilt.

The spineback shrieks, then the sound cuts off, and the body collapses.

Draven yanks the blade out and turns, scanning the sky.

"Draven."

"I know."

"It's still up there."

"I know."

He takes one step toward me. That’s when the second spineback drops out of the snowy sky.

It dives at Tomas’s father.

I see it a half second before it’s on us, and I lunge across the body in the snow, my arms going up over Tomas’s father’s head, my own face turning into the curve of my arm, and as I push forward, my boot catches on something hard buried under the powder.

My ankle rolls.

A bolt of pain shoots up my leg, and I scream and fall over Tomas’s father. The spineback’s claws come down where I just was, and the wind of its wings hits me. I cover my head with both arms and brace.

The strike doesn’t come.

I hear Draven move. The spineback shrieks above me, close, and then Draven is there, his blade driving into the creature’s chest. I feel the impact through the ground. The spineback flails. Draven shoves the blade in deeper.

Behind him, a third spineback drops out of the sky.

I see it through the gap of my arms. It’s coming at his back.

“Draven!”

He’s already pivoting but can’t turn fast enough.

The spineback’s claws rake across his wing in one long downward pass, the bone spines catching, and Draven makes a guttural sound torn from somewhere deep in his chest.

He twists the blade out of the second spineback, lets it fall, and drives the same blade up through the chest of the third spineback as it tries to climb back into the air. The point of the blade comes out the spineback’s back. Both of them are dead.

The bodies hit the snow.

Draven is breathing hard, his wings trembling, his shoulders heaving. Then he turns to look over his own shoulder at his wing.

He can’t see it from that angle.

I push off Tomas’s father and try to stand.

My ankle gives.

I yelp and go back down on my hip in the snow, gripping my leg, biting down on the pain. Draven strides toward me.

He drops into a crouch and yanks the pack open.

“Rose.”

He pulls a scalpel out of the pack and pushes it into my hand. His fingers wrap around mine and the blade, and he holds on for a beat longer than he needs to.

“You have to cut the corruption out.” His eyes meet mine. “If you don’t get all the rot, my wing won’t heal. Do you hear me?”

I hear him.

Fuck, I hear him, and I look at the scalpel in my hand and feel my fingers start to shake.

I haven’t been able to cut since my father died, and now Draven is on his knees in front of me with corruption spreading up his wing, asking me to do the one thing my hands have refused to do for over a year.

“Draven,” I say, already feeling defeated.

Nella’s wing.

Black veins under the membrane. Her eyes. The bone saw I couldn’t lift. The way her face went still when the spreading reached her chest.

My father’s chest. The last look in my father’s eyes before he passed.

“I know what you’re going to say.” Draven’s fighting to stay calm. “I’m asking you anyway.”

The bell tolls above us, and I want to curse it. The twisted creatures are dead. I’m tired of hearing it.

The snow keeps falling.

I look down at the scalpel in my hand and up at his wing where the dark is already starting to spread, blue-black blooming around each torn place where the spines went through. I know I have to cut it out fast, or he will be just like Nella. If it has any chance at healing quickly, I need to cut.

My hands are shaking so hard I can barely keep hold of the scalpel.

He turns and gives me his back, and I see the full damage. It’s not as bad as Tomas’s father’s. It isn’t good either.

There are only two barbed spines.

I grab them and pull them out fast, tossing them into the snow.

Draven doesn’t make a sound.

I stare at the black veins spreading around the two gashes in his wing.

My hand won’t move.

Every time I cut, people die. Every time I don’t cut, people die. My father with his hand on my hand. Nella with her eyes still open looking at the ceiling. The way no one looks at me the same after… I can pretend I am

still a healer, because I am in school, but I am not a healer anymore. I am a girl with shaking hands who watches people die.

I'm going to pass out. I'm going to pass out on the man I'm supposed to be saving. I can hear my own breathing and cannot make it slow down.

The scalpel is so heavy.

It feels like I'm in the clinic. I'm at the table. My father is looking at me and waiting for me to —

"*Rose.*"

I flinch.

Draven's voice is sharp.

I drag my eyes up.

He has turned his head and is looking at me over his shoulder. His eyes are red at the edges, brighter than before, and his jaw is set in a way that is not patient.

"I don't have time for this."

"Draven, I —"

"*Cut.*"

"I can't."

"You godsdamn well can! Pick up your hand. Put the blade against my wing. Cut."

"Draven, you don't understand—"

"I understand fine," he says through his teeth. "I understand that I just killed three twisted creatures for you, I understand that I am bleeding corruption out of a wing I cannot reach, and I understand you are about to let me die because some part of you is still holding on to some past trauma, but I am here now and need you to cut."

I feel dampness on my cheeks. I didn't know I was crying.

"I can't —"

"Maelis, look at me."

I look.

His eyes are red, and his face is gray under it, and there is sweat at his temples, and he and I both know he'll never fly again if I don't do something and fast.

"If I die in this snow because you couldn't cut, I am going to be very disappointed in you."

I laugh despite being a sobbing mess.

"That's not—"

“Cut, Rose.”

My hand is still shaking. The scalpel is still heavy. My breathing is still too fast.

But there is something underneath the panic.

I want him to be okay.

I want him to live. I want him to fly, and the wanting is louder than the panic.

I lift the blade.

I touch the tip to the membrane inside the spreading dark.

My hand shakes. The blade slips. A bead of red wells where it shouldn’t, in healthy tissue, and I jerk back like I’ve burned myself.

“Fuck,” I sob. “Draven, my hands won’t —”

I feel a small weight on my shoulder and look over.

Poppy appears for the first time since last night without me noticing. She is climbing carefully down my arm, her tiny hands gripping my sleeve, her dark eyes fixed on mine.

She reaches the back of my hand.

She steps down and stands on her back legs, stretching her arms up until her tiny paws are over my fingers where they grip the scalpel.

They are so warm.

Something inside me goes quiet.

Poppy’s tiny hands push mine closer to Draven’s wing, and I focus on her warm paws. Her hands are on my hands the way my father’s hands were on my hands, and somewhere inside the panic, something my father taught me a long time ago surfaces. “Steady hands, Maelis.”

I lower the blade.

The scalpel finds the edge of the corruption.

My hand stops shaking.

I cut.

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Chapter Twenty-Eight

"We tell our worst truths to the people who have just kept us alive. There is no other moment that earns it."

— Veilguard Field Manual, margin note, author unknown



The day passed in pieces.

I learned Tomas's father's name is Edric. Once we got him inside and bandaged, he was incredibly grateful. His wife cried. Tomas gave Draven multiple hugs that he took in stride, awkwardly enough to make me giggle. Draven wrapped my ankle on Edric's kitchen floor, and I can walk on it now. It's not broken, just sprained. Edric's wife insisted we stay for a warm meal, and then Edric pressed a bottle of whiskey into Draven's hand as thanks, for saving his life.

I haven't seen Seamkeeper Ostric all day. I assume he's still manning his tower. I want to give him a piece of my mind for not helping, but it's not worth my time, and I'm not going to change the old man or the way these people have been doing things for gods know how long.

It's dark by the time we head back into our bedroom.

The fire in the nave is stocked up for the night, and the wind has died down some. I sit on the edge of the bed and pull off my boots one at a time. My ankle is swollen, and I catch Draven staring at it when I look up.

"What?"

He doesn’t answer and starts removing his boots.

Only his right wing is still out. He told me it should heal enough by morning to be able to retract it. Must be nice to have vampire healing.

I take off my leather pants and jacket. I can’t sleep in all these layers, and Draven has already seen my pink shorts. I have nothing to hide anymore.

He watches me. A smirk tugs at the corner of his mouth as he grabs his pillow off the bed, like he plans to sleep on the floor again. I don’t feel right making him do that after the day we’ve had. Not with his wing the way it is.

“Sleep on the bed.”

He stares at me for a beat.

“And you’re going to sleep on the floor?”

I stare at him for a second, crossing my arms over my chest. “What, you can’t stand the idea of sleeping so close to me?”

He tosses the pillow back onto the bed, sits down, and leans against the headboard.

“It’s you I worry won’t be able to keep your hands off me, Freckles.”

I laugh.

It might be the first time he’s broken that serious facade the whole trip. He grabs the whiskey off the nightstand, takes a couple of long pulls, and offers it to me.

I crawl onto the bed and lean against the headboard beside him. The bed is so small, and he is so large that our shoulders are touching. I don’t mind it.

I take the bottle and a long well-deserved drink. It burns all the way down to my belly until warmth blooms inside me and heats my cheeks. I pass it back.

“Today did not go how I expected it would.” He takes another drink and offers the bottle again.

“I didn’t know what to expect.” I take another swig. “That bell is going to haunt my nightmares for many nights to come.”

Draven chuckles and takes the bottle from me.

“That thing you did today with the shadow bats, is that a vampire thing or just a Draven thing?”

He pulls the tie out of his hair and lets it fall to his shoulders. A few pieces drop into his face, and I watch him brush them away with the back of his hand. His golden eyes find mine.

“I was hoping you’d forgotten about that.”

I burst out laughing.

“Forget hundreds of shadowy bats? You’re delusional if you think I’d forget that.” I take the bottle back and tip it toward him. “I hurt my ankle, not my head. Or did you forget?”

That half smirk appears again. “It’s a bloodline thing. Some in my family are blessed with the gift, but not all vampires have it.”

I take another sip, longer this time, and feel the warmth on the back of my tongue before I swallow. The whiskey has caught up with me. I can feel it in the way my fingers are warm against the glass and the way my thoughts are fuzzier than they were ten minutes ago.

I hand the bottle back, and before I have the sense to bite my tongue, I say, “You mean your royal bloodline. Prince Draven Aldric.”

I giggle.

He snatches the bottle out of my hand so fast I lose my breath. His expression has gone hard in a way I haven’t seen since the snow this morning, and the room has gotten very quiet. I’m suddenly aware of every place we are touching. My shoulder against his. My knee, close enough to his thigh to feel the heat. The slow rise and fall of his good wing tucked behind him.

If I were sober I think this silence would be unbearable, but the whiskey has put a soft layer between me and the moment, and I wait and watch the side of his face in the lamplight.

“Who told you?” he says at last.

It’s a confirmation, and we both know it.

“Nella’s journal.”

His jaw moves.

“She figured it out and was going to confront you about it, I think. She never got the chance.”

“Smart girl.”

He reaches over and sets the bottle on the nightstand, and I get the sense that we have both had enough whiskey for the moment. He tips his head back against the headboard and closes his eyes for a beat, and I watch the line of his throat in the dim light.

I slide down under the covers and rest my head on the pillow. The ceiling above us is old and water-stained, and the cracks in the plaster make shapes I trace with my eyes to distract my mind. After a moment, Draven

turns out the light and slides down beside me, careful with the wing, and we are lying side by side, staring at the same ceiling, and the only sound in the room is the wind outside and the small steady pop of the fire bleeding through the door from the nave.

“Alucard is my mother’s last name,” he says quietly. “I prefer it to Aldric. It’s less known.”

“Do a lot of people at Ashwell know who you really are?”

“The headmaster. A few of the professors. Some of the vampires, but not all.”

So that’s why his little circle is always around him. They are not friends, or not only friends. They are his court. The vampires at Ashwell with the right blood and the right names know exactly who he is, and they have been orbiting him this whole time, and I never saw it because I wasn’t looking for it. I’m shocked Ellavee didn’t see it. I almost let the prince of Valen die in the snow today. I think about that and cannot tell whether the cold feeling in my chest is the whiskey or the realization.

He probably would not have died. We would have found help eventually, but he sure as hell would not have been able to fly again. The man beside me is the heir to the Obsidian Throne and very nearly lost his wing because I couldn’t move my hand fast enough.

I roll onto my side to face him.

He stays on his back. His eyes are still on the ceiling.

“Why keep it a secret?” I ask. “Why are you at Ashwell at all?”

The moonlight is shining on the side of his face, and I can see him deciding how much to say and how much to hold back, so I don’t push. With Draven, the silence is part of the answer.

When he finally speaks, his voice has gone lower. “I went to the Vanguard Academy in the Shadowlands when I was young. I trained as a Vanguard and served as one for years. Vampires who graduate as Vanguards are arms of the Obsidian Throne. We do what the Throne asks of us. We hunt twisted creatures when there are creatures to hunt, and when there aren’t, we handle the rest. Threats to vampire dominance. Threats to the family. Threats my father deemed it best to remove quietly.”

He raises one hand and rubs his face slowly, like he is trying to wipe something off that isn’t there.

“I have been killing things since I was sixteen, that’s fifteen years of deaths on my hands. For a long time, I didn’t think much about it. It was

work. It was what I was raised to do. And then somewhere along the way, I stopped being able to remember the reasons, and I started having to invent them after the fact, and that was when I knew something in me had broken."

I don't breathe as my heart starts to pump faster behind my sternum.

"I told my father I was done. I told him I wanted to learn to do something other than take lives. I told him I wanted to come here and be a healer. He laughed at me, and I went anyway. The best Veilguard who ever lived has saved more lives than even the worst Vanguard has taken. I figured if I could be that, even half of that, then maybe whatever waits for me after this life would have a harder time deciding which side of the door to put me on."

It's not bitter. It's the voice of a man who has done the math and is making peace with the answer.

I want to reach out and touch him so badly my hand actually eases a half inch on the blanket before I stop it.

I stay quiet, waiting to see if there is more.

"I don't want the throne." His voice has gone almost too soft to hear. "I owe my father one more thing. After that, I'm done."

He reaches for the bottle on the nightstand and takes another long pull, and I sit up too, but I don't want any more whiskey. I face him on the bed with my legs folded under me.

"I don't think anything is waiting for you on the wrong side of the door. You saved someone today. We are halfway through our first year as healers, and you saved a man's life this morning. You walked away from a throne and a family and a life that made you good at killing because you didn't want to be that anymore. That is not the choice of a man whose soul is past saving. That is the choice of a man with a soul worth saving."

I lean forward and press my hand flat against his shoulder until he meets my eyes.

I smile.

It's not a tease or flirtation. It is the smile I give people I am trying to keep alive.

The corner of his mouth tilts up reluctantly, like he is giving in to something.

"You don't know what I've done, Rose."

"I don't have to. I know what you're doing now."

He looks at me for a long moment. The moonlight is doing something to his eyes. The gold has gone warm. He's so tired. I have never seen him this tired. And I think, watching him, that I am the only person in this entire kingdom he has told any version of this story to in a long, long time.

He drops his eyes and sets the bottle back on the nightstand without taking another drink.

"Tell me, Rose," he says. "Why couldn't you cut before today?"

He has done me the courtesy of changing the subject, but the subject has not actually changed at all. He has given me his worst thing tonight. And he is asking me in the gentlest way I have ever heard him ask anything for mine.

I pull my knees up to my chest and look at the wall.

There are so many things I don't want to think about, so many things I have spent the better part of a year trying not to think about, so many nights in bed at Ashwell promising myself that tomorrow would be different.

I take a breath. "You're not the only one who's taken a life."

He waits with that patient stillness that has unnerved me since the day I met him, and somehow tonight it doesn't unnerve me at all. I start to tell him about Charlie.

"My father was the only healer in Ironfen, had been since before I was born. He had a clinic on the ground floor of our home. People came at all hours, he treated them downstairs, and most nights he'd come up the stairs covered in someone else's blood and wash off in the basin before he came to dinner. I worked with him in the clinic from the time I could cut bandages. I was his apprentice, and I was going to be his partner, taking over for him when he got too old to stand at the table. That was the plan.

"A little over a year ago, we were finishing up a procedure after dark. A man from the next village had been brought in with an abscess in his thigh, and we'd opened him up, drained it, packed it, and sent him home in the wagon his wife had brought him in. The procedure went fine. We were the only two left in the clinic, and the floor needed cleaning before we shut down for the night."

I lean over him and take the bottle from the nightstand and sip.

"There was a lot of blood on the floor, as usual after a procedure. Most nights we cleaned as we went, but the man had been bad enough that we hadn't gotten to it. I told him I'd handle the floor. He'd been on his feet for

hours. He sat down on the stool by the cabinet and started cleaning the instruments, and I went into the back for the mop and the bucket.”

The vivid images of that night return to me.

“He stood up to put the last of the instruments back. He had three of the long forceps in his hand, the kind we used for deep retraction in larger procedures. I’d put the wet mop down on the floor in front of where he was standing, and I hadn’t warned him because I assumed he’d seen me put it there. The floor was wet. He stepped where I’d mopped, and his foot went out from under him.”

Draven goes still.

“I was facing the cabinet. I heard him slip and fall. The metal hit the floor, and then I heard a sound from him I’d never heard him make in my life. When I turned around, he was on his side on the floor, and one of the forceps had gone into him, below the right ribs, at an angle up into his abdomen. The handle was sticking out. He was holding it with one hand, like he was trying to keep it still.”

I start to feel my pulse in my ears.

“It had gone in, up to the handle. He was already going pale and I was in shock like how is this happening? This freak accident.”

I take the bottle back and drink and keep it this time.

“He told me to help get him on the table. He told me to get under his shoulders and drag him, and somehow I did. I got him onto the surgical table, but the forceps were still in him. The blood ran off the edge of the table and onto the floor I’d mopped, and the sound of it hitting in steady drops was the loudest thing in the room for a long time.”

I try to breathe normally.

“He talked me through the setup first. He had me wash my hands. He had me get out the suture kit and the lamp and the silk and the saline, and he told me to lay out everything I might need. I did it in the wrong order, and he corrected me. His voice stayed calm the whole time. He was already going gray, and his lips were going the color lips go when someone’s bleeding out, and his voice was still so calm. He told me he was proud of me. He told me I was going to be all right. He was calm for the both of us.”

I shake my head.

“He told me what he thought had happened to him on the inside. He said the forceps had probably gone through the peritoneum and either nicked the liver or one of the vessels around it. He said the most likely

source of the bleeding was a branch of the hepatic artery or one of the portal vessels feeding into it. He told me the procedure I was going to need to do, and he made me say it back to him before I started.”

I drink.

“He told me to extend the incision around the entry point so I could see what the forceps were touching. I had to follow the tract of the forceps with my eyes and not my hand, because my hand would go where my eyes told it to. He picked up the scalpel and put it in my hand and folded my fingers around it himself, because I was already shaking too hard to hold it on my own.

“I tried to extend the incision but couldn’t. My hands wouldn’t stop shaking. I cut once badly, and the wound bled harder than it had been before, and he told me to stop and breathe. He told me I had to do this for him. He told me I knew how. He told me he’d taught me how. He kept saying my name over and over.”

I have to wait before I can keep going.

“I cut again, and that time I did it right. I don’t know how I did it, but I did. I opened the wound and could see the forceps inside him. It was up against something pulsing that I couldn’t name in the moment. He told me to identify it before I clamped, and I tried to look closer, and his voice was getting quieter, and I was trying to find the clamp on the tray and his voice was getting quieter, and I told him I had it. He didn’t answer me, and I looked up at him and saw his eyes were heavy and distant.”

I wipe the back of my hand over my cheek where a stray tear had fallen.

“His pulse was still there when I checked it. Fast and weak. I told myself he’d passed out from the pain and the blood loss and kept going. I clamped what I thought was the source. I think I did it correctly. The bleeding slowed. I withdrew the forceps the way he’d told me to, slowly, and the bleeding came back, and I tried to find what I’d clamped in the field but couldn’t see anymore because there was too much blood. I packed the wound, held pressure, and kept telling him I was almost done.”

I take another drink.

“His pulse stopped while I was holding pressure on his abdomen. I climbed onto the table. I’d seen him do compressions before on an old woman who’d collapsed at the market when I was younger, and I knew the rhythm of it and the depth. I started compressions on his chest. I gave him breaths. I checked his pulse between rounds. I kept going for I don’t know

how long. My arms were shaking, and I kept going. I was still doing compressions when my mother and sister came in through the front of the clinic."

Draven's hand had found mine across the blanket. I don't know when it happened.

"They'd been at my aunt's house across the village. They walked back together. The clinic door was unlocked because we hadn't closed up yet. My mother came in first and saw him on the table and saw me on top of him. The sound she made will live in me for the rest of my life, the most blood curdling scream. She came across the room and pulled me off him. My little sister stood in the doorway and didn't move."

I rub the tears out of my eyes.

"My mother kept asking me what I'd done. Her hands were on my shoulders and she was shaking me. I tried to tell her about the forceps and about him slipping on the floor I'd mopped and about him telling me what to do. I don't think she heard any of it."

I take a long breath.

"She hasn't asked me what happened. I think she can't bear to hear it. I think if she let me tell her, she'd have to forgive me, and she doesn't know how. Most days, she can barely look at me.

"And every time I pick up a scalpel, I'm back on that table. His voice is in my ear telling me to find what's bleeding, and I can't make my hands do what he's telling them to do, not when it's a person on the table and there's blood in the field and someone's talking me through it."

It's quite for a long minute.

"Until today."

I look at him.

"Until you."

He studies my face, and I have to look away.

I keep my eyes on the wall. The crack in the plaster runs from the windowsill all the way up into the corner where the ceiling meets, and I follow it with my eyes and wait.

His thumb shifts once across the back of my hand in a soothing circle.

"He told you to find what was bleeding, and you did, Rose."

He shifts next to me.

"You just couldn't stop it in time. That's not the same thing."

I close my eyes. The tears come faster. They've been coming the whole time but now they're coming the way they should have been coming for a year. I don't try to stop them, because there's no one in this room who's going to look at me wrong for it.

"Come here."

His voice is rough. He shifts on the bed, slow and careful with the wing behind him, and his arm comes around my shoulders and pulls me into his chest. His hand finds the back of my head and stays there. His other arm settles across my back.

I press my face into his shoulder and his shirt is rough against my cheek and warm from him, and I can hear his heartbeat under my ear, slow and steady, slower than mine, a vampire's heart at rest. I stay where I am with my face against his shoulder and my fingers gripping a fistful of his shirt. His thumb has started moving in a slow line at the back of my neck, under my hair, so light I would have missed it if I hadn't been so still.

I think about how much of him is touching me.

His chest. His arm across my back. His hand at the back of my head. His other hand at my neck.

If anyone had told me yesterday that Draven Alucard would be holding me through a crying fit at the end of a terrible day, I would have laughed in their face.

My face heats when I remember my dream, and I push off his shoulder and settle back under the covers, wiping my face clean.

Poppy appears and presses her fluffy body between us, rolling onto her back to look up at the two of us. Draven chuckles, and I can't help smiling, because she's ridiculous and adorable, and I don't think I could have cut today without her. Professor Nestor was right. I'm training to be a healer, and I was blessed with a second pair of hands.

"Why Poppy?" Draven asks. I turn onto my side so we're facing each other.

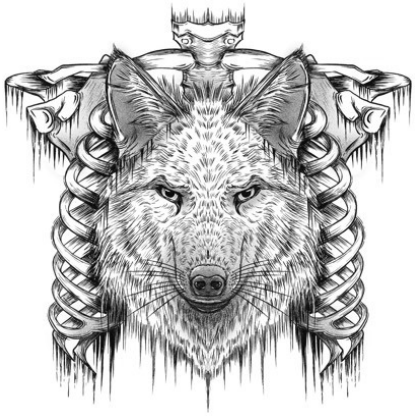
"I buried my father behind our home in a field of poppies."

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Chapter Twenty-Nine

"The body keeps secrets the mind has not agreed to."

— Professor Cane, Fracture and Form



Draven's arm is across my waist when I wake up.

I don't remember falling asleep after Poppy crawled between us. She's gone now, resting within me, and the fire must have burned out, because a cold has crept back into the room through the cracked window above us. Draven's chest is warm and hard against my back, and his hand is splayed open against my stomach where my top has shifted up in the night.

I keep my eyes closed.

If I move, he wakes. If he wakes, he's going to pull back, and the moment will end before either of us decides whether we wanted it to. Last night, I told this man things I haven't told anyone, and he held me through the worst of it, and somewhere in the dark I forgot for a few hours that I don't entirely trust him and that he's a bit of an asshole.

I haven't forgotten this morning.

He's the only person at this academy who keeps appearing in places I don't expect him to be. He vanishes for stretches, and then he's there again randomly in a dark alley, watching me. He has secrets with the headmaster, and he has friends whose company I wouldn't keep, and one of those friends is likely a murderer. I can't with any certainty say which side of any of that Draven is even on.

What I can say is that he carried me to my room when I was drunk, and he brought me Nella's journal when he didn't have to. He trusted me to cut the corruption from his wing yesterday, not that he had much of a choice. He saved a man's life yesterday and admitted to being the prince, to worrying about his soul, to family drama I never expected him to share with anyone, much less me.

This man is such a conundrum. He acts like he hates me, like I'm a despicable human who doesn't belong, and then he protects me, and now he's holding me in bed. And I poured part of my soul out to him last night, though I can blame that on the alcohol.

These are all things I need to think about later when I'm not pinned under a vampire prince's arm in a chapel bed pretending to be asleep.

His breath is even at the back of my neck, and I start to count it. Slower than mine. Around the eighth breath, he shifts, registering where his hand is.

His hand draws back across my stomach with careful slowness in an attempt not to wake me. I keep my breathing steady and my eyes closed as I feel him sit up and slip off the edge of the bed and then out the door into the nave.

I roll onto my back and stare up at the ceiling. My head hurts from a night of drinking, and I press my hands over my eyes and forehead. My eyes feel puffy from crying, and the memory of that night with my father floods my mind again.

My throat closes without warning. One moment I'm fine, and the next there's a fist wrapped around my windpipe, squeezing. The burning spreads down into my chest and settles behind my ribs like something alive, something with teeth. I inhale through my nose and feel my eyes start to well. I swallow hard, trying to shove the thoughts back into the locked box where I keep them.

I can't let myself think of the memories again. The good ones hurt worse than the bad ones somehow. It's easier to pretend. To remember him healthy and whole, humming off-key while he made breakfast, his reading glasses perpetually crooked on his nose. To let myself believe that if I went home tomorrow, he'd be standing in the doorway of the clinic, wiping his hands on that old brown apron, calling me in for dinner like nothing ever changed.

I'm a coward.

The thought of letting the truth settle over me completely, of accepting that he's gone, really gone, is so suffocating I cannot bear it. Losing someone you love is not a wound that heals with time. It is an amputation. It's a piece of yourself carved out and buried in the ground with them. And knowing they'll be gone forever. For all of eternity. For as long as your life stretches on, you'll never see that person again. Never hear their voice when they call your name. Never hear them yell at you for throwing rocks at the neighbor's fence again. Never feel their steady hands guiding yours as they teach you how to stitch a wound properly, patient even when you mess up for the tenth time. Never feel the weight of his hand on your head when you've done something right. The pride in his eyes that said more than words ever could.

Knowing gone means forever.

It's the most unbearable, suffocating, throat-wrenching pain I've ever known. And I can't let it consume me. If I let it in, even for a moment, it'll swallow me whole, and I'll drown in it.

After last night, after reliving everything and telling Draven what happened, it feels so fresh in my mind again. Like in the day-to-day I can pretend it never happened, but when I let the thoughts in, it all comes rushing back.

I feel my eyes start to well up, and the last thing I want to do is cry right now again, but I think admitting the full story out loud last night made me really start to accept it.

I'll never see my father again, never hear his voice again.

Tears blur my vision, and I quickly wipe my eyes, because I've cried enough and should be over it by now, but I don't think it's something I'll ever get over.

One of the things I fear most in the world is death and what comes after, and I wasn't ready to make peace with it. I may never be. Grief is not a wave that breaks and passes, it is the tide, and the tide always comes back.

Something small and warm presses into my side.

Poppy has appeared, and she climbs up my chest with her small hands, and her round dark eyes find mine, and she sits back on her haunches and tilts her head.

I sit up, lift her into my arms, and bury my face in her fur.

She doesn't make a sound. She lets me hold her. Her fluffy body is warm and steady against my chest, and her heartbeat is the same heartbeat

as mine.

“Hi, Pops,” I whisper into her fur.

She presses her face against the side of my neck.

I don’t know how long I sit there with her in my arms before I hear the clatter of something being set on the table in the next room. The soft scrape of a chair. The faint sound of a fire being stoked.

He’s still here. We have to walk back today, and my ankle is already protesting it.

I wipe my face with the back of my hand and kiss the top of Poppy’s head, and slowly put my feet on the cold floor.

I cannot fall apart in front of him.

Not again. Not twice in two days. Whatever last night was, I let him see too much already. I’m not going to walk out into that nave with red eyes and a swollen face and let him think I’m the kind of girl who cries every morning, the weak human he already thinks I am.

I press my palms against my eyes until the pressure spreads. I take three slow breaths and glance at Poppy.

“Want to find some breakfast?”

She’s off the bed and at the door before I can even get my leather pants on.

Food is always the way to her heart. Whoever said eidolons don’t need to eat clearly never met a raccoon.

I get dressed and head into the tiny bathroom with a single toilet attached to the bedroom and get cleaned up the best I can. I run my fingers through my hair, because gods forbid Professor Bale put a brush in our midterm pack.

Once I’m feeling like myself again, I head out of the bedroom and find Draven sitting in the chair with his feet kicked out in front of him, staring at the fire. His hair is pulled back into a usual half bun, but a couple of stray pieces have fallen near his mouth. I follow a dark strand and notice how full and smooth his lips are, and when he clears his throat, I realize I’m staring awkwardly. I brush my hands on my pants and walk over to the table.

“Seamkeeper Ostric was here. He said Lynn, Edric’s wife, dropped this basket off for us this morning.” Draven waves toward the basket sitting open on the table.

“Sad I missed him,” I say sarcastically as I walk over and peek inside.

Without Tomas's family, I fear we would have survived purely on crusty bread this entire trip. Inside the basket are a few hard-boiled eggs and grainy muffins. I toss a muffin to Poppy and start peeling an egg for myself.

"So…your wing's all healed?" I ask, looking over and realizing it's no longer visible.

"Mm."

"When should we head back?"

He gets to his feet, closing the door on the hearth. "I'm going to have a word with Edric, make sure he's healing alright. Pack our things and tell Ostric we're leaving, will you?"

I nod, rolling my eyes to myself, because I don't really care to talk to Ostric.

"I guess last night didn't change things. He's back to his cryptic bossy self this morning, isn't he?" I say to Poppy, who's stuffing her face with pieces of muffin next to the fire.

I eat a couple of eggs, make the bed, and throw everything into our backpack. I wrap up the rest of the muffins and the last egg and put it in our pack for later. Everything is as it was when we arrived, and I head up the stairs to the bell tower to let the seamkeeper know we're heading back to the academy.

The bell tower is set up as a bedroom with a giant bell in the center and floor-to-ceiling windows all around. Ostric has a desk and a bed up here. What a lonely life it must be, living here and observing the fissure in this mostly deserted village.

"Miss Rose."

His voice snaps my attention back to the present, and I shake my head.

"Seamkeeper Ostric, I wanted to bid you farewell. We'll be on our way imminently."

He doesn't look up from his ledger. His pen keeps moving for another moment, and then he sets it down carefully.

"You felt the seam, Miss Rose."

I freeze with my hand on the doorframe.

"I'm sorry?"

"The first night when you walked toward it, you felt something in your chest, did you not? A humming. A pull."

I don't know how he knows that. I never told him.

He looks up at me, his eyes narrow like he's skeptical.

“Most people do not feel anything when they stand near a fissure. They feel the cold but not the seam itself. The seam does not call to them. It called to you.”

My mouth has gone dry.

“That doesn’t mean anything, does it? Dozens of things could explain what I felt.” Though none come to mind, I’m sure there is an explanation.

“It means something.”

“Seamkeeper—”

“Your hands are not shaking this morning.”

I look down at them. How does he know about my hands?

“I noticed them when you arrived. Bone year students with shaking hands don’t usually walk back out of Holloweir. I am glad to be wrong about that, in your case.”

He picks up his pen again.

“Witness well, Miss Rose.”

He turns back to his ledger.

I stand there for a moment. This man lives such a peculiar and lonely life. I still don’t understand what the “witness well” nonsense is about, and honestly I’ll be glad to put this creepy village behind me. I don’t say anything else as I step out and descend the staircase.



The first hour is fine.

The second hour is also fine. I tell myself that, even when my ankle starts pulsing in a way that travels up the bone and into my hip. The path out of Holloweir winds up through the pines, switching back and forth across the slope, and the snow has been packed down enough by the wind that it’s not as bad as I thought it would be. Draven is ten feet ahead of me. He hasn’t looked back since we left the village.

I’m focusing on his cloak whipping in the wind to keep my mind off my ankle when my boot catches on a buried root, and I groan through my teeth before I can stop myself.

Draven stops walking.

“How long has it been hurting?”

“It’s not.”

“Rose.”

“It’s fine.”

“How long?”

I shift my weight off it, and the relief is embarrassing. “Maybe an hour. It’s the cold making it worse. It’s not that bad.”

“Sit down.”

“Draven—”

“Sit down or I am going to make you sit down, and you will not enjoy how I do it.”

I roll my eyes.

There’s a fallen log by the path, mostly clear of snow, and I drop onto it with as much dignity as I can manage, which is none. He turns and crosses to me in three long strides, and he’s already crouching in front of me by the time I’ve gotten my pant leg up over my boot.

He doesn’t speak as he unwraps the binding. The swelling has come back. My ankle has gone the color it was yesterday before he wrapped it, dusky and angry where the bone meets the joint, and he runs a thumb along it with that same careful efficiency he had when he wrapped it.

I look at the trees instead of at him.

“You should have said something an hour ago.”

“It wasn’t bad an hour ago.”

“You were limping forty minutes ago.”

“You were watching me limp for forty minutes. Do you have vampire eyes in the back of your head now?”

“I was listening to you limp.” He glances up at me, unamused. “Your stride changed. I am not deaf.”

I can feel my face getting warm and tell myself it’s the wind.

He finishes rewrapping, sits back on his heels, and looks up at the sky for the first time since we left the chapel. I follow his gaze. The clouds I noticed before we left have thickened and turned ominous. The light has gone flat in a way I don’t like, and the wind has picked up enough that the tops of the pines are bending in long, slow arcs.

“What is that?” I ask.

“That’s a storm.”

“How bad?”

“Bad.”

He looks back at me, serious in a way that has nothing to do with my ankle.

“How bad, Draven?”

“Storms in the Frostlands build out at the edge of the ice fields and then they come down all at once. We have an hour, maybe less. I’ve been watching it since we left the village, and it’s moving faster than I thought it would.” He looks at my ankle. “You’re not going to make it back to Ashwell tonight.”

“I can make it.”

“No, you can’t.”

“Alucard—”

“Rose, I’m not asking. We are not making it back tonight. You are not going to limp through a Frostlands blizzard on a sprain that has already gone bad once today, and I’m not going to carry you for six hours through a whiteout to prove a point.”

I open my mouth then close it. He’s right.

“Can’t you fly us there faster?” I ask, and he gives me an exasperated look.

“I can’t fly us that far in this kind of wind.” He stands and looks around, like he’s calculating distances. “There is a hunting blind not far from here. I saw it on the map this morning when I was checking the route at the chapel. Trappers used to run a line through this stretch in the warmer months. Most of the blinds are abandoned now.”

“How not far?”

“Twenty minutes. Fifteen if I carry you.”

“Draven—”

“Rose, do not start with me.”

“I am not starting with you. I am asking you not to carry me. I will walk.”

“You will hobble slowly, and the storm will be on us before we get there.” He looks at the sky again, and his jaw tightens. “Faster than I thought. Come here.”

I stand up and limp the two steps over to him, and I expect him to turn so I can climb on his back. Instead, he bends and hooks one arm under my knees and the other behind my shoulders and lifts me against his chest.

“Hold on.”

I slide my arms around him because the alternative is dangling, and I lock my fingers together at the back of his neck, and his hair is loose where it has come out of his bun. It grazes against my fingers.

He starts walking.

He travels faster than he did when I was walking behind him. I hadn't realized how much he was slowing down for me. The wind has picked up another notch since we stopped, and the snow has started coming down again, sideways, and I press my face into the side of his neck, because the cold is biting at my cheeks, and there is nowhere else to put my face that isn't his shoulder or his throat.

He doesn't say anything about it.

Neither do I.

"Doesn't vampire blood have healing qualities? Couldn't you just give me a taste and my ankle will be good enough for us to make it back?"

I realize how it sounds the moment it leaves my mouth.

His lips quirk. "You want to taste me, Rose?"

Heat climbs up my neck. I open my mouth, close it, open it again, and produce a sound I would rather die than describe.

He chuckles. "I don't know how your body would react to my blood. It's not something vampires go around doing lightly."

Noctis appears, and I see him disappear in the distance.

We make it maybe five minutes before the storm breaks.

"Noctis found the blind. We're close," he says, and I nod into his neck, thankful he didn't say anything else about me tasting him.

One moment the snow is coming down hard, and the next the wind nearly knocks us over. The trees go from bending to whipping, and the snow turns from falling to flying, and I can't see the path anymore, because there is no path, only white moving sideways at an impossible speed, and Draven curses under his breath and stops walking.

"Hold tight to me, Rose."

"What?"

His wings come out.

They unfurl behind him in a single fluid motion, a span wider than he is tall, dark and leathery and impossibly fast, and the wind catches them, and he braces against it and they curve forward.

He isn't flying us.

He's using his wings as a shield.

The right wing folds around me at his shoulder, the membrane curving along my back, and the left wing comes up at his other side, and the wind that was in my face a second ago is suddenly cut off, redirected around the wings, and the snow goes from sideways to spilling off the edges of the membrane in soft drifts that don't touch us.

It is dramatically warmer inside the wings.

I hadn't understood until now that they were body heat. Whatever blood is in them is his warm blood, and the air inside the curve of them is the first warm air I have felt since we left the chapel. I always thought vampires ran cold, but Draven is always warm.

I tilt my head back to look up at him. His face is six inches from mine, and his hair is loose around his jaw, and his eyes are bright in the dim filtered through the wings.

"We are almost there."

"How do you know?"

"I can see what Noctis sees," he says, and I almost fall out of his arms when I look back at him.

"You can see through your eidolon's eyes? Is that normal? Will I see through Poppy's someday?"

"You really want to talk about this now while I carry you through a fucking storm?" he yells over the wind, and I narrow my eyes.

"Yes, I do."

"Gifts are always different. You're human and shouldn't even have an eidolon. I can't begin to imagine what may develop as your bond grows."

I can't wait to bring this up in class.

The trees thin ahead of us into a small clearing, and I see a wood structure built up against the trunk of a massive pine, partially elevated with a slanted roof that has held against the snow on top of it. It looks more like a shed than a shelter. The walls are old and dark with weather. There is a single door, latched, with no window beside it.

"That's the blind?"

"That's the blind."

"It looks like it might collapse if I sneeze."

"Then don't sneeze."

He carries me the last twenty feet, and his wings stay forward around us until we are almost at the door, and only then do they retract, folding back

into him in the same fluid motion they came out in. The wind hits me again, the second they are gone, and I tuck my face harder against his neck.

He sets me down gently in front of the door, and I lean against the wood with my weight on my good leg while he tries the latch. It sticks for a second and then gives, and the door swings inward into a dark space that smells like old wood and dry pine needles and nothing alive.

He goes in first.

I hear him moving around inside, scraping his boot on a plank floor, and a moment later he comes back to the door and holds out his hand.

“It’s solid. Come in before the storm hits worse.”

I duck inside, and it’s a relief to be out of the wind, but it’s still freezing in here.

It’s a very small room, short enough that we’re forced to crouch, the ceiling low and slanted toward a single rectangular window we can’t see out of because it’s buried in snow. It’s dark in here, not pitch-black but enough that I can make out the shape of Draven and not much else.

I’m missing that hearth in the chapel right about now.

Actually, I never thought I’d say this, but I’m missing Ashwell. How are all the other teams doing? How’s Jace doing? Probably bonding with Killian over how much they despise me. Jace has his reasons. Killian simply despises me for being me.

There’s a single wool blanket folded on the floor in the corner. Draven nudges it toward me with the toe of his boot.

“Romantic,” I say and wrap it around myself.

It doesn’t help. The cold has seeped past the layers and into my bones, and my teeth start chattering before I can clamp my jaw shut. My hair is a tangle of waves, and I quickly push it out of my face and braid it to the side.

“How long until the storm passes, do you think?”

“Hopefully not more than a couple hours. It looked like it was moving at a good pace.” He lowers himself to the ground against the wall and stretches his legs out, his head tilted back against the wood.

“That’s the most optimistic thing I’ve heard you say all week.”

“I am full of surprises.”

“Are you?”

“You shouldn’t look so suspicious. It is unflattering,” he says, and I grunt.

“I’m always suspicious of you, Alucard. You’ve given me nothing else to work with.”

I try to slow my body down, but now that we’re not moving, the shivering has gotten worse. I rub my hands together and blow warm air into them. The blanket might as well be a sheet of paper for all the good it’s doing.

“Your lips are turning blue.”

I look over at him. He’s watching me from the wall, his arms crossed loosely, his head still tipped back.

“It’s too dark in here for you to tell what color my lips are.”

“Vampire eyes.”

“That is going to get old very fast.”

“It’s already old. You’re still going to have to live with it.”

I drag the blanket tighter and try not to let him see my hands shaking inside it. “I’m fine.”

“Your jaw hasn’t stopped moving in five minutes.”

“That is a posture choice.”

“That is hypothermia.”

“You exaggerate.”

“You are stubborn. Why do you always try to hide how you feel?”

“I’m not stubborn. I’m a bone year student on a midterm who has been told her entire life that humans are weaker than every other bloodline, and I would prefer not to prove the point on the floor of a hunting blind in front of a vampire who would never let me live it down.”

He looks at me for a long moment, his eyes like molten honey.

“Come here.”

“I’m fine where I am.”

“Damn it, Maelis, come here.”

Moving would mean admitting I want to, and I am not ready to admit that to him or to myself.

“You are going to make me come over there, aren’t you?” Draven sighs deeply and repositions right next to me. I feel the heat of his body instantly and think maybe I shouldn’t have been so stubborn.

He lifts his arm without comment.

I duck under it and tuck myself against his side, my shoulder pressed to his ribs, and his arm comes down around my shoulders and his hand settles on the outside of my upper arm.

Noctis appears at my other side without warning.

He is so big the entire blind shifts when he settles in. He stretches out along the floor, his massive black body pressed against my hip, and he lays his head down across my lap with the deliberate care of an animal who knows exactly how much he weighs. Poppy chooses now to appear and drape herself over Noctis, snuggling into the fur on his back.

The shivering stops within a minute. The cold in my fingers turns from numb to aching, which I know means they are warming up, even though it feels worse for a second.

“This is terrible luck,” I say mostly because I cannot stand the silence. “It’s like everything is stacked against us. I wonder if any of the other teams have had it this hard.”

“I would not assume any of the teams have had it easy.”

“At least they don’t have a freezing snowstorm on top of whatever obstacles they’re facing. Bale said we were the only team in the Frostlands.”

I throw a hand out to exaggerate, and Draven chuckles.

“Tell me why you’re here, Freckles.”

I know exactly what he means, but I can’t resist. “Because a storm forced me into whatever this is with a broody vampire prince.”

His chest springs under my ear in something that is almost a laugh. “You’re going to have to cut the prince part out of your vocabulary when we get back.”

I tilt my head up to look at him. “Oh, so now you want me to keep your secrets?”

“Why did you come to Ashwell?” he asks, not bothering to acknowledge the question. “How did you apply?”

I consider lying but have nothing left to protect that I have not already handed him.

“I didn’t apply.”

His head turns enough that I know he heard exactly what I meant. I tell him about the parchment that found me in my father’s office. About the line at the bottom in handwriting I didn’t recognize. About the silver fire that ate the page when I asked who wrote it, and the fae who threaded me out of Ironfen with one hand on my shoulder and not a single answer. I tell him about the mirror, what it said about my blood walking these halls before me, and about every empty record I have searched in the library since.

He is so still while I talk that I almost forget he’s breathing.

“If you keep my secret about my identity,” he says, “maybe I’ll help you.”

My interest sharpens. “You’ll help me find the mirror? How?”

“I have my ways. Is it a deal, Rose?”

He must want this hidden more than I realized, though I can’t for the life of me work out why.

“It’s a deal.”

“You need to be careful with the headmaster. He wouldn’t keep the mirror in his office. It’s too well traveled. He will keep it in his private quarters, and I can tell you where they are.”

“Generous of you. The academy is large, but it doesn’t exactly take a genius to find the staff housing. I would have managed.”

“You would have wasted time and likely gotten caught. I will save you the trouble and tell you which one is his. And I will distract him so you can get inside.”

I turn fully toward him.

“When? How?”

“I already know the right time. You will have to be patient.”

I cross my arms. “Enlighten me.”

“The end-of-year ball. All students. All faculty. The breath year graduates. The headmaster will be there, and I’ll keep him distracted while you get the answers you seek. Then we are even.”

I hadn’t realized we were keeping a tally.

“Alright,” I say slowly, “you help me with this, and I take your secret to the grave.”

I tilt my head up to look at him, expecting him to be staring at the wall.

But he’s looking at me. His face is so close I can see little flecks of red and amber within the gold of his irises. I should look away but I can’t.

I follow the line of his jaw, the short manicured beard he keeps trimmed close. The small scar at his temple I’ve never noticed before. My eyes trail down to his lips, and they part slightly, like he’s about to say something but hasn’t committed to it yet.

I think about my dream.

I think about crawling into his lap and making it a reality and how incredibly reckless that would be.

“Draven,” I breathe.

“Freckles.”

“You’re looking at me.”

“I am.”

“You should stop.”

“Probably.”

Outside, the wind has dropped to a steady moan against the walls of the blind. Inside, I can’t hear anything except my own pulse in my ears, and the slow steady thrum of his under my hand, where it has somehow ended up against his chest. I don’t remember moving it there.

“Rose.”

“Yes.”

“If you don’t move in the next three seconds, I’m going to do something that is going to make this entire walk back to Ashwell very awkward.”

I don’t move.

He breathes out, slow and unsteady. I have never heard him be unsteady about anything, and the sound of it goes through me like something hot.

His hand comes up between us, like he’s giving me time to stop him, and then his fingers brush along my cheek, and his thumb settles at the corner of my mouth. I swallow, pulling my bottom lip between my teeth.

His face is very, very close.

If I tilt my head up the last fraction of an inch, his mouth will touch mine.

I dart my tongue out, wetting my lips, and stare into those gorgeous, mesmerizing eyes.

I tilt.

Something slams against the door.

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Chapter Thirty

"Power is not measured in what one can do. It is measured in what one does when the doing costs something."

— Professor Clementine, Endurance of Pain



I jerk back so hard the blanket slides off my shoulders.

Noctis is on his feet before I've registered the movement, a low, dangerous growl rolling out of his chest, vibrating through the floorboards beneath me. My pulse is still in my throat. My lips are still warm where Draven's thumb was. Whatever was about to happen between us a second ago has been ripped out of the room.

"Miss Rose, Mister Alucard."

The voice on the other side of the door is muffled, but I'd know it anywhere.

"If the two of you are alive in there, I would prefer to find out before I freeze to death looking for you."

It's Emil.

Draven's eyes find mine, and gods help me, they're still gold. Still on me in a way that makes the air in the blind feel two degrees warmer than it is.

"Rose."

"Yes?"

“We are going to talk about that.”

My breath catches.

“Are we?”

I turn away before he sees something on my face that I’m not ready to put words to, and I push myself up off the wall and pull the door open before this conversation can go anywhere, I’m not ready to take it.

Because gods, I don’t even know what we were about to do.

The wind comes in first, and Emil ducks under the lintel after it, his cloak weighted with snow, his silver hair gone stiff with frost where it has come out of his hood.

“Ah. Miss Rose, Mister Alucard, you are alive.”

His face is a shade paler than the last time I saw him. The skin around his eyes looks bruised, like a body that has been giving more than it has and knows it.

“What’s happened?” Draven asks, his eyes narrowing.

“There’s been an incident in the Shorelands. A large fissure opened this morning, not cycle sized but close.”

He shakes his head, his eyes dropping to the floor.

A chill that has nothing to do with the wind flits up my spine.

“Why are you here?” I ask. “Is everyone alright?”

“The fissure was long, and there have been many casualties. Many more injured. You’re the last pair I’ve come to thread back to campus. Your help will be needed.”

My stomach drops out from under me.

“Is Jace alright?”

My hand is on Emil’s shoulder before I know I’ve reached for him, and my fingers have closed around the wet wool of his cloak hard enough that I see his pale eyes flick down to where I am gripping him.

“Did you bring Jace back okay?”

He doesn’t meet my stare.

“Emil, tell me.”

Something is off. I can’t lose Jace before we mend things. The last time I saw him…The look he gave me… If something has happened to him…

“Take us now, Emil,” Draven insists.

I turn to look at him.

Whatever he saw in my face has changed his. The gold has gone out of his eyes. His jaw has gone tight. The man who was leaning over me a

minute ago with his thumb at my mouth is gone, and in his place is the version of Draven I met at Ashwell.

Emil steps between us before I can find my voice, one hand settling on my shoulder, the other on Draven's. The pressure of his grip is firm, and I close my eyes.

I'm not ready for any of this.

I don't have time to register the threading. I don't have time to brace for the cold that pours through my bones the way it did the night Emil came for me in my father's office. I don't have time to do anything but feel my own heartbeat slamming against my ribs while the world drops out beneath me.

All I can think about are my friends.

All I can think about is Jace.

The world reassembles around me too fast, and my knees buckle. Draven's arm tightens at my back before I've registered I'm falling.

The cold of threading is still moving through my bones in pulses when the noise hits.

Oh gods, the noise.

I blink rapidly, stepping away from Draven and Emil. We touched down in the entry hall of the patient wards. I have been in the wards a hundred times this year, and I've heard the soft shuffle of menders in corridors, the low murmur of healers conferring at desks, the occasional cry or scream of a patient that gets absorbed into the stone walls before it reaches the next floor.

The screaming reaches my ears first. Then the shouting of someone giving orders. There's a metallic clatter of instruments being thrown into trays too fast, and the sound of something being mopped up. Someone is sobbing.

The smell hits me next. Blood.

There's so much blood and antiseptic I almost gag.

"Rose—" Draven starts, but I can't talk to him right now. We're not out there anymore. We're back in the real world, and I need to find out what's happening.

The main level has been turned into triage for the injured. It looks like Emil brought back students and some non-students as well. I see three bodies on the ground with a drape pulled up over them, and I swallow the lump forming in my throat.

"Maelis."

The voice is wrecked.

I spin around to see Lux across the hall, her pink hair pulled back in a knot at the nape of her neck. There's blood on her sleeves and smeared across her forehead where she must have wiped it without thinking. She's still wearing the midterm gear she was issued for her own assignment, but the sleeves are pushed up to her elbows like she's been working.

Her face crumples the moment she sees me, and she crosses the room at a run.

"Maelis."

She slams into me hard enough that I stumble back, her arms going around me, and she's shaking. She has her face in my hair and her hands clutching the back of my coat.

Lux is crying.

"You're alive. I didn't know where you were assigned and—"

"I'm alive. I'm here. Are you hurt?" I pull back and look her up and down.

"No, I'm alright, it's bad. It's so bad. My father has been helping thread people into the academy all day. Miles is dead, Maelis."

I didn't care for Miles, but fuck I didn't want him to die.

I shake my head and pull her into me again.

"Sera, Tobin, and eight others are dead so far. The Shorelands had sixteen pairs—"

I pull back and look at her.

"Jace?"

I'm scared to say his name, afraid of what the answer will be.

"My father brought him back. Ellavee too."

Something inside me loosens.

"But he's in bad shape, Maelis. Professor Nestor took him upstairs a few minutes ago for surgery. You can probably go see him from the gallery."

I nod, peeling off toward the stairs, ignoring my ankle completely.

I make it to the eighth floor in record time, panting as I reach the first operating room and peek inside through the window in the door.

Fuck.

They're removing corruption from someone, and all I see is oozing black flesh being held up and tossed onto a scale. Once the healer shifts to

the side, I see the patient. It's not him. I don't recognize them, and I go to the next window.

I see the large bone saw before I see anything else, moving across a leg above the knee, and my heart lurches into my throat.

Oh gods.

I look up to see who the patient is, and it's a girl I recognize from Fracture and Form, but I don't recall her name. She's sedated, but my heart breaks for her, because they may save her life, but she's never going to be a Veilguard now without a leg.

I jog to the next room and see a flash of a silvery-white wing.

That's him.

My angel.

I push the door open, running to the bedside to get a better look.

"Miss Rose." Professor Nestor sounds shocked and annoyed.

Then I see him.

"Jace," I whisper as I come up beside him.

He's still awake, coherent, and shockingly calm for the state of him. I swallow as I take in his face. His left eye, still attached to the muscles, is hanging out on his cheek. Someone is there on the other side of him, fully suited up with a mask, gown, and gloves, keeping the eye moist with a syringe of clear fluid.

Jace's good eye finds mine. I place my hand on his shoulder.

"It's going to be okay. Professor Nestor is a mad genius, remember? He'll put it back in. You'll still see out of it."

I'm nodding more for myself than for Jace but trying to reassure him.

"Miss Rose, do not make false promises. This boy's eyeball has a twisted creature's nail stuck in it. It may be beyond saving."

I suck in a breath, my eyes going wide as I look back down at Jace, who still hasn't spoken.

"Is he hurt anywhere else?" I ask, looking across the room at Nestor, where he's arranging a tray of tools he'll need for the procedure.

"He took a bad hit to the head, but he'll survive." He looks up at me.

"I want to scrub in. I need to make sure he's okay."

Professor Nestor shakes his head. "You're too attached to this. Go be useful somewhere else. I need to sedate him now and get started. Out with you." He waves a gloved hand at me toward the door.

I take a step closer to Jace and place my hand gently atop his head, brushing a strand of his light-blond hair from his temple.

“I’ll be watching the whole time. You’re going to get through this.”

His good eye narrows on me.

“Leave. I don’t want your face to be the last thing I see if I don’t make it.”

I almost choke. What he says feels like a stab right through my chest.

I take my hand off his head like he burned me and stare down at him for a moment longer.

“Don’t worry, Red. I’ll take good care of him.”

I look up for the first time to the person across the table with the syringe, and Malric winks at me above his mask.

Malric is assisting, of all people.

I reach across the table, shoving his shoulder without thinking. “Get the fuck off him.”

Someone grabs me around the waist from behind.

“Remove her from my operating room,” Nestor barks, and I’m shoved out the door before I can do anything else.

I hurry around the corner and sprint up the few tiny steps to the observation room, pressing my hands to the window and looking down over Jace.

He’s sedated now, his good eye taped shut.

I can’t hear anything.

I glance around until I see a placard like the one in the lift and hold my hand to it.

Come on, Ashwell. Please give me this.

The placard glows bright for a moment, and then the sound in the operating room comes through, carrying clearly into the observation room.

Thank you.

“Most of the muscles are intact. If not for the corrupted claw, we could place the eye back inside. He would lose sight, but with proper reconstruction, his eye would still move and look normal to everyone else.” Nestor’s voice fills the small gallery as he teaches the two blood years assisting him.

I want to yell at them. *Yes, that’s a viable option. Try to remove the corruption and place the eye.* Jace would want to keep his eye at all cost, even if only for aesthetic purposes.

But I don’t hit the window or I’ll be kicked out of the observation room too.

Gods, I can’t stop replaying what he said in my head. My hand slowly drifts over my chest where it aches.

Did he mean, “I don’t want to die looking at the girl who hurt me?” Or did he mean, “I don’t want to die looking at the girl I love, because if I do, I won’t have the strength to fight?” Or perhaps it was, “I fucking hate you, Mae. Get out of my face.”

I need to get out of my own head and stop over analyzing. The important thing is that Jace is going to live. He’s going to be okay.

“The corruption has tracked along the optic canal,” Nestor says as he works. “We cannot save the globe. We are proceeding with enucleation.”

I squint. The eyeball is lifted free in his gloved hands, the dark claw still penetrating the side, black veins lacing the sclera where they should be red. He places it in the kidney dish at his elbow.

“Note the involvement of the optic nerve. Completely transected. There is no scenario where vision could have been preserved.” His voice is calm, technical, detached.

He looks down at his glove, where Jace’s blood has soaked into the linen of his sleeve. His head tilts a fraction. His brow furrows. He looks up at one of the blood years assisting him then back down at the wound.

“The blood is unusual,” he says, quieter than before. “Higher viscosity than I would expect. Note that. Continue suction.”

Malric leans in.

Nestor’s voice resumes its measured pace, and I cannot tell if he is bothered by what he saw or if he has already filed it away somewhere. Is he worried the corruption spread to his blood? No, there’s no way it would happen that fast.

“We will fill the socket with a current weave to preserve the shape of the orbit. Without it, the lid will sink and the angel’s face will be marked beyond what the wound itself has done. Watch the layering. The current must be set in three passes, here, here, and here before the conjunctiva is closed. We close with silk. The socket will be stitched shut and patched. He will wear the patch for the rest of his life.”

I turn away. I can’t watch this. My heart is breaking for Jace, and I didn’t even ask Lux if Ellavee was injured.

Nestor is right. I need to go be useful somewhere else.

I descend the few steps out of the gallery, and Professor Bale nearly runs me over pushing a gurney, a mender on the other side of it.

“Miss Rose, join us. We can use an extra pair of hands.” He locks eyes with me briefly then hurries into operating room seven.

I see a flash of long blonde hair when I turn to follow him.

I clean my hands and gown up as fast as I can and push the door open with my back, entering the room. Bale and a mender are pulling instruments and potions from the cabinets, setting up a tray, and I look over at the patient and confirm it.

It’s Ellavee.

She’s not conscious. A jagged piece of dark wood, longer than my forearm and splintered at the protruding end, is buried in her below the ribs on her left side. Someone has already packed clean cloth around the entry wound to keep it stable, but it doesn’t look good.

At least it’s from a branch and not a twisted creature.

I take a step closer. I don’t see any corruption.

“Miss Rose, I don’t have a second healer who can hold the angles I need on a frame this small. You have the smallest set of hands on this floor.”

Mender Theo looks over at me, his eyes narrowing.

I swallow, thankful he doesn’t say anything about how miserably I failed at helping Nella.

“What’s the injury?” I ask, moving next to Ellavee.

“Impalement, left flank, below the costal margin. I won’t know what it’s hit until we open.”

“Spleen?” I ask, trying to remember demon anatomy. I do believe it’s slightly different from human anatomy.

“Possible. Possibly the diaphragm. The object is acting as a tamponade right now. We pull it out too soon, and she bleeds out.”

Mender Theo pulls the tray of instruments over to the table, ready to assist Bale in handing him whatever he needs.

Bale comes to the side of the table across from me, next to Theo, and meets my eyes.

“Maelis, this is your friend on the table, and that is going to make this harder. I need you to put that somewhere else right now so you can help me with this. Can you handle it?”

I nod quickly, not looking up at Ellavee’s face, focusing only on the wound. Where he packed the clean cloth, it’s already steadily darkening.

Her abdomen is rising and falling shallowly. Her pulse is steady under my fingers when I press them to the inside of her wrist out of habit.

Demons run a slightly faster baseline than humans.

“Penetrating wound, left flank, below the twelfth rib. The object is angled medially and slightly upward. If it has gone deep enough, it has hit either the spleen at the upper pole or the diaphragm. Possibly both. If it had hit the splenic artery, she would already be dead, so I am hoping for a tear in the parenchyma rather than a vascular injury. If it has hit the diaphragm, we will see air movement in the wound.” I impress even myself with how I know all of that in the heat of the moment. All my studying is paying off. I need to stay focused.

“Good. What is your first cut?”

“A vertical incision parallel to the object. I open the wound around it. I do not pull it. I expose what it has hit.”

“Length?”

“Six inches. Down through skin, fascia, muscle layers. Slow. I do not want to nick the object and shift it.”

“Hand,” he says, and I reach out.

Mender Theo places a scalpel in my hand, and my heart starts to race.

“Ready?” Professor Bale looks at me and I nod, meeting his stare.

“Cut.”

I look down and cut.

My hand doesn’t shake.

Some distant part of me starts to think of my father on the table. Of the forceps stuck inside him. Of the bleeding I couldn’t stop. But I breathe through it, and I feel Poppy sending calming energy through our bond.

My confidence takes over. I can do this, and I’m not alone this time. Professor Bale is here with me, and he knows exactly what to do.

The scalpel goes in cleanly. I make the incision long, slow, parallel to the wood. The skin parts. The fascia parts. The muscle layers underneath part with the precision Bale taught me to use, layer by layer, identifying each one before I cut it.

“Good. Keep going. Identify the peritoneum. Do not breach it yet.”

“Identifying.”

“There.”

“I see it,” I tell him.

“Is the object touching it?”

“Yes, the object has gone through fascia and muscle and is sitting against the peritoneum. I can see where it has dimpled the membrane.”

“Has it punctured?” he asks.

“I can’t tell yet.”

“Open it carefully. If she has a hemoperitoneum, blood will come up the moment you breach. Be ready,” he instructs.

I take a breath and open the peritoneum with the tip of the blade.

Blood does not come up.

“Clean,” Bale says with relief. “She didn’t penetrate the abdominal cavity. The object is contained in the retroperitoneum. Spleen is unlikely then. Likely it is the diaphragm.”

“Air.”

“Look for air.”

I lean closer. The wound bed is dark, but I can see the white of the diaphragm underneath, and I can see the hole.

“It punctured the diaphragm. I can see a small tear, maybe a centimeter, around the tip of the object.”

“That is a fixable injury. Listen carefully. We are going to clamp around the tip of the object and remove it slowly. I will pull. You will hold the diaphragm closed with the curved forceps as it comes out. The instant the wood is clear, you suture the tear. Three interrupted sutures. Silk.”

“I haven’t stitched a diaphragm before.”

“You have stitched in the lab. The diaphragm is muscle you can see. Stitch the muscle. I will guide you if you hesitate.” His voice is completely calm and not the battlefield yelling I’m used to hearing from him.

“Yes.” I nod.

Mender Theo places the forceps in my left hand. The needle driver and pre-loaded silk in my right.

“Position.”

I lean over Ellavee. I don’t look at her face. I look at the diaphragm.

“On three. One, two, three.”

Bale pulls the wood in one long careful motion, and I clamp the diaphragm closed with the forceps. The wood clears the wound. Bale tosses it onto a tray and grabs a suction tube from the mender without looking.

“Suture. Now.”

I drive the needle through the muscle. Tie. Cut. Second pass. Tie. Cut. Third.

“Good. Step back.”

Bale places a gloved hand over the diaphragm. The faintest shimmer of gold rises from his fingers, pale and threadlike, and settles into the muscle along the line of my sutures. The current finds the silk. It seals the tissue around the stitches in a way I cannot explain and have not yet been taught.

The shimmer fades.

“Sealed. Good work, Miss Rose. I will lay current as we go to accelerate the muscle and minimize the skin scar. You take the muscle layer.”

It is the longest stitching I have done on a living person, and Bale moves alongside me, his hands hovering an inch above mine. Where I close, he follows. The gold rises again, faint as candlelight, sinking into the running stitch behind my needle. The muscle knits quickly. By the time I tie off the last loop, the layer underneath is already pink and on its way to healing.

The fascia goes faster.

The skin layer Bale takes himself, and his hands glow steadily now, the gold deepening into something close to amber. He weaves the needle and lays current at the same time, the kind of compound technique only senior healers and Veilguards can perform. The line of the wound seals behind him as he goes. By the time he ties off, the only mark on Ellavee’s side is a thin pink line about the width of a fingernail.

“It will fade further by morning. Demons heal quickly, and my current will help.”

The relief is overwhelming.

“You did good work.” He pulls his gloves and mask off.

“I had a good teacher.” I smile even though he can’t see it under my mask.

“Mender Theo and I will take it from here. Go rest. There’s nothing more to be done.”

I take one last look at Ellavee, still sedated, and go to the sink to clean up. Gloves off. Gown off. Mask off.



“Hell, girl. Sounds like you need to go sleep it off.”

I told Cael everything that happened today while I rewrapped my ankle. I fear I have done more damage to it while running up and down the stairs ignoring the pain. I think adrenaline took over for the past few hours numbing the pain.

The wards have calmed down, and I was going to head to my dorm when Poppy appeared and made a run straight for Cael’s room, probably hungry for whatever scraps he’d saved for her. I let her go, figuring it’d be nice to vent to someone disconnected from all of this.

I let out a sound that is closer to a laugh than I have made in hours. It doesn’t last long.

“I’m not going to sleep.”

“I know you’re not.”

He is propped against the pillows, Poppy on his stomach, feeding her dried meat from a tin in his nightstand. She takes each piece from his fingers like he is family.

I sit in the chair I have sat in every week for months and put my face in my hands.

He lets me sit.

After a while, he says, “Listen to me before I let you go. What happened in the Shorelands today is not a fixed fissure failure. I don’t care what your professors are going to call it tomorrow.”

I lift my head.

“I lived through Thornwall, Maelis. I know what the wards on a building feel like when the world starts to bleed. I have been feeling it for months, and what happened today is loud enough that even a man in a bed can feel it.”

“Is the cycle coming soon?” I ask, though I already know the answer, and after getting my first taste of a fissure and what comes out of it, the cycle is terrifying.

“Maybe. Maybe not.”

“Cael.”

“It is not a thing anyone can say for sure. The world is like a body. A wound that bleeds can be the body clearing itself, or it can be the surface of a deeper tear that has not finished happening. You can’t tell from the outside. Sometimes not for weeks or years.”

“So what do I do?”

“You watch. You stay sharp. Don’t let yourself be told that the world is fine when your body is telling you something else. You have a good head on your shoulders, good senses about you. I can tell these things. And you watch your headmaster, girl.”

I blink.

“He is going to give a speech in the next day or two. He is going to mourn the dead and call this contained. I have known him for two hundred years and have watched him close doors a lot of people did not realize were doors at the time.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means he is good at keeping people from looking at things he does not want them looking at. I am not telling you he is your enemy. I am telling you he is not your friend. There is a difference.”

I sit very still. “Why are you telling me this?”

He looks at me for a long beat, his sharp eyes softening.

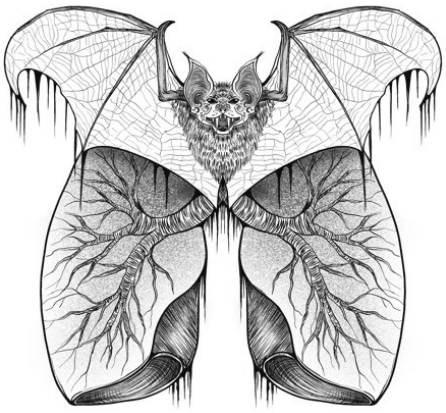
“Because you are one of the people he keeps watching when he thinks no one notices. And because I have been watching him long enough to know it is not the kind of watching that is meant to keep you safe.”

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Chapter Thirty-One

"A power that does not yet know itself is the easiest to remove. A power that learns its own name in time becomes a war."

— Aldric Family Record, Sealed Archive



Eight weeks have passed since the midterm massacre.

Yes, that's what people are calling it.

The wards have emptied of the worst of the casualties. Ellavee is fully recovered, and her scar has faded to a tiny pale line. Killian came back to class three weeks ago with a limp, but he's fine. And Jace…

He has been back for five weeks and hasn't spoken to me once. He wears an eye patch now, and dare I say it makes him look even more hateful.

I have hope that once bone year is over, we'll return home to Ironfen together for the summer break and mend things away from this place.

The headmaster did give his speech the morning after the Shoreland fissure massacre, as Cael predicted he would, and he's been keeping the fear of a looming cycle present. But I can't have constant anxiety over something that's out of my control and still don't fully understand. All I can do is become the best healer I can be, and with my hands cured, I'm on my way there.

Ellavee and Lux have helped me check a couple more places for the mirror, but nothing has turned up, which only further confirms it must be in the headmaster's private quarters. Draven has been distant, returned to who he was before our trip to Holloweir, but I haven't forgotten the glimpses he gave me of what's underneath that rough exterior.

I've kept my end of the deal and not spoken a word about his true lineage, and he said in passing he would still help me the night of the ball after finals.

Finals and the ball are only a handful of weeks away.

Soon, I will have the answers I seek.

"Zuri and Cara found a dressmaker in Whitehaven who can do beadwork in only three days. Zuri said she's going to wear emerald green, and Ellavee wants to wear pink, but she hasn't found anything she likes yet."

Lux has been rambling about this ball for days, and I don't care what I wear to it, because I don't plan on being there long. I haven't told anyone other than Draven about the plan that night. I figured it's better to keep it between us until after.

"Lux," I say, urging her to take a breath.

She sighs and tucks her hair behind her ears. "You said you would go, and I know you don't have anything to wear, and you're running out of time is all I'm saying."

She leans back in her chair and crosses her arms in Professor Nestor's lab while we wait for him to show up.

I raise my eyebrows and bite my tongue. I have far more important things to think about than what dress to wear.

Like the fact that Draven is sitting three rows up and to the right, reading.

Or pretending to. The book in his hand hasn't turned a page since I sat down, and I have been keeping track.

Two rows in front of him, on the opposite side, Jace is sitting with Killian, his new best friend apparently. Flick is on his shoulder, and I swear that tiny bat keeps giving me dirty looks.

"Mae," Lux says, and I turn. She raises a single eyebrow.

"You are doing the staring thing."

I shake my head and reach down to pet Primm, who has settled between us, her white head resting on the desk.

“I’m not doing a thing.”

“You are doing two things, in fact. You’re alternating. Primm has noticed too.”

I look down at the wolf. “You’re a little traitor too.” I laugh through my nose, and Lux giggles beside me.

“Let’s talk about the ball again. Do you think Ellavee will finally introduce us to the guy she’s been sneaking off with?”

Lux beams, relieved at the change of subject.

“Please, she has more than one.”

We both laugh, because Ellavee has game, and Lux and I are both alone. Or Lux is alone in theory. She has been flirting with a demon named Lyrian for three weeks and thinks I haven’t noticed. I’m just waiting for her to bring him up first.

The doors at the back of the lab swing open. “Apologies for the delay. I was speaking with the headmaster.”

Professor Nestor sweeps in with a stack of books under one arm and his coat buttons misaligned. He dumps the stack down on his desk, and the conversation in the room dies before he turns around.

“Bone years, today you are in for a treat. I have set up the room next door for testing.”

A low murmur ripples across the rows.

“Don’t panic. It’s not being graded. Today’s exercise is not for the faint of heart though.”

The room goes quiet.

“You are familiar with the lower bonds with your eidolon. Sensory. Directional. Some early attempts at perceptive.” He proceeds around to the front of his desk. “Today, I am asking you to attempt something the textbooks call a sensory overlay. Eidolons specialize. They don’t generalize.”

We’ve been working with our eidolons in lab once a week now for some time, but I have no idea what sensory overlay means.

“Today, we will test your connection to your eidolon and their specialty.”

A small ping of anxiety blooms in my belly.

“This is blood year Elizabeth. She has agreed to assist me today. She will bring you over one at a time and get you set up. While you are waiting, you may use the time to do this week’s reading assignment.”

Elizabeth pushes off the wall and crosses to the front of the room as Nestor turns and disappears through the door at the side of the lab. She perches on the edge of his desk, crosses one ankle over the other, and tosses her long black hair over her shoulder.

Her eyes find mine across the lecture hall.

She smiles.

I haven't seen Elizabeth much since the Mirror Ceremony despite her insisting she was going to check in on me more, but I'm glad to see she's almost made it through her blood year.

She writes something down and then finds my eyes again. "Miss Rose," she calls, "looks like you're first."

"Of course I'm first," I mutter, pushing my chair in.

"Go terrify him, Poppy," Lux whispers as Poppy peeks out from under the desk and falls into step at my heel.

"Be good, little boners. I'll be right back."

I cringe. Elizabeth has been calling bone years Boners for months, and the joke has not aged.

Out in the corridor, she points to the room next door.

"Don't look so worried, Maelis. It'll be fun. He's right through there."

I nod. Poppy climbs up the side of my coat, and I hold her against my chest as I cross to the door.

"Come, come. Have a seat."

Nestor waves us toward a bench against the wall the moment I step inside.

The room is one of the smaller exam rooms on this floor. Two gurneys folded against the far wall. A line of glass-fronted cabinets along the back. A long counter beneath them with a sink at the far end and a row of stoppered bottles set in careful order. Three straight-backed chairs along the side. The lamps have been turned low.

Poppy hops down from my arms and sits on the bench beside me, her small hands folded in front of her chest like a person waiting to be addressed. Her round dark eyes are fixed on Nestor.

He looks at her for a long moment before he looks at me.

"This little raccoon of yours has been on my mind for some time, Miss Rose."

"Sir?"

“An anomaly eidolon such as her is rare. It is frankly a blessing to see one in my lifetime.”

I shift on the bench.

“In the last eight weeks, I have been making notes on her. Not on you. On her. Her behavior in this lab. The way she sits on your shoulder during my lectures and does not flinch when I dissect a specimen, where most eidolons leave the room or go inside their bearer. She tracks me across the floor. She watches the door before students enter. She is doing things I have not seen an eidolon do at this stage of the bond, Miss Rose, in this generation.”

I look at Poppy, who looks back at me with an expression I can only describe as unbothered by this assessment.

“I would like, if you would permit it, to study her more closely. I would write about her in my private notes. I would ask you questions from time to time about her behavior in your dorm, when she is alone with you. I would simply like to understand what I have been watching for several months now.”

He waits, his hands folded on his knee.

“Why is she so interesting to you?” I ask.

“Because she should not exist, Miss Rose.”

He leans forward slightly, eyebrows raised like a professor about to step into the part of the lecture he loves most.

“There are three known anomaly types in the historical record. A red fox in the eleventh century. A common house cat in the seventh. A mountain hare in the fifteenth. None of them recurred. Each appeared once, attached to one bearer, and the line stopped there. A raccoon has never been recorded in any archive of this academy. Not in any record I have access to. She is a category we do not have.”

“Maybe the records are incomplete.”

“The records are kept by a centuries-old order with limited resources, and they are not infallible, but the records are extensive enough that the absence of a raccoon anomaly, in any era, makes a compelling case.”

He looks at me.

“Your eidolon is not strange simply because she is rare. Your eidolon is strange because she is new.”

Poppy is still on the bench beside me, her clever hands folded, her small body relaxed in a way that tells me she is not afraid of any of this. She

hasn’t moved since she sat down. She is, I realize, waiting for me to make this decision for her.

“Yes,” I say, “you can study her, as long as you ask before you do anything.”

The billionaire had one rule: no falling in love.

We all know how that goes. Browse Lokepub for your next romance.

“You have my word.”

“Sir, can I ask you something.”

He inclines his head. “You may.”

I take a breath. “You told me once to check the library records to see if my father ever went to Ashwell. I did but couldn’t find anything. His name was Charlie Rose. I thought maybe you have access to records I don’t.”

“I have looked, Miss Rose. After what I said to you that first week, I went looking. I didn’t find Charlie Rose in any class list of the last fifty years. I didn’t find him in the visitor logs. I didn’t find any reference to a healer of that name at this academy.”

It makes me a little uncomfortable that he’s taken such an interest in me, but something about Nestor has always seemed kind. I don’t get the same feeling from him I get from the headmaster.

“That’s disappointing. Maybe you’d recognize my mother’s name. Someone at the local tavern thought I was her, and I found out she studied corrupted polar bears here before I was born. I don’t know if she went to Ashwell, but anything’s possible. Her name is Helena Raven.”

He clears his throat and pushes his spectacles further up on his nose.

“Helena Raven.”

“Yes, sir. Have you heard the name?”

He narrows his eyes slightly. “It doesn’t ring a bell, but I’ll look into it for you.” He presses his hands to his knees and stands. “Now let’s get started before the others get restless next door.”

I force a smile and nod, noting how quickly he wanted to be off the subject of my mother.

“This room is shielded,” he says. “The walls are warded against current bleed. What happens here won’t be felt outside it. Use as much of yourself as you need. I won’t assess you on restraint.”

I scrunch my eyebrows. “But I don’t know how to use current.”

“That doesn’t mean Poppy can’t.”

He has me there. I’m constantly learning new things about her and this bond.

“Six objects have been placed in this room. Some are visible. Some aren’t. Some emit smells, and some have texture you’d only notice if you ran your fingers along them. Some are emitting a sound. The exercise is to identify all six through your eidolon’s senses only.”

I open my mouth to ask half a dozen follow-up questions.

He hushes me before any of them get out.

“You’ll be in here.” He opens the closet door beside the gurneys. There’s a single chair inside with a pen and a stack of parchment on the seat. “Poppy stays out with me. Begin when you’re ready. Write down whatever you can. Knock on the door when you’re done.”

I look at Poppy.

She is sitting on her haunches next to the bench, her round dark eyes tracking the closet door with what looks suspiciously like amusement.

“Be good,” I tell her.

She chitters at me, and I step inside.

The door closes behind me, and I’m swallowed by the dark except for a thin sliver of light under the door, just enough to see the parchment and the pen on the chair. The closet smells like old wood and dust and the faint medicinal tang of whatever Nestor stores in here when it isn’t being used as a sensory chamber.

I sit down. I’m not sure where to begin, so I close my eyes.

I reach for her.

I have been reaching for Poppy since the Mirror Ceremony. The bond opens. It isn’t a door anymore. It hasn’t been a door for weeks. It’s a wide room with no walls, and Poppy is at the center of it, and the moment I step inside, she lifts her face to me and offers everything.

Her senses flood mine.

I feel the exam room through her. The faint dried-herb scent of Nestor’s coat. The residue of cleaning solution on the stone floor. A thin sweet trace in the air that doesn’t belong in a windowless room. The metallic tang of the door hinge. The slow steady rhythm of Nestor’s breathing beside her. A muffled hum from the lecture hall on the other side of the wall. A small scratching sound from inside the cabinet to her right.

She turns her head, and the room turns with her.

I can see what she sees. The cabinets, the counter, the gurneys folded against the wall. Sharper at the edges than my own vision. It’s too much, and my head begins to throb.

Poppy is calm, waiting for me. I try to focus again and picture her.

I pick up the pen and write what I smell, what I hear, what I taste through her, what her hands feel as she pads across the floor of the exam room. I write quickly. It feels less like solving a test and more like taking dictation from a friend.

When I finish, I have six items on the parchment.

I open my eyes.

I knock on the door.

The door opens.

Nestor is standing exactly where I left him. Poppy is on the bench. He looks at me.

“How many.”

“Six.”

He extends his hand.

I give him the parchment.

He reads it. Without speaking, he crosses to the cabinet on the right side of the room. He opens it, lifts out a tin from the top shelf, and shakes it. A small scuffling sound rises from inside. He sets it back on the shelf.

He bends, runs his hand under the bench Poppy is sitting on, and pulls out a small wooden block fastened with two iron nails and sets it on the counter.

He turns to a high shelf above the gurneys and lifts down a small dish. The water in it catches the light. He pulls a piece of red velvet from behind the leg of his chair. He opens the top-right drawer of the cabinet on the other side of the room and lifts out a glass vial, half full of a dark liquid. He sets each object on the counter as he goes.

When he is done, he looks up.

His eyes track to the ceiling above the cabinet behind his chair.

The spider is exactly where Poppy showed me it was.

He lowers his eyes to her.

“Miss Rose.”

“Yes, Professor.”

“I have administered this exercise for twenty-one years.”

“Yes,” I say nervously.

“In twenty-one years, three students have identified all six objects. None of them did it in under three minutes.”

I don’t know what to say. He didn’t give me any context before, and I didn’t think it was that hard. Maybe I should have taken longer. I peek over at Poppy, but she’s calm while I am a mess of nerves.

He sets the parchment down on the counter beside the objects. He removes his spectacles and folds them and looks at me without them. His eyes are sharper than I have ever seen them.

“Miss Rose, what are you?”

I chew on the inside of my cheek having no idea how to answer that.

“I don’t know, sir.”

He looks at me for a long beat.

“I believe you,” he says quietly. “That doesn’t change the fact that you are something.”

“Please don’t tell anyone.”

He looks at me for a long moment. The neutrality of his face hasn’t shifted, but something behind his eyes has gone thoughtful.

“I won’t tell anyone.”

“Thank you, sir.”

“Take your eidolon and go back to the lecture hall. Elizabeth can send the next student in.”

I lift Poppy up. She comes to me without resistance and I tuck her into the crook of my elbow and turn for the door.

“Miss Rose.”

I pause.

“Helena Raven.”

He is watching me. The careful neutrality is back. Whatever flickered at the back of his eyes a few minutes ago has been put away.

“I’ll be looking into it. If anything comes back to me, I’ll let you know.”

“Thank you, Professor.”

I release a pent-up breath and find my seat next to Lux again.

Draven turns to look back at me, his eyebrows furrowed.

I quickly look away.

“So how was it?” Lux asks.

“It was good. Primm will do great. You’ll be great.”

She smiles and pulls her pink hair to one side.

“So I was thinking, what if you wore a silvery-light-blue dress for the ball. I think it would really make your eyes pop, and it would look good with your hair.”

I sigh. “Sure, I think that sounds nice.”

Malric enters the room, he and Elizabeth whisper to each other for a moment. Then they both look over at me.

“Maelis, gather your things, please. You’re needed in the patient wards. It’s Cael.”

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Chapter Thirty-Two

"The walls of this academy are older than the kingdom that thinks it owns them. They will outlast every name carved into them, including yours."

— Founding Chronicle, redacted



Malric had the decency to tell me Cael is close to death and has been asking for me. I don't wait for him to tell me anything else and hurry as fast as I can to the patient wards.

I enter his room and find him on the bed. He has always been thin, but not frail. Today, he is small. The blanket has been pulled up to his chest, and his arms are laid out on top of it the way menders lay out the arms of a patient who is no longer turning on their own. His skin has gone the pale gray that demon skin goes in the last hours, a color I have only read about in Cane's textbooks. His eyes are closed.

Am I too late?

I approach the end of the bed, holding my breath until I see his chest rise and fall.

I promised him I'd listen to all of his stories and keep him company until he died. I thought we had more time. I've been listening to his stories for months and I'm not ready for them to end.

Poppy appears and crawls onto the bed, lying right up against his side.

I reach out and hold Cael's hand. He doesn't move.

“Cael, it’s me. It’s Maelis.”

His eyelids flutter but don’t open.

“Don’t go yet, old man.”

His brow twitches.

“Who are you calling old man?” he rasps, and I laugh as one of his eyes opens and finds me. But his lungs sound so bad. The wet, crackling sound of death.

“Cael.”

I move closer. Both his eyes open. His gaze drifts along the ceiling, and then lands on me.

“Girl, you came.” Every word is an effort.

“Of course I came. I should have come sooner. I’m sorry.”

“You came when you were supposed to.”

I’ve decided I’m not going to cry until after he’s gone, and I am holding to that decision. I will not unravel now.

“You should drink some water.”

“No, I’m past that part.”

“Is there anything you want me to do? To tell anyone?”

He’s quiet for a moment. “Tell that little raccoon of yours she’s welcome to my dinner tin.”

I let out a sound that is half a laugh and half a sob.

“She knows.”

“Good.”

His eyes close again. His chest rises and falls, and the rattle in his lungs grows stronger, but I stand there holding his hand.

“Girl.”

I look up. His eyes are open again.

“Yes, I’m still here.” I squeeze his hand. It’s so cold and lifeless already.

“Senna.”

I go very still.

“Cael, what did you say?”

He coughs and rasps again. “Senna.”

I search his face.

“Senna the blood lead died months ago.”

He doesn’t seem to hear me. He is staring off near the window.

“I saw her,” he murmurs.

“Cael, you’re tired. The medication—”

“I saw her last night.”

I furrow my brows. Is he confused? Delusional?

“Tenth floor.”

His voice has gone thin. He coughs, turning his head to the side, trying to take in a breath. I grab a damp cloth from the bedside table and clean his face. I pat his forehead.

“You are not on the tenth floor, Cael.”

I fold the cloth and rest it atop his head.

“I went last night.”

His eyes are closed. I squeeze his hand again.

“How? What?”

“I told her to leave it alone.” His voice is the thinnest I have ever heard it. “I should have told her to run.”

If he isn’t delusional, I’m afraid.

“Run from what? From whom?”

He starts coughing again. “Promise me.” His eyes meet mine and widen slightly.

“Promise you what?”

I lean in closer.

“Promise me you won’t go to the tenth floor.” He swallows. The effort is enormous. “When the moment comes, you’ll know.”

I have no idea what he means, but his eyes roll back, and he starts breathing heavily again.

“Cael—”

His eyes find mine one more time. The brightness flickers up, faint, and the man I have sat with all year is in there for one more second, looking at me, and I see him see me, and I am going to remember this look in his eyes for the rest of my life.

“My girl,” he whispers.

“Cael, you are going to be—”

His chest crackles.

His breathing stops.

The room goes completely silent.

Poppy lifts her head from his stomach and looks over at me. She makes a small sound that is not a chitter. It’s something I haven’t heard her make before.

I kneel down and lower my head to the side of the bed.

I sob into the blanket, and Poppy crawls over to me.

After a few minutes, the mender comes in. She looks at me and stands by the door, waiting.

I sniffle, pulling myself together.

I lean down and press my forehead to his.

“You old bastard,” I whisper and I kiss the top of his head.

Then I sit up, scoop Poppy into my arms, and tuck her against my side. Some people don’t enter your life. They build something inside it. And when they leave, the structure comes down with them.

I don’t look back at him as I leave.

I can’t.

I exit the room as the menders come in and hurry down the hall with my eyes burning and my chest wound tight, not looking where I’m going until I almost slam into him.

The headmaster is standing in the corridor outside Cael’s door with his hands clasped behind his back, his cloak pooling against the stone, his face turned toward the room I left. I realize he has been waiting here.

“Headmaster.”

“Miss Rose.”

I think about brushing past him, because he has done nothing to earn a single word from me today, and I owe him no explanation. But something stops me, some small, foolish grieving instinct that wants to make him to acknowledge the loss.

I open my mouth. “He—”

“I know.” He said it the way a man says he knows the time or the weather. “I think it is for the best in the end for everyone.”

I feel my eyes narrow before I can school them. I want to lash out at him, want to ask him why he is such an enormous asshole, want to blame him for Cael and Nella’s deaths, for the names chalked on the board after the Shorelands fissure, want to confront him about the tenth floor and Senna and the wards he is letting slip and every cold thing Cael said about him at the end of his life. But even with all of it pressing against my teeth, I know better, because there is something sinister behind the headmaster’s eyes, and I’m going to be the one who finds it. I can’t do that if he sees me coming.

I let my face fall into the stoic mask and walk past him. How can he say Cael’s death is for the best for everyone? Did he know Cael was on to him?

I pick up my pace, and I'm almost at the bend when his voice stops me.

"Miss Rose."

I close my eyes for one second then turn.

He has not moved from where he was standing, he's only turned to face me like he was watching me walk away.

"I'm glad you survived your midterm."

I force a half smile, even though he unnerves me.

"Do make it count."

He inclines his head, and I round the corner before he can say anything else, throwing myself into the lift, and the moment the doors slide closed, my legs give, and I sag against the wall with Poppy pressed to my chest and my forehead against the cold metal. I don't breathe until the lift begins to descend. I've never wanted to be away from a person more in my life, and he was barely there.

Once outside, I gulp the frigid air in deep shuddering pulls, my breath plumed white in front of me. Poppy makes a small chittering sound against my coat and then disappears to rest.

Cael was old. He lived a long, great life, and at the end of it he got exactly what he asked for, someone to share his stories with until the end. He was ready, and it was his time.

I close my eyes. *I hope you are at peace, old man.*

The dorm is across the courtyard, and Nestor's class will be over by now. I need to get my mind off things and study for finals. I need a hot shower and sleep too.

I am almost to the side of the building when I see Malric.

He is leaning against the wall with his shoulder set against the stone, one boot crossed over the other and his arms folded across his chest, his head tilted back so that the light catches the underside of his jaw and the hint of red in his brown hair. He's been waiting for me.

Great.

"Well, Red, looks like I'm going to need to assign you new patients."

I stop walking.

"Though everyone around you tends to die." He pushes off the wall, and the crunch of his boots in the snow is the only sound between us. "Let's see. Who don't I like right now?"

"I'm not in the mood, Malric."

"I can see that."

He closes half the distance between us and stops close enough that I have to tilt my chin up to keep my eyes on his.

“You’ve been crying.”

I roll my eyes.

“Let me by.” I glance around. It’s empty between the buildings.

“You remember how I was there for you the last time you lost a patient, Red. I could do that again.” He takes a step closer and inhales deeply, like he’s breathing me in.

I scrunch my nose. “You’re vile. Now move.” I try to sound threatening and not nervous. I wish I had my scalpel right now. I would consider stabbing him with it.

“I just want to talk for a minute. You can spare me a minute.” He picks up a piece of my hair and twirls it around his finger.

I take a step back, but I’m all the way at the wall now. “I don’t want to.” I swat his hand away, and he drops my hair.

“I know. Indulge me anyway.”

His eyes are more red than gold, and I hope he can’t hear how fast my heart is beating.

“You’ve been busy this year, and I’ve been watching. You may have come in playing the unremarkable human, but you have managed to become something else entirely.” He rubs at his chin, studying my face. “I don’t think you understand yet how visible you’ve made yourself and how dangerous that can be.”

I narrow my eyes. “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“Yes, you do.”

A smirk starts on his face, and his voice has gone different. The flirtation has bled out of it, and what’s left is the man I have only seen pieces of. The one he hides underneath the sarcasm and the wandering hands. The one likely responsible for killing Senna.

“I’ve known what you are for a while, Red. Probably longer than you’ve known yourself. It was the bite that did it.”

I don’t know what he means, but I know Malric spews crazy, so I swallow and stare up at him.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about.” I straighten my shoulders. “What do you think I am? Why are you telling me this?”

“Because the orders I have been keeping you alive under are about to expire.”

I think I stop breathing.

“What?”

Is he talking about the Obsidian Throne? Draven’s family? No, because why would they care about keeping me alive. Does he know my mother? Did Jace say something? So many things run through my head. Did Draven tell him about our deal, that I know he’s the prince, but then if he was worried I’d tell, it would be all the more reason to have Malric kill me.

“After the ball,” he says, “I can’t help you anymore.”

“You haven’t been helping me. You killed Senna, didn’t you?”

I decide to confront him. This conversation is already taking a dark turn.

He throws his head back and laughs. “If that’s what you think, you’re blinder than I thought.”

Something about it seems honest, which makes what Cael said about the tenth floor even more alarming.

He steps into me until my back presses into the stone. He leans down and sniffs the top of my head, and I contemplate kneeing him between the legs, but I don’t have anything to defend myself with right now.

He tucks my hair behind my ear, his touch makes my skin crawl.

“Save me a dance, would you?”

“Hell would have to freeze first, Malric.”

He laughs. It’s short and not entirely amused. “We will see, Red.”

He steps away and walks slowly to the end of the alley and around the building.

Once he’s out of sight and I can no longer hear the crunch of his boots, I breathe.

I’m about to push off the wall when something pulls my attention up.

A figure on the balcony of the men’s dormitory across the courtyard. He’s standing in the shadows, but when he sees me looking, he takes one step forward, and our eyes meet across the snow.

Draven.

I shake my head and turn to go inside.

I don’t need to unpack what that means right now.



A long shower and a bowl of soup later, I'm laying on my bed staring up at the designs on the ceiling.

This year has been the second hardest year of my life. The first was losing my father. This year has been hard, but it still doesn't compare to that. The day I got the letter to come here seems like an entire lifetime ago. Things were so different then.

I need to write out all the things I want to ask Ashwell once I find the mirror and make it count. Hopefully it will be forthcoming with answers.

Who applied for me to come here? Who wrote that line on the bottom of the parchment? *Blood remembers what history forgets. Your father knows you are ready.* My father may have applied for me, but he didn't write that on the parchment. Unless someone else applied for me, and it's the same person who wrote that line. Or the school itself summoned me and somehow put the cryptic message there too. This is low on the list of things I need to know, but no less frustrating.

I haven't received any mail from my mother or sister since coming here. My mother not writing isn't a surprise, given we are on rocky terms. But Briana, I thought she would have written something. I can't fault her, because I haven't written either, and she's probably busy with the clinic and helping our mother.

Jace wasn't worried about the crawler in Ironfen, and if it had become a problem, surely we would have been notified by now if a large fissure opened in our home village. Jace still writes to his parents. I don't think he would keep that from me, no matter how much he hates me these days. But then where did it come from? And why didn't we see any crawlers in Holloweir? No one mentioned any across the midterm locations either. Have they become less active, or are they waiting for the cycle to begin?

I borrowed two books from the library about the history of the cycle and fissure events across the continent, but I haven't found the time to read them yet. Almost everything I know about the cycle, I learned from Cael.

I can't believe he's gone. It feels so surreal to lose him and Nella both. I hope I don't get assigned any more patients until next year. I don't know if my heart can ever harden enough to where losing them gets easier.

I need to study. I need to get through finals. I have to keep my distance from Malric, make it to the ball, and find the mirror.

I place my hand over the key necklace at my neck and start to fidget with it.

The headmaster’s been watching me, but I don’t think he realizes I’m watching him too.

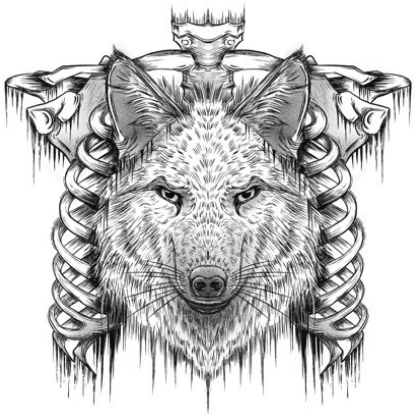
Cael wanted me to promise to stay off the tenth floor, but I never did.

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Chapter Thirty-Three

"The first time current answers you, you will believe you have called it. You have not called it. It has been listening."

— Veilguard Memoir, Unsigned



Lux is on her knees in front of her closet pulling out shoes, surrounded by all the dresses she took out on loan from the seamstress in town. Her entire room is covered in dresses.

"This one." She holds up a black sheath with white lace at the collar and frowns. "No. Too much like a funeral."

"It's been that kind of year, Lux."

"Don't be dark." She tosses the dress over her shoulder onto the pile. "We are celebrating. Finals are over, and we all passed. We aren't bone years anymore, guys. After tonight we are blood years. Real, almost respectable, allowed-to-touch-instruments on our own healers. You should be screaming." She beams at me and Ellavee.

"I'll scream tomorrow."

Ellavee laughs.

"You'll scream tonight, or I'll do it for you." Lux tosses another dress aside.

"Technically, we aren't blood years until we make it back after summer break."

I’m sitting cross-legged on her bed in my robe. Poppy is curled up in my lap, watching Lux ransack her room. Ellavee is at Lux’s vanity, already in her light-pink dress she had picked out ahead of time. She’s braiding pieces of her blonde hair and arranging it into an updo.

“My final mark in my father’s class was low pass,” Lux mutters, pulling out a pair of sparkly shoes. “He gave his own daughter a low. Tell me how that’s supposed to make me look.”

“It means he’s not playing favorites,” Ellavee says without looking. “Be glad.”

“I want him to play favorites. He gave Killian a high pass, and Killian fights like he’s kicking a wagon.”

“Killian got hit in the spleen during midterms. Bale’s marking on bravery now,” I tell her.

“Bravery isn’t a metric.”

“It is at this academy,” Ellavee mumbles, tucking a strand of hair up and pinning it in place.

Lux grumbles and yanks a hanger off the rack. “What did you get in Cane’s, Mae?”

“Low pass.”

She freezes. “You did not.”

“I did,” I sigh.

“I thought you really liked her class. Why low pass?”

“Probably because she had a weird thing for Jace, and I don’t think it went unnoticed that he hates me.”

She laughs.

“What about Nestor?” Ellavee asks, finally turning from the mirror.

“High pass.”

Lux whistles. Ellavee tips her head. “Of course she did.”

I smile. “What does that mean?”

“He is keeping you close, and a high pass keeps you in his class for next year. He obviously has a thing for Pops.”

I scratch the top of Poppy’s head, looking down at her, because Ellavee isn’t wrong there.

“Okay, how’s this one?”

Lux straightens. She’s wearing a navy form-fitting dress with a deep neckline. She spins around, and the back exposes the long line of her spine.

She pulls her light-pink hair into a high knot and lets a few pieces fall along her jaw.

“You look amazing,” I say. “Lyrian is going to be all over you tonight.”

“He is going to forget how to speak,” Ellavee says, and Lux throws a piece of clothing at her.

“Now you,” Lux says, clapping her hands together.

I let her pick out my dress, because I told her I didn’t care what I wore. I have too many other things on my mind, plus she loves this kind of thing.

She crosses to her closet and lifts the dress she’s been hiding from me all week. She refused to let me try it on, insisting it would fit and that she wanted it to be a surprise.

She holds it up.

The gown is a muted silver and icy blue that shifts in the light. A lace-trimmed satin bodice with a delicate bow gives way to a sheer, tight panel adorned with intricate frost-like embroidery that traces down the length of the dress. Tiny off-the-shoulder straps made of lace finish it. The whole gown looks both delicate and commanding.

“It’s stunning.”

She tosses it at me. “Go put it on.”

I slip into it in the bathroom and examine myself in the mirror. I already dried my hair and darkened my eyes, but the dress makes me look regal. It hugs my body, and my red hair against the silvery-pale blue is the kind of contrast that makes a person stop walking. I would never have picked something like this for myself.

I feel beautiful in it.

I exit the bathroom, and Lux and Ellavee are both standing there waiting for me.

“I look—”

“Don’t,” Lux says. “Don’t say ‘fine.’ You look like the godsdamn moon, Maelis.” She squeals.

“That’s a stretch,” I laugh.

“It isn’t,” Ellavee says.

I smile. “Thank you guys for getting me ready. I couldn’t have done it without you. You both look gorgeous too.”

We all hug.

Then we leave Lux’s room together, the three of us, my heels clicking against the stone. Heels were not a smart choice for what I need to do

tonight, but at least it’s a short heel.

I can hear music already. Strings layered with the low murmur of voices.

The grand hall is ahead, and light spills out of the open double doors in long warm bands across the snow. Figures in dark formal wear move in and out of the light.

“Last time we walked into a room like this, it was for orientation. Do you remember?” Lux says.

“How could we forget?”

We step inside, and the room has been completely transformed. The chandeliers above us are massive structures spelled with current to glow faintly from within, casting amber light across the polished floor. Tall ice sculptures rise from each corner of the hall. The sculptures are the eidolons of the academy. A bat with wings spread wide. A serpent coiled. A wolf with its head lifted.

And in the fourth corner of the room is a raccoon sitting on its haunches, holding a brain.

I stop walking. Lux turns to look at me.

“What is it?”

“Why is there an ice raccoon?”

“There’s only one person here who could have done that. I’ll give you one guess,” Ellavee says.

Lux and I both say in unison, “Professor Nestor.”

He’s an earth mage, so controlling the elements is something he’s very adept at.

“Told you he had a thing for Poppy,” Ellavee says, and we keep walking deeper into the room.

An orchestra plays something low and slow at the far end of the hall. Faculty is standing in small clusters along the perimeter and on the second-floor balcony. I see Bale near the window, his arms crossed while he talks to Cane, who looks great in a purple velvet dress.

“Oh gods,” Lux breathes, “Lyrian is here.”

“Of course he’s here, looking all hot and fiery with his red hair.” Ellavee says.

“Hey.” I slap Ellavee’s arm then turn to Lux, “Go. We’ll find you later,” I tell her.

She smiles before disappearing into the crowd in a flash of silk and navy blue.

“I need a drink,” Ellavee says, heading toward the bar.

I need to keep a clear head for tonight, but I still go with her.

Nestor is by the buffet table with a glass of something dark, watching the room over his spectacles. He sees me and inclines his head. I salute and smile. I’ll have to thank him later for including Poppy.

Ellavee takes a shot of something. “I’m going to dance. Want to come?”

I look over at her. “No, go ahead. I’ll see you later.”

She vanishes into the crowd, and I grab one of the colorful bubbly drinks the bartender assured me is non-alcoholic. I take a sip of the fruity liquid and turn to take in the room.

“You look very nice tonight, Mae.”

I freeze when I hear his voice and turn to see Jace. He’s in a white suit, the same color as his wings. I look up and meet his blue eye, the one that has lost its luster. His other is covered in a dark-gray patch.

He grabs his drink and walks away before I can say anything.

I’m too in shock to move. Is he being nice or fucking with me?

“Red.”

I internally cringe and look to my right. Malric is dressed in deep red, and I think it’s fitting, given how sinister he is.

I dip my head to him but don’t say anything. I don’t want to engage.

“I think it’s time I get that dance we talked about,” he says.

I close my eyes and inhale. *Do not lose your shit. He’s not worth your time.*

“I’m not dancing tonight,” I say as pleasantly as I can and take another sip of my drink.

“When are you going to believe me? I’ve tried to tell you that you don’t want to make an enemy out of me, Red.”

I’m not in the mood for this.

“One dance and you’ll leave me alone indefinitely?”

He smiles, because he knows I’m about to give in. He holds his hands up like he’s surrendering.

“Let’s say next time you’ll be asking me.”

I almost choke when I laugh. “Yeah, that’ll never happen. Let’s get this over with so I can get on with my night.”

He holds out his hand to me.

He leads me onto the floor, and the orchestra transitions into something slower than it was a moment ago.

His other hand finds my waist, and he places it lower than is polite. I shift it up two inches without breaking eye contact. His mouth twitches, but he doesn't fight me.

"There she is," he says. "Was wondering when you'd show your teeth tonight."

I roll my eyes. "Don't talk."

"Now where have I heard that before?"

My stomach turns. The exam table flashes through me without permission, his mouth on my throat, his hand sliding down my hip, the moment I came back to myself and shoved him off. I push the memory back. I focus on the rhythm of the steps and the placement of his feet, and I count the music in my head. *One*, *two*, *three*. *One*, *two*, *three*. My father used to count for me when he taught me to dance in the clinic on slow afternoons.

"You're tense, Red." Malric's hand spreads across the small of my back. "You used to be looser around me."

"That was the bite."

He hums against my temple. "It was."

He turns me, and the ballroom rotates around us in a slow blur of amber light and colorful silk and the hum of a hundred conversations. From somewhere on the perimeter, I feel eyes on me. The skin on the back of my neck prickles.

"Your prince is watching."

I narrow my eyes against his shoulder. He knows I know, which means Draven told him. Why would Draven tell him?

I don't look. "Don't flatter yourself."

"Oh, he's watching, Red." Malric tips his head down toward mine, close enough that I feel the cold of his breath against my cheek. "He's been watching since you walked through the doors. He watched you at the bar pretending not to look for him. He's watching while you're in my arms right now, and he's gone very, very still about it."

I keep my eyes on his collar. "You're saying it to upset me."

"I'm saying it because it's true. The lost prince of Valen, who's never given a public damn about anyone in his life, has spent nine months

pretending not to notice a human girl, and he's currently failing to pretend across this entire dance floor."

"Malric."

"Hmm?"

"You agreed to leave me alone after this dance."

"I did."

"Then stop talking about him."

His thumb traces a slow line along my back through the satin of my dress, and for a moment I think he's going to push me. Going to ruin this. Going to give me one last reason to hate him for the rest of the night.

He pulls back enough to look at me, and the smirk is still there, the performance of it all, but underneath it is something I haven't worked out yet.

"What does that look mean?"

"It means be careful tonight, Red."

"You said that already."

"And I'm saying it again."

The orchestra reaches the end of the piece. He turns me one more time, a full revolution, and on the way around I let myself glance toward the place along the wall where I felt the eyes earlier.

Draven is standing alone.

His beard is perfectly manicured. His hair is tied up in his favorite half bun. He's dressed in a pristine all-black suit that fits him the way a sheath fits a blade.

Gods, he's gorgeous, and tonight he looks every bit the prince I now know him to be.

He isn't pretending to do anything. Not drinking. Not speaking. Not even pretending to be looking somewhere else. He's simply watching me across the floor, across Malric's shoulder, with an expression I haven't seen on his face since the chapel in Holloweir.

His honey eyes find mine.

I forget the count for one beat.

Malric pulls me back into rhythm.

"Told you," he murmurs, low enough that only I can hear. "Watching."

The music ends.

He tips his head down toward mine, his face close, close enough that for a half second the dance floor around us could be the alley behind the dorms,

could be the corridor outside the morgue, could be the exam table I've spent weeks pretending I never climbed onto.

"For what it's worth," he says quietly, "I hope you find what you're looking for tonight, Red."

I don't know what to say.

He releases my hand and bows slightly. He steps away from me, and the floor opens around the place where he was standing, and I'm alone for one breath in the middle of a hundred dancers, the orchestra already striking up the next piece, my dress settling around my legs, my hands cold where his were.

I turn.

Draven hasn't moved. Of course he hasn't moved. He isn't going to come to me in front of all these people. Not when he's spent weeks avoiding me since midterms. He's going to make me come to him. He's going to make me choose it, in front of every faculty member and every student and every vampire in his orbiting little court, and he's going to watch me do it.

I stop in front of him with maybe a foot of air between us. He looks down at me, and I look up at him, and the orchestra moves through eight bars of the new piece.

"Hi," I say, because someone has to start.

The corner of his mouth lifts reluctantly, the way it did in Holloweir.

"Rose."

"You're staring."

"I am."

"You should stop."

"I should."

We've done this before.

He sets the glass down on the windowsill behind him without breaking eye contact, his eyes drift down the length of my dress and back up to my face slowly. By the time his gaze meets mine again, I've stopped breathing. I don't know when I stopped. I only know I need to start again before he notices.

"You look beautiful, Maelis."

He doesn't call me Rose or Freckles. He doesn't call me anything but my name, and the sound of it in his mouth, in this dress, after all this time, almost finishes me before the night has properly started.

“Don’t say things like that to me right now,” I murmur.

“Why?”

“Because I have something to do tonight.”

“I know.”

“Then you know I cannot afford to be standing here looking at you.”

“And yet.” He tilts his head, and the corner of his mouth moves again. “Here we are.”

I sigh, because he is going to be like this all night, and I am going to be ruined for it.

Around us, couples have begun to move into the new song. Draven’s eyes haven’t left mine, but his hand stays at his side. Waiting.

“Draven.”

“Yes.”

“You promised me a distraction, not a dance.”

“I know.”

“So you’re going to ask me to dance anyway.”

“That depends.” He shifts his weight, and the line of his coat moves with him.

“On what.”

“On whether you can dance with me without losing your nerve for what comes after.”

I lift my chin. “I can do anything tonight.”

He almost smiles as he extends his hand, and the orchestra changes again.

I take his hand.

The warmth of his fingers settles around mine. He draws me toward him, slow and deliberate. He could close the distance in one motion, but he gives me time to step into him, and I do, and his other hand finds the small of my back and settles there in a way that makes me forget how to breathe.

His hand is wide enough to span half my back.

He hasn’t touched me like this since Holloweir.

My free hand finds his shoulder, and I feel the line of muscle under the black wool of his coat, his collarbone above the open collar at his throat, the slow steady pulse at the side of his neck. I have to remind myself that I’m supposed to know how to dance.

“Breathe, Rose.”

His voice is low against my temple.

“I’m breathing.”

“You’re not.”

“I am.”

“Mmm.”

He turns me into the first count of the music, and my body remembers how to do this even when my mind has gone blank. He’s a better dancer than he should be. Vampire prince, raised at court, taught to move through a crowded room since he could walk. His hand at my back is doing half the work for both of us. He guides me through a turn I would have stumbled on, and on the way out of it his thumb shifts against the fabric of my dress, and a small fire lights low in my belly.

“You’re doing this on purpose.”

“Doing what?”

“You know what.”

His mouth shifts into that almost smile again.

“I’ve waited months to put my hands on you, Rose. You’ll forgive me if I take a moment.”

I look up at him.

He looks down at me.

The music continues and we move through the dance floor together, his hand firm at my back, mine at his shoulder, our other hands clasped between us. Around us, the room has filled with couples, all of them dancing, none of them as quiet as we are. I should care about who’s watching but don’t.

He turns me again, and on the way around he lowers his head a fraction, his mouth close enough to my ear that no one else could hear him over the strings.

“Listen carefully.”

I tense.

“I’m not going to say it twice, Rose, and I need you to remember every word.”

“I’m listening.”

“The headmaster’s cottage is at the eastern edge of campus, past the stone wall by the cloister. Third building from the gate, the one with the dark-green door. Your key will open it. I don’t have any doubts.”

“How do you know?” I feel the press of it around my neck.

“Don’t ask how. Trust that it will.”

I move my head a little closer. To anyone watching, we are a couple too caught up in each other to mind the music.

“Once you’re inside,” he continues, “the front room is a study. Don’t waste time there. The mirror won’t be in plain sight. There’s a second door at the back of the study behind the bookcase on the right side, and it isn’t locked, but it is warded. The wards will recognize the key. They won’t recognize you. Hold the key in your palm when you cross the threshold, and don’t let go of it until you’re through.”

“What happens if I let go?”

“You don’t want to know what.”

I swallow.

He turns me, slow, and the chandeliers swing through their amber arc above us as the room rotates.

“How long do I have?”

“I’ll keep him at the dais and on the floor for as long as I can. Thirty minutes. Maybe an hour if I’m lucky and he’s in a mood. If he leaves earlier than that, I’ll find a way to send word, but don’t count on it. Treat thirty minutes as your ceiling and get out.”

“Thirty minutes is not a lot of time, Draven.”

“I know.”

“What if the mirror takes longer?”

“Then make it not take longer. The mirror responds to the person in front of it. You’ve been in it before. You know what it does. Ask your questions cleanly and don’t let it slow you down.”

I nod against his shoulder. He feels it. His hand at my back presses.

“What if he comes back early?”

“He won’t.”

“What if—”

“Rose.”

He turns me through another count, his hand firm at my back.

“Don’t get caught,” he whispers.

“That’s the plan.”

“I’m being serious.”

“So am I.”

The music shifts, the strings pulling toward a long low note before they pick the rhythm back up, and on the lull he draws me a fraction closer, enough that the front of my dress brushes the line of his coat.

“You’re really good at this,” I murmur.

“At what?”

“At having a heist conversation while you dance.”

“I’m a man of many talents, Rose.”

“Apparently.”

He spins me, and on the way around he allows himself the smallest possible smile. It lasts a second, gone by the time we finish the turn. But I see it, and he knows I saw it, and I will have to do something about how the seeing of it has made the room go warm.

“Why are you helping me?”

“I gave you my word.”

“That’s not why.”

He’s quiet long enough that I think he won’t answer.

“No,” he says, “it’s not.”

The music turns. The room turns. A couple I don’t recognize passes too close, and Draven adjusts our line without thinking, his hand spreading wider against my back to guide me away from them.

“You’ve said six words to me in the last eight weeks. Why?” I ask.

He sighs, “It’s complicated.”

He’s quiet for a long beat. The music carries us through it. When he answers, his voice has gone lower than the music, and I have to hold very still to catch every word.

“I can’t distract you with this tonight. Let’s not forget how worried you were about the angel the second we made it back,” he says, and I lean back to search his face.

“Are you jealous?” I ask, and he pulls me to him again so I can’t see the expression on his face.

“You would know if I was jealous.”

“Then what is it? What’s complicated?” I press. He’s quiet, and it only annoys me further. “You almost kissed me. I hated you, and then I thought things changed in Holloweir. I thought you showed me a little bit of the real you, I shared things with you too, and then we come back to the academy, and you can’t be bothered to act like you know me. What the fuck, Draven?”

“I’m the heir to a throne that would never…” He takes a deep steadying breath. “You’re right. These last weeks felt like a stupid amount of time to

spend pretending I wasn’t going to fail at staying away from you. I spent it anyway. Forgive me.”

“I’ll take it under consideration,” I say, and he chuckles, but I have a feeling that’s not what he was going to say. He’s avoiding something.

“Please do, Rose.”

The corner of his mouth moves. Restraint settles into the line of his jaw like it always does, and I am dancing with the version of him I have come to know, the one who controls every muscle of his face except the one that gives him away.

“By the way,” he says, and the change in his voice makes me look up.

“By the way what?”

“You remember what I said earlier this year about what I’d do if he touched you again?”

I go still in his arms.

“Draven.”

“I’m just reminding you.”

“Don’t.”

“Rose.”

“Alucard.”

His eyes hold mine for a long beat. He doesn’t look angry or like he’s making a threat, no. He looks like a man who has already done the math, decided what comes next, and chosen not to trouble me with the details.

The music ends suddenly, and a bell rings somewhere up high in the rafters. A current ripples through the hall as conversations cut off.

I look toward the dais.

Headmaster Ashmoor steps onto it.

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Chapter Thirty-Four

"The cycle does not arrive. The cycle accumulates. We are inside it now and have been for years, and the moment we recognize it is not the moment it begins."

— Cael Brannock, attributed



Ashmoor's in a coat darker than the night outside, cut close to the line of his shoulders and falling almost to the floor. The collar is high. The fabric catches the chandelier light in a deep matte sheen, the kind of black that looks blacker the more you look at it. His short dark hair is combed back and immaculate, the silver at his temples catching the lamplight.

The hall has gone very still.

Beside me, Draven's hand finds mine.

He lets his palm settle against the back of my hand where it's hanging at my side. "Walk with me," he murmurs.

"Now?"

"Now."

He shifts his weight back, the smallest motion, and his hand closes around mine and tugs once. I follow him a step.

Ashmoor says, "Tonight, we mark the end of another year at Ashwell Academy of Medicine and Alchemy."

Every face in the hall is angled toward the dais. The orchestra has lowered their bows. The bartenders have stopped pouring. Even the small

motion at the edges of the room — the late arrivals, the servers with trays of glasses — have gone still.

Draven takes another step backward. I follow.

“It has been a difficult year. We have lost forty-six students to this academy. Some to fissure events at the midterm assignments. Some left under the pressures of this place and could not return. Some failed the work that was asked of them. Their names will be added to the records of this class and to the long count this academy has been keeping for hundreds of years.”

Draven is angling us slowly toward the side wall.

The chandeliers are at our backs. The dais is in front of us, but the angle is widening. Ashmoor’s eyes have not yet moved from the front of the room, where the breath years are clustered, and the rest of the hall is pulled in his direction.

“To breath years, you have completed three years at this academy. After tonight, you are no longer students. You are Veilguards.”

A small wave of applause spreads through the hall. Draven uses it to slip us another step backward. His hand has closed fully around mine now, and his thumb eases once across my knuckles, and the small contact is doing more for my pulse than the eight weeks of distance ever did to slow it.

“Tomorrow, you will receive your post assignments and soon you will all spread across Valen to do what you came here to do. You will save lives we will never meet. You will hold ground we will never see. We will not see most of you again until the next cycle calls us together.”

The crowd around us has begun to shift, leaning forward slightly toward the headmaster.

“To blood years, make it count.”

Draven turns me around the side of an ice sculpture and the cold of the ice radiates against the warm air of the room. I feel the chill of it pass over the bare skin at my collarbones. We are almost at the wall, and I’ve started to drown out his speech.

“To bone years, you have survived your first year at Ashwell. Some of you will not survive your second. Some of you will. The difference between those two outcomes…”

His voice fades.

Draven guides us behind a tall column. We are out of the part of the hall that anyone is watching. The orchestra is between us and the dais now, and the wall of the side corridor is two steps away.

“Now,” he murmurs.

He pulls me, and I follow.

We move along the wall in a fast, unhurried stride that doesn’t read as fast to anyone watching, my hand still in his, his other hand at the door before I see him reach for it. The side door is propped open on a small iron hook — he prepared this — and he eases me through ahead of him, follows, and pulls the door closed behind us with the soft click.

The cold of the corridor outside the hall hits me, and I gasp.

He turns and walks me forward without saying anything. The corridor is empty. The lamps along the wall have been turned low. We pass a service alcove and a closed door marked for the kitchen, and at the end of the corridor is another door. He reaches past me and opens it.

The night air comes in. Snow is falling.

He leads me along the back of the building in the narrow strip of stone between the wall and the line of trimmed trumpet trees that frame the lawn, where the lamplight does not quite reach. The cold is profound and my dress was not made for this. My breath plumes in front of me, and the fabric of my skirt is already starting to drag in the powder snow, and I am suddenly grateful there’s no wind tonight. Adrenaline alone is going to get me through it without freezing to death.

“Draven.”

“Listen.”

He stops and turns me to face him, my back against the stone wall, and I have to look up to meet his eyes. Somewhere inside the building behind us I can hear, faint and muffled, Ashmoor’s voice.

“The headmaster’s cottage is at the eastern edge of campus past the stone wall by the cloister. Third building from the gate. The dark-green door.”

“I remember.”

“Say it back to me.”

“Eastern edge. Third building. Green door.”

His hand comes up and brushes my hair from my eyes and across my cheek. The motion is so gentle I almost flinch. “Your key will open the door. Hold it in your palm when you cross the threshold of the warded

room. Don’t let go of it until you’re through. You have thirty minutes. If something goes wrong, get out. If you can’t get out the way you came in, the back of the cottage opens onto a service garden, and there’s a low wall along the eastern edge that you can climb.”

“In this dress?”

“In that dress.”

“Right.”

His thumb traces once along my jaw, the gentlest line.

He’s looking at me the way he looked at me in the hunters blind at Holloweir, the way he looked at me on the dance floor, the way he has been failing to not look at me for months. The snow is collecting on his shoulders and in his hair. His hand hasn’t left my face.

“No matter what you find out tonight,” he says quietly, “I want you to remember this moment.”

My breath catches.

“What do you mean?”

He leans in quickly and kisses me. His mouth is on mine, warm against my lips, and his wings come out and cocoon us against the wall, a barrier of warmth and protection as his hands move over me. One finds the back of my neck. The other is on my waist, pulling me tight against him.

His hot tongue presses into my mouth, and it tastes of sweet whiskey as he devours me.

I tangle my hands around his neck and in his hair, and the kiss is rough and uncontrolled. I’m so tight against his body I can feel the hardness of him pressed against me, and a groan slips out of me as I rub my body into his. His tongue presses against mine and explores my mouth, and then his teeth graze my lips, and he breathes me in.

Gods, I want this and so much more.

His beard is rough on my skin, and I want to feel it on other parts of my body.

“Rose.”

He murmurs my name into the kiss, and I don’t have the words to answer him with, so I tilt my chin up another degree and deepen the kiss. It’s insatiable, and I never want it to end.

His hand slides from my neck up into my hair hard enough that my scalp tingles, and he uses the grip to tilt my head back exactly the way he

wants it. His mouth follows the line of my jaw, slow at first, then less slow, and when his lips find the soft skin below my ear, my knees nearly give out.

“Draven—”

Against his throat, I feel his pulse leap under my mouth. I press a kiss against it without thinking, and he makes a sound I have never heard him make before, and my whole body goes hot.

His hand at my waist slides lower to the curve of my hip where the satin of my dress bunches, and his fingers press into the fabric there in a grip that is not gentle. I feel the heat of his palm through the satin, through my skin, and lower.

“You taste—” he murmurs against my temple then catches himself. He kisses me again harder, his other hand cradling the side of my face.

His tongue parts my lips, and the kiss goes deep enough that I feel him in my chest, slow enough that I lose track of time. The whiskey is dark and rich on his tongue, and I chase the taste of him.

A small sound escapes me. Pleading. Wanting.

He answers it with a low hum against my mouth that vibrates down my spine, and his thumb glides once across my cheekbone in a touch so gentle it doesn’t match the rest of him at all.

“Maelis.”

I rise up onto my toes to press into him harder, my body asking for things my mind has not given permission for, and he shifts to meet me. His grip on my hip tightens. He leans forward into me until my back is fully against the cold stone of the wall behind us, his wings curled tighter around us, and the contrast of the cold stone and the heat of him pressed against my front nearly undoes me.

“Gods,” I breathe.

“I know.”

“Draven, I—”

“I know.”

His mouth finds mine again, and this time the kiss is not slow at all. He is taking, and I let him take, and my hands move into the open collar of his coat to feel the bare skin of his throat and his collarbones, and I feel the small tremor that is rolling through him underneath the control.

He is shaking.

A man who controls everything is shaking against me.

The wave of desire that hits me at the realization is uncomfortable, a heat pulling low in my body, an ache I have never had in quite this shape before. I press myself harder against him, and my hand slides from his collarbone down the front of his coat, down the line of buttons toward his stomach, and his hand comes up and catches my wrist before I get there.

He pulls back from the kiss.

His chest rises and falls fast. His amber eyes are dark, the gold deepening at the edges, and his hair has come loose at the temples where my fingers found it. The cold of the night between us is the only thing keeping me upright.

“Rose.”

“I want—”

“I know what you want.”

“Then—”

“Not here.”

He raises my wrist to his mouth and presses a kiss to the inside of it, his lips lingering against the place where my pulse is hammering, and he closes his eyes for one beat as if he has to gather himself.

“Not like this.”

“Why?”

“If I don’t stop now, I won’t stop at all.”

I open my mouth to answer, and he beats me to it.

“Because you have a job to do tonight, and I will not be the reason you don’t do it.”

“Draven.”

“Rose.”

His hand finds the side of my face again, and he tilts my chin up to look at him.

“I will give you all of it, every last thing you are asking me for, when you walk back out of that cottage. Do you understand.”

“Yes.”

“Say it.”

“When I walk back out.”

“Good girl.”

Then he steps back.

His wings disappear, and the cold of the courtyard rushes in to replace them.

“You need to go, Rose.”

I nod, still trying to catch my breath and never wanting this to end at the same time. “I know.”

His eyes narrow on me. The control is back mostly, except for the slight unsteadiness at the line of his jaw.

“Thirty minutes.”

Then he’s gone, running back toward the ball before I can say anything else, and I press my fingers to my swollen lips.

Gods, that kiss.

I touch the key at my throat. I need to get going.

I turn east. I start running toward the headmaster’s private quarters.



The cottage door is dark green, weathered, set into the stone wall of the third building from the eastern gate.

I can hear my own breathing.

I look back. The path is empty. The snow has been falling steadily for the last few minutes and is already covering my footprints, which is a small mercy I will count tonight. The lamps along the cloister are turned low, their flames cupped in iron lanterns that sway gently in the wind. The hall is far enough behind me that I can’t hear Ashmoor or the music anymore.

I lift the key from my throat.

It is warm in my hand. The metal hums faintly against my palm, a small steady vibration that I have never felt from it before, and I stop for one breath to register it.

The school knows what I’m doing.

Ashwell is helping me.

I close my eyes and slide the key into the lock.

Please.

I turn it. The lock clicks open, and I step inside.

Thank you.

I close the door behind me as quietly as I can and lean my back against it for one held second, my heart hammering so hard I’m sure he can hear it across the campus.

The cottage is dark.

A single oil lamp burns low on a table near the door, its flame guttering in the draft I let in. The rest of the room is shadow and shape, slowly resolving as my eyes adjust. There is a faint smell I cannot place, something dry and herbal, like the back room of an apothecary.

I take three steps in and stop.

The study is long and narrow. The walls are lined floor to ceiling with shelves, books packed so tight in some places that they bow the wood.

A leather chair faces the massive desk at the center of the room. Above the desk, on the wall, hangs a portrait.

I don’t have time to look at the portrait, not properly, but my eyes go to it before my mind decides to look at it, and I get a half second of impression before I force myself to look away. A woman. Curly hair. Eyes I cannot make out from this distance. The frame is plain dark wood, no plaque, no name. The portrait has been hung at the eye level of someone sitting in the leather chair.

He looks at her every day.

I put the question away.

I’m not here for the portrait. I’m here for the mirror.

I cross the room. The bookcase on the right is taller than me. The shelves are organized by subject, anatomy texts, fissure reports, what looks like a row of old journals bound in matching leather, a small collection of older books in a language I do not recognize. I put my hand against the side of the bookcase and feel along the seam of the wood. There.

A small iron handle, recessed into the side, hidden unless you know to look for it.

I pull, and somewhere in the back of my mind I want to know how Draven knew all of this.

The bookcase swings inward on a hinge, exposing a narrow door behind it.

The wards hit me immediately.

I feel them before I see them. The air in front of the door has gone thick, and my breath catches in my throat. The hair on the back of my neck rises.

I close my hand around the key.

I close my fist tight enough that the edges bite into my palm.

I step forward.

The wards push back.

It’s not a physical pressure. It’s something deeper behind my eyes, a feeling of being seen by an intelligence that doesn’t have a body. My ears ring. My pulse jumps in my throat. I take another step and another, and the pressure builds, and I understand suddenly what Draven meant when he said not to let go of the key.

One more step.

The wards peel back.

I cross the threshold.

The pressure releases all at once, like a hand letting go of my throat, and I stumble forward two steps into the warded room and catch myself against the wall with my free hand. My breath comes ragged. I am sweating despite the cold.

I straighten and look up.

The mirror.

I know it is the mirror without lifting the cloth.

I can feel it.

The same low pulse I felt in the cavern at the Mirror Ceremony, the same slow heartbeat that is somehow not coming from a heart, the same listening presence that knew my name before I gave it to anyone. It’s here, waiting.

I stop in front of the cloth.

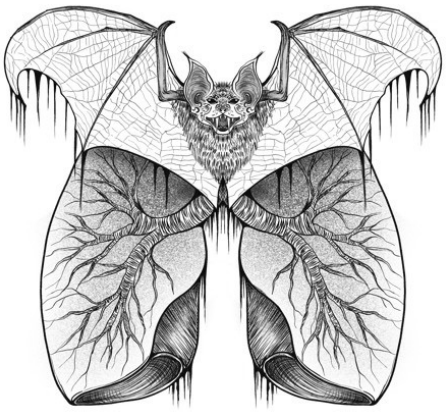
It knows I’m here.

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Chapter Thirty-Five

"We do not choose to become healers. The work selects us, and we spend the rest of our lives pretending we agreed."

— Professor Nestor, Lecture Notes



I touch the black cloth, and it falls to the floor, forcing me to take a step back.

It's the mirror. The same bone frame, ribcage curling up the side, antlers branching out at the top. The liquid surface ripples, and my reflection ripples with it.

It knows me, and I don't have time to be afraid.

I close my eyes, breathe in, and think about the list of questions I've been carrying for far too long.

Then I step inside the mirror.

I'm instantly swallowed by a cold darkness. I look around but can't see anything. Then I hear the heartbeat, as a presence settles around me.

"Maelisss Rossse."

The sound of my name slithers up my spine like a serpent, and I try not to shiver.

"You have come to viss-it me again so sssoon. So sssearching."

"Before, you recognized my blood. You said my father walked these halls, but I can't find him in any school record."

The presence shifts in the dark.

“Ah. Yesss. Perhapsss...you were searching for the wrong name.”

I take a breath and hug my arms around myself to keep warm. I don’t like these cryptic answers. I need to be more clear.

“Did Charlie Rose attend or visit Ashwell Academy?”

“No, sweet child. Charlie Rose never set foot inssside thessse walls. He wasss a healer of a small village. He stayed where he wasss kept.”

As though my father was placed in Ironfen by someone and meant to stay there.

I press a hand against my chest before I can stop it. I know where this is going, but I can’t believe it. I can’t believe it until I hear it.

“Was Charlie Rose my father?”

An ill feeling takes hold.

“Not by blood.”

I take in a sharp breath that feels like it’s going to come back out as a sob, and I grit my teeth and force it down. *Not now. Not here.*

“Who is my biological father?”

The presence in the dark shifts. The slow heartbeat echoes in my ears, slow and soft.

“You already know, Maelisss Rossse.”

“Tell me anyway,” I demand.

“It isss not for me to ssspeak hisss name. He hasss withheld it from you, and he will give it to you himssself, when the time isss right.”

I close my hands into fists at my sides.

The grief I have been holding back starts rising in my throat, and I can’t let it through. Charlie, my father, the man who taught me everything.

“He knew, didn’t he?” I whisper. “Charlie knew I wasn’t his.”

The voice that comes back is softer than before.

“He knew and chose you anyway. He loved you, and the blood you carry isss not hisss, but every other part of you he ssshaped with hisss own hands. The healing isss hisss. The empathy for patientsss isss hisss. The way you hold a sssscalpel isss hisss. No blood will ever take it from you.”

I cough on a sob and quickly wipe my face. In the dark of the mirror, I feel the cold presence watching me.

I steady my breathing.

“Who applied for me to come here? Or did you summon me yourself?”

“I would have sssummoned you eventually, but it wasss Helena Raven, your mother, who applied for you.”

Finally a straight answer.

But how did she know?

My mother, who has not looked me in the eye since my father died. My mother, who according to this same mirror has been hiding me from my real father for my entire life.

She sent me here. To him.

“Why would she do that?”

“That isss not mine to give, sssweet child. Asssk it of her when you ssstand in front of her again. There are reasssonsss.”

I am going to ask my mother the next time I see her. I am going to look her in the face and ask why she sent me to him.

“Did my mother ever attend Ashwell Academy?”

“Sssshe hasss walked thisss campusss, but it wasss not to attend classsesss.”

So she was here studying corrupted polar bears and getting knocked up.

“Tell me what I am, since I am no ordinary human.”

“You are a blood mage, Maelisss Rossse, the sssecond born to your father’s line.”

The answer startles me.

“No, it can’t be. I— I can’t even use current. I have no power.” My voice has gone thin. “Is the headmaster my father?”

I choke on the question, because it can’t be. I can’t accept it. I won’t.

“You are asssking the wrong questionsss.”

I run my hands over my face, wanting to scream in frustration. I keep it together. I need to hurry. I can’t tell how much time has passed, but it feels like too long.

“If I’m a blood mage, then why can’t I use current? I should be able to create it, like you.”

That chill presses against my spine again, the presence drawing closer.

“Two half-siblings, only one may come into power. For that to happen, one of you must die.”

The dark goes silent.

“I’m sorry. What?”

I think my vision would be narrowing with anxiety if it wasn’t already completely black in here.

“Blood remembersss blood, Maelisss Rossse. Thisss perssson will be closer to you than you think. You will be drawn to one another in sssome way.”

“How do I even go about finding this person? Who are they?”

“That isss not mine to give either. The ssshape of the answer is already in your handsss.”

I start to spiral. It could be anyone. I can’t kill anyone. The thought of having a half-sibling I’ve never known and being asked to choose between us—between my power and theirs, between my life and theirs—makes the dark pull tighter around me.

“What if neither of us wants to be a blood mage?”

“One of you will die. It isss dessstined.”

I shake my head. “No, I don’t believe you.”

“You ssshouldn’t worry about thisss now, child. You have more pressing mattersss to attend to.”

I almost laugh.

“More pressing than having a half-sibling and one of us destined to die.”

The coldness comes back.

“Tell me, child. What family hasss been known, for centuriesss, to eliminate any threat to the throne of Valen?”

I go still.

“What?”

“Anssswer me.”

“I don’t—”

“You do. You know thisss one. Sssay it for me.”

My mouth has gone dry. The presence is pressing in close, the slow heartbeat of Ashwell beating slow underneath my pulse, and I can feel the question with my whole body before my mind catches up to it.

“The Aldrics.”

“Yesss.”

“What does that have to do with—”

“What family, Maelisss Rossse, hasss for four hundred yearsss hunted blood magesss to near extinction? What family ssspilled the blood of your kind acrossss every kingdom of Valen until there were ssso few of you left that the world believed your line had ended?”

“No.”

The word leaves me before the mirror has finished asking the question.

“Sssay it, child.”

“No. No, no, no—”

“Sssay it.”

“The Aldrics.”

“Yesss.”

I cannot breathe.

I am standing in the cold dark of the mirror with Charlie gone and my mother lying to me and a half-sibling I am supposed to kill or be killed by, and now the family that has been hunting my line for four hundred years has a name, and the name is Aldric.

The same name as the lost prince of Valen.

The same name as the boy who walked away from his throne.

The same name as the man who kissed me in the snow nearly thirty minutes ago.

“And now, Maelisss Rossse,” the voice slithers, soft and almost amused, “you find yourssself at thisss very ssschool with one of them.”

The dark spins.

A low rumble starts beneath my feet. The slow heartbeat of Ashwell skips a beat, and the cold around me deepens. No not the cold of the warded room, not the cold of the dark, but something icier, something arriving from somewhere else. The hair on my arms lifts. My breath plumes white in front of me.

The presence in the dark begins to recede.

“Wait.”

The cold tightens.

“Wait, mirror—”

The presence is moving away from me, the slow heartbeat already growing fainter, and I’m out of time. I lunge forward into the dark with my hand out as if I can catch it.

“Does he know what I am? Does Draven Know?”

The voice doesn’t answer.

The slow pulse beneath my pulse stutters and fades.

“Mirror! Ashwell!” I yell into the void.

The room shakes harder. The dark around me is fracturing, splintering in long thin lines that run away from me toward edges I cannot see, and I

can feel the trance failing, the mirror slipping out of my reach, the warded room calling me back into a body that suddenly cannot hold itself upright.

“Mirror, please.”

Nothing.

The presence is gone.

The dark is mere dark now. Empty. Cold. The slow heartbeat has stopped.

A pain begins behind my eyes that I have never felt before, sharp, building. My head pounds. My hand reaches for something to hold and finds nothing, because there is nothing in the dark anymore. The mirror has let me go, and the room shakes around me, and the cold sinks into my bones, and the rumble beneath my feet has become a groan. I feel everything starting to come apart at the seams of itself.

I stagger backward with my hands at my temples, and my knees buckle, and I drop to the cold, dark floor that is no longer there. *Draven, did you know?* The pain at the back of my eyes cracks open and the dark of the mirror becomes a different kind of dark.

Black.



I blink rapidly, and a blue-hued light comes into view overhead with a low hum.

“What?”

Then I see him. His face comes into focus as he leans over me. It’s the man I think is my father.

“Welcome to the tenth floor, Miss Rose.”

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Ashley R. O'Donovan writes romantasy, always with a darker edge. She lives in Monterey, California, with her husband and dogs. When she isn't writing, you can find her curled up with a good book, watching a horror movie, or traveling.

If you loved Bone Year, please consider leaving a review on Amazon. To read more from Ashley or find her on social media, scan the code below.

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